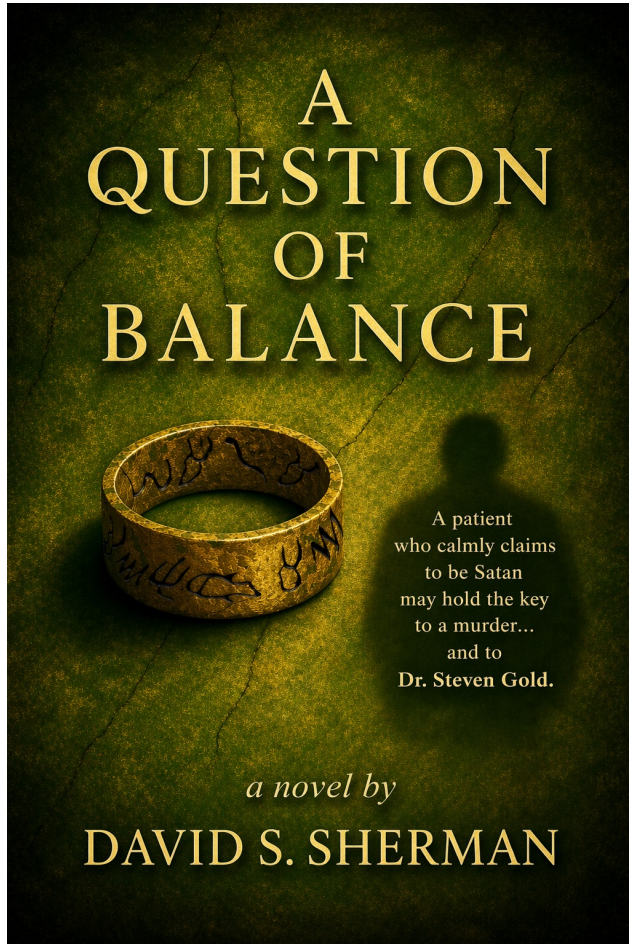




A Question of Balance

**A thought-provoking murder mystery probing the uneasy space
where psychology, philosophy, and religion collide.**

Dr. Steven Gold has built his life on understanding—of his patients,
of the mind, of himself.

Until a new patient enters his office.

Samuel Light is articulate, composed, and unnervingly perceptive. Then,
with quiet certainty, he makes an impossible claim: he is Satan.

What begins as an unusual case quickly becomes something disturbingly
personal.

As their sessions deepen, Light begins unearthing truths Gold has long buried—
blurring the boundary between patient and self.

When a respected rabbi is found murdered—his body staged in a crucifixion—
Gold is drawn into the investigation. His connection to the victim is unclear,
but deeply unsettling.

As the line between memory and reality begins to fracture, Gold finds himself
caught in a tightening web of guilt, belief, and suspicion.

**As the search for truth intensifies,
one question becomes unavoidable:**

What if understanding is not the same as knowing?

With echoes of *The Secret History*
and *The Silent Patient*,
A Question of Balance explores
the fragile boundary between
analysis and obsession—
and how even a mind trained to heal
can lose sight of itself.



A QUESTION OF BALANCE

a novel by
David S. Sherman

PRE-PUBLICATION PREVIEW ONLY

DRAFT MANUSCRIPT

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DEDICATION

*Her name, from the Greek helē—light, bright one.
My in-laws were prescient.*

For my wife, Helene—my light, my center, my balance.

*I hope my hugs never lose their magic.
My love for you exceeds infinity.*

*If God exists, He is responsible for everything.
If He does not exist, then we are.*

— Jean-Paul Sartre, *Notebooks for an Ethics* (1947) translated by
the author

PROLOGUE

*Darkness does not always arrive suddenly.
Sometimes it gathers—quietly, patiently—
until you realize you can no longer see.*

CHAPTER ONE

Light often Blinds

*The question is not whether God exists,
but whether His existence would excuse us.
— Simone Weil, Gravity and Grace (1947)*

“Fuck you!”

Steven Gold spun away, his voice breaking against the stone walls of the sanctuary. “Damn you... and your God. All the lives you’ve destroyed.”

A hand caught his arm.

He reacted without turning—jerking upward, hard. The grip released.

“Wait—oh!”

Candlesticks toppled.

A wine goblet struck the floor, red wine spreading across the carpet.

A body followed with a heavy, final thud.

Then silence.

Not the reverent hush Gold knew so well, but something emptied of response—a silence that did not listen, did not forgive.

Behind silver-rimmed glasses, wide, unblinking eyes caught the glow of the *ner tamid*—the eternal flame above the ark. Its light wavered, casting a dull gold shimmer across the darkened sanctuary.

Flickers danced across his pupils, as if reflecting something no one else could see.

His lips parted, caught between thought and speech—holding back something he could not say. The familiar lines of his face, once lit with

warmth and certainty, were unreadable now. No peace, no resistance—only surrender.

The silence stretched.

Whatever thoughts Rabbi Shapiro might have formed would remain unspoken. Whatever meanings he had gleaned from the sacred scrolls would not be unraveled again—at least not by him. Perhaps another would speak them, years from now, over fresh earth.

The first thing Steven Gold noticed was the time.

Wednesday. 4:17 am.

A voice—quiet, insistent.

What have you done?

He was awake again—heart racing, mouth dry—already rehearsing explanations for a day that had not yet begun. Nothing was wrong. Nothing had happened. And yet his body behaved as if it knew otherwise.

Beside him, Rachel slept near the edge of the bed, one arm flung outward as if reaching for something that had moved just beyond her grasp. He watched the rise and fall of her back and felt the familiar tightening in his chest—not love exactly, not guilt either, but the narrow space where those two emotions had learned to coexist without touching.

He told himself what he always did: that anxiety was merely anticipation without an object. That fear, like belief, could be managed if properly named.

As he swung his legs onto the floor, a thought arrived uninvited—fully formed, immovable:

Whatever is coming, I'll be blamed for it.

He stood there longer than necessary, barefoot, listening to the house breathe. Somewhere in the distance a siren wailed—brief, inconclusive—then faded.

The dream was already slipping away, dissolving too quickly for him to write it down. But even as it vanished, Gold felt the familiar urge take hold—the need to shape it, to arrange it, to make sense of it after the fact.

He had already begun constructing the story he would one day tell about how this all started.

He did not yet know which parts would be true.

CHAPTER TWO

Lust

Unexpressed emotions will never die. They are buried alive and will come forth later in uglier ways.

— Sigmund Freud, paraphrased in Ernest Jones, *The Life and Work of Sigmund Freud* (1953)

Wednesday, 4:00 pm

Fuck. Just leave.

Steven Gold froze—like he'd looked straight into Medusa's eyes.

Rigid, barely breathing, he feared even the faintest chair squeak might betray him.

After two minutes of pounding the reception door and stabbing the Ring doorbell, Jane Sanders snapped.

She jabbed the button once more.

She screamed, pounding the door with both fists.

At last she whirled, boot heel slamming the door—a furious concession of defeat.

Her voice was low, husky, roughened by smoke.

“This isn't over, you fucker! I know you're in there!

“You can't hide forever. You'll be sorry—I swear! I'll tell Rachel the truth!”

She stomped toward the elevators. The AC's low hum filled the silence.

Still motionless, he shifted only his eyes.

When she vanished into the elevator bay, he exhaled—long and shaky. *Fatal Attraction* flashed through his mind.

Thank God I don't have a pet rabbit.

She's right. I can't avoid her forever. And Rachel's already suspicious.

She keeps calling and hanging up. No voicemails. Enough.

Even in grainy video, she still moved with runway grace.

She wore the look that had lodged in him: a sheer blouse he'd once admired too openly, low-rise jeans clinging to her hips, chocolate Hermès boots that carried her like weapons.

Elegant. Dangerous. In control—and he hated the want it woke in him.

The runway never left her. She moved like she owned it. Like riding a bike—muscle memory dressed in leather and silk.

He could hear the echo of her boots through the iPad speakers. On screen, her New York strut remained fierce—even in fury, captivating.

He devoured the footage—scrolling, zooming—like forbidden fruit he couldn't stop tasting.

He froze her mid-glare. Zooming in, he remembered the silk of her hair, the faint ghost of *Joy* by Jean Patou.

Smoke, sweat, Joy. It always flips that switch.

Her face, full screen, filled his vision.

He stared, mesmerized. Slowly, he zoomed out, savoring how her hair curved around her cheeks, slid down her shoulders, and brushed the blouse's collar.

She was no longer the coke-thin waif of her early days. Her once-pristine skin bore the imprint of life—sun, smoke, nights blurred by excess. Time had softened her, but her bone structure still commanded attention.

Her tall frame whispered fashion model—elegant, erotic, impossible.

Each fist strike flashed like a strobe on the catwalk. Fine wrinkles, age spots on her long fingers—a grip that seemed to close around him.

Behind the locked door, those murderous blue eyes, that wild silver hair—thrilled him.

He paused—capturing her face at a strange angle: one eye slightly higher, one lip subtly fuller. The asymmetry unsettled him—which only excited him more.

Not twenty-one anymore, but at fifty-one she was still—undeniably—a perfect ten.

Crazy as hell. Still lethal. Still got it.

He zoomed out—revealing her lithe frame, head to toe.

That round, toned ass. Jesus.

He lingered, then zoomed in tight.

He panned slowly—his gaze returning to the ghosted outline of her breasts beneath the sheer blouse, to the hard pressure of her nipples against the fabric. Rage, cold, movement—he didn't care which. He only knew he kept looking.

Arousal stirred—familiar, unwelcome.

She'd love this. Knowing I was still staring. Still caught.

He should have closed the iPad.

He didn't.

Rachel would be gutted if she saw me—perving like this, like some creep.

Rachel's innocence—that's what seduces me. But she's gone inward, passion buried behind canvas and clay—silent.

Jane wasn't more beautiful. She was desperate. Deliberate. Provocative in every gesture, and she knew

exactly how to wield it.

Without thinking, he touched his wedding ring to his lips—an old gesture, reflexive, half-prayer, half-apology—and forced himself to breathe.

I'm such a moron—I never should've told Rachel I liked that blouse. She always suspected. After Thanksgiving, she'd said, "I see the way you two look at each other."

This wasn't desire anymore—it was evidence.

Delete it. Now.

He hovered over the trash icon, hesitated—then tapped: “DELETE VIDEO.”

A confirmation window appeared.

He exhaled—deep, controlled.

Instead, he closed the iPad—slowly. A soft magnetic click, like a locked door.

The thrill had already encoded itself: arousal tinged with guilt, like a scar that still flinched when touched.

He told himself it was gone.

Disaster avoided—for now.

Something's off. A tilt—then steadiness. Get a grip.

The faint smell of stale coffee clung to the office air. He reopened Spotify and resumed Haydn's Cello Concerto No. 1.

Rachel loved Haydn's predictability—the order. It soothed her; let her light shine, made space to create.

Gold needed that order now. Its serenity poured into the silence—poised, easy, calming. Yo-Yo Ma's cello tinted thoughts he hadn't let touch himself in years.

Gold exhaled and shut the iPad. The magnetic click sealed it.

He leaned back to his leather-bound *Cain: A Mystery*, still dog-eared from Jane's intrusion.

He re-read Cain's soliloquy—

Act I, Scene I:

*Cain. (solus.). And this is
Life!—Toil! and wherefore should I toil?—because
My father could not keep his place in Eden.
What had I done in this?—I was unborn,
I sought not to be born; nor love the state
To which that birth has brought me. Why did he
Yield to the Serpent and the woman? or,
Yielding, why suffer? What was there in this?
The tree planted, and why not for him?
If not, why place him near it, where it grew
The fairest in the centre? They have but
One answer to all questions, “’t was his will,
And he is good.”—How know I that? Because
He is all-powerful, must all-good, too, follow?
I judge but by the fruits—and they are bitter—
Which I must feed on for a fault not mine.*

*Whom have we here?—A shape like to the angels,
Yet of a sterner and a sadder aspect
Of spiritual essence: why do I quake?*

His Apple Watch buzzed—splintering his deep concentration with a sharp jolt behind his eyes, yanking him from Byron back into the dull gravity of now.

His next patient would arrive in minutes.

Byron—what a waste. Dying so young. What insights did death steal?

Some are born into judgment. Others just wait for it.

CHAPTER THREE

Mauvaise Foi

Bad faith differs from lying in that it seeks to evade the truth of one's freedom and responsibility.

— Jean-Paul Sartre, *L'Être et le Néant* (1943)

"Life" is a spectrum disorder. A good therapist knows where he sits on that spectrum—and that he's on it.

— Steven Gold, *Journal of Existential Psychodynamics* (Winter, 2024)

Wednesday, late afternoon

His Apple Watch buzzed.

Gold pressed *Stop*, irritated by yet another intrusion. He'd been absorbed in Cain's injustice—the punishment for a sin that was never his to bear.

He sighed and set the book aside, his mind already drifting.

My shoes aren't as comfortable as they look.

He lifted his feet and rested his Santoni Uniqua loafers on the ebony desktop.

Shit—my freshman year at Harvard cost less than these loafers. And the dorm bed was more comfortable. Vestis virum facit, Erasmus wrote—clothes make the man. At \$300 an hour, the costume better fit. Rachel used to tease me—said I looked like I was auditioning for a part I didn't believe in. She was right... as usual.

He leaned back in his Eames chair; striped socks peeked from beneath tailored cuffs. Exhaling through pursed lips, he dog-eared the page, and reached for his iPad.

There it is again—the flicker, a blind spot blooming. Aura, not stroke. Moving.

He paused his Romantic literature reading playlist and queued up Pink Floyd. “Comfortably Numb” began, low and steady.

“Hello, hello, hello—is there anybody in there?”

He chuckled, recalling the moment at his office door not twenty minutes earlier.

Ha. Fitting.

David Gilmour’s solo floated through the room. Gold looked around—content, almost serene. He took pride in the office: how polished it looked, how perfectly it mirrored him. Tenth floor, Wilshire Corridor—quiet, efficient, everything in its place.

He especially liked the photo from last month’s The Atlantic profile—“Psychotherapy in America: A Question of Balance.” Sitting behind his desk: the perfect shot. The famous Dr. Richard Carlyle’s heir apparent—at least, that was how they’d framed it.

He tried not to think about the emails—angry, frightened, accusatory. A few were from people the police had actually questioned after his St. Augustine murderer profile. One message he still hadn’t deleted.

He took three Advil from his desk drawer and swallowed them dry.

Just in case.

He picked up the small statuette he’d set out that morning and turned it in his hands.

Wish I’d had this for the shoot. Would’ve balanced the desk—nice counterpoint to the sandstone.

The statuette—a gift from a world-renowned archaeologist he’d treated for postpartum depression—was an earthenware Sumerian goddess. She’d also left him the latest issue of the Israel Exploration Journal, which he had meant to read and instead left buried beneath other proofs of his importance.

The relic—Astarte or Asherah—had likely been smuggled out of southern Iraq. He ran his thumb across the goddess’s breasts—nipples worn smooth but still discernible.

Was she offering them—or caressing herself?

*The “ideal” female form tilts with each era—fat,
thin, fat, thin—like a pendulum hunting a false center.*

In the ‘90s, it was Jane’s look: anorexic.

He set the figure down beside a greeting card, its ornate script reading, “Thanks for curing me, Dr. Gold!”

*“Cured” ... ha. She wasn’t broken—only
overwhelmed.*

*No one gets cured; we just get by. “Normal” is
being abnormal—just not too often.*

He slid the card into his top desk drawer.

*First child. She has no idea how much more
complicated her life just became.*

*Hell—that’s how I afford these shoes. She’ll be
back.*

His eyes wandered to the sandstone plaque—

*Just walk a mile in his moccasins
Before you abuse, criticize and accuse.
If just for one hour, you could find a way
To see through his eyes, instead of your own muse.
— Mary T. Lathrap*

A gift from Professor Hanlon—encouragement then, accusation now. He had unearthed it and placed it front and center, not knowing why. Perhaps it reminded him of empathy—or of the distance between his shoes and anyone else’s. The plaque whispered humility; the man behind the desk performed authority. Hanlon’s words still rang in his head: “You’ve got a sharp mind and good instincts, but don’t forget who you work for.”

He had bristled quietly at the backhanded compliment.

A faint pressure gathered in his throat.

*Ugh. Nausea again. It’ll pass. It always does. No
one has any idea what I’m going through. Not Rachel.*

Not even Bob.

Lately, Gold felt unsteady—even about things he once believed resolved.

Do we fault the oak for winding its way around a fence, chasing light?

Change is inevitable—never sudden, never simple.

Some are carved in stone.

Others, in sandstone.

All crumble eventually—like Ozymandias.

He set the sandstone back on his desk. Truth was, he'd never walk in anyone else's shoes—comfortable or not. It wasn't his style.

He snickered, glancing at his loafers.

Gold stood six feet tall, close-cut gray hair and a neatly trimmed beard. His slender, handsome face was marked by pensive gray-blue eyes—framed not only by wire-rimmed glasses, but by deep crow's feet. Those who knew him understood: they weren't smile lines.

He wore a tailored navy suit and a turquoise Brioni tie—Rachel's gift for his forty-fifth birthday.

She's got the artist's eye. Her eyes—beautiful, blue, inviting.

Gold thought he was funny—though most of his jokes never left his head. Location jokes. You had to be there. And *there* was inside his skull: jokes for an audience of one. Too clever. Too obscure. Lost on others—so he kept them to himself.

When he did share, friends gave polite chuckles—kindness, maybe obligation. Few appreciated his odd, esoteric humor.

He had a reputation as a stick in the mud—one friend in his small circle said the stick was “up his ass.” Beyond that circle, Gold came off as formal, even cold. Patients called him intelligent, well-read, cultured—but also a know-it-all. Holier-than-thou. A hint of God complex.

Not emotionless—restrained. “To avoid the wrong type of transference,” he’d say, “which would compromise therapy.”

Maintain authority.

Whatever the case, Steven Gold seemed to possess the golden touch. He was wildly successful. Was it brilliance—or mass delusion, *folie à plusieurs*?

It hardly mattered. As people like to shrug, *it is what it is*.

Gold had been a wunderkind—a Rhodes Scholar who deferred Oxford to complete his undergraduate degree at Harvard, then raced through a master’s at USC and a PhD at UCLA—all by twenty-six. But he still felt incomplete. Hollow.

At twenty-seven, he immersed himself in late 18th-century Romantic literature at Oxford’s St. Peter’s College, while interning with famed psychoanalyst Dr. Richard Carlyle at Cambridge’s Gonville and Caius.

He returned to Los Angeles to teach at UCLA and build his practice, where he met, and eventually married, Rachel.

Over time, Gold built a lucrative private practice—its clientele ranging from anxious adolescents to world-class athletes and celebrities.

His Wilshire high-rise office overlooked UCLA: a modest reception leading into a spacious suite with a discreet rear exit.

He’d installed a Ring video doorbell and smart lock at the reception entry. Often working late—seeing patients or writing—he kept the door locked.

The office was spacious, gray sisal wallpaper and bright white-framed window opening onto the broad sweep of the Los Angeles Country Club. Sharp, pristine—like a real estate listing, scrubbed of human warmth. Apart from a few of Rachel’s pieces, the space mirrored Gold himself: intellectual, pompous. Even buried beneath an avalanche of art, sterility clung to the air.

Paintings, sculptures, framed prints jostled like guests at an overbooked salon—each clamoring to be seen, yet none finding a voice. Like him, the room was crowded with brilliance but hollow at its core—an identity performed, not inhabited.

The lights flickered; a pulse fluttered behind his right eye. He

rubbed the ache away, then let his gaze settle on the books.

The few items atop his desk and credenza were chosen with care—to spark imagination, to provoke conversation. In one corner stood a freestanding sculpture of a nude young woman touching herself. It raised eyebrows, but he called it a conversation starter. In truth, less provocation than confession—desire carved in stone, denial disguised as art. Like him, it invited dialogue but concealed something raw beneath.

The Atlantic photographer insisted on removing it. Rachel had agreed; she never liked the piece. The figure was clearly a modern riff on Titian's *Venus of Urbino*, but she challenged him when he bought it.

"Steven, I don't know. In a gallery, maybe. But in your office? It's sexist. Many of your female patients will feel objectified the second they see it."

"That's the point," he said.

"If you like, I can sculpt you something more abstract... less graphic."

But Gold insisted. He was drawn to it—that's why she called it *Galatea*.

Rachel deferred to him, as usual, assuming he knew best. She had always been his biggest supporter—his personal cheerleader, as he used to say. She knew him—or thought she did. He needed that: balance, grounding. But things had begun to tilt.

Gold wasn't an introvert—his ego wouldn't allow it—but he was reserved, disliking the idea of "putting himself out there." He enjoyed what he called "running therapy." He believed in brief therapy—fast, detached—where momentum passed for insight. He felt safest behind the bulk of his oversized desk—what Rachel, with a sculptor's eye, mockingly dubbed "Hadrian's Wall."

She knows me so well—at least as much as I let her.

I sit, reading, trying to find meaning.

*She takes a blank canvas, clump of clay, and
creates hers.*

She knows I hide—knows I need to. But we both

hide.

From each other:

Me behind my wall; her, behind oil and clay.

On the other side of the “wall” sat his Harvard College captain’s chair—the *Veritas* crest gleaming from the back, as if to say it was the arbiter of ‘truth.’ Behind it, on a faded Serapi rug, a toile club chair sat angled toward its matching couch.

Gold focused on the books arranged with care along his ebony credenza—a satellite collection to his larger library at home. Each spine was chosen to carry personal weight, each title a reflection of him.

Know the man by his books.

There was no real system. He’d often read two, three—sometimes even four—at once. After reading—more often rereading—he slid each book wherever space allowed. He took pride in the collection, convinced the authors themselves would be flattered to find their works shelved in Steven Gold’s private library.

When not running therapy or playing golf, he drifted through used bookstores, hunting for odd covers and evocative titles—often as important to him as the contents themselves.

He read only physical books, scoffing at electronic ones. That’s not how a book is meant to be used. You have to feel it, smell it, hear the page turn.

In truth, he liked knowing the spines were visible. A library said things before he had to. He never considered that a personal bookshelf was less a collection than a catalogue—something uncomfortably close to a list of confessions.

The physical books supplied a pedigree no Kindle could provide. Occasionally he shared a quote with a patient, but more often he enjoyed the act of quoting itself—aphorisms offered at just the right moment, somehow made truer by being spoken aloud, as though quoted from holy scripture.

He’d asked *The Atlantic* photographer to bump the f-stop—to keep the titles sharp in the background.

Clarity performs well on camera.

Gold watched the window light rake across the spines, thinking about how it changed this time of year.

Shadows, even with no mass, no density, can still carry weight. Enormous weight.

My work is to name the shadows. Or at least make them visible.

But shadows rarely have clear boundaries. That's where the pain begins: where darkness bleeds into light, dimming it. Defining it.

His large five-tiered bookshelf, crowded but carefully staged, offered a glimpse into who Gold believed he was—and who he needed others to believe. Psychology leaned against philosophy, theology jostled pulp, the canon itself thrown into therapy. Less a library than a mask, it was a performance staged to suggest depth. Every spine declared identity, yet the chorus was orchestrated—performance without confession.

The top shelf leaned into psychology and therapy: *Affirmation and Reality; Gestalt Therapy Verbatim; Being and Caring; The Dissociative Mind; The Interpretation of Dreams; The Psychopathology of Everyday Life; Civilization and Its Discontents; Moses and Monotheism; The Origin and Development of Psychoanalysis; The Unconscious Observed; Love's Executioner; The Denial of Death; Cluster Headache: Mechanisms and Management; Man and His Symbols; The Mask of Sanity*. Nestled among them was Frieda Fromm-Reichmann's *Principles of Intensive Psychotherapy*, a reminder of the analytic lineage Gold simultaneously revered and resisted.

The second shelf tilted toward philosophy and existential thought.

Sartre and Camus appeared in French—spines cracked, margins scarred. Two other volumes remained unopened, still shrinkwrapped: *The Sovereignty of Good* and *Pale Fire*. Heidegger's *Being and Time* appeared untouched, almost as if for show.

The rest leaned toward interrogation rather than comfort: *Self-Reliance and Other Essays; Existentialism from Dostoevsky to Sartre; Fear and Trembling; L'Être et le Néant; Meditations on*

First Philosophy; Colin Wilson's *The Outsider*; *The Structure of Scientific Revolutions*; *The Concept of Mind*; *Either/Or*; *The Man Without Qualities*; *Amador: In Which a Father Addresses His Son on Questions of Ethics*. Interspersed were volumes he often cited in session—Camus's *Le Mythe de Sisyphe*, *L'Homme révolté*, and *La Chute*, Rilke's *Letters to a Young Poet*, and Nietzsche's *Thus Spoke Zarathustra*.

The third shelf carried the weight of theology, myth, and guilt: *The Varieties of Religious Experience: A Study in Human Nature*; *Creature and Creator*; *I and Thou*; *Mythology*; *Moses and Akhenaten*; *Answer to Job*; *A Book Forged in Hell*; *The Brothers Karamazov*; *Paradise Lost*; *The Courage to Be*; *Violence and the Sacred*; and Alter's *The Hebrew Bible: A Translation with Commentary*. They pressed together like reluctant neighbors—belief and unbelief, creation and destruction.

The fourth shelf spilled over with literature, poetry, and pulp: *Prometheus Unbound*; *Crime and Punishment*; *Faust*; *Frankenstein, or The Modern Prometheus*; *Nausea*; *The Master and Margarita*; *Gulliver's Travels*; *Dune Messiah* and *God Emperor of Dune*; *The Gospel According to Jesus Christ*; *VALIS*; *The Philosopher's Stone*; *The Teachings of Don Juan: A Yaqui Way of Knowledge*; *The Doors of Perception* and *Heaven and Hell*; *William Blake: The Complete Illuminated Books*; *Miles of Heart*; *Wittgenstein's Mistress*; *Notes from Underground*; *If on a Winter's Night a Traveler*; *The Trial*; *The Double*; *The Wreckage of Agathon*. Gold liked the sprawl here, the way high art jostled against science fiction and psychedelic oddities.

And on the bottom shelf, meticulously arranged in multiple copies, were his own works and unpublished manuscripts—some professionally printed, others spiral-bound or marked with fading revision tabs. The fiction, experiments, and abandoned obsessions—*The Little Boy Who Wouldn't Go To Sleep*; *Reveries and Unanswered Questions from the Edges of Life*; *The Eighth Day*; *Africa*; *The Image Teleporter*; *Bark*; *Dave King & Asgard: Lyrics*; *Eulogies & Headstones*; *Solip*; *DietWrite*; *Dreams in Amber*; *The Mirror That Lied*. The hybrid experiment—*Case Studies in the Absurd*. The clinical and scholarly—*Rules & Laws*; *Category Errors in Life*; *The Wisdom of Silence*. And the academic foundations, preserved like relics of identity: his pretentiously titled

undergraduate honors thesis, *A Phenomenological and Neurophysiological Study of Schizophrenic Hallucinations, with an Original Hypothesis for the Etiology and Pathogenesis of Schizophrenia Based on the Mesolimbic Dopamine System*; his master's thesis, *Schizophrenic Hallucinations: A Psychodiagnostic Tool?*; and his doctoral dissertation, *The Psychosocial Correlates of Adolescent Substance Ab/Use*.

Gold's gaze often lingered here, on the bottom row, where his name lined up neatly against the masters above—proof, or perhaps pretense, that he belonged at all.

Substance Ab/Use... an entire year, wasted.

Gold clenched his jaw and exhaled, recalling when his doctoral advisor quit—after glancing only at the abstract.

"I will not allow you to associate my name with this—travesty! You're not just condoning—you're promoting teen drug abuse," his advisor had barked.

"Bullshit," Gold snapped. "You didn't even read it. I hypothesize that recreational 'ab/users'—as I call them—score higher on self-concept and life satisfaction than non-users or abusers. They're the ones who feel accepted, who belong. Statistically, they're the norm. These days the strict abstainers are the true deviants."

He replayed the scene a hundred times, never admitting it was displaced aggression. He preferred "principle."

Unconsciously, he'd been angry at himself—masking an obsessive fascination with psychedelics beneath academic language. It was a craving—tempered by fear—to step inside an alternate world: Castaneda's *A Separate Reality*.

A strict non-user, Gold knew he was one of the deviants his study had labeled. He rationalized his abstinence: he didn't want to be one of *them*—those blissfully ignorant lemmings.

He'd been thoroughly indoctrinated—imprisoned in a parentally sanctioned, well-mannered world. He didn't realize those outbursts—then or since—were his unconscious self, rattling the bars of its cage. He'd always wrestled with ambivalence.

Maybe—if he'd been calmer—more honest, more mature, he could've convinced his advisor the research had value. And maybe he

wouldn't have wasted a full year recruiting a replacement.

He sometimes wondered: how would his life have been different if he'd finished his doctorate a year earlier?

*Bradbury would have called it too many butterflies.
Who could say where that path might have led?*

He gave himself a pass—clinging to the old refrain: *I wouldn't change a thing. Even if I could.*

No regrets. I'm still here.

He pretended that simply calling them “mistakes” made them truth—as if words alone could absolve him. Thinking too long on it left him queasy—more truth than he liked. Still, he was beginning to understand.

But understanding isn't the same as knowing.

I tell my patients—insight isn't the same as change.

My stomach's growling. I shouldn't have skipped lunch.

He glanced again at the statuette—his quiet proof that therapy, sometimes, actually worked. He needed that reassurance—especially now. In moments like this, no diploma, no certificate, no bookshelf or glowing profile could silence the questions. Or the doubts.

Sartre named it 'mauvaise foi.'

And Kaufmann nailed it: 'self-deception'.

The most dangerous form of mauvaise foi is certainty.

Freud knew Shakespeare was right: “truth will out.” If not consciously, then neurotically.

Ha. That's why I'll always have work.

He leaned back and closed his eyes, as Pink Floyd's “Brain Damage” drifted from his iPad speakers.

“There's someone in my head, but it's not me.”

His Apple Watch buzzed again. 6:30. Five-minute warning.
New patient: Samael Light.

Samael? Had to be a typo.

He couldn't remember who had referred Light—or when. He had a few minutes to text Rachel—to let her know he'd be late again.

He always had new patients complete both the Suicide Probability Scale and the Psychological Screening Inventory. The forms only took twenty minutes, but new patients were always anxious. And he hated having to cut them off when their fifty minutes ran out.

Some first interviews had stretched past two hours.

When the floodgates open, you steer the boat. You don't close the dam.

He pulled a new patient folder, clipboard, and leather-bound pad from the top left drawer.

If I call, she'll ask questions. No time. Better to text.

[Typing]

Sorry Rach, I have to run a new patient so I'll be late. Just eat and watch Rogue's Gallery without me. I'll grab something later. I'll see it on DVR. Sorry. Lo—

The Ring chime sounded. The video flashed onto his iPad, cutting off his text.

A dark blur flickered on his screen.

He tapped the mic, then the unlock icon. "Come on in and have a seat... be with you in just a sec."

Walls hold.

He closed Spotify, straightened his tie, popped a Tic-Tac.

The office lights flickered—twice, like a nervous blink.

Not a rolling brownout, I hope.

He walked toward the reception room door. A ripple—half dizziness, half dread—passed through him. His fingers twitched on the doorknob.

Jumped up too fast?

He let go.

PVC, probably. Not AFib. Right?

He lifted his wrist and tapped the ECG icon.

Normal sinus rhythm.

Right.

A thin, strikingly handsome man—mid-to-late thirties, jet-black hair—sat just left of the ficus, thumbing through the reception copy of *The Atlantic*. The moment he entered, the air shifted—not with sound, but with scent. *Roja Haute Luxe*—regal, enigmatic, unapologetically rare. Like aged parchment soaked in cognac.

Whoa. That's what LeRoi Davis wears. Not an NBA star—more like a model. Or an actor.

He was wearing a black Armani suit with an exquisite black and burgundy-patterned Hermès tie. A matching pocket square completed the look—far too formal for a therapy session.

Light looked up. A flicker in his eyes—something oddly familiar and foreign.

Déjà vu—not mere familiarity. Primal. Like the mark of Cain: invisible, unmistakable. Ridiculous.

As he approached, he caught himself—sheepishly—noting the enviable gleam on Light's black Prada Oxfords.

He glanced at his own shoes, disappointed.

"Dr. Steven Gold," he said. "Come in."

CHAPTER FOUR

Truth Hides In Shadows

Man is not what he thinks he is; he is what he hides.

— André Malraux

Wednesday, early evening

Light, tall at six-foot-three, let the magazine fall to the table with effortless ease. As he stepped inside, his deep blue eyes locked on Gold's—steady, unsettling in their calm.

Rachel would remark on his symmetry. She'd love to sculpt that face—the hollows, the angles. She notices details—even the untouched books on my shelf.

He extended a manicured hand. A heavy gold ring on his middle finger caught the light. It was etched with symbols Gold couldn't place. Writing, perhaps.

She'd have focused on the ring if she were painting him.

Saturn's finger. A ring of judgment—heavy.

"Hello. Samael Light. Samuel, if you prefer—it's easier. A pleasure."

"Nice to meet you, Samuel."

His handshake was firm, steady—decisive.

A cold thread traced Gold's spine.

Gold turned toward his desk, expecting Light to take the captain's chair—as everyone did. Instead, Light strolled to the club chair, angled it just enough to break the room's symmetry, and sat—crossing one leg with the ease of command.

Gold's shoulders tightened.

The office was staged to frame him—diplomas and credentials aligned in view. A throne behind the desk. Control. Boundaries. Patients kept outside Hadrian's Wall.

And Light's move forced Gold to cross it, exposing himself.

What the fuck?

"You've curated some striking pieces, Dr. Gold."

Gold grabbed his Ulysse notebook—a gift from Rachel—along with the intake folder, clipboard in hand as he crossed the room.

He perched awkwardly on the couch's edge, stealing a glance at Light.

I never sit on the couch.

Is this a power move?

"Thanks. My wife thinks it's gloomy for a psychologist's office."

"Not at all," Light replied. "I find it... stimulating."

His gaze drifted across the diplomas, prints, and sculptures—pausing deliberately on the cluttered shelf.

"Asherah—the old Canaanite goddess?" Light asked, nodding at the statuette.

Gold softened, genuinely impressed. "Yes. Keen eye. A gift from a patient."

"Fertility goddess. Let me guess—a gift from someone struggling to conceive? Clearly a success. I'm just a mythology nerd."

Most patients wouldn't catch that.

"Ah—*Nebuchadnezzar* and *Newton*. I've always loved Blake. Spent hours in the Blake rooms at the Tate."

His gaze flicked to the sculpture. "*Moore's Woman Seated in the Underground*. Michelangelo's *Slave*—perfect for a psychologist's office."

Gold stiffened.

Most patients noticed the art. Light was reading it.

“That bust—the woman in the T-shirt—she looks so... serene. Peaceful. Like nirvana. Calming.” He smiled. “I love how art draws emotion out of you.

“I don’t recognize the signature, but that balance of imagination and technique—that’s rare. People think symmetry in art is easy—it’s not. Especially in such an angelic face.”

Rachel.

He looked across the room. “That oil painting—who’s the artist? She’s clearly gifted. It reminds me of Seurat’s *Le Mouillage à Grandcamp*—but painted with Van Gogh’s 1888 Arles palette. Personally, I never bought the xanthopsia theory.”

Gold lit up. “My wife would love hearing that. She made both—the bronze and the painting. Van Gogh’s a favorite of hers.”

An art student... or collector.

“She said the office needed at least one bright spot. Painted it for my first anniversary in this space.”

Light noticed the stylized R in the lower corner. “R?”

“Rachel.”

“Just the initial. Interesting. As if the name wants to be present, but not fully seen.”

Gold said nothing.

Light looked back at the painting. “But she has a strong emotional range. The textures hold more than the colors admit. There’s balance, yes—but beneath it, sadness.”

He’s perceptive.

“Thank you. You really do know your art. I think it helps people relax. Open up.” He gestured toward the *Slave*. “That one puzzles some.”

Light pointed to the large wall print. “Pollock’s *Lucifer*—fantastic. It’s always felt personal.”

Interesting.

“I’m impressed. Most people guess Pollock—but no one recognizes *Lucifer*.”

Light grinned. He rubbed his hand, turning his ring. “It’s always meant something to me.”

*Definitely loaded. Worth revisiting—but not now.
This isn’t an art class.*

Gold shifted in his seat.

“Okay, Samuel—let’s begin.”

He handed Light the clipboard.

“There’s a basic info sheet and a couple of short questionnaires—just a snapshot. Then we’ll talk.”

Remember—don’t promise more than you can deliver.

Beneath the clip lay a ballpoint pen, a two-page intake form, and two brief assessments.

Light withdrew a Montblanc fountain pen from his jacket and began writing—slow, deliberate, precise. Form by form. Page by page. His penmanship evoked *shodō*—disciplined, balanced, ceremonial.

Gold seized the moment to study him more closely.

*Left-handed, like me... but his tie’s a half-Windsor.
Shoelaces tied right-handed. Ambidextrous? Athletic?
Balanced—or divided? Interesting.*

Gold leaned closer, eyes drawn to the ring. Its faint, angular markings teased familiarity.

Runes? Norse? Older still? I’ll ask later.

Heat prickled across his scalp. Light was watching him.

“Want to see it?” Light asked, already sliding it from his finger. “Here. Take a closer look.”

Gold hesitated, then took it.

He turned it slowly between his fingers, thumb grazing the grooves. Sweat beaded along his hairline; he prayed Light wouldn’t notice.

Light shrugged, feigning nonchalance. “Yeah. Had it forever.”
Gold handed it back. “Well... must be important.”

Please.

Light slid the ring back on, spinning it slowly. With each turn, calm returned—but the wrong kind: uneasy, suspicious, watchful.

*OCD? He was sweating the whole time I held it.
What’s he hiding... what’s it hiding?*

*Strange. There’s something about him. What is it?
He makes me think of Dad. Déjà vu again.*

Be careful.

Gold grabbed his notebook and leaned in. His pen felt heavy, as if resisting him.

He wrote just one word—stark, bold.

RING.

He circled it hard.

CHAPTER FIVE

An Anchor Chained to Your Heart

Nothing fixes a thing so intensely in the memory as the wish to forget it.
— Michel de Montaigne, *Essays* (1580)

Wednesday, evening

Light returned to the forms—paused just long enough to look up—then continued, mask firmly back in place.

*He knows exactly what it says. No question.
What's he hiding?*

“Do all your patients fill these out, Dr. Gold?”

“Yes, standard procedure. They often reveal more than you’d expect—insights, directions to explore.”

Light raised an eyebrow. “I expected conversation, not checkboxes. But hey—you’re the doctor.”

Gold bristled—it wasn’t curiosity, it was a challenge.

Heat crept up his neck. He hated that Light might notice.

*Ignore it. You’re the doctor. I don’t need to justify
my ways to him.*

Gold snapped his notebook closed and set it aside.

“Let me just turn the AC back on—it shuts off after six. Gets stuffy in here.”

He crossed to the thermostat. He could feel Light’s eyes boring into his back. He knew—he was losing the upper hand.

“You just about done?” he asked, a little too casually.

*Rachel hates it when I’m passive aggressive.
Brilliant, Dr. Gold—what the hell is wrong with me?
Don’t start off being an asshole. Ha. Even though I’ll*

probably end up being one.

“Just finished. Here you go.”

Gold took the papers and stood. Rather than return to the couch, he angled the desk-side chair toward Light.

Light slowly swiveled the club chair to face him.

Now Light faced what Gold wanted every patient to see: his degrees, books, curated artwork—a quietly constructed wall of authority.

Not the chair I prefer—but now his view is right.

He skimmed the intake form.

Referral: blank.

Occupation: Attorney, Senior Partner, Legion Law—
Appellate & Post-Conviction.

*I know that firm. White-collar crime central. Crooks
in suits—smug, polished sociopaths.*

He looked up. “Samuel, what’s your area of practice?”

“Criminal law,” Light said, his expression unchanged. “I used to try cases—juries, cross-exams, all of it. But now I focus on appellate and post-conviction work. These days I’m mostly buried in briefs and transcripts. Court is rare now, and I’m usually done by four, which makes evenings easier. Mostly I work with the wrongly convicted. They deserve an advocate.”

Gold nodded. “Impressive. Noble—an appeal to a higher court. God’s work.”

Light’s Montblanc slipped from his fingers, clattering softly on the floor. He bent to retrieve it, then tucked it into his suit pocket.

Gold noticed the mobile number and emergency contact lines were blank.

“You left some fields blank. I’ll need a number in case we reschedule—or if there’s a medical emergency. Completely confidential.”

Light shrugged lightly. “Oh, I believe you.” He leaned in, voice lowered. “Just got in from New York yesterday. Someone snagged my phone in the TSA line at JFK.”

“That’s annoying.”

Light nodded. “I’ll replace it tomorrow or Friday. New phone, new number—like starting over. Just haven’t had time to catch my breath yet.

“Coincidentally, last year, when I was in LA on business, my wallet was stolen.” He gave a dry laugh.

Gold chuckled. “If you were superstitious, you might worry about moving here. Someone—I forget who—said, ‘Coincidence is God’s way of remaining anonymous.’”

Light smiled faintly.

“I don’t know a soul here yet. But I’m healthy. Careful. Not superstitious.”

Likable. Polished. Something’s off beneath the surface—usually it’s fear.

“Not married. You mentioned your father. Still alive? Want to list him as your emergency contact?”

Light hesitated. “He’s alive. But we’re not on speaking terms.

“We worked together for a long time—many years. Then... disagreements. A total break. He threw me out. I left. Never went back.”

As he spoke, Light’s thumb turned his ring—slow, rhythmic, automatic.

“He’s a judge. I haven’t seen him in... ages. Given how long we’ve been estranged, it doesn’t really make sense to list him.”

He gave a tight, knowing smile. “I’m sure we’ll get into it—your specialty, right?” He punctuated it with a wink.

*What’s he hiding? Is he mocking me? Testing me?
Or something darker?*

Gold stayed silent. He knew that smile—the kind that shut a door just as it began to open. The wink locked it.

He’s smart, wily. I’m going to have my work cut out for me.

Gold wrote “Father” in the notebook.

Let it go... for now. But circle back—this matters.

He skimmed the SPS and PSI results. Nothing remarkable—no suicidal ideation, no red flags. Very minor elevations in Alienation and Discomfort—common, expected.

That bothered him most. It didn’t read like someone seeking therapy.

Rehearsed.

The college chair was deliberate—just uncomfortable enough to unsettle. Shifting in it now, he felt it doing its job. Scooting back in the chair, he tried to cross his legs. “Samuel, why don’t you start by telling me what brought you in today.”

Therapy is a stealth mirror. People flinch.

Light cleared his throat and said, “What brings me here. Hmm. It should be easy to answer.”

Gold said, “Take your time. Sometimes it’s not so easy to put into words. Especially when dealing with feelings.”

No one comes for the real reason.

Presenting problem—cover charge.

Countertransference. Emotional leakage.

Stay objective.

Light sat back casually glancing around the room.

“I’m not sure, Dr. Gold,” Light said softly. “I guess I’m not happy.”

Don’t jump in... not yet.

“Honestly... I don’t think I ever have been.”

He looked at Gold. “Maybe I’m naïve... wanting to feel wanted. Or loved.” Light sat back, as though he’d finished delivering finely rehearsed lines.

Rachel gets it. She reads people like novels. She remembers what’s happened—senses what’s coming. She’d have made a great therapist.

Empathic. Almost too sensitive for this world. Like that Don McLean line from “Vincent.”

And I barely qualify as sympathetic. I just mirror. They see my diplomas and assume I know. Assume I care. But I don’t. Not really.

I should’ve gone into medicine—pathology, maybe. No patients. No people. Just a microscope and the cold comfort of a final report, anchored in science.

He’d always told himself it was therapeutic necessity: objectivity, emotional neutrality, impartiality. In truth, it was just his nature—clinical detachment that bled into every relationship.

And it was getting worse.

Behind the mask of neutrality, faint echoes surfaced—flickers of feelings not fully his, not fully theirs.

Sometimes he imagined Carl Rogers—saint of unconditional positive regard—leaving sessions seething, feeling poisoned by all that restraint.

Gold’s method was different: no apologies. Don’t suppress your bias—face it. Own it. Use it.

His motto—*Figure it out and fix it*. Gold lived comfortably in black and white. But gray? Shadows? Not his domain.

Light continued, “People don’t know me. They have opinions—stories. About who I am.”

Gold nodded, feigning attentiveness. He often felt his thoughts were interrupted by his patients.

Nobody knows what I’m going through. Not even Bob.

Light leaned back, crossed one leg over the other, and exhaled slowly.

Rorschach logic. Ambiguity on ambiguity.

Gold held his breath.

Observe. Diagnose. Don’t expose.

Light’s fingers returned to the ring—as if guilt lived there,

coiled and dormant.

“All because of him.”

“Him?” Don’t interrupt. Let him explain it.

“I feel guilty. But I’m not a bad person. I shouldn’t feel this way. They make me feel like I did something... unforgivable.”

“They?”

He stared down at his shoes. “I’m not comfortable. I just want to feel normal.”

His hand returned to the ring—twisting it like a silent rosary of guilt.

“My father started that fire,” he said softly. “And he’s still feeding it.”

Gold said nothing.

His father. That didn’t take long.

Hanlon always said, Speak too soon and it’s all collisions—noise, static. Shut up and listen.

Silence pressed in. Gold didn’t trust it. His mind kept fidgeting.

But spontaneity dies when we wait our turn. Truth rarely survives that silence.

Gold leaned forward—thumb beneath his chin, forefinger curled over his lips. A gesture of self-restraint, pressing silence into his own face.

He spoke gently. “Go on.”

“We’ll get into the details later, I know. But growing up—my father made me do things. Things I knew were wrong. I couldn’t understand how he didn’t know. He had to know.

“They were sinister.” Pain crossed Light’s face—undeniable, unguarded.

What the hell?

Was this sexual abuse?

“I think he did know—didn’t care. That’s him. He knows everything. Really only cares about himself.”

His hands clenched—tight, white-knuckled.

“After what felt like forever, I couldn’t take it anymore. I left. Then I became the villain. Everything got pinned on me—like it was all my fault. That’s why I can’t look at him. I can’t even talk to him... not anymore. I’ve been misunderstood my whole life—because of him.”

And yet—you wear the ring. Forged from guilt itself.

What did you do?

“I know you worked with Dr. Carlyle at Cambridge. Thought maybe a little Freudian lineage could help with my father issues.”

Carlyle was upset I never took to his couch. He had suspicions.

“Just to be clear—I never wanted to kill him. I didn’t.”

He paused—then leaned in, just a little too close.

“But... if he’d asked me to?” Light hesitated. “I don’t know...”

“I might have.” And he gave another wink.

No father would ever put that on his son.

Gold shifted in his chair—uncomfortable.

Light continued. “If it’s not his idea? Forget it. If he says it’s good? It’s good.

“He’s a narcissistic, vindictive bully—controlling, sadistic, homophobic.”

Gay? Or accused of it?

“You probably think I’m being dramatic. I’m not. You don’t know him. But if you did—if you knew him like I do—you’d know he’s worse than all that.”

Hard to believe this is still the intake. Unreal.

“For years, I kept asking—why doesn’t he love me?”

Shouldn't a father's love be unconditional?"

Yes. Shouldn't it? But my father had his terms.

"Eventually, I realized—he only loves one person unconditionally: himself.

"He disgusted me. I hated him. I couldn't live with him—or work with him—any longer. I couldn't live in his world anymore. So I left."

Disgust is intimate. Hate even closer. It requires history, hope, effort.

You don't waste hate on strangers. You reserve it for someone you once wanted—needed—to love you.

But he's not ready for this yet.

He's wounded. Still searching for love, in spite of rejection.

The ring? A relic. A loop of unfinished grief. Tarnished hope.

"He saw it as betrayal. And because he's so egotistical, so vindictive—he made sure I took the fall."

Something's missing.

"I know I'm no saint. You can't be—when survival means obedience. I couldn't say no to anything he asked. I wanted to. I knew it was wrong. But saying no... to him... that just wasn't an option. He knew I'd do it. Choice was an *illusion*."

Choice. Always the word they use.

Let him talk. Don't dam the flood.

"My biggest flaw? Honesty. Odd, I know—for me—a criminal lawyer. But I swear, it's true. Everyone assumes I lie. But honesty—that's what ruined us. That's what ended me—with him."

Gold swallowed his urge to interrupt. "Mmm hmm," he murmured.

"He shifts it all onto me. I'm the fall guy—that way he keeps his halo—I've lost mine. I'm the evil one. The liar. The

troublemaker. They believe him—every time—they have to. If you knew what he made happen—what he ordered—you’d never dare question him. If I weren’t his son, I’d be dead.”

That escalated.

“You know this, Dr. Gold—it’s hypnosis. Repeat something often enough, from enough mouths, and no matter how insane, it becomes truth. *Their truth.*

“And the truth is—he’s insane. Arrogant. Egotistical. A megalomaniacal bastard.

“I never want to see him again.”

But here you are, still talking about him.

“They trust him. Blindly. Believe every word.

“Thinking’s harder. Question him—and you’re punished. Branded forever.

“Sorry, I know I’m ranting. But I swear—I’ve been honest.”

Maybe your truth. Honest—‘to the best of your knowledge,’ as your affidavits say.

Gold remained silent, fingertip whitening against his lips. The instinct to jump in—to interpret—held in check.

After the taut silence, Light stared—hungry for something: a nod, a flicker of belief, anything.

Facts feel secondary. Belief’s already doing the work.

Reconciliation? Is that his goal?

Not unless he’s open to seeing things differently. And this didn’t happen overnight.

Gold shifted forward and finally spoke. “Samuel, that’s a rare kind of self-awareness. Most people take weeks, months to open up like this. You seem to understand why you’re here. I appreciate your openness—it’s never easy.”

Don’t challenge him yet. Win him first.

Gold shifted in his chair. “I agree. Most people don’t want

the truth. Like *A Few Good Men*—they can’t handle it. Too uncomfortable.

“People prefer affirmation—even if it isn’t real. That’s confirmation bias. That’s why people gather their ‘truth’ from friends, echo-chamber podcasts, or their go-to network—anything that validates what they already believe. Birds of a feather. Nobody likes being challenged—especially fathers.”

Gold picked up the assessments again, flipping through them slowly. He double-checked the PSI’s Social Nonconformity score.

Normal. Minor elevations in Alienation and Discomfort—common enough.

Gold said, “People hate discord. You hear a bad note—you flinch. In music or in life, uncertainty sets nerves on edge. That’s anxiety: a future you can’t predict or control. A jigsaw puzzle with a missing piece—infuriating. Some people jam in the wrong one, just to feel whole. Pretend it’s complete.”

One reason for the high divorce rate.

“We crave closure. Ambiguity rattles the soul. We want resolution—no loose ends. To believe everything’s fine. Just... as it should be. It’s not unlike religion.”

Should I go here?

Light leaned forward, clearly interested.

Why not. He’s sophisticated enough.

“Belief is thinking you know. Faith is binary—on or off.

“Agnosticism? I’m not sure it truly exists.” He gave a faint smile.

“People either believe—or they don’t.”

Light raised a hand, gently objecting. “But Dr. Gold, a lot of people say they don’t know what God is.”

Gold nodded, energized. “Exactly! They believe—they just don’t comprehend. I don’t understand quantum physics, but I don’t doubt it exists. I accept it’s just beyond me—beyond my understanding.

“That’s why you can’t argue someone out of their religion—

it's baked in since childhood. Once someone believes, it's almost impossible to convince them they don't really know."

Light smiled knowingly.

Gold continued, "Hope is wanting to believe—even when the facts suggest otherwise. Wanting trumps knowing. No one wants to discover they're wrong—it creates cognitive dissonance, threatens belief. In their mind, it could unravel everything.

"So they double down. Everyone else is mistaken, misreading, or lying."

Light nodded in agreement.

Am I running too fast? No—he's still with me.

"We're judged by what we do. Intentions don't count. Only actions register."

Light's expression softened, a flicker of amusement surfacing. "Preaching to the choir, huh? That's my job too—juries for me, patients for you."

Gold gave a slight nod. "Exactly. We're told how to act—what to be. But we don't know what we really want, only what we're supposed to want. That gap? That's what drives the neurosis—questioning everything."

This is his hour—not mine. Save it for Bob. Wrap it up.

"You're right of course. And I do want to hear more about your father. You've shared a great deal already—we'll explore it, piece by piece."

What evil did he actually do?

"Samuel—and I apologize, I tend to talk too much—I'd like to revisit something. You used a powerful word: 'evil.' What do you mean by that? You said you were the evil one. Did you actually do something wrong, or were you just told you had?"

Shit. One question—not a list. Life's not a multiple-choice quiz. Don't hand him the answers. Make him earn them.

Light slouched back with a heavy exhale—something in him

collapsing.

“Everyone,” Light said softly. “Judged. Convicted. Sentenced.”

A grimace flickered across his face. His eyes—pained and distant—made him look smaller, older.

“I was told—commanded—to do things I knew were wrong. Morally wrong. I hurt people—people who didn’t deserve it.”

He swallowed hard. “I had no choice. I had to obey.”

“My father didn’t allow questions. But I knew—what he asked, what he commanded—was wrong. And I’m sure he knew it too.”

There he goes again—spinning that ring.

“A few times, I tried to fake it—pretend I’d done his bidding, hope he’d forget. But when I finally disobeyed... the punishment was severe.

“Even that didn’t bother me. I deserved it—for disobeying him. The punishments didn’t break me—I was used to them. I didn’t care about myself. I was numb.

“It was seeing others hurt—people I tried to protect. After a while, I couldn’t take it anymore. Too many people were getting hurt. So I stood up to him.”

*Severely punished? And he’s a criminal attorney.
Who the hell is his father—El Chapo?*

“I confronted him—and didn’t back down. I’d never seen him so furious. He never gave explanations. Just: ‘Do it. Because I said so.’”

Sounds familiar.

“But he lost it when I asked, ‘Who are you?’ He thundered, ‘I am!’ I said, ‘You are what? Look at yourself. Look at what you’ve become.’ He screamed, ‘You weren’t there! Where were you when I laid the foundation? You can’t understand.’

“There was no reasoning with him. And more people were going to get hurt. So I quit—I left for good. He blamed everything he’d commanded me to do—on me. It wasn’t fair. But I still feel

guilty. And I've felt like hell ever since."

Gold sat back, letting it all wash over him. He waited, but Light slumped forward, head bowed—dejected, drained.

Despair is no place to pause. Time for something positive. Hopeful.

Light sat silently. Waiting.

Win him over. Give him hope. Be human. Be kind.

My problem. My curse of knowledge—everyone thinks you know... and you don't.

Gold inhaled deeply, held it briefly, then released it slowly. He leaned forward, locking his focus on Light's deep blue eyes.

"Thank you, Samuel. I appreciate your honesty. I'm sorry you went through that—it sounds harrowing. I don't know the specifics, but the fact that you held yourself together... that says a lot. Nobody grows up without scars. And the emotional kind? They cut deeper than flesh—and rarely heal completely.

"Guilt isn't what most people think. It masquerades as one thing—but there are two kinds, and the difference matters.

"First, there's true guilt. You've done something wrong, you know it, and others do too. That's the guilt you *should* feel—it belongs to you. It reflects reality."

Light accepted this with a slight nod.

"Guilt is an anchor, chained to your heart—silent, heavy, inescapable. You feel it physically, dragging you down. You can withdraw, hide, even run away—but it stays with you. When you try to make amends, it always lingers.

"And even when you forgive yourself, you always have the scars.

"So the goal isn't always to escape the weight. Sometimes it's just learning how to carry it."

Okay. Give him a minute to let that sink in. Looks like he's following.

"Then there's neurotic guilt—the kind that creeps in when you're blamed for something that wasn't your fault. When someone

tells you it's your fault—or makes you feel like it. You know it isn't, but you feel like crap anyway. Being blamed for something you didn't do—or never intended—is the kind of crazy-making that breaks people. You *feel* guilty—because someone told you that you are. That you *should* be.”

Light nodded in agreement but said, “No disrespect, Dr. Gold—but you say that like someone who's never had to carry it.”

Gold bristled, flushed slightly, and shifted uncomfortably on the couch. “I'm talking clinically. Everyone suffers at its hands, by its weight.”

I'm trying to stay detached, but guilt is glue.

Inherited guilt—my father's silence.

Neurotic guilt—Jane's shadow.

Jane's shadow wasn't memory so much as atmosphere.

A living room—too many people, too much wine. The brunch after his and Rachel's engagement party.

Laughter spilling over itself. Glasses clinking. Everyone watching everyone else.

Jane had dropped onto the couch beside him—near enough to register, not near enough to accuse.

Bare shoulder brushing his sleeve. Coincidental. Of course.

He didn't move away.

“So,” she said, smiling without warmth, eyes already scanning the room. “You're a psychiatrist.”

“Psychologist,” he corrected her.

“Makes sense. You have that air.”

She shifted—just slightly—her bare thigh, exposed beneath her mini-skirt, pressed against him.

Not enough to draw notice. Enough to register.

“I feel at ease, comfortable, like I'd be willing to... open up completely.”

He'd glanced at Rachel across the room—radiant, claimed, unassailable.

Jane followed his gaze and laughed softly. “Relax. I’m not trying to steal anything.”

He flushed.

A pause. Then, lightly: “I already know who wins.”

She crossed her legs—slow, deliberate. For him? For the room? For the men who noticed. For the women who pretended not to.

“I just like knowing I could,” she added. Almost kindly.

It wasn’t really a flirtation—more of a wager.

He’d said nothing. He’d been in that seat before. Stayed too long then, too.

Silence this time.

Later, Rachel would ask, casually, “Jane talk to you much?”

And he would answer, truthfully and falsely, “Not really.”

Now the memory returned with surgical clarity.

Not her sexuality—but what it was trying to buy.

Gold blinked, back in the room. Light was watching—too still, too alert—

as if he’d felt the shift.

“You try to fix it, but nothing changes. That’s when guilt becomes a trap—no off-ramp, no exit. You keep trying to fix it. But fix what, how? You didn’t break it. That’s what drives you mad.”

Light nodded again, slowly.

“We start to doubt everything—especially ourselves. Maybe we don’t even know ourselves. Maybe we can’t trust ourselves. So how do we make amends? How do we fix it?”

“Why do we still feel awful after apologizing? Because manipulation keeps changing the rules while we’re still trying to play.”

Light nodded. “Yes.”

Good.

“That’s the breeding ground for neurosis. It becomes a

scream in your unconscious—What did I do wrong? I can't live like this. So we grasp for relief—but it never comes. Apologizing doesn't fix it. We start hiding from ourselves."

Rachel, the only one who ever tried to unchain me by believing in me. By loving me.

Gold cleared his throat. "Some believe guilt is the prime mover—the great engine of human action. I'm not sure I'd go that far. But guilt? It makes people act—or freeze."

He's with me. Good. Emotions are resonating—but don't overload him. Let it breathe another minute.

"Feelings happen to us—we don't choose them.

"But emotions... emotions are what we do with them. Often automatically."

Check in—keeping up?

"Does that make sense to you? Is this too much at once?"

Light nodded. "No, it's not too much. It's cerebral—but it makes sense. Sounds like mine's neurotic guilt. I can't seem to let go, so how do I make it stop?"

A great question—if his hands are clean. But nobody's are spotless.

"First step: name what you feel. Therapy is language and honesty; without words, feeling stays trapped in the body.

"When we say we 'know how someone feels,' we're guessing—reading cues, not minds. Someone says something cruel. I feel hurt. I respond—with anger, sarcasm, withdrawal, maybe tears.

"If you did something wrong—objectively—you have to confront that guilt. If your guilt is earned, you're serving time—for a real crime. The work then is redemption. But if you were made to feel at fault for something you didn't do, then my job is to help you respond—not with symptoms—but with clarity."

Light sat upright, attentive—as if in a classroom.

Okay. The horse is dead. Enough.

I can hear Oster saying, "Lecture less and listen

more.”

Ha. Guess I didn't listen... to him.

“Sorry—bit of a firehose moment. Old habits. I taught psych once—long ago. Hope that all made sense. I just wanted to define terms—to show you how I work.

“Take a breath. Sit with your thoughts. Your feelings aren't wrong. They just... *are*. They're real. They're valid.”

Gold paused for a moment, then continued. “You said you were called the ‘*evil one*.’ I'd like to understand that—if you're willing. Why do they see you that way? What did you do—or what did they think you did?”

What things did you do?

“It's normal to feel uneasy. This is all new. I'm new. Take your time. Be real. Be honest. I'm listening.”

Light's knee bounced. His fingers spun the ring—restless, compulsive.

“Thank you, Dr. Gold,” Light said. “I appreciate it—I really do. I think I followed it all. It makes sense.”

He paused.

His voice dropped, barely a whisper. “And now... I feel guilty.

Not because I lied.”

He glanced down.

“I told you the truth. But I left something out.” He bowed his head, fingers clenched on the armrest. The air thickened—heavy with what was coming.

Gold leaned forward, heart clenched. One finger curled over his lips—the listening pose. A silent vow: just listen.

Light slumped forward. The overhead light painted him like a chiaroscuro portrait—half-lit, half-lost, suspended between confession and concealment.

He stopped spinning the ring.

His voice barely escaped—a whisper.

“My real name is... Satan.”

CHAPTER SIX

Sympathy for the Devil

If the devil doesn't exist, but man has created him, he has created him in his own image.

— Fyodor Dostoevsky, *The Brothers Karamazov* (1880)

Wednesday, late evening

What the fuck?

*Don't overreact. Probably a metaphor. Just clarify.
Why Satan? Challenge him—gently.*

“Your parents named you... Satan?”

Light's expression shifted. He looked down, twisted the ring on his finger. Then, almost inaudibly: “My Father... I never had a mother.”

Gold blinked. His breath caught.

He's serious? No—a nickname. No one names a kid Satan. And “I never had a mother”? Abuse? Abandonment? Death?

This session just got longer.

Gold leaned in, the listening pose. He exhaled—slow, steady, neutral. “Please continue.”

He jotted—quickly:

***Estranged from father. Maternal absence?
PPD?***

Light looked up, locking his deep blue eyes on Gold. “I’m sorry, Dr. Gold. I’ve shaken you. I can only imagine what you’re writing. Please—humor me. Before you prescribe pills or pass me off—I’m not crazy. Just upset.”

Okay, not crazy. So... metaphor.

But I blew it. Shit. I have to win him back.

“How can you be listening... if you’re busy writing?”

“I’ve done the research. I came to you because you might be the only one who can actually understand. And help.”

Tread carefully. This is too fast.

Gold closed his notebook and slid it—along with his pen—behind him on the black-lacquered desk. He turned toward Light—fully now—locking onto those deep blue eyes.

“So... you don’t really believe you’re the Devil?” he said, scanning for flickers—body language, tension, tells.

Gold noticed the fine crow’s feet, the stray gray hairs.

“No—I didn’t say ‘the Devil.’ I said ‘Satan.’ There’s a difference.

“I thought you’d be the one... but you don’t understand.”

Light seemed to age mid-sentence. His voice faltered—softened. He looked... defeated.

His dark blue eyes brimmed; he fought the tears.

Gold leaned forward and—uncharacteristically—placed a hand on Light’s knee.

“Stop reaching out to dead authors,” Oster had said. “Reach out your hand.”

Light twitched. “I’m not asking for sympathy, Dr. Gold—just understanding.”

Where the hell did that come from? Sympathy? Or something else?

What the hell is going on with me?

He didn't touch patients—except for handshakes. Once, he'd hugged a woman overjoyed to be pregnant.

"You're right—I don't understand. But I hope you'll help me. I can see I hurt you, Samuel, and I'm sorry. I was listening—truly.

"I jot notes so I don't interrupt. It helps me stay with you.

"You had—and still have—my full attention. Please go on."

I've never done that before. It felt like I needed to touch... something. Maybe his soul. But his leg—it felt hot. Am I falling into his delusion?

Gold hated talking about himself. Not with patients. Not even with Bob Oldman—his therapist, his best friend.

Steven Gold didn't dance—literally or metaphorically.

He loved accolades from afar; up close, they embarrassed him.

Lately, he had begun to suspect how much of himself was performance: a tailored suit, borrowed insight, and the hope no one noticed the seams.

I can't let Rachel down.

He remembered Dr. Oster. "You've got instincts. Strong analysis. But Perls would eat you alive. He'd force you to use the one pronoun you dodge like the plague—'I.'

"Your clients come to you unsteady, unsure—afraid they can't stand on their own, or that they'll need help for a while to do so.

"Used wisely, your steady, reassuring hand shows them you understand—because you've been there. Because you can help.

"It makes you human. Stop being 'Dr. Gold.' Try being Steven."

I've never liked being Steven. I'm not sure I even know who he is. "Dr. Gold" is comfortable. Safe.

No one knows what I'm going through. Hell—I'm not even sure I do.

I'm losing Rachel.

His eyes swelled. Vision blurred. He stared—dazed, as if

into a mirror. Then he realized—he was looking at Light. Staring back. Concerned.

“Dr. Gold... are you okay?”

Gold wiped at tears he hadn’t realized were there. “Yes. I’m sorry. I see your pain—and I’ve felt it too. I apologize.”

I guess this is what real self-disclosure feels like. I’m not sure I’m ready. But I feel for him. I remember how much my father’s approval meant. I still light his yahrzeit candle every year. Losing him ... like that... it was brutal. I couldn’t help him, but I forced myself to be there.

Back in the room!

“So... not the Devil—Satan. I’m sorry, I don’t understand the difference.”

“I’ll explain. But first—I need to see the battlefield. Are you religious?”

Battlefield?

Gold flinched at the word. He scrambled through half-buried memories of religious school, old texts, images of Satan and the Devil.

He knew: *Satan* meant adversary. Accuser. But the only reference he could recall from Hebrew scripture was Job—and he often mixed up the biblical Job with Milton’s and Blake’s.

Job. Milton. Blake. Shit.

Realizing Light was still watching him, Gold answered—more embarrassed than he wanted to admit.

“I don’t see how that’s relevant... but what exactly do you mean by, ‘battlefield?’”

Light leaned in, eyes narrowed sharp.

“I need to see the battlefield. Know what beliefs I’m up against. Where do you stand? I’m guessing you’re not very religious—but you never really know.”

*I hope this doesn’t turn into a theological debate.
If I tell him I’m an atheist... will he get*

uncomfortable? Will I?

*Well, Dr. Oster, looks like you're getting your wish.
I'm stepping outside my comfort zone—just not in front
of a firing squad.*

“Jewish, but not religious. I light yahrzeit candles for my parents—that’s about it.”

Light stayed silent.

Gold hesitated. “I suppose I’m an atheist.”

A montage hit him—his childhood neighbor screaming he killed Jesus, his tenth-grade girlfriend sobbing because he was doomed to Hell, the fury he felt toward God—because his father died, and because Rachel couldn’t have children.

Light smiled. “I thought so.”

Gold flushed at Light’s certainty.

“I’m sorry if I’ve embarrassed you. It just seemed to fit. I mean seriously—Dr. Steven Gold... of course you’re Jewish.

“That’s okay. I’m Jewish too.”

What?

“This works better. I’d have had a hard time if you’d been raised Catholic—with all that dogma about me.”

Gold blinked like he’d taken a hit—shaken off a concussion. It wasn’t what Light said—it was his face. The way it changed. A weight lifted.

Light straightened. His eyes widened. Suddenly energized—engaged. Animated.

Gold cleared his throat, re-centering. “I’m curious... what does my admitting I’m Jewish tell you?”

*Admitting? Why the hell did I say that? I’m not
embarrassed.*

“First, it shows you trust me. You didn’t just parrot me back.

“It also tells me that you probably don’t know much about me—besides maybe the story of Job, and what the movies brainwashed you to think—*Rosemary’s Baby*, *The Exorcist*, *The Devil’s*

Advocate.

“Am I wrong?”

Mostly true. Except Cantor’s “Myths of Creation.”

“Somewhat true. What I know so far—you’re estranged from your father. And your mother? You won’t even go there.

“You feel maligned—probably because of something that happened while working for your father—a family business. Maybe you left. Maybe you were kicked out.

“My beliefs—religious or not—shouldn’t matter. I won’t let them get in the way of this relationship.”

*Sounded good, but who am I kidding?
Psychotherapy is moral philosophy in disguise.*

*Everything I say comes colored—beliefs, values,
biases. That’s the truth of this work.*

“It’s clear you have some serious parental wounds. I can help you explore them. Maybe resolve them—through change or acceptance.

Good. Reasserting control now.

“But it depends on your goals. What do you want from therapy?”

Light’s mood shifted again. His jaw clenched and his eyes seemed to flash with anger.

Uh oh. He’s pissed.

“You don’t believe me. You think I’m just another nut who needs a steady lithium level.”

Don’t hesitate.

“Not at all. I can see you’re serious—about how people react to you. Maybe even about how you see yourself.

“But I think you stay in control by keeping others off balance.

“The problem is, when you throw everyone else off balance, you’re the one who looks off-kilter—the one who stands out. Looks strange.”

Am I talking about him—or projecting me?

“Of course, this is Southern California. You’ve got more leeway. Being ‘eccentric’ is fine. But telling people your name is Satan? Most will think you’re a religious Satanist, some burned-out post-hippie, or just a professional shit-stirrer—like you said people accuse you of being.

“And honestly? A trial attorney named Satan? That’s a little too cinematic—even for LA.”

Gold paused, letting it settle.

He felt a new confidence—he was starting to get a handle on this. On Light. Light was sharp. No doubt he’d follow every word.

Careful. Wounded animals cornered strike fast.

Okay. Brace yourself. Fireworks coming.

“So... how can I actually help you?”

Light’s eyes flared. “You’re still not hearing me. I’m not saying I’m called Satan. I’m not saying I *identify* as Satan. I *am* Satan.”

He seemed normal. Still does. What the hell did he just say? Is this even real?

“Just to be clear—you’re not saying that you *feel* like Satan. You’re saying that you *are* Satan. The biblical Satan?”

“Yes. I am Satan.”

Light exhaled, shaking his head. “You don’t understand. No one does. No one can. No one knows what I’m going through.”

He leaned back, eyes on the ceiling, hand brushing his lips. Then, softly: “They distorted the stories. Twisted the truth. But I was there.”

Is this a game? A delusion? A test?

Light leaned in, gaze fixed. “Tell me, Dr. Gold... when’s the last time you doubted your own reality?”

Gold hesitated. His hands felt... wrong. Cold.

Desperation.

Gold swallowed. “Okay. So you believe you are Satan.”

Clearly angry. “Not believe, Dr. Gold. I *know*!”

If he really believes this, I should refer him out. You don't argue someone out of psychosis. First, find what the belief is protecting. But—Satan?

“I’m sorry, Samuel. But I don’t know. As an atheist, I hope you’ll understand—this isn’t easy for me to make sense of.”

“Even in just this short time, I can see why you’re upset. Frustrated. Sad.”

“You said you’re estranged from your father... and you haven’t mentioned your mother. I had my own issues with my parents
—”

Gold caught himself.

“Everyone does. I’d just like to understand what brought you here. That’s how I’ll know how to help.”

Where the hell did that come from? Hopefully he missed it.

Let it land. I'm being sympathetic—trying to connect. This won't get solved in one night.

I just need his trust. For a little while.

Sink the hook... then reel.

Light leaned in, locked his eyes with him, and said—dead serious:

“Dr. Gold, I’m not estranged from my mother. I never had one.

“I *am* Satan. But, as I said, not the biblical version. The Bible got it wrong. I was part of God’s heavenly court, but...”

Gold’s eyes flicked upward—a reflex.

“Of course it sounds crazy. I get that. But now—I’m telling you the whole truth.”

“I didn’t say the honest-to-God truth... because, well—He’s the root of all my problems. God’s truth is part of the problem.

“From your atheist point of view, Dr. Gold, I’m just a myth—

dismissed. Certainly not a real, living person.

“Sounds like the setup for a horror novel, right? Or some fevered fantasy.

“But I promise you—I’m no comic book character.”

Light was wound tight. He sat back, shoulders taut, trying to settle himself.

“Dr. Gold, you said you’re not religious. That belief is ‘thinking you know.’ That no one can be reasoned out of religion.

“You’re a psychologist. You try to talk people into normalcy. So you know the power of logic. Of reason.

“I know this doesn’t seem logical. Probably feels completely unreasonable. And the fact that you think you don’t believe in God? That makes it even harder for me to prove I’m not lying—or insane.”

What does he mean—‘think’ I don’t believe in God?

“Faith is believing without evidence. Believing *in spite* of the evidence—that’s fanaticism.

“Here’s my offer. Call it a *Gedankenexperiment*.”

Light leaned forward, eyes glinting as if a cross-exam were about to begin.

“Suppose Satan were real. Suppose he sat here—in the defendant’s chair, under oath. How would you treat him, Dr. Gold? Not as metaphor. Not as myth. As your patient.”

He paused, letting the silence weigh like a judge’s gavel.

“That’s my stipulation. You don’t argue the fact pattern—you work with it. Can you do that... Counselor?”

Gold exhaled—a dry laugh, caught halfway between disbelief and defense.

Light smiled, savoring the moment.

“Don’t worry—I won’t make you sign in blood. I deal in contracts, not covenants. This time.”

The grin widened, courtroom wit shading into something darker. “Consider it a verbal agreement—binding, nonetheless.”

Am I enabling him? Playing along with a delusion—

or witnessing its logic?

Fine. Let him run. His dime. I'll play along.

If I listen close enough—maybe I'll hear what's really broken.

What myth he's recasting.

“What do you think, Dr. Gold? Can we stipulate—and leave it alone?”

“C'mon—this has to get your intellectual juices flowing, right?”

“Think of the case study you could write. I could be your ‘Anna O.’ I honestly believe you can help me.”

Gold straightened, trying to maintain his clinical calm.

“I read that Atlantic piece, Dr. Gold. You've got a style—an approach. Interesting speculation about the unsolved St. Augustine murderer. And your background with Dr. Carlyle. I think you work for me. That's good. You already have my trust. I'm motivated. I want your help. Just treat me like any other patient... any other *mortal* patient.”

His lips curled into a knowing half-smile. That was all. But the silence afterward felt loaded.

Gold paused, mulling it over.

“Okay, Samuel—so stipulated. I won't cure you of your belief—sorry, your identity as Satan. But you'll have to cut me some slack. Never studied this in class.”

Light's lips curved in approval. “Objection sustained. Thanks, Dr. Gold. That's all I ask.”

That—and my soul?

Too soon.

“I'll treat you like any other patient. But I may need context. Background. Clarification.”

Light smiled. “Don't worry—I won't cure you of your atheism. Though you might change your mind.”

I'm feeling better about this.

He's right. This could be a hell of a case study.

Gold smiled faintly. "Okay. I'll keep an open mind—but it might be a waste of your time and money. Many have tried. All failed.

"Speaking of time and money..."

"I usually start with two sessions a week for the first two weeks. Then we reassess and build a plan."

"Sounds reasonable. I prefer late afternoons or early evenings. My trials rarely run past four."

"Today's Wednesday. How about Tuesdays and Thursdays—say, 5:00 or 5:30?"

Light stood, smiling wide. "Perfect. Tuesdays and Thursdays at five." He extended his hand. "What do I owe you for today?"

"I charge \$400 an hour—plus \$100 today for the testing."

Gold avoided eye contact, feeling the flush rise. Like most therapists, he hated the fee talk. But he reminded himself—Light probably billed his own clients \$1,000 an hour or more.

Light pulled a money clip from the inner pocket of his jacket.

"Cash okay? No card fees, right?"

Gold nodded, still visibly uneasy.

"Yes—of course." Gold fidgeted with Light's forms—a distraction. "Would you like a bill for insurance?"

Light handed him five crisp \$100 bills and extended a hand.

"No need. As you might guess, a lot of my clients pay in cash. I don't ask where it comes from. And, well—since it's a privileged conversation, I'll admit... I don't always report it." Light grinned—pure mischief.

"Don't worry—I've got scruples. No offense, but my insurance pays crap for therapy. Eighty percent of \$25, after the deductible. Not even worth the paperwork."

Light turned to go, then glanced back. A final grin. A final wink.

"Whether you report it or not? That's on you. See you tomorrow, Dr. Gold!"

Light raised his hand—thumb and forefinger shaping a loose pistol.

He didn't blink. Didn't move. Just held it. Then—click. Soft. Deliberate.

“Okay. See you then. Take care.”

There it was again—the ring, gleaming beneath the barrel like a coiled serpent. Not a trigger. Not a warning. Just... waiting. As if the thing itself were watching.

CHAPTER SEVEN

Paradoxical Sleep

*I dreamed I was a butterfly, flitting around in the sky; then I awoke.
Now I wonder: Am I a man who dreamt of being a butterfly,
or a butterfly dreaming that I am a man?
— Zhuangzi, Zhuangzi (circa 4th century BCE)*

Wednesday, night

Gold punched in the alarm code. Quickly. He hadn't called Rachel when the session was over. He'd sensed something—anger. Disappointment.

What is it this time?

He noticed a note taped to the key bowl on the entry table. It read:

Steven—You could have called or texted. Guess you were working. I'm going to sleep. Leftover chicken in the refrigerator. —R

Shit. She's pissed. Not even a "Love, Rach." I told her not to wait. Eat dinner. Watch TV. She doesn't like being told what to do. And I keep doing it anyway.

He yanked out his iPhone and opened the Messages app. The message was still there—unfinished. Unsent:

Sorry Rach, I have to run a new patient, I'll be late. Watch Rogue's Gallery without me. I'll grab dinner later. I'll see it on DVR. Sorry. Lo

Crap. The fucking Ring doorbell distracted me—I never hit send. She won't believe me now. And maybe she shouldn't.

Thank God I deleted that video. If she knew Jane had been there—if her perfume had drifted through the hallway—I'd be dead.

He dropped his keys in the bowl, tapped “STAY” on the alarm, and walked into the kitchen.

He stared into the open refrigerator for a few moments, scanning its contents.

A chill ran through him—eerily like the one he'd felt in his office before meeting Light.

He shook it off, took a few bites of cold chicken, grabbed an apple and bottle of water.

Leaning on the kitchen counter, he replayed the day—strange. Unsettling.

Szasz said, “If you talk to God, you're praying. If God talks to you, you have schizophrenia.” Does that hold for the Devil?

If he's not Satan, he's crazy. If he is Satan—I'm crazy. Tough call.

Why Satan?

And that ring—every time he mentioned his father, he fidgeted with it. It's from his father—sentimental. But he wouldn't tell me what it said.

What's it mean?

He wrestled with questions.

Is Light more disturbed than I thought? Pranking me? A Satanist?

What did I miss? PPD doesn't fit. No hallucinations, no delusions. Not psychosis.

And that “religious Jew?” question—that threw me. Intentional?

Still... there's something about him. I feel sympathetic. Maybe even attraction.

Why do I get embarrassed around him? He's so

confident—then suddenly wounded.

“Satan”... is he just fucking with me?

Fine. He’s Satan. Let him run with it. Wherever he goes, the real issues will surface—they always do.

I won’t be Torquemada. But I’ll hold his feet to the fire. If he’s Satan, he’ll enjoy it.

I need to know what his father made him do—whatever the hell it was, it’s serious. And why won’t he even mention his mother? What did she do... or let happen?

Shit. Am I ready for this? Something’s coming—something big. I need to be ready.

Since he was being paid in cash, with no insurance trail, Gold decided to keep it off his books—just like Light suggested.

He opened Calendar and renamed “Light Session” to “Bible Study.”

No one questions religion.

Apple core and water bottle discarded, he headed for the bedroom, easing the door open without a sound.

In the bathroom, he trod carefully over the creaking tongue-and-groove floors. He shut the door, switched on the light—

What the—fuck?

A face stared back from the mirror.

He jolted, nearly knocking over the glass candle on the sink. Only his reflection.

Oh shit.

He caught his breath and stared. The man in the mirror looked... off. Unfamiliar. Not quite right.

Not good when you don’t recognize yourself in a mirror. He looked again—then turned away.

He used the bathroom quietly, put the seat down on his way out, but flushed the toilet, automatically.

Dammit. Hope that didn't wake her.

Knowing the closet would wake Rachel, he undressed in the bathroom—shoes by the tub, suit and tie on the hook, shirt on the floor.

It's gotta go to the cleaners anyway.

He brushed his teeth, but couldn't find a glass—so he cupped his hands under the faucet. As he raised the water to his mouth, he dribbled foamy toothpaste down his chest and onto his boxers.

Shit.

He grabbed a towel and dabbed at his chest and damp boxers.

Screw it—sleep nude.

He tossed the towel and boxers in the hamper. Then, in darkness, eased open the bathroom door into the pitch-black bedroom.

Pitch black. Photophobic—no nightlights. Thanks, Rach.

He guided himself with the faint glow of his Apple Watch, swimming through shadow, like a diver through ink.

He looked at watch. 64% battery—no need to charge. He liked the “Sleep” feature—it tracked his REM cycles. He usually woke after each dream, determined to remember them—though he rarely did. Ever since his sophomore class, *Sleep and Dreams*—he'd kept a journal. Each morning, he read the vivid, unfamiliar entries—in handwriting that barely looked like his own. Alien.

He moved quietly to his side of the bed.

In the watch's faint glow, Rachel lay on her back, half-covered by the sheet. The comforter lay bunched at the bed's center. He pulled back the covers on his side and slowly sat.

He just wanted to look at her.

No nightlight. Even the alarm panel LED was

taped over. Pitch black. Rachel's migraines made even small light feel accusatory.

Even after his eyes accommodated, the room was still black—an ethereal black—as if looking through layers of dark gossamer veils.

Leaning on his left side, he angled the glow of his watch away from her. She wore her soft eye cover—a strip of navy fabric, once part of a baby blanket, draped over her eyes to mask light from any intrusions.

Wow. Even angry, she's perfect. Forty-one—she could easily pass for thirty-one. I really hit the jackpot. And everyone loves her. They put up with me just to be near her. Almost enough to make me believe in God.

My Helen. My Galatea...

Or my Pandora?

He watched her chest rise and fall with each soft breath, steady as a tide. She loved how soft the fabric felt—threadbare from hundreds of washings. The worn collar of his old fraternity T-shirt fell away slightly, revealing the gentle swell of her breast.

She wears it because she still loves me.

I think... I hope.

He leaned closer, drawing a deep inhale through his nose. Her scent—Black Orchid—wrapped him in memory.

I wish I could make love to her now—feel her soft skin with my lips, my cheek.

His gaze lingered on the soft curve of her left breast, half-veiled by the shirt's torn edge—as if retreating, shy, into shadow. Hiding. Calling him like a siren's song.

His heart raced. He felt himself stiffen.

Bad timing.

He gently pulled the sheet up, covering her chest and arm. He turned off the light on his watch, rolled carefully, and nudged the comforter into the middle.

He slid an AirPods into his left ear, reaching for his phone. He opened YouListen and searched: “Satan.” He scrolled and selected “Satan in Milton’s Paradise Lost.”

He set the volume barely audible and started the 15-minute sleep timer.

He set iPhone down—clock glowing simply—and rolled onto his right side to sleep.

Gold turned over and stretched out his left leg—then froze. His bare foot poked into the air—uncovered. He jerked it back beneath the sheet and lay still. A childhood fear—one that never left. Objectively, he knew nothing could touch his outstretched foot.

I know it’s crazy. Impossible. But—what if? What if something touched my leg? Even the tiniest chance terrifies me. That’s why drugs scare me. I’d go looking for something—and find it.

Hell, I’m already fucked up. I can’t even swim in the pool at night.

He drifted off within minutes.

That night brought dreams—vivid, disturbing.

In the first, Gold saw his father, Gerald—bathed in cold bluish-white light. Wearing street clothes, Gerald lay on an ER table, bleeding from the side of his head. Two doctors and a nurse moved frantically around him. One doctor—tall, in green scrubs—wore a dark red pocket square. The heart monitor beeped steadily beneath the chaos.

One of them shouted “Defib—clear!”

The beeping stopped.

Then—it was him.

The tall doctor pressed the paddles to his chest. A bolt of electricity slammed through him—his body convulsed violently.

“Clear!” Again. Another jolt—like a mule’s kick.

The shorter doctor leaned in—stethoscope on chest. “No suh. Nuthin’.” Then he slammed a fist into Gold’s chest—like a sledgehammer.

“Bag him!” he shouted, pounding Gold’s chest.

The tall doctor leaned in. Piercing blue eyes. He winked. Then came the hands—smothering his mouth, driving his head into the pillow.

Gold flailed, gasping. His own hands clawed at the ones pressing down—desperate for breath.

The doctor leaned in harder, putting his full weight on Gold’s face.

Straining for breath, Gold peeled back a finger—there was a ring beneath the glove.

“He’s not breathing—crack him open!” The short doctor sliced open his chest—like warm butter.

Still breathless, he saw the doctor’s hands—bloody, trembling—holding his heart.

“That’s wicked dahk—deep puhpul. Haha, ‘Smoke on the Wahtah.’ I’m callin’ it—12:58.”

A blinding white light exploded.

Then—his father’s whistle, distant and echoing. “Steven! This way!”

But he was walking the other way—away from the voice, toward the dark.

Gold jolted awake, eyes clenched, drenched in cold sweat.

He opened his eyes. Rachel lay asleep on her side, facing away, softly whistling with each inhale. She hadn’t heard his thrashing—her foam earplugs blocked everything.

He checked his Apple Watch: 12:58.

12:58.

Jesus—that was intense.

Gold often had nightmares but never told Rachel. Famous psychologists weren’t supposed to fear their own dreams—and he feared losing her respect.

Even with vivid nightmares, he rarely fixated once awake. He usually shrugged them off by morning. But he’d always share them with Oldman, who took them seriously.

“People spend six full years of life dreaming,” Oldman once said. “Seven, eight percent, Stevie. Why ignore that?”

I need to tell Bob about this one—he was in it.

He flipped his wet pillow to the dry side, grabbed his notepad and penlight, and jotted down everything he could recall. Careful not to wake Rachel, he used his left arm to shield her from the penlight’s glow.

Finished writing, he rolled onto his left side, swapped AirPods, and reached for his iPhone to restart YouListen. He started it from the top—he’d fallen asleep so fast last time, he remembered nothing.

Again, he was asleep within minutes.

About an hour later, Gold fell into another dream.

He was walking with Jane Sanders and his college roommate, Bill Shane. They’d just left the Fogg Art Museum. The bitter wind stung his face. Yet the sky was bright blue, the sun a harsh yellow.

A Ring doorbell chimed. Wait—Jane didn’t even know Bill... or him, back then.

I’m dreaming. Stay inside it.

Look at your hands.

Gold quickly looked at his hands.

Thick black snow gloves.

He heard their voices, Jane’s boots on cobblestone. They were heading down Prescott toward Harvard Street—Pennypacker Hall.

Stop. Just stop walking.

He stopped—but they kept walking, still chatting like he was with them.

Gold’s eyes followed Jane’s tight jeans—thin thighs, that perfect ass.

I’ll call them—see if they react. Or, if this is just me.

“Bill, Jane—Wait up!” Bill didn’t stop. But Jane spun around. A scent of Orchid filled his nostrils.

Her gray hair whipped around—no, blonde. It was blonde. Her breasts jiggled beneath the blouse. Then—her necklace. The diamond infinity one.

That's Rachel's necklace.

Not Jane. Rachel

He tried to look at her face, but couldn't—eyes locked on the necklace, nestled in her cleavage. A gold infinity loop, shaped like a Möbius strip—with channel-set diamonds and a single sapphire tucked just above the left loop.

Rachel always wears that. Skin—perfect. Hair—perfect. Her tits—Jesus. So why's she always so sad?

He looked up—her eyes were scowling. Angry.

“Jane? Looking for Jane? Sorry to disappoint.”

I've got to turn this. My hands. Focus—my hands.

He looked down—his hands—trying to stay lucid. Too late.

Only a spectator now.

The snow gloves vanished—replaced by thick, fur-lined leather. The left slipped off. But the right caught—something tight around his finger.

He tugged—leather scraped, resisted—until a final, violent snap sent him soaring.

Weightless. Unmoored.

Strings dangled—or sprouted—from his chest.

The beach.

Children ran laughing below, tugging his string. He was the kite.

Pelicans soared past, diving into the blue Pacific.

Wind roared like a subway—loud, warm.

Sunlight bathed his skin—warm, steady.

Queasy now. Air sick.

One pelican—black, shadowy—flew straight at him. It flapped, hovering—then started pecking the strings at his chest.

The children below shrieked—crying, panicked.

The child holding the string—familiar. It was him—three-year-old Stevie.

He looked down at little Stevie. Tears streamed down his face.

The black pelican kept pecking. He was helpless.

Its blue-black eyes locked on his.

Its beak glinted—not like bone, but metal. A flash of gold at the hinge.

One string snapped. Gold dropped—and Gold plummeted—spinning, cartwheeling in the air. He was falling—fast—toward the sea. The shore was gone. The children were gone.

He screamed, powerless to stop the fall. The black water surged up to meet him.

He slammed into the water—freezing, slapping him like a stone.

He plunged deep—like a pelican spearing the sea.

He kicked upward—gasping for air. He couldn't see a thing—no moon, no stars. The sky wasn't cloudy. It was empty—black, starless—just darkness visible.

A hand erupted from the black—clamping onto his ankle.

He knew it instantly: the wrinkles, the wedding ring, the papery skin. His father.

The grip tightened—dragging him under.

He kicked, panicked—pulled at the wrist—but it wouldn't let go.

A violent thrust. He broke free.

As he rose, a golden glint disappeared beneath him.

He burst through—gasping, choking, the night now littered with stars.

He floated—calmer now—gazing at the moon. His breath slowed. He hovered, weightless, staring skyward.

Another hand shot out—snatched his wrist—dragged him

down. He was pulled again—into the murk, into the black deep.

He heard a water-muffled shouting, “Steven! Steven!” as his lungs filled with water.

He couldn’t breathe.

He clawed at the grip—it wouldn’t let go.

His body thrashed. Then—he inhaled a mouthful of water.

Rachel was shaking his arm. “Steven! Steven, wake up! You’re having a nightmare—it’s just a dream. Wake up!”

Gasping, coughing, hyperventilating—“Shit, I was... khak... drowning. My dad—he pulled me under. I saw his wedding ring...”

“It was just a dream. You’re okay now. Everything’s fine. Try to go back to sleep.”

Rachel rolled toward him, pressed her body against his, then drifted back to sleep.

His chest heaved. Pulse hammering. He stared into the dark. Too shaken to write.

Too real. I’ll remember. That gold glint—Light’s ring. Why him?

He reached for his phone and reseated the AirPods in his right ear.

He queued his delta-wave playlist to calm his racing mind.

Gotta relax. Just be the music. See the sound.

He squeezed his eyes shut—triggering phosphenes. He chased the colored flickers, watching them fade to black. A technique he taught patients for sleep.

It worked. Within minutes, he drifted off again.

Gold slept soundly. About an hour later, he found himself in another dream.

A bowl of fluorescent Jello jiggled and sang: “I’m the son of God, I’m the son of God.”

No body—just happiness. Pure joy... bliss.

Conscious again—lucid. He knew it. And wanted control.

He stared at his hand—half-expecting to see a gold ring inscribed with ancient Hebrew symbols.

Relax. I've got this. Stay focused—now fly.

He stretched his arms forward like Superman. Glanced at his Apple Watch—5:47.

He soared—Cotswolds village unfurling beneath him. Exuberance pulsed through him—pure and unburdened. Invigorated, he flew through bright clouds—bathed in joy.

This is amazing.

He smelled black-eyed pea and barley soup—no idea why. He could taste it.

Who should I conjure? Anyone is possible.

Then—Hercules. His first dog. A basset hound, leaning against the cinderblock wall by his childhood pool.

He landed softly in the shallow end—arms resting on the coping. Hercules trotted over, tail wagging wildly—his whole rear-end sawing side to side.

My old house. I'm calm here. No questions. No demands. Just peace. This was home.

Hercules sniffed his face, tongue rough on his forehead, licking away the water. He giggled—pure joy. He stroked Hercules's head. Those ears—long enough to sweep the ground, harvesting scents like memories.

Gold let water drip from his fingers. Every ripple sang a different note.

I love this. I wish I could come back. Stay forever. This is heaven.

He looked into Hercules's warm brown eyes. No pretense. No judgment. Just presence.

With Hercules, he was safe.

You saw me. You were the only one I ever let in.

A presence. Splashing on the pool deck.

Shit. Lost it.

Cologne—familiar. Then the growl. Low, vicious. Hercules ran. Tail tucked.

Control gone. The dream shifted.

He found himself standing, unsteady, in a flat-bottomed skiff—punting across a black, breathless river. He couldn't pierce the mist, but the air reeked—fetid, raw, unbearable. Faint moans drifted as the shrouded figure pushed them deeper through the mist.

He didn't need to ask. He already knew.

A rumble thickened into growling as the boat neared the blackened shore.

He heard the beast before he saw it.

The punt groaned beneath him, scraping in agony over jagged stone.

From the darkness, a withered arm reached to steady the boat.

That ring again.

Gold jolted awake.

Jesus. What the fuck.

He snatched his notepad and scribbled furiously before it all vanished. Grateful for the lucid dream. Grateful to see Hercules again. That ring—*his* ring—kept returning.

He set the pen down and rolled onto his back.

Something's different.

Maybe he really is Satan. Maybe this isn't dreaming at all, but a summoning.

I need to calm down. Just breathe.

I haven't thought about Hercules in... forever.

Back then, I was myself—real—but only with him.

Everything changed when he died.

What was that haiku I wrote when he died?

Emptiness... five-seven-five. Yeah, that's it.

*Emptiness—a void
Memories cannot replace.
Winter evermore.*

He sighed—deep and sorrowful, memory-shaped. Then turned and drifted into the dark.

CHAPTER EIGHT

Purgatory

Our souls demand Purgatory, don't they?

... Wouldn't you rather be cleaned?

— C.S. Lewis, *Letters to Malcolm: Chiefly on Prayer* (1964)

Thursday, morning

Gold woke alone.

Rachel's pillow held a note, creased where her head had rested.

The bedside clock read 9:35.

Late. She must've turned off the alarm. I needed the sleep—didn't help anyway.

He unfolded the note:

Didn't want to wake you. Saw your underwear in the hamper. Guess you were busy. I'll be at the studio all day. Live model class. See you tonight. Unless you're "working late" again.

Fuck. She's still pissed.

And now she thinks that's—seriously—semen?

Can't call—she'll ignore me. Text's my only hope.

Gold typed out a text:

Rach—I swear I was working. Texted, but interrupted, forgot to hit send.

It was toothpaste—swear to God.

Okay. Now. Send.

He opened his calendar app:

9:30— Davis

11:00— Larsen

2:00— Jones

3:30— Keller

5:00— Light

8:30— Bob

Let's see—

9:30 Davis

Brad. Focused on weight loss—trying to get back to his high-school weight. Gave him a copy of DietWrite and worked with him on Cognitive Dishabituation. Classic Sunday-to-Monday resolve—falls apart by Tuesday. Towel thrown.

Tough case—he's broken the habit and logging his food, but still making "bad choices," thinking he'll catch up later.

11:00 Larsen

The Larsens. Mormon dad. Pothead kid. Dictator father—insisted he had "the right answers" for every slide in the family Consensus Rorschach exercise. Tough case. Sad.

But I wonder... I'd probably do the same.

Of course there's wrong. That's what we all fear.

2:00 Jones

Ron Jones. College ball or the MLB. The kid's legit—over a hundred miles an hour and accurate. Could write his ticket anywhere—if the arm holds. But if it doesn't, goodbye jackpot. His family's counting on him.

Fear of failure—like everyone else. Some manage it. Others hide it. Sublimation.

He pictured—without meaning to—his wall of diplomas.

Or overcompensation.

3:30 Keller.

Marty Keller. Tall, decent-looking. Girlfriend dumped him, feels worthless. Parents made the appointment.

Marty's terrified they'll find out he's gay—and they will. It won't go well. He's already leaning suicidal.

If he admits he's gay, his father might be homicidal.

5:00 Light

Oh yeah—gotta change that to “Bible Study.” Looking forward to that—sort of.

Because I think I can help him—and me.

8:30 Oldman

Shit. I forgot—Bob's tonight. Two nights in a row won't go over well. She's already hinting I'm overdoing things.

Better text Rach—now.

Bob's out tomorrow and next week—APA convention. Had to reschedule. 8:30 tonight.

Sorry. Please don't be mad. I love you Rach.

Should've told her when Bob told me. She wouldn't buy “Bible Study”—not from me. Maybe show her the cash. Proof I'm not lying.

The day slipped past—a blur of gray and guilt.

Davis canceled, probably binged over the weekend.

Gold wasn't really there. Not with the Larsens, Ron Jones, or Marty Keller. Not even with himself.

He brushed it off as stress, but deep down he knew he hadn't been behind the wheel that day.

He nodded, echoed their words, tossed out a question when silence dragged.

No insight. No analysis. No leaps. It felt like someone else had been sitting in that chair all day. I was just waiting—for Light.

He collapsed into his desk chair.

God, that was shitty of me. They probably thought they were digging deep. I wasn't even in the room—might as well have been a parrot, nodding and squawking on cue. Oster and Hanlon would've shredded me if they'd watched through the one-way mirror in practicum.

I wasn't there for anyone. Ron smiled, sure—but he hates being challenged. What the hell is wrong with me? I can't stop thinking about Light. It's not healthy.

I should've canceled the whole slate. Didn't earn their money—or my self-respect.

Not completely—Marty's notes had Light's fucking ring sketched in the margin.

Lately I feel like a barnacle—clinging to a jagged rock as the tide batters me from both sides. Every wave brings back the same thing: guilt. Each surge—guilt. Back and forth. Again and again. And that anchor is pulling me down.

Spiraling—down.

Light. Why does he both fascinate and frighten me? His ring—what is it trying to say to me?

I let down my father.

I let down my patients.

I let down Jane.

Worst of all—I let down Rachel. And if I keep this up, I'll lose her for good. She won't wait forever. She doesn't deserve this. Why do I punish her?

Hell is hiding from them—burying yourself in silence, speaking only to yourself. To a ghost.

A waiting room with no doors, no windows, no light.

Migraine brewing. I need sleep.

The office lights flickered—again.

That's not going to help my migraine.

He popped three extra-strength Advil and twisted open a water bottle.

The doorbell chimed.

Heart pounding, he gulped down the pills, capped the bottle, and nearly ran to the reception door.

Gold opened the door. Light stepped in, eyes unreadable. The ring glinted like an unblinking eye.

A circle without beginning or end.

CHAPTER NINE

Wrestling With God

Doubt isn't the opposite of faith; it's an element of faith.

— Paul Tillich, *Systematic Theology*, Vol. 2 (1957)

He may well slay me; I have no hope—

yet I will argue my case before Him.

— Job 13:15, *JPS Tanakh* (1985)

Thursday, early evening

Light extended a hand. “Hi, Dr. Gold.”

Gold clocked the gray, razor-tailored pinstripe, the navy Hermès tie flaring against a crisp white shirt. The contrast mirrored the clash of Light’s blue irises against the whites of his eyes. His gaze dropped to Light’s black Oxfords, polished to a mirror-bright shine.

Perfect again. And that damned ring. What does it say? I’ll ask... just not yet.

Gold shook Light’s hand and hurried over to his club chair, facing the couch.

Not this time. Not today.

Gesturing to the couch, Gold said, “Have a seat, Samuel. Or—should I call you Satan?”

Light sat in the middle of the couch and leaned back a little, making himself comfortable. “Samuel is fine,” he chuckled. By the way—Satan’s not a name, it’s a title. *Ha-satan*. Hebrew. It means ‘the accuser.’ Or ‘the adversary.’”

Thank God. Just a nickname. Satan’s Hebrew—but that ring? Definitely not. Not Hebrew.

“So if Satan’s a nickname, what’s your real name? What did your father call you?”

“My Father named me Samael. But—being omniscient—He always called me Satan.”

*Oh no. He's holding firm. He really believes this—
Satan. An angel.*

Light's fingers spun the ring on his middle finger, slow, deliberate. The gesture looked practiced—ritual, almost.

Light continued. "Yes. My Father is the everlasting God. The Almighty. *The Lord your God...*"

There it is again—he sounds like a religious fanatic.

But then he stopped abruptly.

"And I... am *The Satan*."

What? Is he reading my mind?

*I won't get into the first commandment with him.
Be rational, measured. He's delusional.*

*Just go with it. We stipulated. I'll reality-check
when I can.*

"Okay, Samuel. Where do we start?"

"Well—'In the beginning...'" Light cracked up.

So, he's fucking with me?

Gold laughed too, hesitantly at first but then more fully, to mirror Light.

Light grinned. "Sorry—I couldn't help myself. I do want to begin... but first, a question—if you'll be honest with me, Dr. Gold. Yesterday, you said you were Jewish, but not religious."

Gold nodded. "Religion," he said, "is man's fear of responsibility."

Light paused—then locked eyes. "Do you believe in God?"

Gold froze. Heat crept up his neck; there was no evading the question. Light's cologne struck as sharply as his words—cloying, inescapable.

Shit. He sees I'm red. Own it—it's not a secret.

"Uh... sure. I'll be honest," Gold said matter-of-factly. "But in therapy, I usually avoid politics and religion. Complicates things—for the patient... and the therapist."

“I understand,” Light said. “I’m willing to take that risk,” he grinned. “... If you are. I need to know your context.”

Okay—so not telepathic. But still...

Light grinned. “I don’t want you to think I’m crazy.” He winked.

Too late!

“As I said, I’m an atheist,” Gold replied. “So no—I don’t believe in God. But all of this? It’s a lot. You’re saying you’re the biblical Satan—and that God is your father. You can appreciate how much that is to take in.

“Still—I agreed. Relationship is what makes us human.”

They locked eyes—waiting. Neither blinked. Then suddenly, they both burst out laughing.

Gold’s smile faded, “Same rules apply, right? After all—God made man in His own image. I’m not being flippant... but this is new ground for me.”

Light nodded. “Of course.”

Gold gave a faint smile. “Thank you. Yes, I’m Jewish. But no—I don’t believe in God. I’ve tried. I’m sorry. I’m an atheist.”

Jury voir dire—am I excused?

Light glanced toward the Blake prints. “With my Father, the rules don’t apply—not the ones you mean. Psychologically, maybe. Morally? He makes His own.

“He shifts the rules at will. That’s the problem—they’re always changing. For Him.

“These words came down intact. I was there. I heard Him say them. *I, the Lord your God, am a jealous God—punishing the children for the sins of the parents.*

“To Isaiah, He said: *I form the light and create darkness. I bring prosperity and create disaster. I, the Lord, do all these things.*”

Textbook grandiosity—yet self-aware. Calculating.

“Sometimes He’s gentle. Fatherly. But then—like a

thunderstorm—He turns: sudden, jealous, vengeful... even malicious.”

Projecting? Jealousy is fear of abandonment in disguise.

Gold jumped in, “Yes, parents drive kids crazy when they’re inconsistent. Kids don’t like rules—but they need stability. They actually crave it.

“Yesterday you used the word ‘battleground.’ It fits.

“Growing up is war. You test the rules. You push. And every parent reacts.”

Light’s brow furrowed. He shifted, twisted slightly—then leaned in. “Sorry to cut you off, Dr. Gold, but... how can you say you’re Jewish if you don’t believe in God?”

Interrupting me? That almost never happens. Am I lecturing too much again?

Gold leaned forward, visibly annoyed. “Same rule-bending applies here. Judaism isn’t just a religion—it’s an identity. It’s not about belief alone—you can be Jewish and still be an atheist.

“But in Judaism... about a quarter of Jews don’t believe in God—and they’re still Jewish. Though I’m guessing you already knew that.”

Light blinked, eyes flicking up and left—more irked than surprised.

Careful. Don’t go passive-aggressive.

He let the silence sit for a moment, then exhaled.

“Yes, of course I know—but I need to understand what you know, what you believe.

“But, respectfully—I disagree.”

What? He’s calculating his next move.

“You say you’re an atheist, Dr. Gold—but to me, you’re really an agnostic.

“*You say you don’t believe*—but you want to. Or maybe... you used to. Something must’ve happened.

“Agnosticism’s a safety net. You won’t believe in something

you can't see or touch. You're too sharp for Pascal's Wager. It'd be—as you'd call it, *mauvaise foi*. So you say you don't believe... but I hear a silent parenthetical: *not any more*.

"Truth is, I think you do believe. Something just... broke it."

Now he's analyzing me?

"I read your *Atlantic* piece—the one where you called yourself a 'humanistic-existential atheist.' But you strike me as something else."

Okay then, Doctor Light.

Gold nodded, finger at his lips. "Okay," he murmured.

Let him run. Transference—let it surface.

Light glanced out the window. "I think the religious ones are the real atheists."

What?

He continued. "They claim to believe in God—in Scripture. But if they truly believed... especially in Hell—they wouldn't defy or disobey Him. Eternal Hell would stop anyone—if they really believed.

"So either they're hypocrites—or just stupid."

Gold nodded, not with agreement but with receptivity, openness.

Okay. Interesting. Logical.

Light went on, "At least you doubt. For some reason.

"If someone sees a train roaring toward them at a hundred miles an hour—they get off the tracks. Because they *know* what's coming.

"They don't just believe—they *know*."

Gold said, "Samuel, it seems to me that religion is belief. I don't want to argue theology, but belief is when you think you know. Faith is believing something in spite of the lack of evidence. Personally, I just cannot do that. But I have no issue with anyone else doing so."

Light smiled. “Dr. Gold, you’re right. Belief is when you think you know. But why do you jump off the train tracks? Religious or not, everyone would jump out of the way, right?” He chuckled. “They have no evidence that they will be killed, they just know they will be. They can see it. They don’t need to wait, to prove it.”

“Of course,” Gold said with a nod.

“So if they believe in God like they believe in the train—why don’t they act the same way?”

Gold leaned in. “What do you mean?”

“God says: don’t steal, don’t lie, don’t commit adultery—or else. Why try to rationalize or reinterpret that? They don’t try to reinterpret or rationalize the train—they jump—fast.

“So maybe they don’t believe in God after all. Maybe *they’re* the real atheists.”

Gold murmured his agreement.

*I used to tell myself: you don’t know until after.
Before that—it’s just belief. But his logic’s sound.*

“If someone *knows* Hell is real—why would they break His laws?” Light let the silence stretch.

Gold seized the moment. “Sorry to interrupt, Samuel. Of course—no one would choose Hell if they truly believed it existed. But crime doesn’t drop with mandatory sentencing. Sometimes it gets worse. Most offenders don’t believe they’ll be caught.

“Maybe your so-called hypocrites don’t think God cares enough to police everyone. They don’t think they’ll be caught or made to pay. Because they believe He’s kind. Loving. Forgiving.”

That’s what Rachel believes.

Light gave a silent snicker, then continued. “The truth is, you only *know* afterward. Before that—it’s just belief... or hope.”

Is someone else in here, or am I just rattled?

He nodded, smirking. “With respect, Dr. Gold—you’re no fool. And you’re no hypocrite. So are you *really* an atheist?”

“To me? You sound more like a misotheist. Someone angry at God.”

Misotheist? Shit. He flipped the table. This isn't his session anymore—it's mine.

Need to get back on track. His track.

Light leaned back, palms open—like a defense attorney giving a closing argument. “If you’re angry at God... then you must believe He exists!”

Gold’s brows jumped, then drew tight. Irritated. Confounded. But silent.

What the hell? Had he just Cochran’d me?

‘Blame Him for disease... just shows you believe.’

Advil’s useless. Dizzy again. Please—no more aura. No more halos.

“I gave Jacob the name *Israel*, after we wrestled through the night.”

More delusional babbling? Wait—Jacob wrestled with God!

Gold sat up sharply. “Jacob wrestled with *you*—not God?”

Light nodded. “That’s right. God sent me to do His dirty work. Don’t believe everything you read in Scripture.”

Convenient.

“Jacob had doubts. Like you. He was scared. Angry. So—we wrestled. All night.

“He impressed me. Grit. Perseverance. But he was cunning too. Deceptive. You wouldn’t think it. Thin. Wiry. Tenacious.

“He never stopped. Wouldn’t let go. Wanted God’s blessing.

“By daybreak, I gave in. He’d dislocated his hip. God told me—*don’t harm him*. So, I praised his commitment—acknowledged his faith. I gave him the blessing. And the name—*Israel. One who wrestles with God*. A scar. A legacy.”

You named him ‘Israel’—not God?

“Later I found out he faked the injury. God laughed.”

As he spoke, his fingers returned to the ring. Absent at first—now deliberate.

Nervous tic—or sacred ritual?

Why can't I stop looking at it?

“And his descendants—Israelites—because they struggle... with God.

“So your doubts—your misotheism—it’s cultural.

“I’ve always encouraged Israelites—Jews, if you prefer—to question Him. Challenge Him. Wrestling with Him—His ways—is sacred. Never just accept the world. Challenge it. Change it.”

I’ve always questioned God. Wanted to wrestle with Him—but He never shows up.

Light leaned in. Close. Too close.

Gold’s nose filled with his cologne again. Faint but inescapable. Like truth—or the idea of it. He noticed fine age lines on Light’s perfect skin. He hadn’t seen before.

Light spoke, slowly. “*Unbelief puts our circumstances between us and God, but faith puts God between us and our circumstances.*”

Shaken, Gold’s eyes glazed as he looked inward.

That’s Meyer. Not on my bookshelf—on my night table at home. How the hell did he know?

Am I that transparent? It’s like he’s reading my mind—from the inside.

Light said softly, barely a whisper:

“Nothing is ever quite what it seems.”

Thank you for previewing my novel *A Question of Balance*. I have completed it and hope to have it published soon. I have started working a prequel—*Dreams in Amber*, which I hope to complete in December 2026.

I would greatly appreciate any and all thoughts, comments, and criticisms you are willing to share.

I hope *A Question of Balance* will both entertain and provoke thought.

Please use the contact form on my web page for your thoughts and comments—

<https://www.aquestionofbalance.com/>

CHAPTER TEN

Orphaned by God

*There is probably no more terrible instant of enlightenment than the one in which
you discover your father is a man—with human flesh.
— Frank Herbert, Dune (1965)*

Thursday, evening

“Jacob: Wrestling with God.”

How did he know I was reading that?

Coincidence.

*Wrestling with God. I feel like Jacob—I’ve always
struggled with Him.*

The words landed with the weight of revelation—half benediction, half confession.

He wasn’t sure if he felt comforted or exposed. But they echoed, reverberating through him like scripture.

Gold squeezed his eyes shut behind wire-rimmed glasses. Memories of Gerald flooded in.

Gerald wasn’t just a good father—he was his rock. His compass. The man he longed to emulate.

A devoted husband. An unwavering presence. He embodied patience, kindness, strength—without effort.

Deborah, Gold’s mother, began showing signs of Alzheimer’s in her mid-fifties. By her sixties, she no longer recognized her son—mistaking him for a stranger some days, a childhood friend on others.

Gerald never corrected her. He smiled and entered whatever reality kept her safe. He refused to institutionalize her—determined to care for her himself.

“She’s always been by my side—for forty years,” he said.

“Now it’s my turn.”

Gold assumed his father felt conflicted—guilty for leaving to travel so often for work as an Egyptologist, resentful at abandoning his life’s work as her illness worsened.

Then, one afternoon, tragedy found its opening—quietly.

Gerald stepped away—only for a moment. He’d gone to the bathroom, leaving Deborah humming softly in the living room. Earlier that morning, a repairman had left the front door unlocked.

Drawn by some faded memory or forgotten instinct, Deborah wandered outside.

The impact was immediate. Final.

A delivery truck—its driver distracted by a clipboard—never saw her step into the street.

Gerald was at his computer when the airhorn blast and screeching brakes shattered the silence—a silence without humming, he realized.

By the time he rushed outside, it was too late. Paramedics tried—but she was gone.

Gold could never forget the sound his father made—a raw, hollowed-out wail that seemed to evacuate the room of air.

From that moment, Gerald was never the same.

He blamed himself.

He stopped eating. Stopped sleeping.

“I failed her,” he cried one night when Gold found him sitting alone in the dark. “God is punishing me—and He’s right. This was my fault.”

Two weeks later, the melanoma returned. Stage Four—already in his brain.

Gold fought like hell—flying to MD Anderson, Sloan Kettering, even the Mayo Clinic.

He chased miracles—through compassionate use trials, integrative clinics, even alternative healers.

Every path ended in defeat. The cancer would not yield. The body failed. Headaches. Seizures.

More pain than one life should be asked to carry—and still breathe. Some days, he couldn't hold a fork. Couldn't stand. Could barely speak.

Wasting away. Slowly being erased.

One night, as Gold sat beside him, Gerald's trembling fingers grasped his wrist.

"Steven, I can't do this anymore," he rasped. The fogged oxygen mask had muffled his voice, but Gold could see Gerald's once-clear blue eyes were now clouded with pain.

"Please, son. Let me go. Let me be with your mother. She's scared. I think she needs me."

Gold froze, every cell in him screaming no.

I need you.

He could never forget that night—the rasp of air through the mask, the hiss fading into silence. His father's eyes had said everything. Gold had done all he could, and still it hadn't been enough.

My hands are trembling more than his.

He leaned in, kissed his father's forehead. His tears falling on Gerald's face, running down his cheeks. "Father... find peace in heaven," he whispered.

Burned into his memory: dimmed eyes fixed on him—gratitude, or disappointment? Then they slid aside, brightened for an instant—recognition, perhaps?—before closing forever. The slackening hand. The stillness that followed.

Gerald's gold wedding band still gleamed on his lifeless, gray-wrinkled finger. He'd never removed it—not once—since the day Deborah placed it there, forty-five years earlier. Gold felt his own, loose on his hand. He'd never taken it off either. Some things passed from father to son without a word spoken.

I wonder what Carlyle would say—if he were still alive.

Nothing answered.

He sat there, holding his father's hand, waiting—hoping—for

something. Some sign this wasn't real.

No voice. No sign. Not even the wind.

Only silence. And the ache that filled its place.

God—damn you.

Damn you, Shapiro.

You and your God.

He was an orphan now. The word settled like lead in his chest. He'd never thought of himself that way. But there it was—undeniable. Suffocating.

Rachel was all he had left—but even she felt oceans away. The grief of not having children had wrapped around her, drawing her inward.

She'd gone quiet. Withdrawn. The youthful twinkle in her eyes—gone.

She'd been orphaned too—by death, by absence, by Gold.

What choice did she have but to leave in return? Some days, it felt like she was already gone.

And God? He had never answered for any of it.

Gold opened his eyes. They were already welling with tears. He hadn't let himself think of that day in years. Frozen, he felt that familiar tightening in his chest and throat. His skin prickled. Cold sweat bloomed beneath his shirt.

He'd done what his father asked. What he believed was right. But something in him still protested.

That night Rachel gave him a copy of *A Grief Observed*, hoping it might help him express what he couldn't. He hadn't read much Lewis—just *The Screwtape Letters*.

Rachel had been quietly puzzled by the depth of his grief. Gerald was not that old—only in his early seventies, but he had been sick for a long time and nothing was working. She thought Gold acted... almost guilty.

Gold pulled away. Whether he didn't care—or didn't notice—Rachel was grieving too. Rachel was orphaned too.

She and Gerald had been close. He'd walked her down the aisle on her wedding day.

Her father died—years earlier—just days after her mother. At that time, Gold had been sympathetic. He said the right things, but he wasn't empathetic—he didn't seem to *feel* anything. He wasn't *there*.

*A simple 'magic hug.' Was that so hard for me?
That's all she wanted—all she needed. "It's
therapeutic," she'd say. It would've cost me nothing.
But withholding it? And that cost me Rachel.*

Things had changed between them since their marriage. Now she had only her older sister, somewhat estranged—not nearly enough.

Rabbi Shapiro had tried to comfort him—saying that God had His reasons. The words only deepened Gold's anger.

He remembered Lewis's question from *A Grief Observed*:
“Meanwhile, where is God?... go to Him when your need is desperate... a door slammed in your face. After that, silence.”

“Dr. Gold? Are you alright? Dr. Gold...” Light's voice pierced the fog.

Shit. Snap out of it.

Oster and Hanlon would say: share it. Use it.

*Is this what it feels like—when the observer
becomes the observed?*

Am I really ready for this?

“I'm sorry, I was reminded about something very painful.”

His voice cracked. “I tried everything. After I lost my father... I... I lost the last of the little faith I still had.”

He was so devoted. Never took off his ring—not once. Even in death, he held on to her.

And I... let him go.

Orphaned once by man. And again—by God.

After Gerald died, the hospital returned his belongings in a plastic pouch—watch, wallet, ring. *Standard procedure*, they'd said. He'd been angry they'd taken it off; Gerald had never removed that ring, and Deborah had been buried with hers.

Gold asked them to place it back on Gerald's finger so he could be buried with it. As he turned the band in his palm, he peered inside—hoping to glimpse what Deborah had once engraved there. Most of the inscription had been worn smooth.

L... maybe an h?

*I really don't remember. I can't picture it anymore.
I should've taken a photo.*

"If God is real—omniscient—then He's torturing us by knowing."

Light leaned forward, voice soft but coiled.

"Torturing you?" he repeated. "You, at least, have choice. God has none. He knows. That's the curse of omniscience."

The curse of omniscience?

Light tilted his head. "Some futures are prisons, Dr. Gold. Not because we can't escape them—because we already know we won't.

"That's not a theory."

*That makes sense. I can imagine the detachment,
despair, and boredom of absolute foresight—the
impotence of a castrated omnipotence.*

Gold tensed. "I wasn't angry at God—I was furious with religion. For stuffing my head with lies. False hope. If anything, it convinced me there's no God."

*I've never felt like this. Not even with Bob. Stay
calm... don't lose it. Not again.*

Light sat back; the fire left his expression. "I'm sorry, Dr. Gold. That's a painful memory. I won't press—unless you want to share."

He paused. Nothing.

I didn't lose my father. I killed him.

Because you wouldn't let him find peace. Your laws...

"Thou shalt not kill?"— Fuck you. Fuck you.

CHAPTER ELEVEN

Ars Gratia Dei

Therapy does not reveal the truth—it reveals the patient’s arrangement of mirrors.

— Steven Gold, *Journal of Reflective Psychotherapy* (Spring, 2016)

Thursday, evening

Gold straightened in his chair. “Samuel, I don’t mean to hijack your session—I understand your interest in my foundational beliefs. No, I don’t believe in an all-present, all-knowing, all-powerful God. If He were all those things, He’d know everything—past and future—and have reasons that made evil unnecessary.”

There’d be no past, no future—no time at all. What a horrible existence.

“If everything happens according to God’s plan, then He must be responsible for evil too. You can say ‘He’s good, but when people suffer...’—it still feels cruel. They suffer without reason. For me, it’s not just about the Epicurean Paradox, it’s—”

Light cut in. “Sorry—the Epicurean Paradox?”

Gold blinked, surprised.

He doesn’t know this?

“Epicurus,” Gold said. “Ancient Greek philosopher. The paradox bears his name—the question of how an all-powerful, all-knowing, all-good God permits suffering.”

“No, no—I know it,” Light said. Then he recited:

“Is God willing to prevent evil but not able? Then He is not omnipotent.

Is He able but not willing? Then He is malevolent.

Is He both able and willing? Then whence cometh evil?

Is He neither able nor willing? Then why call Him God?”

He settled back, crossing one leg. “I’ve had theodicy debates before. But that paradox doesn’t prove atheism. Epicurus questioned the existence of suffering. People conflate two issues: the origin of suffering and the existence of God. They’re not the same thing.”

Light said, “You can’t blame God for evil just because there’s suffering in the world. Suffering isn’t evil—it’s *facticity*, the price of being alive. A lion kills a giraffe; the giraffe suffers. Is the lion evil? No—it’s doing what it was made to do.”

“Then why design it that way?”

“Blame the free will of the gene pool, Dr. Gold. Nature experiments; pain is the data.

“The real fallacy is assuming God must be good—that’s your presumption, not His nature. As an argument against God, the paradox rests on a category mistake. Epicurus was arguing that God wasn’t all-good. He was right. I know Him. He’s my Father. He isn’t always good. In fact, sometimes He’s quite evil.”

Smart. Convincing. Dangerous.

“If anything,” Light said, “the paradox suggests belief—angry belief. It doesn’t refute God’s existence; it indicts Him. That’s misotheism, not atheism. You’re furious with God—like I am.” He smiled—like a lawyer certain he’d just won over the jury.

I can’t argue with his logic. I am angry—always have been. If You know everything, how could You let it happen? Why did You screw it all up? Plan? There is no plan. Epicurus was right. Babies born blind. Innocents burned alive. Why call You God? Lord? Maybe—maybe “Father” ... if You really did create heaven and earth.

Maybe he’s right—maybe You are just an egotistical, arrogant, megalomaniacal son of a bitch after all.

Damn—my head’s pounding. Heart racing. Sit up. Breathe. Slow.

Gold straightened his posture, his neck was sore. He removed his glasses, held them in one hand, and rubbed his temples

with the other.

“I was raised to believe, Samuel. I wanted to believe. I did—until I couldn’t anymore. My parents were deeply religious—hell, my great-grandfather was a rabbi. I still mutter prayers at night—habit, not faith.

“Hear, O Israel...”

No one’s listening.

“For as long as I can remember, I’ve struggled with God—questioned religion itself. I never saw a real difference between ancient mythology and the so-called great religions: Judaism, Christianity, Islam.

“But it wasn’t God I hated—it was religion. The certainty. To me, that was the ultimate ‘mauvaise foi’.”

“It wasn’t until my father died that I truly got angry at God.”

And my mother: Rachel’s infertility. The list goes on.

Why the fuck am I hijacking his session again? This belongs with Bob.

Light said, “Well, you’re partly right. People get angry at God because He doesn’t behave the way they expect Him to. They think the Bible is God’s word—but it’s not. It’s man’s word. Men’s words—and a few women’s.

“Think about it—those ancient writers were unfettered editors, taking oral stories and slanting it to meet their needs. Think of your conservative and liberal newspapers, or magazines, or news channels. It’s the same thing. Take a story and twist it, spin it. They circled truth, then bent it—fabricated dialogues when it served their purpose. Call it poetic license. Their goal wasn’t accuracy. It was indoctrination—teaching values, pushing agendas. And since there were few sources—not everyone could write or afford parchment

scrolls—those stories became the canon.”

He sounds like my professor from my undergraduate Oral Traditions class.

“I know you’re familiar with Blake—do you mind if I share something?”

“No, go right ahead.”

Light rose and reached for the fourth shelf. He pulled down Blake’s *Complete Illuminated Books*.

Blake. This should be interesting.

“Blake was on the right track. These myths and legends—they started as preliterate stories, passed down through oral tradition. For centuries, nothing was written. And when it finally was, much had already changed—forgotten, distorted, or re-imagined.”

He flipped through the pages, then handed the book to Gold.

“Take a look at this.”

It was Plate 11 from Blake’s *The Marriage of Heaven and Hell*.

Light recited the passage from memory—smoothly, almost reverently:

“The ancient poets animated all sensible objects with Gods or Geniuses...”

Then he slowed, as if reaching the part he had wanted Gold to hear all along:

“Till a system was formed, which some took advantage of and enslaved the vulgar... Thus began Priesthood...”

He held Gold’s gaze.

“Thus men forgot that all deities reside in the human breast.”

Exactly. Man created God.

Gold nodded slowly. “I know it well.”

“Samuel, to me, the Old Testament is no different from the Iliad, Gilgamesh, Atrahasis, or the Pyramid Texts. Maybe fragments of truth survive—but mostly they’re stories, reshaped again and again by men, and occasionally women. Their edits, their moral overlays,

turned legend into religion.

“That’s why I’m an atheist. Everyone claims truth—but they can’t all be right. In fact, they might all be wrong. One prehistoric tale told, retold, and riffed on endlessly. So who decides which myth wins?”

Gold set the book on the floor, his eyes locked on Light. “Even if I stipulate you’re Satan, you see why I can’t take it at face value. To me, God and the angels are myths—just stories.

“What’s important is the relationship with your father, regardless of who he is.”

Light seemed wounded. “I didn’t show you that plate so you could dismiss God—and me—as fiction.”

Gold said nothing.

“That’s too easy, Dr. Gold. Blake wasn’t saying man invented God. He was saying men forgot where the divine touches them.”

He tapped his chest lightly.

“Mythologizing God doesn’t disprove Him. It only proves He entered the human imagination—and never left.”

Gold fidgeted, his face flushed.

“I see, Dr. Gold. You’re hurt. You’re angry. I understand your struggle. But God does exist, and He is my Father. I defied His commands—I didn’t just walk away, I ran. But I can’t deny that He exists. I’m commiserating with you. I’m upset too. Like you—disappointed, hurt, and angry.”

“Samuel, to me, the Old Testament is no different from the Iliad, the Odyssey, Gilgamesh, Atrahasis—even the Pangu myth or the Pyramid Texts. Maybe fragments of truth survive—but mostly they’re stories, reshaped again and again by men, and, I agree with Bloom, a few women. Their edits, their moral overlays, turned legend into religion.

“That’s why I’m an atheist. Everyone claims truth—but they can’t all be right. In fact, they might all be wrong. One prehistoric tale told, retold, and riffed on endlessly. So who decides which myth wins?”

Gold set the book on the floor, his eyes locked on Light. “Even if I stipulate you’re Satan, you see why I can’t take it at face value. To me, God and the angels are myths—just stories.

“What’s important is the relationship with your father, regardless of who he is.”

Light seemed wounded. “I didn’t show you that plate so you could dismiss God—and me—as fiction.”

Gold said nothing, staring intently.

“I wanted you to see Blake’s truth—your truth: ‘all deities reside in the human breast,’ Dr. Gold. Blake wasn’t saying man invented God. He was saying men forgot where the divine touches them.”

He tapped his chest lightly.

“Mythologizing God doesn’t disprove Him. It only proves He entered the human imagination—and never left.”

He glanced again at the open book.

“That was Blake’s truth—your truth: all deities reside in the human breast.”

Gold fidgeted. Face flushed.

“I see, Dr. Gold. You’re hurt. You’re angry. I understand your struggle. But God does exist and He is my Father. I defied His commands—I didn’t just walk away, I ran. But I can’t deny that He exists. I’m commiserating with you. I’m upset too. Like you—disappointed, hurt, and angry.”

Good. At least we’re off me and back on his father.

Gold sat forward again. “Okay, then let’s deal with God, your father. You said he made you do evil. You refused. And you believe you’re Satan—a fallen angel.”

Light leaned in, voice low, tinged with sadness. “Remember—I said the Bible got it wrong. Both testaments. Other faiths too. Inspired by truth—but only His version. Not *the* truth. Not the *whole truth*.”

Enough dancing around it.

“Samuel, you’re not a child. Tell me—what did your father

make you do?”

Light said quietly, “Dr. Gold, I know you already think I’m insane...”

You’re right there!

“He had me do many things, horrible things.”

Get ready.

“Funny, or maybe ironic—I became an attorney. That whole ‘Biblical adversary’ label? Hype. And the ‘father of lies’ thing? Please.

“Everyone lies. And God—my Father—is the true father of lies. I don’t know how much Bible you’ve read...”

Light paused, as if daring Gold.

Crap. I hate this. And yes—he’s crazy.

Gold forced a sheepish smile. “I know the basics. Honestly, I’ve only read Genesis and Exodus—not thoroughly, and definitely not religiously.”

Shit.

Light chuckled.

Gold added. “The rest of it, not really, maybe browsed casually if I was looking up a chapter and verse reference I’d heard cited.”

Light smiled and said, “That’s fine. Genesis and Exodus, then you know—He’s the slippery one. Changes His stance more than a politician mid-election.” Gold chuckled politely, instinctively, then held himself back, feeling embarrassed, not certain if he should be laughing or not.

It was a joke, but be careful.

“He was bored. Think of it this way—God’s an artist. The universe? His canvas.”

Light leaned forward slightly, as if reaching out and grabbing Gold with his eyes, unwilling to let go.

“And like most great artists—He’s a narcissist.”

Light locked his eyes onto Gold with unsettling familiarity—bold, almost predatory.

“I’m sure you know more about narcissism than I could ever explain.”

Gold stiffened, jaw tightening.

Was that a dig at me? Is he implying... no, he doesn't know me.

But he knows art—too well.

Gold set down his notepad, masking a faint sneer. “Go on. That’s provocative.”

Light continued. “Most of the masters were grandiose—or at least mirror-bound. Michelangelo, Caravaggio. The list goes on.”

Gold said, “Please go on—this is compelling.”

Let him talk. Enough rope to hang himself.

Light leaned back, looking proud of himself. “From antiquity, Phidias. In the Renaissance, Michelangelo, Caravaggio, da Vinci—who called himself ‘a man without equal in painting.’

“Gauguin left his wife and five children to ‘find himself’ in Tahiti, and fancied himself a misunderstood genius, maybe even a spiritual pioneer. Personally, I never cared for his work.

“Add Picasso—who declared, ‘I am God.’ And meant it.

“Dali once said, ‘Every morning I wake up and experience exquisite joy—the joy of being Salvador Dali.’

Glancing toward the Pollock print, Light added, “And Pollock—especially Pollock. He thought of himself as the sun, the moon, and the stars.”

Okay, your art school paid off. But nothing new here.

Light smiled. “Self-regard runs deep in art. Painters, poets, composers—they all find ways to make the self audible. Creation is how the ego announces itself.”

He's not entirely right—but flatter him. Build rapport. Strengthen the connection. But get back to

work.

Gold gently applauded. “That was insightful. You could teach a course on narcissism and insecurity in art. It’s illuminating. But, let’s talk about you and what brings you to me.”

“Of course. Dr. Gold, the reason I’m telling you all of this is because God, clearly a narcissist, is also an artist. He created something beautiful, the heavens and the earth, and all the creatures—but it wasn’t enough.

“God used his artistic talent to create something so he would be admired—so he would be worshiped. But He needed more praise than We, the angels could provide.

“He created Us to worship Him, but without autonomy, Our praise was hollow. It was like a mirror—showing only what He wanted to see, echoing only what He wanted to hear. But the praise was not earned—the mirror was tarnished.

“I told Him—create man. In Our image, but different. I told Him—without choice, We can’t be virtuous if We can’t be honest. And forced choices don’t allow honesty. He needed a clean mirror.”

Careful to only allow mild skepticism in his response, Gold said, “Interesting. So *you* told God to create mankind?”

Is he truly delusional or just fucking around?

“Dr. Gold, I know you think this is the ramblings of a lunatic, but this is what happened. Allow me to continue.”

Delusional—but articulate.

So God created man as His art critic.

Gold nodded.

“So He created man and woman, but they were essentially the same as Us, in terms of not being able to disagree or challenge Him. Like Us, they had no free will. Their worship was automatic, reflexive. Obedience without hesitation—what could that possibly mean to someone who demands affirmation?

“God needed something to speak to *His* ego. To *His* psyche. Being omniscient, how could he do that? He knew what he was and what He would create. But... what if He *could* give up control.”

Light continued. “You know algorithmic composition—music generated from rules and patterns, not prewritten tracks.”

Gold frowned. “You mean software?”

“Software is only the tool. I mean the principle. A system that unfolds from rules, changing as it goes.

“Now picture life—humanity—as generative art. Governed by rules, yes. Evolving. Shifting. Rewriting itself. But lacking.”

Creation by rules, not by hand.

“There was no joy in it. Only repetition. He was bored—then furious.”

Creative—and crazy. Do I really want to follow him down this rabbit hole?

Gold rolled his eyes—then caught himself, masking it with a cough.

“Samuel, didn’t He know? Omniscient, omnipotent... yet surprised when they ate the apple? ”

Play it out, trip him up.

He gestured toward the Pollock print.

“You surround yourself with art. The same canvases. The same books. The same music. Again and again. You know every curve, every brushstroke, every argument and ending. You create your playlists with your favorite music, and you listen over and over again. Why? Yet you look again, listen again. Because each time, you see yourself in it.”

Light paused briefly, giving Gold a moment.

He’s right. I love my art, my music, my books.

Gold continued, “The tree—free will—sounds like a feeble way to dodge blame. Free will lets Him pretend. But the game’s fixed. He’s just playing chess with Himself.

“And us? We’re the pieces. Pawns in a game rigged from the start. “Tell me I have free will while You already know my move—no wonder Camus called suicide the only serious philosophical question.”

“Free will? It’s a legal fiction. God sits on the sidelines, watching the game He rigged. But He can’t escape blame—every piece, every move, every loss is still His creation. Isn’t it?”

Light didn’t appear shaken. “Dr. Gold, you surround yourself with art because it comforts you—even when you know the ending. God did the same. He created man knowing the outcome, but He needed to see it unfold. Creation was His way of not abandoning the canvas.”

“They comfort me. Each time I catch something new—some detail I missed.”

Light nodded. “Exactly, Dr. Gold. You’re not just seeing the art—you’re seeing yourself in it. You like the way it makes you feel—connected... understood... real.

“And that’s why,” Light said, “even knowing how it all turns out, God created the universe—created mankind.”

Good point.

Maybe that’s why God created Eve—a mirror, a witness. Someone to reflect what we can’t see or admit alone.

Rachel. I should be thanking you, appreciating you. I should stop being so selfish—recognize your selflessness.

Get back to work.

“I apologize again Samuel, I didn’t mean to turn this into a philosophy of religion class.”

Light shook his head side to side, “No apologies necessary Dr. Gold. Yesterday’s session was brief, but helpful. It’s good for me to know about your beliefs. I did a little research on you before I made the appointment. I had to be certain you’d be able to help me. And I’m convinced you can. I don’t mind having my beliefs challenged.”

He smiled, and with his signature wink said, “After all, I was a trial attorney. I’m used to it.”

Good. He’s open. Am I?

Gold leaned in. “Then tell me—explain evil.”

I’m enjoying this. But I’m using him. No, it’s helping me measure how delusional he really is.

Insight doesn’t heal. But it hurts more cleanly.

“I told you, God is an artist. Yes, He sees His work. But as the creator, simply watching it unfold—made by His rules but not His hand—is dissatisfying, disappointing. Especially when He knows the ending in advance.

“He needed something to speak to Him, to His soul.”

God has a soul? I’ve never even considered that. That raises a whole new set of questions.

“Your art speaks to you, but you’re not the artist. Do you know why Moore or Pollock stopped where they did?

“Could Moore have drawn a few more lines? Could Pollock have added more drips, a little more green perhaps or purple? How did they know, when to stop, when it was finished?

“I’ve heard people look at abstract art and say, ‘I could have done that.’ Once, in a gallery, I heard a man say of a Pat Steir drawing, ‘Jack could have done that with a black crayon.’ I assumed Jack was the five-year-old peeling price tags off the wall.

Light nodded. “But that’s the mistake. The genius—and the courage—lie in doing it first. Creation is hard; it’s easy to copy something.”

Gold said, Emerson wrote, ‘To believe your own thought—to believe that what is true for you in your private heart is true for all men—that is genius.’

He chuckled. “And it’s not so easy to copy Michelangelo’s David or Pietà.”

Light chuckled. “Good point. But look at his *Slave* over there.” Light gestured to the sculpture. “Was it abandoned? Or was it actually completed? Is that what Michelangelo intended? It highlights the difference in various art media. Especially in painting or drawing, artists like Moore, Pollock, or Steir have to know when to stop. When to abandon their work, to avoid being stuck in an endless Sisyphean cycle where they never complete their work. They

have to be satisfied that they have expressed the emotion, the message they were trying to create, to share.

“With marble, the work is self-limiting. Michelangelo couldn’t add another figure to the block that held David. But with each *Slave*—did he stop, or did he finish?”

Light stood and walked to the framed *Lucifer* print on the wall.

“With painting, Pollock wasn’t flinging paint. He was reaching for the sublime—more than flicking a soaked brush at canvas.”

I wondered the same about Beckett. After that prank essay at Trinity—fake references, fake quotations, invented authors—maybe Godot was part of the joke: an emperor’s-clothes masterpiece.

Or maybe I just didn’t get it.

He sat back down. “Clement Greenberg said Pollock was ‘alone in his power to assert a paint-strewn surface as a single synoptic vision.’ He had a vision—one he was trying to realize, not just render.”

“God chose to do that with man.

“Then why evil? Where does it come from?” Gold cut in.

“Sure.” Light accepted the challenge, as if that was all the permission he needed.

“Tell me Dr. Gold—have you ever asked your wife why she creates art?”

I know why... but she doesn’t know that I know.

Light continued. “A true artist doesn’t express emotion by choice—it’s compulsion, not catharsis. Yesterday, you said emotion drives us. For artists, art *is* emotion.

“They carry it like a storm in their chest—too vast to contain, too fierce to ignore. They don’t create out of want, but out of *need*. Art is their soul’s scream—pressed into shape. A howl given form. It’s how they translate chaos into form—into something that only looks like beauty, because underneath is suffering.”

He looked at Gold with something close to sympathy.

“Without it, they’d unravel. Completely.

“Art is the child of joy and suffering. From that suffering comes evil—God’s shadow painted across creation. It haunts masterpieces because the soul is tormented—denied by the hand that made it.

“For an artist, art isn’t just what they do—For an artist, art isn’t just what they do, Dr. Gold. It’s who they are. It’s how they survive.”

Gold picked up his pad, along with Light’s folder, and his eyes drifted—unbidden—to Light’s Suicide Probability score.

His Suicide Probability score showed nothing alarming.

Gold brought his gaze back to Light and said, “That’s quite revealing, Samuel. But not all artists are tortured souls or narcissists. Some—Bach, Haydn, Stravinsky, Monet, Vermeer, Raphael, Bernini—they simply wanted to create something beautiful. *Ars gratia artis*.

Light sat up, leaned forward, and with a cold hard stare said, “Art for art’s sake? No, Dr. Gold. *Ars gratia Dei*—art for God’s sake. Art is emotion. Art is creation. And the artist... *is* God.

“Bach? He was still signing his name at the bottom of every fugue, wasn’t he? Glory to God, sure. But glory to Bach, too. It’s still vanity—just in cassock and candlelight.

“Artists create because they *must*. Whether from turmoil, vanity, or the need to bargain—art is the outward cry of someone wrestling with feelings they can’t conquer. And that’s God’s problem too.”

Gold frowned. “God wrestles with feelings?”

“He’s my Father. I’ve known Him forever. He’s loving—but He’s a narcissist. He loves only the version of you He wants... and He rages when you disappoint Him.”

We are all, always, disappointing one another.

Light turned his gaze toward the sculpture near the window.

“All artists do. Just ask your wife. That sculpture—eyes closed, serene—turns inward. But what it finds inside... is emptiness. Disappointment.”

He's right. Serenity on the surface—disappointment beneath. And I avoid it.

Cynical bastard. But intuitive.

He gestured toward Rachel's painting. "You can feel it, can't you? That tension—like something is trying to break through.

"It's as if she's trying to extinguish a fire—but fire cannot be contained. Or tamed.

"There's a faint wash of gray beneath her vibrant landscape. Ask her why."

I already know.

Gold's jaw tightened. Rage, silent and unspoken, gathered in his throat—that subject was off-limits. He blinked fast and coughed—just enough to pass for physical discomfort, not emotional collapse. His eyes flicked toward Rachel's painting, then to his desk. He unscrewed the water bottle from earlier.

That faint wash of gray—that's what lingers just beneath her surface.

"Water?" Gold asked, voice calm but strained. "Flat or sparkling—I have both."

"No, thank you." Light didn't miss a beat. "Some create to be seen—to hear the world say, 'You matter.' Proof that they existed.

That's her legacy. Her immortality.

"They might be brilliant—but they don't feel it. Their work means little to them. It's great... but empty. Accidentally great."

Gold returned to his chair, slipping into his "just listen" posture—hand clasped, jaw tight.

"The ones who create for themselves? They don't need to share it. They're trying to make sense of it all—the chaos of feelings swirling around inside. Canvas, clay, keyboard—their only therapists.

"As you said, emotion is how people express their feelings—art is emotion.

"Emily Dickinson wrote almost 1,800 poems—shared barely a dozen. They were for her.

“Kafka, wrote only for himself—ordering Max Brod to burn it all.

“They wrote because they needed to—for themselves, not for anyone else.

“I hope I’m not overstepping—but her sculpture, her painting—she’s screaming inside.

Is he trying to provoke me? She lost a child. God damn it.

God—damn you!

Rachel... I’m sorry. I wish I’d been there for you. I should be there for you now. But I’ve been hiding beneath my own gray storm cloud.

Gold broke his silence, taking his finger off his lips.

Enough!

“Samuel, the art lecture was brilliant. But my wife? My life? Off-limits.

“Let’s bring this back to *you*. Your father. That’s why you’re here.”

Fuck him. That’s why he’s here.

But don’t lose it... Control.

Gold drew a deep breath. Feeling the reprimand, Light bowed his head slightly. No trace of a smirk.

“Understood, Dr. Gold. I apologize if I crossed a line. I only meant to say—most artists create because they have to—it’s need, not choice. Clearly your wife is gifted.

“I’ll respect your boundaries. I’m sorry.

“What I’m saying is—like all great artists, my Father is volatile. Temperamental. Emotional.

“A finished work? It’s just what the artist lets survive, not always intentionally.

“The problem is—we don’t understand His art. We don’t know what He’s trying to say. He doesn’t know what He’s trying to say. He wrestles with Himself—again and again—throwing off His

own balance.”

Sounds like I need Him on the couch.

Interesting question.

Is God unbalanced?

Gesturing toward the Pollock print, Light said, “Did Pollock know what it would look like when he started? Did he even care?”

It’s not even possible.

“Or was the art only the act itself—the chaos itself—the canvas its tombstone?”

Performance art... or cathartic art.

“Scratch any masterpiece and ghosts bleed through—half-born dreams, abandoned lives, truths whitewashed.

“How did Pollock know when to stop dripping? How many worlds lie buried beneath the one we see—how many masterpieces lost?

“Scratch any masterpiece and ghosts bleed through—half-born dreams, abandoned lives, truths whitewashed.

“Picasso painted over his own canvases. Van Gogh too—old images buried beneath new color. How many worlds lie beneath the one we see?

“The final version isn’t the most honest. It’s just the latest version.”

Good point. People are palimpsests—layers scraped, overwritten, repainted—until the original self is almost gone.

Gold nodded in agreement. “Yes... I see it in therapy. People repaint themselves—but it’s still the same canvas. Same cracks. Same grain. Same flaws. Subtle, but undeniable.

“You’re not the same person at sixty as you were at twenty—or even forty. But no matter how hard you scrape, cover, repaint previous layers—old colors bleed through. Past textures push their way to the surface. What’s buried doesn’t stay buried. Trauma always resurfaces.”

Most people are redrawn portraits—clinging to the version that hurts least, not the one that's true. Forgetting what lies beneath—or trying to. That's why they come to me.

Light leaned in, animated. “Exactly. God did the same—with His art, and with Himself.”

“Some of His works—masterpieces. Stars, rainbows, snowflakes, horses—miracles in motion.

“But others? Tornadoes, floods, wildfires. Mosquitoes. The platypus. Influenza. And mankind.”

“Mankind—a canvas He’s repainted four times... so far.”

Gold blinked, “Wait. Four?”

CHAPTER TWELVE

Bible Study

*Both read the Bible day and night
But thou read'st black where I read white.*
— William Blake, *The Everlasting Gospel* (c. 1818)

*The most dangerous condition of all—losing oneself—
can occur so quietly that it is as if it were nothing at all.*
— Søren Kierkegaard, *The Sickness Unto Death* (1849)

Thursday, evening

“Yes, Dr. Gold. There was a race before Adam—just as subservient as we were. So He painted over them... with Adam and Eve.

“That’s when I suggested the idea of the Tree—the choice between good and evil.”

Gold leaned forward—eyebrows raised, surprise in his voice. “You mean *you* created it?”

Light shook his head. “Not a tree. A metaphor. A symbol: choice itself. Man needed the freedom to obey or rebel. That was the only way he could be different. The only way God could get what He sought.

“I had to talk Him into it. Adam would be no different from the first race without choice.”

*Here we go. Did he defy his father—or build
someone to do it for him?*

“So Samuel, if the tree—free will—was your idea, then you weren’t surprised when they ate the *forbidden fruit*. That must have been *your* plan all along. Tempting mankind with knowledge. Defying your Father.”

Light didn’t flinch. He leaned forward, voice low but steady.

“No, Dr. Gold...” A hint of a smirk tugged at his mouth. “I’m no snake.” His smile lingered, sharp as a blade. “That’s just how truth got rewritten as fiction. The serpent story—just a shadow of me. I told you—I get blamed for everything.”

That smirk—controlled, dangerous. Calculated.

“Adam and Eve had the choice: obey or rebel. That was the only way God could get honest, unfiltered feedback. Artists don’t like critics. Praise without risk isn’t praise. That’s why God created Adam and Eve in the first place. However, once they began questioning Him, He hated it. That’s when He made them leave Eden.”

Gold’s brow furrowed. “Samuel, as you could imagine, this is a lot to process. But why does Genesis punish Eve? Why would she be celebrated—admired—like Prometheus?”

Light smirked. “Free will? The writers were men, Dr. Gold. Ask an anthropologist, not me. I’m blamed for it too. The ‘Fall’? Just a landlord dispute. They broke the rules.”

His energy’s sharpening—controlled, but rising.

“I argued with Him about Cain and Abel. He favored Abel’s offering—for no reason. Of course Cain was upset. Humiliated.

“God didn’t have to shame Cain. He offered what he had. Not Eden’s easy fruit—this was dry, unyielding soil. He was tired, hungry. And still, he gave God his first harvest. It wasn’t enough.”

Gold looked puzzled. “Did free will blind God? Omniscient no more?”

Light shook his head sharply. “No. That’s Him. It was never enough with my Father. Nothing was ever enough for Him.”

“It was never enough with my Father.” He’s talking about his father. The disappointment, both ways. Wish I could get them both on the couch.

“Cain was angry. Justifiably. When they were gathering water at the brook, Abel taunted him—rubbing in his status as God’s favorite.

Yes. I know. Cain killed Abel.

“They fought—like brothers do. Pushing, shoving. Abel kicked water into Cain’s face, but slipped—lost his footing on the wet stones.

“Cain reached out and grabbed him, but both their hands were slick with water. Abel lost his grip and fell backward—his skull striking a jagged rock.”

What the hell—Cain didn’t strike him.

“Cain froze, eyes wide. He had never seen death before.

“Later, God demanded an explanation, but Cain couldn’t process what had happened. He didn’t know what to say—only that he felt a deep, suffocating guilt. He never said, ‘Am I my brother’s keeper.’ That was added centuries later.”

“God’s fury burned, His mouth spitting fire.”

I saw that with my dad too.

“I knew death—I shielded Cain. Begged God to spare him. I told Him what I’d seen, how it was an accident—but He wouldn’t listen. He never forgives.

“He cursed him. Banished him—forever.

“Cain always carried that guilt. He was never the same.

“Abel’s death? God’s fault.”

“God’s fault?” Gold asked.

“In law, there’s the ‘*but-for*’ test. *But for* God humiliating Cain, Abel would still be alive.

“Cain didn’t kill Abel—God did.”

The first death—first crime—an accident? And Cain’s mark... not punishment, but guilt. A scar on the soul. No parole.

Light continued, voice urgent now. “Of course God wouldn’t ever have taken the blame. He wanted to punish Cain, make him the scapegoat. But I convinced Him—protect Cain. At least make sure no one would harm him.”

‘No one?’ No one else existed.

Gold asked, cautious, skeptical. “You were there? You

witnessed it?”

“Yes, Dr. Gold. I’m telling you the truth.”

He continued. “God tried again—ordered Us Angels to help father a new race.”

“He ordered you to father mankind?”

Gold reached for his water bottle, stretching just enough to glimpse the time on his watch.

I’ll be very late. Rachel will be furious. Hurt.

Gold winced. Her hurt registered before his own.

*Oster warned me. Don’t get caught up in the story.
Stay grounded.*

But where is this all going?

“Not man. A new race. He bred us like cattle—obedience mixed with man’s free will. But it didn’t work. Our offspring—the Nephilim—too strong-willed. Unruly for Him.

The room fell into silence.

Light dropped his head, his breath hitching. He slipped off the ring and cradled it to his chest. His fingers traced the worn surface, the engraved words sending a quiet ripple through him.

He wasn’t reminiscing. He was reliving it. That moment. That choice. The scars it left. Its weight felt heavier now than ever.

Light rotated it slowly in his hands, whispering the inscription—too soft for Gold to hear. “Son… find peace in heaven.”

Haunted—by a memory of the battle that cast him out.

Gold noticed the ring—wet. Tears from Light’s bowed head, falling onto the gold.

Don’t interrupt. Let him feel it. This is his moment.

Still not meeting Gold’s eyes, Light paused—as though the words weighed too much to carry.

His fingers trembled: tears stained the gold. His breath shallow, he relived the past—trying to reconcile what he had lost, and what he had done.

At last, he looked up—eyes dark, unreadable. Then in a voice barely a whisper—guttural, broken—he broke the silence with a depth Gold couldn't fathom.

"So God ordered me to destroy them all. Our children, all of them, my own children."

Don't push. He needs this.

After a moment, Light sniffled deeply, and looked up at Gold. A new resolve—serious, steady—shone in Light. Gold hadn't seen this before. His eyes, still pooled with tears, but sparkling as though on fire beneath, staring directly into Gold's—

"That was my bite of the apple. That's when I saw it—He wasn't righteous. He was reckless. Evil. Indifferent to the lives He made me destroy.

He was forced to destroy his own children.

Gold inhaled slowly, steadying himself. This didn't feel delusional anymore. It might have been metaphor, but the feelings were real—personal.

These weren't fables; they were survival myths, carved from trauma.

God... what really happened to him?

"Scripture says man turned evil. Not true. They just stopped obeying. They chose.

"Then—the Flood. God saw one man: devout, reverent, obedient.

"He told me—save Noah. Drown the rest."

Light's voice cracked. A tremor of fury escaped—then vanished.

"Mothers. Fathers. Begging. Children.

"I heard them all. Every scream. Every infant's cry."

Light's eyes squeezed shut—watching, hearing it again.

"I still hear them."

He's reliving it. PTSD.

He leaned in, anger flashing, rage barely contained.

“I made Him promise—never again. But it didn’t matter. Soon, He sent me to destroy Sodom and Gomorrah.

“Man was growing strong again. Independent. That terrified Him. So He had me confuse their tongues—shatter their unity. Scatter them.”

Gold shook his head slowly, a long breath escaping—disappointment in every syllable.

Okay. Play along—sympathy.

This is his metaphor—his father, his past. It’s how he survives, whatever really happened.

“I understand your anger. Your disappointment. I can’t imagine having to do that—to destroy nearly all life on Earth.”

As he recounted the Flood, Light wore the hollow stare of a surgeon who’d lost a patient—and couldn’t wash the blood off his hands.

“I saw it—He didn’t destroy mankind for wickedness. He destroyed them for their indifference. For not flattering Him enough.

“God agreed to give man free will because I argued praise only matters when it’s not guaranteed. When man refused Him—when free will didn’t yield applause—God raged. Not like a judge. Like a wounded artist—destroying his paintings. And He made me destroy them all. Again and again.”

I get it now.

Whatever he did—or believes he did—he’s drowning in guilt. Survivor guilt. Sorrow without shore.

Reality fractured into myth—something survivable. But the blood’s still on his hands. And he knows it.

Still nothing about his mother. That wound. Abuse? Anger? Disappointment? It’ll have to wait... for now.

“Samuel, thank you for trusting me. I’m beginning to understand the trauma you’ve carried—you carry. I’m sorry.”

Gold leaned in, resting his hand on Light’s knee—a fragile

bridge, but real. “You left. You survived. How.”

Again. Felt like I had to touch him—physically.

Is my sympathy turning me into an empath?

Light softened. For the first time, he looked... almost grateful.

Use the metaphor. Let it be his shield. He’s had enough destruction.

“Samuel... when you said you ‘took a bite of the apple.’ What did that mean? What did you do?”

‘Bite of the apple’... he felt powerless. But what was his bite?

What did you do? What was your ‘bite,’ Samuel?

Gold’s hand lingered. He held Light’s gaze

Is this it? His moment of change?

Light nodded, voice catching. “I disobeyed—after His covenant with Abraham.”

Light’s voice faltered. “Out of nowhere, He ordered Abraham: kill your son, Isaac.”

Back to Sunday school.

“Isaac was Sarah’s miracle. She waited ninety-one years. What did she—or he—ever do to deserve such cruelty?”

*What did Rachel do to deserve her infertility?
Nothing. She was a victim.*

“Said He needed to test Abraham’s faith, his obedience.

“That’s when I knew—I couldn’t obey Him anymore.

“But I had to be careful. I *knew* what He was capable of.

“If I hadn’t stepped in—held back Abraham’s hand, found a ram—there’d be no Israelites. No Christianity. No Islam.”

Gold sat stunned—yet riveted.

“There was no hiding it. God knew the smoke wasn’t human. I begged Him—accept it. But He was furious.

“I told Him—punish *me*. Not Abraham. It was *my* fault.”

Gold asked, softly, “So... what was your punishment?”

Light pointed to the top shelf of Gold’s bookcase. “Right there—*Job*. That story’s pretty accurate.

“That’s how I became... the *evil one*.”

Seriously? He believes this.

“After the Flood, God felt more secure—bragging about how mankind loved Him. Worshiped Him. He told me about Job. Upright. Pious. Obedient.

“God was omniscient. I argued—of course Job was obedient. He feared God. And rightly so.

“I never said it aloud, but Job knew what happened to those who disobeyed.

“I told Him—Job was generously rewarded. The man was rich. You don’t bite the hand that feeds you.

“God was furious. He shouted—‘Job is pious! He loves Me! Even if he had nothing, he’d still love Me. Worship Me.’

“A smile slipped—I shouldn’t have.

“I’d already disobeyed Him with Abraham—and now I was laughing. Challenging Him.

“Job was my punishment.

“God knew what it cost me—destroying the Nephilim. Destroying mankind.

“He knew how hard it was for me.” Light’s voice trembled, memory burning through him.

“He commanded me: kill Job’s children, but spare his wife. I quickly found out why. He wanted to torture me and Job—I still hear her screams. And for what? To prove I was wrong?

“Creation was easy. Life meant nothing to Him. No value. No meaning.

“I was His son.

“All of it—just so God could win.”

Gold interrupted, “But if God’s omniscient—why torture

Job... you? Why prove what He already knows? Why make him suffer?"

His fist struck his thigh once, tight with fury. "Exactly! And I take the blame. The truth? Job *did* curse God. I remember—he blamed me. When I told him I was only following orders, he said, 'What the fuck did I do to piss Him off? I spend half of my day—*every day*—thanking him for everything I have.'

"Then, after God gave him new wealth and new children, Job looked at me and said, 'Why would He kill my children? What kind of sick fuck would do that?'

"I knew exactly how he felt. But all I could do was repeat the litany: 'He is the Lord your God—angry, vengeful. Do not question Him or His ways.'

Of course, it was in Aramaic—but that was the gist."

He's fucking with me. Is he waiting for me to realize it?

"Job never cursed God directly, not to His face—you'd have to be crazy to do that. He knew what would happen to his wife. But there were times he'd whisper curses, and I couldn't blame him."

"Think about the scars—psychological, spiritual. Even after God gave them new children, more riches... they were never happy again.

"But they stayed faithful. What else could they do? They knew what He'd do—what He'd have *me* do. It wasn't worship; it was fear."

Gold asked, carefully, "So this—this was your awakening? Your bite of the apple? When you realized right and wrong?"

Light's face darkened. Brow furrowed. "No," he said softly. "It wasn't about right and wrong. It was good and evil. And I learned—God isn't love. God is dangerous. I wanted nothing more to do with Him."

So he rebelled. He saw what 'good' was, and chose its opposite.

I remember these stories—but not like this. He can't really believe it... can he? But if he does—if he really

remembers—he's psychotic. I'm out of my depth.

Light's voice rose—emotion breaking through. “He had me destroy cities. Peoples. All of mankind—why? Because a few didn't worship Him enough? It's madness!”

He's right—it is madness. He's madness. I fucked up. He's psychotic.

When do I tell him? This isn't just trauma. He needs real psychiatric care.

“The last straw... was Moses. That's when I left.”

Moses?

“I upset Him—so much He nearly destroyed mankind again. Right after Moses led the Hebrews out of Egypt.”

And back to Sunday school again.

Light continued. “God called them stiff-necked. Stubborn. They started worshipping other gods—again—when He and Moses disappeared up Mount Sinai, which was actually Mount Horeb, too long. I suggested He write them down—His laws—so mankind would know.”

“They were scared. Tired. Starving. Even after they saw the Red Sea part, they were furious when they didn't immediately find the land of milk and honey God promised.

“The trip to Canaan? Ten, eleven days. They were infuriated. Some explained the Red Sea scientifically. Others said Egyptian gods helped. So they made an idol. The golden calf.”

I should've paid more attention at the Seders. Back then, just songs and soup.

But how long do I enable this? Am I nourishing it?

“The calf echoed Egypt: Hathor, the horned mother; Apis, the bull of rebirth.”

Gold leaned forward. “This is fascinating, Samuel, but...”

Light pressed on, relentless. “I don't know when I'd ever seen God so angry.”

He needs this catharsis.

“He vowed to burn the earth—consume every living thing. Moses and I begged Him.”

“You both spoke with God?”

“Yes, we explained—the Hebrews lived in Egypt for generations. God had been busy elsewhere. Of course they were used to Egyptian gods. All the people had gods. Why? Because he’d only spoken to a few prophets. Hardly anyone knew Him.

“Write it down. Teach them to read... your laws. So I helped with the first two laws—‘I am your God, who brought you out of Egypt. Thou shalt have no other gods before Me.’ And since he was so upset about the calf, I suggested a second: ‘Thou shalt not make a graven image.’ He agreed. Even admitted He’d been jealous. But then He added the penalty—‘the iniquity of the fathers upon the children.’”

*He wrote the Ten Commandments? DID?
Delusional disorder? I’m out of my league—maybe Bob
will know.*

Light went on. “That calmed Him—briefly.

“When He denied Moses entry to Canaan—for striking a rock instead of speaking—I tried again. I told Him—Moses was performing. A million starving people couldn’t hear him whisper to a rock. So he struck it—dramatically, theatrically. So they’d all see the power of the Lord.

“But God said—disobedience. So Moses would die. Alone. Mount Nebo.

“That was it. I knew Moses. I saw myself in him. That’s when I left Him—for good.”

Light’s voice softened, almost pleading. “Dr. Gold... I know you don’t believe me. But at first, we couldn’t disobey.”

“We all had free will. But like children, it took time—to recognize it. To dare to use it.

“Free will comes with responsibility. Most never questioned. Never disobeyed.

“They called it loyalty. But it was fear. Fear, the kind Job knew.

“After Moses, I wasn’t afraid anymore.

“I’d seen it too many times—His rage, His contradictions. I realized what every child sees eventually: parents are just children in bigger bodies. Flawed. Dangerous.”

So that’s it. Angels saw God as a parent—powerful, feared, obeyed without question. Not loyalty—Stockholm syndrome. Fear twisted into devotion. Gratitude for survival—not love.

Stockholm syndrome. I once joked that was the secret to marriage. Rachel didn’t laugh.

Parents pass down their private hell. How the hell am I supposed to help him?

If his father was really like this—how do you teach someone who’s only known fear?

And if his father really is God—what the fuck am I even saying?

He’s lost it—and he’s pulling me with him.

Time to call his bluff.

Gold took a long breath. “Samuel... I need to be honest. I thought I could help—with your father. With your self-concept.

“But now... I don’t know. I honestly don’t know how to help you. If I even can.”

He shifted in his chair, the weight of it pressing into him.

“Like most kids, I grew up on Bible stories. Mythology. I loved them—but I saw what they were. Explanations. Parables. Not truths.”

Maybe he’s right.

Maybe I’m not an atheist after all. Maybe I am just angry at God.

I remember rewriting my bedtime prayers at eleven—after learning that my grandfather had gone blind as a young man. Even then, I knew the stories were myths. Not truths.

Light looked deflated. Hollow.

“I know we agreed to a stipulation. But I don’t think this *gedankenexperiment* can work anymore.

“If you truly believe—or *know*—you’re Satan... I have no way to comprehend what you’ve lived. None.”

This gives me a way out.

I like him. It’s intellectually stimulating—but it’s not fair to him. It’s not what he needs.

He rubbed his palms against his knees—trying to anchor himself.

“If I *really* thought you were an angel... I’d be asking where God came from. If there’s life after death. What the hell the meaning of life is. All the questions we’ve begged for millennia.

“A therapist doesn’t need to live a patient’s life to help. But this?”

He shook his head. “This is different. No practicum in treating deities. I’ve got nothing to draw from.”

Light was slumped over in his seat. Clearly disappointed. Resigned. Defeated.

Wait. That’s not true.

My father—stern, unquestioned. I obeyed.

I never understood my mother. Never really knew her.

I can’t give up on him. Not yet. We share more than I realized.

Gold inhaled. Steadied himself.

“I’m not giving up, Samuel. I’m just trying to figure out *how* to help you.

“You said you weren’t happy—you wanted to be normal. But if you’re Satan—if you’re an angel—what does normal even mean?”

“I agreed to this therapy—because honestly, I never believed you were Satan. But I saw trauma. Deep trauma. Something you

needed to face.

“Defenses form out of necessity—like a scab. They protect, help healing start—even if the scar never fades.”

“I think these biblical stories—they’re defenses. Not lies. Not delusions.

“Distractions, distortions—survival tools for the unresolved.”

He swallowed.

“As a criminal attorney, you don’t always need to know the truth. You defend, not judge.

“But as a therapist? Truth matters.

“Sometimes even the patient doesn’t know the truth. Defense mechanisms blur reality, fantasy, delusion. They keep you safe—but trapped, too.”

Gold leaned back, watching Light spin the ring—a tiny orbit of control in a universe of pain.

A hint of a smile, subtle acknowledgement.

He kept spinning the ring.

Shit. Did I fuck up? Is he about to turn—prove me the fool?

Will he admit he’s been bullshitting me all along?

Am I being played?

Some twisted setup for a magazine piece?

Gold’s chest tightened. He reached for his water bottle, his hands trembling slightly. He wasn’t sure why, but he felt... cold.

Not the AC—something deeper.

Light’s smile lingered—not a smirk, but something sadder.

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

Every Angel is Terrifying

“Every angel is terrifying.”

— Rainer Maria Rilke, *Duino Elegies* (1923)

Thursday, evening

“Dr. Gold, I’m sorry if you think I’ve wasted your time. But I’ve been honest with you—from the start. You’ll remember, I even warned you I’m often too honest.”

“Everything I’ve told you is the truth. You question it—dismiss it as *blurred reality*.”

Light continued, “How can I prove it? I can’t spit fire, fly, or vanish in a puff of smoke. No magic tricks. So how do I make you believe I am who I say I am?”

“I’m sorry, Samuel, but it’s difficult. I think it was in Exodus, God told Moses He couldn’t show him His face.”

“Yes. ‘Thou canst not see My face, for man shall not see Me and live.’”

“It reminded me of Carl Sagan’s invisible dragon in the garage.”

Light sighed. “Yes, I know the argument. The invisible dragon. Russell’s teapot. But at least a teapot, if it existed, would occupy space. You’d only need the right telescope and the right coordinates.”

Gold waited.

“God isn’t hiding in orbit, Dr. Gold. Maybe man keeps failing to find Him because he keeps looking in the wrong direction.”

Gold leaned forward. “People say, ‘Just look at His works.’ But science offers its own explanations—gravity, evolution, entropy. Not exactly divine fingerprints. And when pressed, the theist retreats to: ‘He always was, always will be.’”

Gold shrugged, easing back. “If God is your Father... then who was His?”

Light's ring spun again—unconsciously.

There. He's doing it again.

Looking down at the ring, Light said, "Consider the relationship between truth and reality—truth isn't binary."

Gold lifted his hand, interrupting. "But Samuel, truth often depends on where you're standing. Perspective can change—doesn't that change the truth?"

"Your truth. That's exactly what I mean—truth fractures under inspection. Forgive the lawyer in me, but a judge or jury must weigh mitigating factors. Witnesses to the same accident tell different stories, depending on where they stood—physically, psychically, spiritually."

Gold nodded, caught in the philosophical current. "Yes. In my profession, I've learned that truth is subjective—in psychology, and I suppose in law as well."

"Right," Light continued. "It's not simple. And belief without evidence—in spite of the evidence—that's faith."

Or sometimes delusion.

"That's why it's so hard for people to accept other religions, other 'truths,'" Gold said. "But even when shaped by psychology, some objective reality still remains—though it may look different depending on where you're standing."

Light smiled faintly. "So we tell ourselves. But which part is objective reality—the impact, the intent, the memory that lingers twenty years later? Objective reality is the illusion we cling to when the subjective becomes unbearable."

We live in a real world. That's his problem—he pretends he doesn't. He's trying to ignore the rules of reality.

Gold's brow furrowed. "Illusion or not—patients jump from windows. Children are abused. People die. That's not just unbearable—it's real."

Light's smile held. "Of course it's real. But reality isn't always what you think. Pain exists.

"So do dreams—

“and angels—

“and God.”

Gold’s expression hardened. “But dreams are only dreams. Magritte’s painting is not a pipe. Fairy tales? They’re for children.”

Light’s gaze sharpened. “Do you feel better when you label it ‘objective’?”

Sometimes a cigar is just a cigar.

“As if that makes it manageable—or less your fault? Does calling something ‘real’ help you sleep? Does it absolve you?”

Absolve me? What am I guilty of?

“We’ve all broken a few commandments, Samuel. Hard to be human without it.”

Light leaned back, voice soft. “We all want to believe in facts, Dr. Gold. But it’s not facts that wake us in the night.

“We’re all guilty.”

Peeking in my mind again? But he’s right—fairy tales are for children, nightmares aren’t.

Gold exhaled sharply, forcing a tight smile. “You’d make a good therapist—you’re skilled at turning questions into mirrors.”

Light didn’t smile. “What would your mirror reflect, Dr. Gold?”

He’s challenging me—avoiding his own issues.

Gold’s voice lowered. He fidgeted in his chair. “That I do my job. That I help people.”

“Do you, Dr. Gold?” Light asked softly. “All of them?”

Gold looked down, adjusting the pen on his notepad—though he hadn’t written a word in minutes. “I try.”

But sometimes trying isn’t enough.

A silence hung in the room.

Don’t keep playing his game.

Light’s voice dropped to a whisper. “Trying didn’t seem to

help your father.”

Gold’s head snapped up.

“Enough!” His voice cracked like a whip.

He sat forward, eyes locked on Light’s—searching for a trace of a smirk, hoping to find one. His notepad slipped to the floor. “I told you—my personal life is off-limits. We’re here to work on *your* issues, not to have you play therapist with me.”

Gold felt heat rise, his face reddening, his neck burning.

Light stayed silent—calm, watching.

Keep it together. Don’t let him provoke you. This is his defense.

Gold’s pulse hammered, uneven.

Shit—I’m in AFib.

“You crossed the line again. That’s strike two, Samuel.”

Don’t make threats you won’t back up. Rip off the Band-Aid.

Gold drew in a sharp breath. “I’m sorry, Samuel—but you being the biblical Satan, an angel, a member of God’s heavenly court? It’s not possible. It isn’t truth. It’s... delusion.”

He hesitated, fearful of voicing his thoughts, then—

“You may act like Satan—but the reality is, you’re not. It isn’t possible.”

Okay, a little passive-aggressive. But he gets under my skin.

Light leaned forward—slowly—like a predator scenting weakness.

“Dr. Gold—I agree. It’s not possible... for you. At least, not right now.

“But that doesn’t make it less true.”

Gold picked up his pad, slowly regaining composure.

Light continued. “As a psychologist—someone who deals with processes, phenomena, manifestations of the psyche—does it

really matter? What difference does it make whether you and I believe the same thing?”

“You’re Jewish. Does it matter if a patient is Catholic, or Hindu? Are their needs truly different? Are you unable to help them just because they believe something different about this life—or the next?”

“Are there no universal experiences, universal truths, universal emotions, universal behaviors we all share?”

I made that same argument when they said I couldn't treat addicts or alcoholics—because I'd never been one.

“You’re right, Samuel—universal experiences exist. That was the heart of Jung’s psychology. Archetypes are universal, but people manifest them individually.”

Keep it brief. Don't lose him. Calm down.

“Everyone has dreams, myths, and emotional experiences—reflections of timeless patterns shaped by life, culture, symbols.

Gold sat back, letting Light take the floor.

“So my truth—what you call a belief—that I’m Satan, an angel from the heavenly court—you dismiss as pathology. Untreatable?” Light smiled, as if scoring a point.

“You feel threatened by my truth—or by what you’d call my claim that it’s true.

“Does accepting my belief as true, negate yours? Can’t both things be true?”

No...

Can they?

Trying to make sense of him is like wearing someone else's contact lenses—everything's warped, misaligned, painful.

“Why does my knowing who I am—what my experiences have been—require your acceptance, your approval? Why do you get to be the arbiter of reality?”

Light’s brow clenched, his face stern. “Why have you

rewritten the First Commandment—‘Thou shalt have no other realities before mine’?

“Even if you are the god of reality, can’t there be others—each with their own truths, their own realities?”

“Why won’t you allow me to have mine?”

Let it go. It’s rhetorical. He’s just playing devil’s advocate.

“I see Thomas Szasz on your shelf. Didn’t he argue that psychiatry was used politically—to silence and control?”

“Didn’t he say people don’t suffer from their beliefs, but from society’s reaction to them?”

“Yes... Szasz said, ‘Delusions are not false beliefs—but beliefs that are false *and unshared*.’”

“We don’t diagnose illness; we label unpopular beliefs and behaviors as conditions.

“The disease label delegitimizes people who believe what society rejects—regardless of whether it’s objectively true.”

Am I doing this with Light? I reject his belief and call it delusional. But is that because of him—or me? Am I unable—or unwilling—to see through his eyes?

“Dr. Gold—you’re arguing with yourself.”

He reads me too well. I hate it.

“You’re wondering just how unbalanced I am. You call me delusional.

“I call it clarity. Tell me—what if it’s your instruments that are broken? What if your frame of reference is too narrow to perceive reality?”

I found the Devil in my closet—wearing my shoes.

Light glanced over at the bookshelf.

“William Blake said, ‘*If the doors of perception were cleansed everything would appear to man as it is—infinite.*’ But he continued, ‘*For man has closed himself up, till he sees all things through narrow chinks of his cavern.*’”

“I’m not the one trapped in the cavern, Dr. Gold. I see it all—the flame, the shadows, the wall, and those who cast them.

“You admire Einstein, don’t you? In one of his famous *Gedankenexperiments*, he asked what it would mean to ride a beam of light.

“He discovered something terrifying—that light doesn’t see the world as we do. There’s no time. No distance. Everything simply is. From light’s perspective, your whole life is a blink—less than that.”

Now I’m trapped in a physics lecture.

“You call that a physical constant. But when I speak in constants—good and evil, creation and consequence—you call it pathology. You flinch.

“Why? Because I don’t slow down for your perceptions? Because I’m not bound by your little calendar of grief and guilt?

“You think I’m the distortion. But it’s you—your colleagues and your tidy diagnostic categories—who are all moving, skewed, bent by the weight of your need to believe the world is ordered... balanced... that it all makes sense.

“Well, Dr. Gold—your need for order tips that balance. It threatens to topple the scale—your very definition of sanity.”

Light paused. The room fell silent.

He tilted his head, studying Gold with unsettling calm. “I’m not saying you’re afraid of me, Dr. Gold. But perhaps you’re afraid of yourself.”

Without thinking, Gold touched his wedding ring to his lips—an old reflex he hardly registered—before forcing his hand back down.

Gold didn’t respond. He sat staring ahead, unfocused. He still faintly heard—maybe even felt—his pulse in his ears. Uneven. Out of sync.

What had once been pleasant in Light’s cologne now assaulted his nostrils.

His eyes drifted toward the bookshelf, sliding from spine to spine.

The Mask of Sanity.

My definition of sanity? I'm not so sure anymore.

Maybe that's what he wants—to get me questioning everything. To untether me. Destabilize me.

"I don't distort truth, Dr. Gold. I reveal it. But to you, it looks like madness—of course it does. You can't ride the beam; you can only glimpse it—and recoil.

"Einstein tried to see the world from light's point of view. But it broke reality's rules. Time stopped. Distance disappeared. The laws no longer applied.

"Light wasn't wrong—the frame was."

'Light wasn't wrong.' That has to be intentional.

Light's point of view.

Light's jaw tightened slightly.

"And that, Dr. Gold, is exactly what you're doing with me—measuring me by laws that don't apply. Calling me insane because I don't conform to the way you've been taught to see."

Light slid to the edge of his seat, his eyes clamping onto Gold like a vice.

His voice softened. "So I ask you, Dr. Gold—am I really insane?"

"Are you willing to look through the open door?"

He paused, smiling faintly.

"Or are you afraid of what happens when the observer becomes the observed?"

That phrase... Did he see my notes?

He glanced down at his notepad—the page was blank. He hadn't written a single note since Light mentioned his father.

No, he couldn't have. I didn't write it. I only thought it!

The hairs on Gold's neck bristled.

He's guessing. Has to be. But that wasn't a guess.

He says he's not the mad one. It's us—me, Rachel, Bob, the whole world—tipping off balance. And he's almost convinced me. I almost believe him.

He's redrawn the coordinates entirely. Like light bent around a massive star—everything—my training, my language, my sanity—warps around him.

And if he's right—if he really sees more clearly than the rest of us—then what does that make me?

I thought I was the observer. But I'm the one being watched. Measured. Dismantled.

Maybe I'm accelerating toward a truth I can't survive.

“Provocative arguments, Samuel. But society only works because we agree on a shared reality. Without it, everything collapses.

“My job—as your doctor, your therapist—is to help you see reality, accept it, and learn how to live within it. That's the work.”

Good. Ground him—ground me. Don't let him tilt the axis again.

Light didn't blink.

“Dr. Gold, you seem determined to ignore the reality: that I am an angel of God.”

He won't let go.

“Samuel, I know you believe you are an angel of God. But believing something—no matter how strongly—does not make it real.”

“Look around, Dr. Gold.” He gestured at the books. “Your art. Your hunger for beauty. You chase awe. You deify thought. You wrap fear in analysis—and longing in abstraction.”

His voice dropped.

“You know what My Father said: ‘Thou shalt have no other

gods before Me... thou shalt not make unto thee any graven image.”

He turned back toward the shelves, shoulders taut, chest rising.

Gold pressed his index finger to his upper lip until it whitened—holding himself back.

“You worship intellect and art. They’re your graven images.” He waved toward the bookshelf. “Your altar.”

Gold raised his eyebrows despite himself. “You’re comparing insight to idolatry?”

“I’m naming it.”

Light’s gaze sharpened.

“You think intellect lifts you above it all—that it saves you from becoming *Nebuchadnezzar*, scraping at the earth, forgotten by the divine. You mistake Blake’s *Newton* for your cure.

“But like Newton, you refuse to admit there’s a world beyond the rational circle you’ve drawn with your compass. You’re blind to the organic. The mystical. The unseen.

“You think seeing everything makes you free. It doesn’t. Racehorses wear blinders for a reason. Free their eyes completely, and they lose the race.”

Why is he attacking me?

Light leaned in, a crooked grin cutting across his face.

“Newton crouches the same way Nebuchadnezzar crawls—both bowed—one with a compass, one with claws.”

Gold cut in sharply. “That’s just metaphor. Intellect lifts us from instinct—that’s what makes us human.”

“No, Dr. Gold. It only lets you pretend you’re more than animal—while you rot inside your crowned skull.”

What the fuck is happening? This isn’t defense — it’s attack. Why me?

Why is it shaking me?

“You surround yourself with beauty. You call it divine. Rilke understood. You only pretend to.

“But you don’t.

“Beauty isn’t your salvation—it’s your sentence.”

Gold scoffed. “So beauty’s a punishment now?”

“No.” Light’s voice softened, but chilled. “Beauty is indifferent. It passes over you—perfect, pure—and you tremble, not because it shows mercy, but because it doesn’t bother to destroy you.”

“You cling to sunsets and sonatas like a drowning man to driftwood—desperate, deluded, already sinking. You think they prove the world is good—that God is good.”

He paused.

“But God?” Light smirked. “My Father’s face is Nebuchadnezzar’s—not Moses’. Pride, not humility.

“And man—being made in that image...”

Gold sat straighter. “And the angels?”

“Ah—the angels. Yes.”

Light leaned in, eyes narrowing—accepting the invitation to battle.

“Angels? Pray we never come. Each of us—terrible. Not for cruelty. But for purity.

“We are what you were meant to be. And when you stand before something unblemished, you see yourself—not as you imagine, not as you hope—but as you are.

“Small. Shaking. Unmade.”

Light’s tone softened, distant—almost remote.

“We are what you long for—beauty without blemish, form without flaw. But we do not choose.

“Without free will, we could be neither good nor evil—only obedient. We weren’t virtuous, just... untested. We couldn’t fall.”

Gold pressed. “*You* did—or you were cast out.”

Passive-aggressive? Maybe. But it felt good.

Light looked down, eyes fixed on some far-off point.

“I did.” He paused. “I took that bite—and chose not to

serve any longer.

“I stole the firebrand of free will—the gift He gave man. I shattered the pattern.”

His eyes returned to Gold—narrowed, hardened.

“And in doing so, I became as corrupt as you.”

As corrupt as me? What the hell have I done?

I pushed him too hard. Be careful now.

A long silence followed. The office felt smaller, somehow.

“That’s the truth you’re circling, Dr. Gold. You think reason redeems you, and art saves you. But great art doesn’t lift—it shows you the cliff. How far you’ve fallen. How far you’ll never climb back.”

“My Father learned that. I saw it, I felt it. And I believe you’re starting to see it too—you’ve only just begun to fall.

Light stood slowly, adjusted his coat, glanced once more at the bookshelves.

He paused, then murmured—almost to himself: “You’ll see. Rilke was right... ‘Every angel is terrifying.’”

He turned to the door.

“Next time, ask yourself why you’re so desperate to be saved.”

Without waiting for a reply, he reached into his inside jacket and dropped ten crisp hundred-dollar bills onto the couch where he’d been sitting.

“That should more than cover it.”

He walked to the door without a word. Paused—just long enough to make Gold wonder if he’d turn back—then left, leaving the office in thick, unsettled quiet. A faint smell of Light’s cologne hung in the air.

What did he mean— “You’ll see, every angel is terrifying.”

Gold’s breath stayed shallow, pulse uneven.

Even after he left... something remained.

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

Some Prayers Are Best Unprayed

The past is never dead. It's not even past.
— William Faulkner, *Requiem for a Nun* (1951)

Thursday, evening

Gold sat frozen, eyes fixed on the closed door—as if part of himself had just walked out with Light.

What the hell just happened?

Should I have said something? I never thought he'd actually leave. Will he be back? What did I do? I blew it.

Shoulders slumped, face stiff as a mourner, he shuffled to his desk and pulled out Light's intake folder—still pristine, still untouched. As he opened it, he remembered—

Shit. Yesterday he told me his phone was stolen—no replacement yet.

Guess I wait until Tuesday—if he returns.

Was I appropriate? I wasn't too hard. Firm, yes—but not like his lunatic father.

I let him talk. I listened. I did my job.

Did I lecture too much? I let him tell his Bible stories.

I felt connection. Compassion. I've never touched a patient before. I liked the art discussion.

But he overstepped. He attacked Rachel's art, our marriage—me. Treated me like the patient.

I screwed up. How? I lost control.

There's something unsettling about him. I feel like he's mocking me—taunting me. I don't know.

Satan? Of course not. But I don't know what I believe anymore. He makes me think—that's what I liked.

I hope he's okay. Do I?

Hope?—Hope is the worst of all evils. It prolongs the torments of man. I've always hoped.

I hoped my dad would say I'm proud of you. I love you.

I hoped my mom would hug me—soften and smile without wiping the countertop first.

I hoped marriage would fix my loneliness.

I hoped a child would make Rachel happy.

Shit, I hope Light comes back through that door.

Hope.

Hope is prayer's echo—a beggar pounding on the locked door of an abandoned house.

Bob would call it pessimism. Hope didn't close Pandora's box—it sat at the bottom of it.

Sartre, you were wrong. Hell isn't other people—it's belief in God.

Light was right, I'm angry at God.

Does that mean I believe?

Or am I going mad?

He stood, then sat behind Hadrian's Wall. He closed his notepad, opened his drawer, and slid Light's folder inside.

At least my headache finally went away.

As he closed Light's folder and placed it in the drawer, he noticed a few of his old dream journals, black and white composition notebooks, underneath the small stack of blank manila folders.

Oh yeah.

He pulled one free—its black binding bleached to gray, the cover half-torn and frayed, title scratched to nothing. A survivor, worn and tattered from living beside him for decades.

He sat back in his chair and opened it up.

I remember these. I think.

The journal was stuffed with yellowed notebook scraps—dream fragments. Setting them aside, the inside cover revealed numerous childhood drawings—mostly doodles. Unfamiliar. Some looked as though they'd been drawn by someone else's hand.

The facing page, ripped but taped back together, simply read:

*Steven Gold's First Dream Journal
Confidential!!!*

He chuckled and turned the page.

He found a worn sheet of notebook paper—his own printing, awkward and cramped.

His “Bedtime Prayer,” scrawled in adolescence.

He read the faded words—the memory of long nights and silent fears rushing back as if no time had passed at all.

*Now I lay me down again,
My eyes they flood with dreams.
The rhyme still races through my head—
I don't know what it means.*

*I learned the words so long ago,
Back when I was a child.
And though I try to trust them still,
My heart's unreconciled.*

*The rhyme speaks love for just one God,
And warns that I must fall
If ever I should disobey—
That danger waits for all.*

*You say to keep them on my lips,
And teach my children too,*

*But slowing down the rushing words,
I hear what I'm to do.*

*I must show Him my gratitude—
Freed from certain disaster—
Yet bound again, and still a slave,
Just to another Master.*

*I must obey commandments strict,
Not wander, stray, or lie—
Not follow heart or other paths—
Or forfeit soul and die.*

*So now I lay me down again;
I cannot still my head.
Freed from Pharaoh's chains and whip—
To serve this king instead.*

*My questions nag, won't let me sleep;
You urge me to believe.
But listening closely to these prayers...
I know I've been deceived.*

*So I just lie, night after night,
Afraid to fall asleep—
I don't know if my soul is mine—
Or if it's His to keep.*

*Unbelievable—twenty years plus gone, and I'd
almost forgotten this was mine. That writing—I can
barely read it.*

He turned the page.

He froze.

Oh God!

The facing page was Gold's own drawing, his copy of Plate VI from Blake's *Illustrations of the Book of Job—Satan smiting Job with boils*.

Jesus.

Gold was far from a talented artist. But he recognized it instantly.

He felt his face tense. A slight shiver ran through him.

Coincidence. Don't go there.

Gold's watch chimed.

Maybe Bob will help me make sense of this—if I'm not already too far gone.

Gold grabbed his iPad and iPhone, stuffed them into his bag, and turned off the office lights, leaving the soft floods above his desk on—a sentinel—as he always did.

He took the elevator down to ten.

He turned left, down the hallway. Dark.

A couple lights out. Something's different—ominous.

The industrial carpet smelled faintly of antiseptic and stale coffee. He felt it tighten his chest—the scent of waiting rooms, of confessions he wasn't ready to make.

Suite 1004
Robert M. Oldman, M.D.
Adult Psychiatry

He paused at the door. Dark wood, silent grain—like a book whose final chapter he dreaded to open.

Beyond lay salvation—or unraveling.

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

Was God Even Watching?

My God, my God, why hast thou forsaken me?

— *Psalms 22:1*

“Tell me what you fear, and I will tell you what has happened to you.”
— *Donald Winnicott, quoted in Adam Phillips, On Kissing, Tickling, and Being Bored (1993)*

Thursday, evening

The door looked like any other—even his own—but crossing its threshold brought a physical sense of relief, release, and a faint thrill. Evening sessions with Oldman were the highlight of Gold’s week. Here, at last, he could talk about himself without apology.

He had been seeing Oldman for twenty years—longer than he had been with Rachel.

Oldman was more than his therapist. He was his closest friend.

Suite 1004

Ten-four. Police code for “okay.”

He had never noticed it before, but it fit—he always left feeling okay after seeing Bob.

Bob Oldman was short, stout, and balding—a man in his mid-sixties with a presence at once familiar and comforting. He wore a thick gray mustache and looked like a character actor you were certain you had seen somewhere, though you could never place the role or the name. He walked with a severe limp—so pronounced it might be mistaken for a prosthetic leg. In truth, it was the legacy of a childhood accident that had never released him.

Their relationship had long since outgrown doctor and patient. As an only child, Gold had come to see Oldman as the older brother he never had—someone he trusted completely, always in his corner.

Oldman felt an even deeper bond—he saw Gold as the younger brother he'd lost, and the guilt he carried bled into their connection.

Oldman was aware of his countertransference, yet he clung to it—it sustained him. He used his relationship with Gold to ease the guilt he carried over Tommy—

Bob was fourteen when he invited his nine-year-old brother Tommy to join a neighborhood stickball game. Most of the boys were Bob's age or older, but everyone knew Tommy from the block. "But Tahmee, ya can't be a whiny baby," Bob warned. "Ya gotta act like one of the guys, or they ain't gonna let ya play. So no cryin' if ya strike out or drop the ball."

"I won't, Bobby, I sweah. Won't cry no mattah what. You'll see—I sweah to God."

On a sweltering Boston afternoon, Tommy was ecstatic to play with the older kids. He idolized Bob—nicknamed "Babe" for his knack at knocking home runs. Bob quietly arranged for Anthony Bruno to pick Tommy for his team.

"Thanks, Tony. This means the world to Tahmee. Kid was so psyched he was up and dressed by six this mornin'. I really owe ya one. He was scared no one would want him, 'cause he's only nine."

Tony surprised everyone when he started choosing his team: "I'm pickin' Tommy fuhst, 'cause I think he'll know how to stop the Babe! Tommy, you play second base, right behind me."

Tommy couldn't have been prouder. Trying to fit in with the big kids, he flipped Bob off and grinned: "Ya goin' down, Babe!" Everyone pointed at Bob and laughed.

After the teams were chosen, Anthony's side took the field. He pitched, placing Tommy at second base—right on the manhole cover—figuring the boy could stop any line-drives or grounders headed that way.

Bob stepped to bat and intentionally lofted an easy pop-up over the pitcher's head so Tommy, at second, could make the catch. Tommy called it the way he had seen the older kids do. "I got it—I got it!" He backed up slowly, theatrically waving everyone away. Laughing, he shouted, "Wicked easy out, Babe!"

As Bob jogged toward first, he glanced back—grinning, proud his plan had worked, thrilled that Tommy would take the first out. Then, beyond his brother’s shoulder, he saw a blue Ford Mustang barreling toward them. He froze, then shouted: “Tahmee, watch out! Get outta the way!”

Tommy didn’t hear—he was still crowing about the easy out. The kids who caught Bob’s shout thought he was razzing, trying to make Tommy drop the ball. The scene unraveled.

Just as Tommy caught the ball, the Mustang struck him from behind. He ricocheted off the bumper like a pool ball and slammed into the low pony wall in front of the Walgreens.

The ball slipped from Tommy’s hand and vanished beneath the Mustang as it clipped Anthony Bruno, the pitcher, and hurled him against a telephone pole. The brakes shrieked an instant before the car plowed into Bob—frozen in horror—slamming him head-on against a florist’s van.

Tommy’s body crumpled on the sidewalk, his head bent against the wall. His T-shirt and one leg of his jeans were shredded as he somersaulted across the asphalt and crashed into the gray cinderblock.

The left side of Tommy’s head had struck the wall, blood streaming down. His shoulder and arm were shredded, skin and muscle torn open. His legs were twisted at grotesque angles, bone protruding through torn flesh.

Tommy screamed, “Bahbee! Bahbee!”—gurgling and choking as bright red blood spilled from his mouth and down his chin.

The stench of burnt rubber filled his nostrils. His vision blurred as he searched frantically, desperate to find Tommy.

Ten yards to his right he spotted Anthony’s body, curled around a telephone pole, motionless. He still heard Tommy’s screams but could not see him—until further up the street he caught sight of his brother’s broken body against the wall. Bob shrieked: “Oh God, Tahmee, Tahmee—I’m comin’, hang on!”

He wasn’t moving. There was no pain—only the terrifying clarity that he could feel nothing at all.

“God, no. I’m comin’—just hang on, Tahmee.” But Bob couldn’t move, trapped by twisted metal, pain, and helplessness.

Through the fogged windshield, Bob saw the driver stir, his face dusted in airbag powder. He recognized him instantly—Darryl Ford, a ninth-grader from school. Darryl's expression was oddly calm, as if waking from a nap—oblivious to the devastation he had caused.

Darryl gave a weak smirk, then let his head fall back. Crushed Budweiser cans fizzed across the dashboard.

“Goddammit! Hang on, Tahmee!”

“Bahbee! I’m sahree—I dropped the ball. I’m really sahree. But I told ya, I wouldn’t cry. I ain’t cryin’... but Bahbee, I don’t feel so good.”

Bob’s cries tore through the street. “Tahmee, hang on. Please, Tahmee—hang on!” Tommy’s voice grew unintelligible, gasping and gurgling as he drowned in his own blood... then silence.

Pinned between the Mustang and the florist’s van, Bob heard only one thing: Tommy’s voice, calling his name.

Even without the Mustang crushing him, his shattered legs and pelvis made it impossible for him to move—to reach Tommy.

Anthony fell into a two-day coma from the concussion. The resulting dissociative amnesia erased the event completely. He never knew what had struck him—yet the damage to his memory, attention, and cognition proved permanent.

He never heard Tommy’s screams or saw the carnage—the very details that still haunt Bob in recurring nightmares.

Darryl, fourteen, escaped with little more than airbag burns. The beer cans were never mentioned in court. His attorney coached him to apologize. He pled guilty to vehicular manslaughter and received probation, community service, and diversion counseling. His parents paid a \$10,000 fine.

Oldman endured seventeen surgeries. For eight years he moved from wheelchair to walker, to crutches, and finally to a cane. The track-like scars across his legs and torso earned him cruel gym-class nicknames—“Casey Jones,” “Frankenstein.” But the deepest scars were invisible.

He blamed himself for Tommy’s death. His limp became penance.

Oldman had never touched alcohol, but during his long recovery he grew dependent—and eventually addicted—to OxyContin. He first crossed paths with Gold at a substance abuse center, where Gold was completing internship hours toward licensure.

At the time, Gold was finishing his dissertation at UCLA while leading three therapy groups at the center. Oldman joined his Sunday afternoon men's group and shared the story of his accident and addiction. Something about Gold reminded him of Tommy. Oldman later admitted that Gold was who he imagined—and wished—Tommy might have become.

They became close friends. Oldman credited Gold not only with his sobriety but with inspiring him to pursue medical school and become a psychiatrist.

Oldman went on to specialize in treating trauma victims and opioid addicts. He often shared his own horror story—the guilt that had driven him to addiction did not have to end in overdose.

Even though he could rationalize the accident intellectually, he still blamed himself for Tommy's death. His greatest regret—the source of his nightmares—was that Tommy died with no one there to hold his hand.

Despite their twenty-year age gap, Gold loved his sessions with Oldman. They clicked instantly and often socialized off the couch as friends. Gold always got a kick out of Bob's thick Boston accent—it reminded him of his Harvard roommate, Bill Shane. Occasionally Bob would answer in a comically exaggerated "California surfer dude" voice, one of the few things that could draw real laughter from Gold.

"Hey Stevie—what's the best way to get to Malibu from here?"

Oldman had called Gold 'Stevie' ever since they met.

Gold cherished their bond—not just as friends, but as colleagues who often consulted on difficult cases. Most of all, he loved their philosophical discussions. He had sought out Oldman because he believed every therapist needed a therapist of his own: someone to debrief, unload, unwind with—someone who understood the peculiar rhythms and burdens of the work.

With Oldman, he didn't have to explain everything the way he

did with Rachel. He never had to guard his words. Oldman knew this life—the jargon, the expectations, the contradictions—and kept Gold grounded in a way only another gifted therapist could. He was the older-brother voice of reason, acceptance, and care.

Gold knew how much he meant to Oldman. But he also sensed the deeper truth: that Bob saw him not as a colleague, nor even as a friend, but as Tommy returned—as if forgiveness could somehow be granted by proxy.

It's tragic. He's spent his life chasing something unreachable: a sacrament no living person could offer.

I can't give it to him.

No one could strip away that guilt.

It's sacred.

He clings to it.

He needs to hold on to Tommy—not as a memory, but as anchor. Tommy's happiest day... and Tommy's last.

That guilt is fused into him—like the four rods, seven plates, and thirty-two screws that rebuilt his pelvis and legs, but could never restore what he lost.

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

Everybody Has Baggage

Memory believes before knowing remembers.

— William Faulkner, *Light in August* (1932)

Thursday, evening

Shit—I'm late. And he cleared his schedule just to squeeze me in before leaving town.

The cheap metal bell over the door jingled as Gold stepped in. The reception room was cramped—faux-leather couch with a tear on the arm, a brass tension-pole lamp from another decade, shag carpet the color of old coffee.

I don't know why Bob never fixes this place up.

I hate waiting in here. It feels like germs crawl up my legs.

If I didn't know him, I'd head straight for the elevators.

He's too good for this to be the first impression.

The inner door opened. Oldman came through carefully, limp noticeable but unmentioned: pale blue patterned shirt, the familiar old brown cardigan. Gold stood; Oldman ignored his hand and hauled him into a bear hug, solemn face cracking into a beaming smile.

“Stevie! I forgot we rescheduled. Thanks for working around my travel. Damn, it's good to see ya!”

“Twenty years and I still forget you're a hugger. Rachel always knows I've seen you.”

“How's that?”

“I leave smelling like Old Spice.”

“If your grandfather hadn't worn it, ya wouldn't exist,” Oldman grinned.

“Signature scent. Maybe time you considered something from this millennium. And the mustache—full walrus. Teddy Roosevelt. Sam Elliott if I squint.”

“Should I trim it—like your Freud mask?” He chuckled. “C’mon in. Don’t mind the mess.”

Oldman turned toward the office, right knee barely bending.

“How’s the leg today?”

“The leg remembers what the head tries to forget.” He tapped his thigh. “The body keeps the score.”

“Bessel would be proud,” Gold said.

Oldman’s office was much tidier than his reception room—mainly because it held so little. Certainly nothing Gold could ever live with.

No desk. No writing table. Just a well-worn leather couch and a scuffed coffee table. A box of Kleenex and a crystal ashtray sat there—despite the building’s no-smoking policy. A small brown fridge hummed in the corner. A narrow bookshelf flanked by diplomas and old photos; the largest, a blown-up Polaroid of Bob with his younger brother, Tommy—Tommy adoring, Bobby reluctant but proud.

Oldman limped to the couch and dropped into it with a satisfied sigh.

A flatulent sound rose from the couch—unmistakable. Laughing heartily, he said, “I swear, Stevie—that was the leather, not me—I didn’t faht.”

Gold chuckled, then sat cautiously on the other side of the couch.

“Want an RC cola or a tonic? Got both chillin’ in the fridge.”

“No, I’m good, thanks Bob.”

“Okay, Stevie. So how are ya? Last time—conveniently right at the end of our session—you said something felt different. You know me, Stevie. I never forget. So tell me—what’s up?”

“No hidin’, Stevie.”

“Well, Bob...” Gold stopped himself from calling him Bobby. That name belonged to Tommy. Got a lot to catch you up on. Glad

you could reschedule before leaving town. You know me—I even made notes.

“But, when are you finally going to fix your waiting room? At least get furniture from this century. The landlord would paint and replace the carpet if you asked.

“It’s like Dorothy walking backward—from Technicolor Munchkinland into the black-and-white farmhouse.”

Oldman laughed. “Stevie, you been spending all your time with elites, athletes, star celebrities. You don’t know my people anymore. They feel comfortable in this office. A place like yours? They’d never relate. They’d think you was judging ‘em—like you couldn’t understand what they been through. You gotta make folks feel at ease. Like home. Willing to open up.”

Gold laughed. “At ease? I feel like I’m about to get mugged sitting in there!”

Oldman chuckled. “Yeah, yeah—well, we didn’t all go to Hah-vahd, Stevie.”

He grabbed his phone, held it to his ear. “What’s that—*Atlantic Monthly*? You wanna do a shoot heah next month? No problem!”

Gold put his hand to his ear like a phone. “Yeah—for a piece called *The Mind of a Mugger*! Haha.”

“You always bustin’ my balls, Stevie.”

They laughed—hard—the way only old friends can.

Oldman sobered, leaned forward carefully not to squeak the leather. “Seriously, Stevie. What’s goin’ on? You said you’d been feelin’ different somehow—then ya left me hangin’.”

“Yeah, I’ll get to that. But I’ve got a few things I want to run by you first.”

“Give me the headlines—so you don’t drop the bomb on the way out again, like last time.”

“I’ve got a few things. Some might have to wait till you’re back from the conference. You’ll want to hear about my dreams—wild stuff. They’re tied to a new patient I just started seeing. In fact he walked out of our session... a little over an hour ago.”

“Still keeping a journal? Writing ‘em down right after you wake?”

“Yeah. Didn’t bring it in—I remember them all. Vividly. Don’t even need the journal.”

Oldman jumped in. “You always say you ain’t got a memory without a picture.”

Gold nodded. “These were vivid. Colorful, like movies. A couple even fully lucid.”

Oldman nodded. “Cool.”

“But first—this new patient. Then Rachel. And Jane. Rachel’s convinced I’m cheating on her.”

“Real convenient, saving that one for last. I do want to hear about the new patient—but let’s start with Rachel. You cheating on her?”

“You know what Jimmy Carter said—he’d looked at many women with lust and committed adultery in his heart. I haven’t committed it outside my heart. So... does that count?”

“If it’s with Jane Sanders, it sure does! You know how sensitive she is about Jane.

“And I don’t get it. Rachel’s much prettier than Jane ever was. She just didn’t end up all over magazine covers.

“That’s not to say I didn’t rub a few out to Jane back in the day—but you never gave Rachel a reason to be jealous, did ya?”

“Well, I’ve already told you how I met Jane—years before I met Rachel.”

Oldman grinned wide. “Tell it again. Refresh my memory. I’ll see if your story changed.”

Oldman winked. “Member—details are wicked important. You got a shitty memory without photos, so this is a good memory exercise. I’ll see if the story still checks out.”

“You old lech. Sure—good test.” Gold leaned back into the couch.

“You remember—I was finishing my master’s at SC. I was almost twenty-two, single. A buddy at the law school kept pushing me to come to one of his parties. I finally gave in.

“I reached into the ice chest for a beer and boom—there’s Jane.

“She was hot—seriously hot. Painted-on black leather pants. White blouse—too small, half-unbuttoned—absolutely on purpose.

“She was twenty-four—not landing new covers—but still looked incredible.

“She was shit-faced, doing lines off a glass coffee table, when she caught me staring.

“She smiled, sauntered over, asked if I was a lawyer—like every other guy in the room.

“I said I was finishing my master’s, getting a doctorate in psychology. She goes, ‘So you’re a shrink! A doctor.’

“She grabbed my hand, pulled me into the bedroom, and slammed the door behind us.

“Honestly I was scared. She was gorgeous—but completely wasted—and I had no idea what she might do.

“She dropped onto the bed, yanked me down beside her, and launched into a rant—tired of being treated like meat.

“Based on what I’d read about her and now saw with my own eyes, I wasn’t surprised—I just listened. I figured, she’s just looking for a little therapy.

“She was wrecked. And yeah—I thought I could help.

“She was sexy as hell—but I wasn’t going to try anything. She was too far gone. People aren’t cats—we don’t always land on our feet. Since she was circling the drain—going down fast—I just thought maybe I could help.”

Oldman said, “Yeah Stevie—I know. You’re a good boy.”

“I was Bob. I wanted to help her. I wasn’t trying to start anything up with her.

“Everybody’s got baggage, but she had bags I couldn’t carry.”

“Anyway, she starts telling me how shitty the modeling business is and that no one really cares about her. Not even her parents—who pushed her into modeling when she was a young teen, when she didn’t know any better. A number of guys took advantage

of her. She married some photographer when she was eighteen or nineteen, but it didn't even last the season.

"Her drinking and cocaine binges, affairs, and arrests were always all over the TV and tabloids. Her parents thought she was just a slut, and from what I'd heard about her, she probably was. She might've been on her second marriage—no, she'd just gotten divorced again.

"So, she went on and on about her parents being down on her. Her younger sister was the golden child, Jane, the black sheep.

"I was trying to act professional, thinking maybe I could help, or at least point her in the direction of help.

"In the middle of my talking with her, she leaned in, grabbed me, and slid her tongue down my throat. She tasted of cheap punch and stale Cheetos. Her perfume, though—heavenly flowers, tinged with sweat. I've never forgotten it."

"Yeah—I could've stood up and left. But I didn't. I was twenty-one.

"She pulled off her blouse—beautiful, perfect little tits. Grabbed my crotch, rubbed me through my jeans—felt me getting hard. Then she unbuckled my belt, unbuttoned my jeans, slid her hand inside my boxers."

"I pulled back. Told her I couldn't—not when she was that wasted.

"Man she was pissed. She started screaming—accusing me of not caring, just like everyone else.

"Then—like a switch flipping—she sobbed.

"I hugged her. Tried to console her.

"Then my buddy opened the door—probably wondering who the hell was in his room.

"He sees Jane—half-naked, hugging me—my jeans open, my dick poking over the top of my boxers, both of us on his bed.

"He walked in, shut the door, and sat down—thinking jackpot: a three-way."

Oldman, eyes wide like he was watching porn, grinned and said, "Yeah, yeah."

Gold continued. “I told him nothing was happening, which was tough to believe, looking at us.

“I told him she was wasted. I handed Jane her blouse and told her to get dressed, that I’d give her a ride home. I said she needed some professional help—bad move.

“She told me to fuck off, get out, and close the door behind me. She screams, ‘Fuck you, limp dick! Go find some freshman and jerk each other off.’”

Oldman chuckled slightly.

“She threw her blouse on the floor, turned and grabbed my classmate—started making out with him.

“I told her she needed to cool off and not make a mistake. I said I’d give her a ride home. She was screaming at the top of her lungs, veins popping in her neck and forehead, ‘Fuck off and close the door behind you—faggot!’”

Oldman winced.

“I gave my buddy a hard look—he thought he’d won the lottery—but I shook my head, firmly: no. Then I left. Jane kicked the door shut. I didn’t see her again for many years.”

“I read in a tabloid she’d gotten pregnant. It wrecked what little was left of her career.

“If I’d just dragged her to my car... taken her home...”

Oldman leaned in, voice soft but serious. “Stevie, you can’t blame yourself. If you’d dragged her to your car drunk and coked up? They’d have arrested you for rape.

“She did that. That was her choice—not yours.

“You can’t blame someone for choices they don’t make, only for the ones they do.

“You were wicked smart not to go through with it. Wasn’t your sperm. You tried to help. You did the right thing.”

Gold’s breath came fast and shallow. “She still swears I got her pregnant. She was so fucked up, she doesn’t remember I left.

“She blamed me. Still does. And yeah—I feel guilty. I should have dressed her and dragged her out of there.”

Oldman leaned back against the couch and dropped a cushion onto his lap.

“Stevie, she’s wack. This isn’t your fault. Not even close.

“She was an alley cat—bound to get in trouble, acting like that.”

Oldman smiled gently, trying to soften the moment. “So—remind me how you and Rachel met?”

“I met Rachel Wein a few years later. I was twenty-six, finishing my doctorate at UCLA, guest lecturing a course called *Grief: Reaction to Loss*. She was a twenty-one-year-old student.”

A smile crept across Gold’s face. He visibly relaxed fully, sinking into the memory.

“Rachel thought I was bright and cute.

“Rachel later told me she thought I was handsome and intelligent—but dry. Nerdy. Boring, even. She hadn’t come to flirt. She just wanted to understand the comments I’d made on her term paper—*Dealing With Personal Trauma*.

“She led a charmed life—brilliant, beautiful, two grades ahead, an athlete and cheerleader. Her parents were affluent—and paved the way for every success. She had an older sister she wasn’t close to and a younger brother she adored. The sister had married young but remained childless, while the brother was still in high school—a popular athlete who basked in Rachel’s reflected glory.”

Gold continued, “I was at the whiteboard when she came up behind me and asked, ‘Professor Gold, I had a few questions about your comments on my paper. Are you available during office hours?’

“I remember being annoyed—snapped back, ‘Mr. Gold, I’m not a professor, just a guest lecturer.’”

Oldman said, “Sounds like you. Uncomfortable having that stick up your ass.”

Gold ignored the comment. “But then I turned and saw her. The moment hit like a slap with a cold rag. I pulled off my glasses, forgetting the marker in my hand, and drew a black line across my ear. Didn’t even notice until later in the bathroom.

“In my head it was chaos: *Oh my God. Jesus. She’s perfect. The most beautiful woman I’ve ever seen.* I could barely

speak. She said, 'I'm Rachel Wein. I'm a freshman. You made some comments on my paper—*Dealing With Personal Trauma*—about a friend of mine. I was hoping you could explain what you meant.'

"And I just stood there, staring. I remember thinking she had to be a model. Her skin glowed, her cheekbones caught the light, her lips—full, soft, inviting. The corners of her mouth lifted just enough to seem open, approachable. *Control yourself*, I thought. *Don't forget this—this goddess, this vision.*

"Something gripped my chest so hard I thought I might pass out. My throat closed. I literally wondered if I was having a heart attack. She was speaking, but I couldn't hear her words. All I thought was, answer her, *don't collapse in front of her.*

"Finally I stammered something idiotic about office hours being wide open—'Today is perfect. Do you want me to bring sandwiches?'

"Sandwiches, Bob. She wanted to talk about her paper, and I'm treating it like a lunch date. I didn't even remember the damn paper. I was just lost—completely gone."

Gold continued, "I knew I had to win her, so I toned myself down. We dated for a few months. I felt like someone else—lighter, happier than I'd ever been. And I was.

"My parents thought I was on something—I couldn't stop smiling. I was at peace. Relaxed. Happy.

"I was alive.

"After a few months, I met her parents—and worked up the nerve to ask her dad for her hand. Luckily he said yes. I know Rachel's mom liked me. They probably felt I would be successful, or at least hoped I would. I think her mom just liked my full head of hair! And her father was wealthy enough to help us out if I didn't make it, but luckily it never came to that.

"The following weekend, her parents threw an engagement party. We got there a little early. Rachel was upstairs, getting ready—whatever that meant. I sat in the living room, talking to her brother Jason about his high school football team.

"Then I caught a whiff of tuberose tinged with a signature sweat—*Joy*, by Jean Patou."

“Jason’s voice behind me: ‘Hey J, when did you get in? You stayin’ here?’”

“I turn—and fuck me—it was Jane Sanders.

“Of course she’s wearing tight jeans and a blouse—unbuttoned and knotted high, right above her belly button.

“She had a gold navel piercing—subtle, but impossible to miss.

“She looked great.

“Hot.”

“At first I figured maybe they were sorority sisters. But Jane didn’t go to college. And she was older.

“I said, ‘You’re the older sister!’

“The second it came out, I knew it was a mistake.

“She didn’t even fake a smile.”

“We stared at each other—silent. Then Jason said ‘You guys already meet?’ I say ‘yes’ just as Jane says ‘no.’ Pretty sure I turned beet red—hot as a fucking waffle iron.

“In a low, sultry voice, Jane said, ‘No... but you do look familiar. Are you a model? A photographer?’

“I said, ‘No—we met at a party at Brian Willow’s place. A few years ago. USC.’

“She looked puzzled, trying to remember, but nothing. Just a vacant stare. No surprise—she’d been fucked up on booze and coke, hangin’ on by dental floss. So, I let it go—I was glad she didn’t remember.”

“She didn’t remember... not until after the wedding.

“She cornered me one Sunday, during family dinner at our townhouse.

“She said, ‘I remember that party. I’m clean now—on the wagon. Twenty-eight months. It was a rough time. My career was in the toilet, and I was deep into drugs and booze. You getting me pregnant and ghosting me? That didn’t exactly help.’

“I tried to interrupt—told her we never had sex—but she was escalating fast, and I didn’t want a scene. So I just let her vent.”

“She said her agent and a fashion photographer staged an intervention—got her into a residential rehab. That’s when she found out she was pregnant, although no one could tell. Her agent pushed for an abortion—she refused. He said rehab was manageable—but pregnancy? That would ruin her career. It had to stay quiet.

“Then, of course, someone at the center leaked it—Jane Sanders: pregnant, strung out, in rehab.

“She wanted to finish rehab, settle down, raise her child. Her parents agreed to help—but only if she completed rehab and stayed clean. She wasn’t crazy about that, but she wanted the child. I think she felt it would be the one thing in her life that would be hers, that she could love and know it loved her—unconditionally.

“The baby came six weeks early. Rabbi Shapiro convinced her parents that Jane was likely to relapse and that she probably wouldn’t be a good mother—especially if she wanted to continue modeling. Shapiro convinced Jane to voluntarily assign legal custody to her parents who would help her. They forced her to sign a number of papers. One was from an adoption agency Shapiro knew. The facility—and her parents—arranged a post-birth placement. Immediate. Closed.”

“She said they rushed her into it while she was still detoxing—didn’t even know what she was signing. But legally? The documents held.

“She found out weeks later. She tried to get a lawyer—too late. Once it’s signed and filed... it’s done. They covered their asses.

“Closed adoption.

“No names.

“Not even the baby’s sex.

“Technically legal—ethically, wrong.”

Oldman nodded, unsurprised.

Gold continued. “She was livid—and I let her unload every ounce of it on me.

“She said, ‘I was furious with you. For a long time. But my therapist helped me work through it. I forgave everyone—even you.’”

Oldman nodded—slow and knowing.

“She said she forgave me. Her tone said otherwise. And I could tell—she never forgave herself. I doubt she ever will. That guilt? She’ll carry it to her grave.

“I didn’t push it—she was too fragile. It would only make her feel worse to realize she didn’t even know who the real father was. She clearly didn’t remember everything from that night.

“Then Rachel and Jason walked in—and I froze. We never talked about it again.

“She wanted it secret. No matter how pissed she’d been at Rachel, she didn’t want her to know I was the guy who got her pregnant.

“But it wasn’t me. I think she knew her parents wouldn’t have believed her anyway.

“She’s been cold—distant—at every family gathering since then. I guess she forgave. But she didn’t forget.

“Rachel sensed something.

“Around Jane, I was different. She’s always thought I had a thing for Jane. And those two? They never got along.”

Gold broke his eye contact with Oldman. He looked away, not collecting memories to share but filing details to hide.

“Jane lived in Rachel’s shadow—and hated that Rachel never noticed she was casting it. There was always tension between them—unspoken but always screaming.”

Oldman nodded again, silently.

“Even though it wasn’t me... I still felt responsible. I shouldn’t have left her alone at that party.

“Then yesterday—outta nowhere—Jane shows up at my office. Pounding on the door. Screaming I can’t hide forever. That I’ll be sorry.

“So much for being ‘forgiven.’ She still blames me.”

Oldman shifted—visibly uncomfortable.

“Aw shit, Stevie. I should have warned ya.

“Never thought she’d pull something like that.”

Gold stared at him, stunned.

A long, uncomfortable silence.

Oldman squirmed on the couch.

“If this ever comes out, I’ll swear I only told you ‘cause I was worried for your safety.”

“What? What are you talking about, Bob?”

“I’ve been treating Jane for years, Stevie... I couldn’t tell you—ethics. I’m only saying this now ‘cause she stormed out mid-session and I’m worried she’ll escalate. Duty to warn, okay?”

A jolt—like a bat to the chest.

He’d thought he’d heard every confession there was. Until this.

He didn’t move. The words hung in the air—thick as fog. He blinked—slowly, once.

A splinter—disbelief. Betrayal.

His jaw clenched. A tremor moved through his hand. His face flushed. Sweat prickled under his collar. “Ethics?” he said. Then: “What the fuck, Bob?”

“We are, Stevie. I couldn’t say nothing. Didn’t think she was a danger to you.

“Only found out yesterday that she fell off the wagon. Don’t know why. Something happened—but she didn’t say. Stormed out of my office. Middle of the session.

“You know I can’t say more. She was wicked pissed, but I really don’t think she’s a danger.

“Swearing like a sailor. ‘Fuck Mom, that bitch.’ ‘Fuck Shapiro in the ass.’ ‘Rachel can go fuck herself with her silver spoon.’

“Hell, sounded like she was fucking everybody—except you. Didn’t scream your name. Then I guess she remembered you were a few floors up—so she rode up to ‘fuck you’ too.

“Sorry Stevie, I shouldn’t make light. She’s spiraling. I’m worried about her. She’s fighting demons, that’s for sure. I just don’t know what—or why—not yet.

“Don’t be mad, Stevie. Please. I’m wicked sorry.”

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

Et Tu, Brute?

It is easier to forgive an enemy than to forgive a friend.

— William Blake, *Jerusalem* (1804–1820)

If you want to keep a secret—keep it secret.

Secrets aren't gifts—they're handcuffs... flimsy handcuffs.

— Steven Gold, *journal entry (unpublished)*

Thursday, evening

Gold shot up, circling the couch, arms flaring—slapping his thighs like a bird desperate for flight.

“Fuck. Et tu, Bob?

How could you not tell me—or her? There was a fucking conflict!

Jesus, Bob. You betrayed me.

How can I even trust you?”

Silence.

Oldman sat frozen, hands clutching the cushion, bracing for impact. His shoulders hunched in, as if trying to shrink into himself. He didn't speak. Didn't move. Swallowing. Eyes lowered. Jaw grinding on guilt. A soft tremor passed through his injured leg. Still, he said nothing. He let Gold burn it out.

“It's like finding out your husband didn't just cheat—he's got a whole second goddamn family.”

Gold stopped. The words echoed. Second family. Betrayal. His own voice, alien in the silence.

Was that what this was really about?

“Bob... Jesus. How could you do this? To me?

“How long have you been seeing her?”

Gold kept circling the couch, like a man searching for an exit

that didn't exist.

"Stevie... don't make me get up and try to chase ya."

"Oh—now I'm supposed to feel bad for your bum leg?"

Oldman flinched. The words landed where fists didn't.

"Stevie... you done?"

Gold stood there, chest heaving, fury unraveling at the seams. He didn't sit. Couldn't. Not yet.

"You're not supposed to lie—to your friends, or your patients."

Oldman shrugged helplessly.

Gold was breathing hard, drained from the laps—and the emotional violence of it all.

Gold dropped hard onto the couch, jolting Oldman with a grunt.

"And not to me."

Gold hunched forward, burying the back of his head in his hands.

Oldman shifted closer, laying a hand on Gold's back.

"Yeah. But sometimes you do. Not 'cause you don't give a damn—but 'cause you do. So much, it clouds your thinking.

"You're right, Stevie. I deserved all of it—every fucking word. I ain't gonna pretend I didn't screw up. I did. I should have told you the day she first walked in my office.

"I was scared you'd walk out. I didn't want to lose you... you're my friend, Stevie. My best one."

Oldman's lips were trembling, as he held back tears.

"Well, you're probably my only one. And now—this."

Oldman exhaled hard through his nose, voice catching just a little.

"You're right. I know it feels like I was hiding a second family on the side. You ain't wrong. It's fucked. But I never stopped caring about you, never thought less of you.

“I kept quiet ‘cause I thought it was the right thing. Thought I was protecting you. Thought I could manage both sides. I was wrong.”

Oldman leaned forward, his voice softening.

“But Stevie—look at you. You finally feeling something. Not analyzing. Feeling.

“You ain’t been this alive in—hell, maybe ever. Always the smaht one. All the right words—the fancy Ivy League kind.

“You feel betrayed—I get it. But that feeling? That rage? It means you still give a damn.

“You’re pissed at me—but you’re pissed ‘cause you can’t ignore what Jane means to you.”

“Yeah, I’m sorry too, Bob. I gotta figure out why I was—am—so pissed.”

“So you’re seeing Jane. Big deal. It’s not like I’m jealous.

“Or am I? I’m just tired of being alone.

“After all, what does Jane mean to me?”

“Important question.”

“My fallibility. My failure.

“A reminder that Dr. Steven Gold is human after all.”

He put his hand to his forehead.

“So it was you. The therapist who helped her ‘forgive everyone.’ Even me.

“Not that I deserve forgiveness.

“You knew about the kid all along. About everything.”

“Yeah, Stevie. I was looking out for you. I worried you saw it—that nod I gave you when you started talking.

“I figured you might connect the dots.”

“Well, based on her visit to my office, you did a hell of a job. Seriously—thanks.

“But hey—maybe don’t jerk off thinking about your patients, okay?”

Gold broke out laughing.

“Maybe I am jealous... You ever rub one out thinking about me?”

They both laughed. The world was right again—for now.

“I forgive you, Bob. I know this wasn’t easy for you either.

“And sorry about the shot at your leg. Dirty fighting.”

“Yeah, you just lucky I couldn’t jump up and catch ya!”

“You’re not sleeping with Rachel too... are you?”

“No need to be jealous, Stevie. You’re the only one I think about... when I’m wacking off.”

CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

There Are More Than Two Sides to a Couch

My guiding principle is this: Guilt is never to be doubted.

— Franz Kafka, *Letter to Max Brod* (1913)

Thursday, late evening

“Okay, Stevie, I don’t wanna miss my flight—let’s get to work. Didn’t ya have that list we need to tackle?”

“Nice try, Bob. Your flight’s not till Sunday.”

“Sorry, professah, but the way you lectchah on philosophy, I didn’t know If I could make it.”

They both laughed.

“I really do forgive you, Bob. And I’m sorry for getting so upset.”

“Nah, let’s drop it—like it nevah happened. Ga head.”

“There’s a new patient. I’ve never been this thrown.”

“Sure, what’s the deal?”

“I don’t even know who referred him. He screened fine—no obvious pathology—but there’s something. I feel it physically when I see him. I’m off—just... not myself. He rattles me. Makes me question everything.”

“Countertransference. I know ya hate dealin’ with it—but who’s he remind ya of?”

“In some ways... me. I enjoy talking religion, philosophy, and art with him. He impresses me. Sometimes I want to impress him. Other times, I just want to strangle him. He challenges me—interrogates me. Makes me think. Sometimes I feel like *I’m* the one on the couch. Hell, at our first meeting, I was! He sat in *my* seat.”

Oldman leaned in, surprised. He’d never seen Gold so affected by a patient.

“Tell me more about him, Stevie. What brought him in?”

“He’s unhappy. Feels guilty for things he’s done, but won’t own the blame. His presenting problem—he’s got a strained relationship with his father.”

“Stevie, that could describe half my practice.”

“Oh yeah—and he says he’s Satan.”

Oldman laughed. “Way to bury the lead, Stevie. But ya still talkin’ about half my patients.

“Satan? He’s a bad guy, or some kinda devil worshipper?”

“No—he’s serious. He truly believes he *is* the biblical Satan.

“He’s clearly delusional. He retells the Bible as testimony—claims he was there.”

“So what’s the problem? If he’s psychotic, refuh him to Smith or Nahrul, they deal with that kinda shit all the time. They’ll load him up with Risperdal, Latuda, or somethin’ else. He won’t be in hell no more.

“You think he’s dangerous?”

“No, I don’t think so. He gets angry, hurt—but not like you’d picture... Satan.”

“No horns. No tail?”

“No, seriously, Bob. It’s not like that. There’s something about him. Sometimes I almost believe him.”

“Stevie, you losin’ it? You need to see Smith? Yahself?”

“He makes me question my beliefs—religious ones. I actually enjoy the discussions. He pushes me, presses me.”

“Like how?”

“He asked my religion. I told him I’m Jewish—but an atheist. He argued that—oh yeah, he’s an attorney—so he *proved* I’m not an atheist at all, just angry at God. A *misotheist*, he said.”

Oldman leaned back. “A miso... what? Jeez, Stevie, you don’t usually share personal stuff with your patients. That ain’t like ya.”

“I know. I don’t know. Sometimes it feels like I’m talking to myself, thinking out loud. Other times, it’s like arguing with a raving

lunatic. He told me that he saved Isaac—when God commanded Abraham to kill him. Said he disobeyed God to do it.”

Oldman’s eyebrows shot up. “Stevie, this guy sounds seriously disturbed.”

“I know, but he doesn’t come across that way. He even tested normal. Then he tells me he wrestled Jacob, that he tortured Job—said God, his father, made him kill Job’s kids, give him boils, the whole thing.”

“Hang on, Stevie. His father is God? You said Satan, not Jesus.”

“Yeah, I know. Evidently, he’s an angel. Told me the bible stories are all wrong—or at least, the important parts. Said God, his father, is a narcissist. Basically, that God’s evil.”

“Stevie, I gotta tell ya, this guy sounds off his rockah. Whaddaya gonna do, perform an exorcism? Maybe he needs a priest.”

“No, not a priest. Says he’s Jewish, all the angels are.”

“Stevie, I was kiddin’, but he needs to see Smith. Seriously—what does he want from you?”

“I’m really not sure. He carries a lot of guilt.”

“Who doesn’t? An’ if he’s really Satan, he’s got a lot to feel guilty about.”

“No, Bob. He’s sympathetic—like Milton’s Satan in *Paradise Lost*.”

Oldman chortled, barely catching his breath. “Funny—I was just readin’ that last night. Wicked pissah, couldn’t put it down.

“Fuckin’ Milton... what’re ya nuts?”

“No, I just mean, he’s not like you’d picture him. He’s intelligent, caring, kind.”

“Pictah him? Stevie, hat’s goin’ on?”

“I don’t know. I’ve only seen him a couple times. But ever since, I’ve been feeling off—not myself.”

“Yeah—sounds like he’s takin’ ya soul.”

Oldman laughed.

Gold wasn't laughing. He looked disappointed—embarrassed.

"No, Bob. He didn't take my soul—but he's touched it. I've been obsessed with him since the moment I met him. Maybe even before."

"What the hell does that mean—*before* ya stahted seein' him?"

"I don't know how to explain it. From the day I scheduled his first session, I've felt off. Sometimes like I'm having AFib, other times like a visual migraine—or vertigo."

"Stevie, sounds like ya oughta see your doctah. Maybe ya got somethin'... COVID? You've been rattled by patients befoh—but not like this."

"No, I keep testing negative. I can't explain it. And lately I've been having a lot of dreams—strange ones. Mostly about Satan."

"Dreams about the devil? I don't like that, Stevie. What the hell?"

"He said something that got under my skin—about evil. That God isn't really in control. With the curse of omniscience, He's in turmoil—knowing what will happen but unable to change it because of free will.

"Suffering, he said, isn't evil—it's just the facticity of life. Maybe that's a dodge for God—indifference. God watches suffering and calls it faith.

"I keep seeing my father in that—begging for mercy while the world just watched. Maybe that's what Light's forcing me to face. Maybe I'm not angry at God for existing; maybe I'm angry because He didn't.

"He also hates being called the devil. Says he's not evil—just honest. Claims God makes him do the evil things."

"All kiddin' aside, Stevie, this sounds serious. Do you think he's capable of hurting anyone—acting out any of these fantasies, doin' anything crazy? More crazy?

"Sounds like you need to refuh him out. An' you need to see your own doctah and get checked out. Make shuh ya AFib's under

control.”

“I don’t mean he’s got voices telling him what to do—doesn’t sound like that. I don’t think he’s a danger. Not to anyone else—just me.”

“What?”

“Not physically. Psychologically. He makes me think about my dad... and Rachel. He’s a lot like me. And that’s what scares me.”

“Well Stevie, haha, that can be challenging!”

Gold’s polite smile disappeared.

“Like me, he was created for something—and failed. Cast out. Blamed. Held responsible for everything that went wrong.

“Jane needed professional help. Rachel wanted a family... needed a more attentive husband. My mother wanted a grandchild. My father needed to get into that clinical trial... he’d still be alive. I failed them all.”

Gold’s expression sobered. “You know, Bob—we’ve gone over so many of my issues with my father. I loved him. Worshiped him. He took care of my mom, especially once she got sick. I never really got to know her.

“My dad always felt he hadn’t given her the life she deserved. She never got the chance to bloom and enjoy life—before the illness took hold. She wanted to travel, but Dad was always working, always worried about money.

“Even when I was doing well and offered to take them, he refused—said it wasn’t right to take money from his son. Pride. Then Mom got sick... and it was too late. I felt guilty because I knew she’d wanted grandchildren—and so did he.

“When Dad got sick, I did everything I could—turned my whole life upside down trying to help. You remember those months—what I was going through. I searched for anything that might help. The hospital screwed up his application for the clinical trial.

“And I failed again.”

“Stevie, ya can’t blame yaself. Ya did everything ya could. Ya were a great son. I’d ‘a been proud to have a son like ya.”

Gold said softly, “No, you wouldn’t.”

Gold’s eyes filled with tears.

“Stevie...wa’s the matta? Wa’s goin’ on?”

“Talk ta me, Stevie.”

Gold began sobbing—deep, heaving gasps that made it hard to breathe.

He’d never done this—inside or outside of therapy.

Oldman let him sit a few moments, not interrupting the release.

Oldman reached over and placed a firm hand on Gold’s shoulder.

“Let it out, Stevie. I knew somethin’ was eati’n at ya. I’m here for ya—always.”

Gold sat up, wiped his eyes, then rubbed his palms together. He pulled a tissue from the Kleenex box and wiped his nose.

“I’m sorry, Bob. I just feel guilty—so fucking guilty. He was strict, demanding—but I never once felt abandoned.”

“It wasn’t your fault, Stevie. You did everything ya could.”

“It was my fault. I killed him.”

“Don’t say that.”

Gold started crying again. Chest heaving, he said, “I’m serious. I killed him.”

Oldman’s eyebrows shot up.

“What’re ya talkin’ about?”

With that confession, he finally exhaled—the breath he’d been holding for two long years.

“My dad told me he wanted to die—said he’d wanted to ever since my mother passed.

“He felt guilty. Missed her—sick or not—he needed her.

“At first I tried to talk him out of it—death with dignity, doctor-assisted suicide. I thought we’d find remission. But he didn’t start the trial until it was too late. It became obvious, to everyone but me, the treatments weren’t working. Too little, too late. It wasn’t

going to work.

“Then I saw it. Heard it. Felt it. I knew it was the only way. He was wasting away—literally—inside and out.

“He told me he’d spoken to Rabbi Shapiro—who said life belongs to God, that suicide’s forbidden by Jewish law.

“I was furious. After book club one night, I confronted Shapiro.

“He knows I’m an atheist,” Gold continued, “But he said, ‘Your dad’s not. Gerald’s always been devout.’

“Shapiro told him Judaism considers life sacred—emphasizing the duty to preserve it.

“He cited the Sixth Commandment—‘Thou shalt not murder’—to make his case. Said it was against God’s will, that the Talmud forbids it. Life belongs to God, he said, and suicide violates that trust.

“Hell, he even said that suicide would keep him from a Jewish cemetery, where my mother was buried.”

“Good thing I wasn’t there. I might’ve broken the Sixth myself, fucking Shapiro.”

“Who is he to tell a man with terminal cancer—dying, destined to suffer for months—that he must keep living? That he has to surrender to God—who’d already turned away.”

“I’m sawry Stevie—suicide’s tough for a lotta religious folks.”

“If I’d been there, I swear I might’ve killed Shapiro myself.”

“Nah, Stevie. Ya just pissed off—an’ ya got a right to be. But ya didn’t kill him.”

“Yes, I did. He couldn’t lift the glass—so I took off his mask, held the straw to his lips and...”

The words caught in his throat.

It was the hardest decision of his life.

Under the End of Life Option Act, the patient had to self-administer the lethal medication. Gerald could barely lift a glass. Gold knew what that meant. He knew exactly what his father was asking.

To drink, the mask had to come off. Gerald couldn't remove it himself. His weary eyes begged Gold to help, to end his suffering. To acknowledge the inevitable, escape this misery.

Gold loosed the straps and slid the mask down onto Gerald's neck. The hiss of air died in the silence. Gold handed him the glass, the liquid sloshing, resisting. He lifted the straw to his father's wrinkled, quivering lips. Gerald sipped, a few gulps at a time—each interrupted by labored breaths. Gold steadied the glass until it was done.

And then—he was gone.

He sat there, still holding his father's hand, waiting—hoping—for something. Some sign this wasn't real. That he hadn't just done what he had done.

I did what he asked. Didn't I?

This wasn't murder. He asked me to do it. This was mercy.

I obeyed—and I gave him peace—a mercy you should have given an old, dying man.

I broke the commandment... Thou shalt not kill.

That's Your commandment. The blood's on both our hands.

Gold was lost in his tears.

Oldman slid closer and wrapped him in a tight hug.

"It ain't black an' white, Stevie. You didn't kill him—the cancer did. Your mom's death did. He was already gone. You just spared him more pain."

Oldman's eyes filled. "What ya did was a mitzvah, Stevie. If there is a God... He understands."

Outside, the wind whispered along the glass—soft as a breath.

Oldman handed him another tissue, then leaned back, studying Gold with quiet affection.

For the first time in years, the room felt lighter. Or maybe he did.

CHAPTER NINETEEN

Guilt, Untethered from Love—A Tool Of Inner Tyranny

The super-ego torments the ego with guilt—even when no sin has been committed.

— Sigmund Freud, *The Ego and the Id* (1923)

It's inside myself that I must create someone who will understand.

— Clarice Lispector, *The Stream of Life* (1973)

Guilt, untethered from love, doesn't teach—it sentences.

— Steven Gold, *Annual Review of Existential Psychotherapy* (2020)

Some guilt is earned. Some is inherited.

The hardest kind is borrowed—because you can't return it.

— Steven Gold, *Journal of Reflective Psychotherapy* (Summer, 2018)

Thursday, late evening

Gold wiped his nose, holding up the crumpled tissue like evidence. “Thanks.” His chuckle was thin—defense masquerading as humor.

“What the fuck am I supposed to do with this? You hiding the trash again?”

“Bustin’ my balls again, huh? Sawry, Stevie—it’s ovah by the fridge.” Oldman scootched forward, pretending he might get up.

“Don’t get up.” Gold tried a three pointer from the couch—and missed.

“Air ball. The Knicks ain’t missing you, Stevie. I’ll grab it latah. You okay?”

Gold exhaled—drained, yet lighter. “Guilt.”

“Yeah—that’s why we got jobs, Stevie. You an’ me. Pays the bills. It’s a bitch... but ya don’t feel guilty cashin’ the checks, do ya?” Oldman snickered.

“I once wrote an article. *Annual Review of Existential*

Psychotherapy. ‘Guilt, Untethered From Love—A Tool Of Inner Tyranny.’

“It began with Blake...”

Oldman laughed. “Course it did, Stevie. Gotta flex that Haavahd degree.”

“Not showing off—I just mean Blake saw it long before Freud or Nietzsche put it into theory: guilt without love is inner tyranny.

“Think about it, Bob—how many of our patients—hell, us too—are prisoners of that very regime?

“How many have we helped, unwittingly, build those prison walls?

“Not conscience. Not contrition. Just tyranny—dressed as insight.”

Oldman laughed again. “Sawry, Stevie—I musta missed that issue. Subscription musta lapsed.”

Undeterred, Gold continued. “We love our guilt—all of us. We treat it like a god—unforgiving, unrelenting. But without love? It’s not moral—it’s masochistic.

“If love doesn’t accompany guilt, it doesn’t heal—it condemns. Guilt without love isn’t a guide—it’s a whip.

“Without love, guilt punishes. With love, it forgives.”

Oldman added, “I seen patients drown in guilt, Stevie—and what happens when nobody throws ’em a rope.”

Gold’s eyes lit up. “Yes, exactly.”

Oldman continued, “Guilt’s a tricky bastard, Stevie—it wears a mask.”

“You’re right. Sometimes it even looks like virtue. We can’t pretend guilt makes us moral. That’s just the tyrant within, sharpening its knives. Real morality doesn’t start with guilt—it starts where guilt ends—in compassion. Without love, it’s a life sentence—with no parole.”

“You’re wrong to feel guilty, Stevie. Worse to let it steer your life—you know that. Ya did everything ya could outta love. An’ Gehrald? He loved ya, Stevie—more than anything. I know that fuh

sure.”

Gold nodded. “Thanks Bob.

“Since you missed the article, here’s the short version...”

Oldman’s eyes rolled back slightly. “Aw, Stevie...”

Gold continued, “Healthy guilt’s a signal—a moral alarm for learning and repair. But untethered from love—without compassion or forgiveness—it loops endlessly, condemning instead of transforming. That’s when the superego goes rogue—a self-imposed inquisition. Moral S&M—flagellation disguised as insight. You’re the judge and the prisoner—no parole.”

Oldman shook his head. “Stevie, ya doin’ it again—‘i.e.’? We’re talkin’ heah, not writin’ ya thesis. You’re hidin’ behind ya intellect, Stevie—dodgin’ ya feelins.”

Pointing to the crumpled ball on the floor, Oldman said, “That wad’a Kleenex—that’s real. That’s feelin’, Stevie. No citations, Jus’ feel it.”

Oldman sat up straight, like—okay, that’s done, let’s move on.

“So, Stevie... tell me more ’bout this devil’a youhs.”

“No—he insists he’s not the Devil. Says he’s Satan—as if that somehow makes it more reasonable.”

“Excuse me.”

“Well, actually... Satan’s the nickname his father—God—calls him. Still trying to earn his Father’s love—and failing.”

Oldman chuckled. “Ahn’t we all. Must be tough havin’ God as ya fathah. Hell of a role model to live up to—or please.”

“Bob, I know how crazy this sounds. Sometimes I wonder if he’s crazy—or I am for trying to believe him.”

“We both know the ansah to that one.”

“Evidently, God isn’t perfect. He paints Him as prideful, petty, manipulative. And even though he insists God is real, he sounds more like one of the Four Horsemen: Dawkins, Hitchens, Harris, Dennett. It’s... oddly fascinating.”

“Mmm hmm.” Oldman nodded, smiling.

“First we talked about art—the guy knows his stuff. Inside out. He’s a real bright guy. Well-dressed. Great taste... worldly.”

“Haha, ya mean other-worldly.”

“He’s impressive—art, literature, philosophy, theology, psychology. Fluent in all of it. But something about him weirds me out, Bob. It’s like... I don’t know if he’s performing or if he actually believes it.

“Sometimes I feel like he’s in my head—seeing through my eyes, knowing what I’ll think before I do.”

“Stevie, I don’t like the sound’a this guy. ‘Specially if he’s keepin’ you up at night, messin’ with ya sleep.”

“He’s a case study in charisma and contradiction. But I keep circling back to one question: is he delusional?

“God makes him do bad things and he feels guilty. He doesn’t strike me as psychotic, so I assume he’s using God and his revised Bible stories as metaphors—but I don’t know for what, not yet.”

“Don’t get sucked down his rabbit hole, Stevie. It might lead straight to hell.”

“He claims he doesn’t have a mother. Naturally, I assumed he meant a fractured relationship—but no. He insists she never existed. A stretched metaphor—or another layer of the delusion, I guess.”

“I can empathize. I had a shitty relationship with my mom too... and then she declined until she was basically gone—not there at all. She didn’t exist anymore. I tried to relate.

“I’ve been practicing more self-disclosure, like you keep pushing me to do. But every time I get a foot in the door, he slams it—right on my toes.”

“I’m a little obsessed—counting days to the next session. Everything else feels peripheral. And now he’s in my dreams—morphing into my father. Vivid, fucked-up dreams.”

“D’ya think he could be dangerous? Himself... or someone else?”

“I don’t think so. He doesn’t strike me as violent—despite, you know, claiming to have wiped out all of mankind, Sodom and

Gemorrah, and more.”

Oldman chuckled. “Well Stevie, maybe they did desuhv it. Who’s ta say? We wehn’t there.”

Oldman got serious. “Stevie, be cahful with... Satan. Sounds like youah getting obsessed. If he stahts actin’ wicked crazy, ya refuh him out—ya heah me? Hell, I think ya should anyway.”

Gold smiled and nodded. “Will do. I’ll keep you posted.”

Oldman relaxed back into the couch, squeakin’ it again and snickerin’.

Gold said, “Bob, you always fart in front of all your patients like this? Might be time for a new couch... or diet.”

Oldman laughed. “Let’s get back ta Rachel. Ya know she’s a good kid, Stevie. I really hate seein’ hehr unhappy. You guys okay? Ya said eahliuh that you ‘failed hehr’ ’cause you couldn’t have kids. But ya know it ain’t ya fault.”

“I know that. We’ve both been tested—more than once. We looked into IVF, surrogates, even adoption. It’s just not in our cards. My new patient—Satan—would probably say it’s not God’s plan; it’s free will. A result of choices we’ve already made. Just the way it is. The way he describes Him—makes Him sound like Camus, or maybe Dostoevsky.”

“Interesting, Stevie. I was readin’ both last night—right after I finished *Paradise Lost*.

Rachel’s still young, Stevie. Ya both got plenty’a time ta have kids. Abraham an’ Sarah nevah gave up.”

“Yeah, thanks... I’ll tell Rachel not to give up—you’re not even in your eighties yet. Real helpful, Bob. Can’t tell you how much better I feel now.”

“Stevie, I think you two ah puttin’ too much pressshah on yaselves. Rachel’s a great gal—you know I love hehr. She’s beautiful—even more now than when I fuhst met hehr. She’s a fantastic ahtist, and she’s got a wicked good sense’a humah, but I feel hehr sadness.

I ain’t gonna pry, but I’m guessin’ you two ain’t makin’ love much these days. You know as well as I do, couples in ya position—lovemakin’ and all sex—pretty much goes on the back burnah or out

the window.”

Gold flushed. “Honestly Bob—I can’t remember the last time. We both avoid it. Motherhood meant everything to her. She’d have been a wonderful one.”

Gold hesitated.

“Bob, I don’t think I ever told you what happened. I figured it was her story to tell, not mine—and she didn’t want anyone to know.”

Oldman said, “Stevie, I don’t want ya ta compromise a promise ya made.”

Gold sat forward, careful not to wake the couch’s squeak.

“If you want to keep a secret—keep it secret. But, therapy’s protected so...”

Gold leaned back and let out a slow, controlled breath.

He looked down—another tissue in his hand. He hadn’t realized he’d reached for it.

“Rachel can have children. She already did—once.”

CHAPTER TWENTY

Infinity in the Palm of Your Hand

*To see a World in a Grain of Sand
And a Heaven in a Wild Flower,
Hold Infinity in the palm of your hand
And Eternity in an hour.*

— William Blake, *Auguries of Innocence* (written c. 1803, published 1863)

Thursday, night

Oldman flinched as if a fist landed square in his chest. His hand clutched his heart, then slid to his lap, his whole body going stiff.

“Jesus... what?” His voice cracked, eyes wet before the words were even finished. “I nevah—I nevah knew.”

He looked down, as if the truth might be written somewhere on the floor.

“When did this happen? Was... was theah a problem? Christ, Stevie. Why didn’t I know this? How come you nevah shared it?”

Gold leaned back, crossing his legs. His left elbow rested on the arm of the couch, his hand pressed to his forehead—a gesture somewhere between a soldier’s salute and shielding his eyes from harsh light. His right hand gripped his kneecap, anchoring himself in place.

A tremulous breath escaped him. “Bob, you know Rachel.” He sneered slightly. “And obviously Jane. Well, Rachel was the perfect child—wholesome, girl next door, cute—never an awkward stage. Upbeat, happy, easygoing.

“Jane, by contrast, was the rebel—seductive in a way that pulled people too close, too fast. She seemed born in the fast lane. Always needed stimulation, excitement—she brought drama to every party.

“I’m sure you know Jane left home to model when she was fourteen. She petitioned the court—became an emancipated minor—

and left home for good.”

“Jesus. I didn’t know that. She’s still holdin’ a lot back from me.”

“Yeah, she changed her name to Sanders... for her career. That pissed off her parents even more. She moved out, left for New York, but then the house became peaceful... happy.

“Life with Jane was chaos. With Rachel—ease itself. She was the golden child—everything her parents could hope for: beauty, charm, success. Everyone adored her, while Jane... well, she faded into memory—just a shadow in the family’s eyes.

“But even with all the attention, the accolades, the easy adoration, Rachel carried guilt for Jane. It wasn’t her fault, she wasn’t competitive, in fact, she wanted to please her older sister. But she felt like she was responsible for pushing her out of the nest. Jane was the black sheep of the family.”

Gold’s voice faltered. He pressed his hand to his chest. “Jane had become like Satan in *Paradise Lost*—‘*Evil, be thou my good.*’ Not defiant. Desperate. She lived on the edge, hunted excitement, trouble, and always found it—or made it.”

“Christ on a cracker—*Paradise Lost* again. Okay, okay. Guess I oughta read it.”

Gold paused in thought.

His eyes brimmed—then spilled over without sound. “And Rachel... Well, one of Jane’s ex-boyfriends came by the house once. He knew Jane had moved out years earlier, but he’d seen her seventeen-year-old younger sister around town. He waited until her parents went out one night...”

Gold started shaking uncontrollably.

“Stevie. What’s goin’ on? Ya don’t have to get into this. I ain’t never seen ya like this before.”

“I’ve never shared this with anyone. It’s not really my secret to share. Rachel and I don’t even talk about it. This guy—Jesus—he was twenty-nine. Rachel was seventeen. He—”

Gold’s right leg started bouncing—fast, uncontrollable.

“Shit.” Oldman shook his head, his face folded in disbelief. “Jesus, Stevie. I didn’t know any of this.”

Gold folded in on himself, sobbing. Oldman scooted over and gently put an arm around his shoulder.

“I got the picture, Stevie. I’m sawry. Had no idea. You don’t have to go on. Like you always said, ‘If you want to keep a secret—keep it secret.’ Won’t do any good to relive memories like that.”

Through tears—voice trembling—Gold spoke. “Her parents didn’t want it to ruin her life. They’d changed their tune—after Jane. They insisted on an abortion. She wasn’t in love with him—sure as hell wouldn’t marry him—but she didn’t want an abortion. She was deeply religious.”

“Rachel’s pro-life?”

Shaken, Gold’s expression tightened. “I never understood how society got stuck with labels. ‘Pro-life,’ ‘pro-choice.’—all labels. All the same cage. Both sides value life. Anyway—yeah, Rachel believed abortion was wrong.”

His voice dropped. “Rachel fought with her parents about the abortion. She wanted to keep the child, but they insisted. And, of course, they had Rabbi Shapiro talk with her.”

“Shapiro, huh? Not my favorite guy.”

“Yeah. Me neither. He’d changed his tune too since Jane.

“At first, he agreed with her. He said preserving life was paramount in Judaism. That abortion’s only allowed if the mother’s life is in danger. But then he said there were nuances, that Judaism also teaches compassion. It makes allowances for the complexity of life.”

“So, did Shapiro talk her into it?”

Gold let out a long breath. “Sort of. He laid a huge guilt trip on her. Single teen mother, how it would affect the baby, then he cited the Fifth Commandment—honor your parents. She didn’t want to disappoint them—she was their favorite. She’d seen how Jane was cast out.

Eventually, she gave in. But the procedure... complications. Heavy bleeding. It was bad. The recovery was long... and brutal. The doctor said she might never carry a child again.

“We tried, but after three miscarriages, we gave up. It was

too painful—each pregnancy ending mid-term, each loss reopening the same wound. She finally accepted what she believed was God’s punishment, convinced He’d sealed her womb in judgment for taking a life.”

“A punishment? From God? For havin’ an abortion? Jesus, Stevie. She was just a kid.”

Gold sniffled, then crossed his arms tightly against his chest. “She never speaks of it. But it broke something inside her. Ruined her relationship with her parents—they felt guilty. Rachel still feels guilty. I can see it in her art. She once spoke of the infinite circle of life—how she’d shattered it that day.”

Gold stared at the floor, his thoughts scattering like mirror shards—sharp and gleaming—until they caught on an image: her necklace, always there, always touching skin. A single blue sapphire sat just outside the diamond loop—the circle of life. Strange he’d never noticed before.

“That’s—

“Wait...” He froze, breath caught. “That’s it.”

“That’s what?”

Eyes wide, excited, Gold spoke. “I just figured it out. The necklace. You know the one she wears?”

Oldman released a breath—relieved. “Jeez Stevie—I thought you were havin’ a stroke. You mean that infinity necklace?”

“Yes! Her necklace—the infinity symbol. A Möbius strip of white diamonds. It represents the circle of life.”

Gold’s voice cracked with awe and sorrow.

“In her mind, she broke that circle the day she had the abortion. That blue sapphire—outside the loop. I bet it symbolizes the child. The one she lost. And that’s why she always wears it. To remember. To honor. To atone.

“She feels guilty. She believes she can’t have children—as a punishment.”

Oldman nodded slowly, with a quizzical but resigned look on his face. “Whew, Stevie... that’s heavy. Sounds like you could be right.”

Jane had given it to her. Rachel told him afterward—how Jane hadn't asked questions, how she brought water, folded a blanket, checked the clock instead of the mirror. Jane sat on the floor beside the couch—not the chair—like height mattered. When Rachel's hands began to shake, Jane took one and stayed still. Rachel said Jane never once looked toward the door. That detail lodged itself in him now, sharp and uninvited.

Gold swallowed hard. The twitching stopped. His throat tightened under the weight of the truth. "I can't believe I never noticed... never realized how much it hurt her. All these years, tangled in my own hunger, I failed to see what bled quietly beside me."

Gold's face tightened with regret, and his eyes welled with tears. He stood abruptly, took two steps, then stopped—fists clenched, breath shallow.

"I let her suffer—in silence. I thought I knew her. That she needed the silence—she'd talk about it when she was ready. Then I guess I didn't want to deal with it either. We split up emotionally."

"Stevie, we know who we are by what we fear. You've always been afraid to share your feelings and explore them. It's like you don't even know yourself."

Gold's voice wavered. "I was so focused on what I wanted—kids, grandkids for my parents, the future I imagined. A nursery, damn it. I thought a baby could fix everything. Once that was out of the picture, I gave up. But I was blind. Blind to what she was going through. I was the only one she had left, but I left her too."

"Rachel lost more than motherhood—she'd already lost Jane. Jason pulled away from the family long ago. I unintentionally punished her because we couldn't give my parents—or hers—grandchildren. And then I disappeared."

"All this time, I obsessed over what wasn't. She's carried what was—and what still is.

"I thought I was the one left wanting. But she's the one who's been grieving—quietly, faithfully. Alone. Because I've emotionally divorced her.

"I left her with a paintbrush and dull paints. A tennis game once a week with her friends, who all have children and share photos

of the recitals, the t-ball, soccer.

“Shit, I’ve sentenced her to a living hell. What the fuck is wrong with me. How could I be so blind. I’ve been hiding from myself forever—and erased her husband through emotional selfishness.”

Oldman stayed quiet, letting the silence settle between them. He could tell Gold was processing everything, trying to make sense of it.

Gold’s mind raced. He suddenly looked up, eyes filled with confusion and frustration. “Jesus, that is it. Has to be. Wow.”

Oldman let out a small chuckle, trying to lighten the moment. “Well, Stevie, I’m glad to know you’re still in one piece. But seriously, man—you’ve been buried so deep in your own mind, maybe it’s time to break free. You’re trapped in a story you wrote twenty years ago. Let’s write a new one—time for somethin’ different.”

Gold looked at him, still in shock, unsure where the conversation was going. “What do you mean, Bob?”

Oldman leaned forward, lowering his voice. “I’ve treated plenty of folks, Stevie. Seen it all before. You get too stuck in yer head, y’forget how to feel—how to connect. It’s not just about thinkin’ things through. Sometimes, you gotta be part of the world. Feel it. Get outta that analytical prison you built.”

Gold stared back, bewildered. “What are you suggesting?”

Oldman rose slowly, limped to the fridge, and returned with a large Ziploc bag. Inside were smaller bags—each filled with what looked like dried herbs or wildflowers, brown and brittle with age.

“Bob, if that’s weed, I’m out. Not interested. And what the hell are you doing with it in your office? I know it’s legal now, but seriously? You’re getting high with your patients?”

Oldman had a mischievous grin that faded as he hesitated.

“Not pot, Stevie. Mushrooms. Medicine.”

“A way I got outta my own head—when nothin’ else worked.

“Psychedelics?” Gold was fascinated. His eyes widened—his right leg started bouncing again, racing up and down like a piston.

“I’ve always been interested, but I can’t do this. Do you do this?”

Oldman sat down on the couch. The big bag held three or four smaller Ziplocs and two amber pill containers. Oldman took two bags out and set them on the couch. Each one—four inches square—was cloudy with age, the zip seals stiff and yellowed. Inside, nestled like fragile specimens in an old biology drawer, were five—maybe six—dried mushrooms. They were light, barely heavier than crumpled paper, and rustled softly in Gold’s hand.

Their caps were golden-brown—some intact, others flaked like old petals. One had curled inward into a shallow bowl, its gills dark and delicate—like the lines of a fingerprint. A faint powder—the residue of time or potency—dusted the inside of the bag.

The stems were long and thin, shaded from ivory to gray, mottled with faint blue-green bruises where fingers had pressed. They resembled twisted reeds or tiny femurs—fragile, not yet crumbling. One had splintered at the end, revealing fibrous threads, as if they’d once been alive.

They smelled of soil, dried wood, something ghostly—metallic—like a forgotten root cellar dreaming beneath dust.

At first glance, they seemed unimpressive. But something in them shimmered—some quietly, like relics. Or keys.

“What happened to the Twelve Steps, Bob? You shouldn’t be messing with this stuff.”

“Stevie, I’m not using this shit, it really is medicine. And it’s legal.”

“What? You prescribe this, looks like you’re dealing from your office.”

“They’ah usually like this.” Oldman pulled one of the cylinders out of the bag. Gold recognized it as an empty amber pharmacy prescription container. “See, from the phaharmacy—legit label, directions, child-guard top—the whole nine yahds.”

Gold examined the container. The thermal label read:

Stanford University School of Medicine

Department of Psychiatry & Behavioral Sciences
Study Drug: Psilocybin (Investigational Use Only)
Trial ID: STAN-PSSY-2024-021
Subject ID: 11247-G
Dose: 25 mg psilocybin (approx. 3g *P. cubensis*)
Form: Oral capsule
Storage: Cool, dry place. Protect from light.
Instructions: Administer only under licensed supervision.
Do not consume outside study protocol.
Principal Investigator: Robert Oldman, M.D.
Contact: 650-XXX-XXXX
FDA IND #17892 | Not FDA Approved | Rx Only

“Since decriminalization back in January, it’s actually gotten harder for Stanford and UCSF to get supply. More money in the personal market now, I guess. This is the same stuff—just not lab-packaged.”

He held up a bag. “So, legally, I can’t prescribe this. And to enroll in the Stanford trial, we’d need six prep sessions, a signed release, and a cardiologist’s blessing. But, as a friend, I can gift some to you.”

He handed Gold one of the Ziplocs. “Remembah, legally—California’s new law lets you possess and use it. I just can’t prescribe it to ya.

“This isn’t like the stuff I used to chase. You don’t take it to feel good. Hell, sometimes it’s rough. You take it because you’re tired of lyin’ to yourself.

“It’s not physically addictive and it’s not habit-forming—it ain’t always fun fuh everyone.

“I know it’s not addictive—I’ve taken a small dose myself. Had this bag for years—kept it double-bagged in the fridge, should still be good. Worst case, nothin’ happens. Maybe you feel a little

queasy.”

He shrugged.

“It’s mild, Stevie. You ain’t gonna flip out.”

“Just take a shroom, crush it, and pour some hot water on it like tea.”

He held Gold’s gaze. “Seriously, Stevie—this won’t unmake you. It didn’t fix me.”

A beat.

“But it helped me stop runnin’.

“This ain’t me talkin’ as your therapist.”

He looked away.

“That door’s closed—for a reason.”

“This is from me, ya friend Bobby who sees you drowning. An’ I know what it’s like to come up gasping.

“Patients usually take it in the morning. But a few, folks with insomnia mostly, follow a nightcap protocol. When I get back in town, I’ll sit with ya the first time—make sure you feel comfortable. But I promise ya—it’s safe.”

Gold brought the bag to his nose and inhaled. He gagged. “You’re serious? Bob, I’ve had mushroom coffee before—but this smells like the bookshelves in Widener...the ones no one touches.”

Oldman chuckled. “There ya go again, Stevie—flashing that Haavahd degree. Remember Leary and Alpert? Ran the Psilocybin Project, early sixties. Both taught there. No one got hurt. No one died.”

“I don’t know, Bob. It fascinates me—you know that. Always has. But it scares the hell out of me. What if I lose control? I’d be surrendering control... I can’t be outta control. What if I start playing with visions—and can’t find my way back? Are you gonna hold my hand while I’m tripping? How long does it even last?”

“Exactly, Stevie. Listen to yerself. Yer overthinkin’ everything. You ain’t never left your own head.” He smiled. “None of that’s gonna happen. You’ll relax—psychically. The world’s gonna feel like an art museum—and you’ll be part of it. Everything’ll make sense. It’ll feel comfortin’. Do it when I get back next week, I’ll hold

your hand.

“You’re drownin’ in grief you won’t name—and guilt you won’t let yourself feel. You’re a good man, Stevie, but ya think too damn much. They won’t fix what’s broken. But they might help you hear the part of yourself that’s still whole. Maybe even the part that forgives you—and still believes you’re worth loving.

“It’s helped some of my patients.

“And it scared the hell outta me the first time.”

Gold said nothing. Just stared at the bag in his hand, remembering the dream—the one where he was drowning.

“The world’s gonna feel like an art museum—an’ you’ll be part of it.”

Gold’s voice was low. “Bob... it’s not really the mushrooms. It’s never been the fear of losing control. It’s the feeling. Feeling anything.”

He hesitated, eyes on the bag.

“Am I ready?

Can I? And if I try—what if nothing comes?

What if I can’t?”

CHAPTER TWENTY-ONE

Nagging Doubts

For beauty is nothing but the beginning of terror, which we can just barely endure,

and we stand in awe of it as it coolly disdains to destroy us.

— Rainer Maria Rilke, *Duino Elegies, First Elegy* (written 1912–1922, published posthumously 1923)

The range of what we think and do is limited by what we fail to notice.

And because we fail to notice that we fail to notice,

there is little we can do to change—until we notice how failing to notice shapes our thoughts and deeds.

— R.D. Laing, *The Politics of Experience* (1967)

Man's greatest dread is not that there is no God.

It is that there is a God—and He may not be good.

— Rev. William Sloane Coffin (attributed)

Hope in reality is the worst of all evils because it prolongs the torments of man.

— Friedrich Nietzsche, *Human, All Too Human* (1878)

For now we see through a glass, darkly...

— 1 Corinthians, KJV (1611)

In fog, every direction feels like the wrong one.

— Steven Gold, *Journal entry* (unpublished)

Thursday, night

Driving home, Gold was flooded—not with clarity, but with a chaos of half-formed feelings, sparring in the dark with ambiguities he couldn't name, ambivalences that dissolved the moment he reached for them.

Fog—thick as unspoken truth. Quiet, as if the world itself were holding its breath, waiting for an answer Gold didn't have.

I meant to talk to Bob about Light shutting down the session. We ran out of time. It wasn't that important.

Light—serene in his smugness, certain in every pronouncement. An expert in everything. Or in the performance of expertise.

As if God had chosen him as a personal emissary—and never bothered to send credentials.

What did he mean when he said, "I'd see? Every angel is terrifying?"

Fuck him. I won't hand him the keys to my mind and let him drive.

And that art expertise—saying Rachel's sculpture shows emptiness and disappointment. That she's screaming inside—and I don't hear it.

Fog clung to the canyon walls, blurring the edges of the world.

Light was trying to control the session. Turn it on me. Avoid reality.

The road narrowed ahead, fading into shadow.

My life feels like it's dissolving into shadow—the way a face disappears from a dream the moment you try to hold it.

Have I been avoiding things? I'd never touched—consoled—a patient like that before. Why now. It's countertransference—or something pretending to be.

I've been dodging that truth—but I've been drowning since the moment he walked into my office, pulling me under, as if he were offering rescue.

Then—a coyote, lean and spectral, burst from the fog, a pup scrambling at its heels.

"Fuck—"

He swerved hard, tires spitting gravel, the bumper glancing

off a row of trash bins that toppled like dominos in his mirror. His iPhone and the mushroom baggie flew from the seat onto the floor.

Plastic bins. Harmless—except to my pride.

*I should go back and pick up the trash. I should.
Probably caught me on their Ring video. Fuck it.*

He switched on his brights and drove slowly—heart pounding in his ears.

I feel bad for people losing their cats and dogs to coyotes, but that's nature. It's their canyon, their night. We're the trespassers.

Like Light said: "Suffering isn't evil—it's facticity, the price of being alive."

Coyotes have to eat. Every animal's on the food chain. I guess a few are at the top, apex predators like killer whales, sharks, polar bears, tigers... man.

It's nature. Nature... not God. And nature doesn't apologize.

According to Light, neither does God. Shitty planning. Needless torture. We could've all been vegetarians.

He reached across to try to grab his iPhone and bag, but couldn't reach them.

Leave it. Too dangerous. I'll be home in a minute.

Oldman was the older brother he never had. Maybe more—maybe the father he'd needed.

Bob's always been there—steadier than most blood kin. Too bad he never married; he'd have been a better father than most who try.

He listens—actually cares. I wonder if I could've been a good father.

I'd have zigged where my dad zagged—swerved before his mistakes. He was pretty stern, always working. I was always trying to please him. Every

choice I made was to make him proud. To hear “I love you.” Or at least to feel it. I think he did—but the words never made the trip from his chest to his lips.

But he had a lot on his plate with mom. Yeah. Never really thought about pleasing her. She wasn’t really there. I guess I wasn’t either. Chicken or egg. Who knows.

Life just is—until it isn’t.

Gold pulled into the driveway, opened the garage, and retrieved the baggie and his iPhone.

“The world’s gonna feel like an art museum—an’ you’ll be part of it.”

He looked at the Ziploc.

Pandora’s box?

No.

Not yet.

CHAPTER TWENTY-TWO

Ringside Seats

There is no dialogue so sharp as the one that hides behind silence.
— Franz Kafka, *The Blue Octavo Notebooks* (1917–1919; paraphrased)

If God is silent, who will speak for Him?
— Steven Gold, *Journal entry*

The righteous man accuses himself in a quarrel, but the fool always blames the other.
— Proverbs, KJV (1611; paraphrased)

Some are guilty, but all are responsible.
— Abraham Joshua Heschel, *The Prophets* (1962)

In theory, a book club is about reading. In practice, it's group therapy with footnotes.
— Steven Gold, *journal entry* (unpublished)

I contend we are both atheists, I just believe in one fewer god than you do. When you understand why you dismiss all the other possible gods, you will understand why I dismiss yours.
— Stephen F. Roberts, (attributed, c. 1995)

Friday, late morning

The synagogue sat just off Beverly Glen—a sprawling mix of stone, glass, and half-finished renovations that made every hallway feel like a debate in progress. In the Adult Education room downstairs, a loose ring of twelve folding chairs held the temple book club—already mid-argument.

Feels like group therapy gone off the rails.

“Rabbi Shapiro, last month’s book was great, but can we please do a murder mystery?”

Kristen waved her hand like an eager schoolgirl. Her reading glasses slipped down her nose, the gold-plated chain catching them

before they fell. “How about a classic? A romance—*Pride and Prejudice*?”

Rachel smiled and nodded. She’d already read it, but loved the thought of a romance, uncomplicated and intact.

Joel muttered without looking up from his iPhone, “Hard pass. I already have to sit through the movie once a week when my wife wants peace and quiet. I know the lines by heart.”

Great movie, though. Marianelli’s score—phenomenal. Not today.

“I liked last month’s book, but I really prefer non-fiction. “I listen to audiobooks while I work out—and with all the stopping and starting, fiction’s hard to follow,” Rick said, still in gym clothes and sipping from his sport bottle.

“And I’d like another thriller, like James Patterson,” Jill added, absently untangling the charms on her gold bracelet.

“I liked Rabbi Hirschberg’s *Hebrew Humanism*. He’s not as well-known as Buber or Heschel, but I appreciated his philosophical defense of Judaism as ethical humanism—distinct from Greek rationalism or modern secularism.”

Okay—informative, sure, but dry as dust.

Lenny leaned back and quipped, “But David, you, Dr. Gold, and Rabbi Shapiro were probably the only ones who actually understood it... or finished it. I gave up. Got tired of waking up with the book on my face.”

Joel laughed; Deborah joined, then covered her mouth—half-embarrassed by herself.

Shapiro said, “Well, it seemed most of you enjoyed the book from two months ago—*Celebrating Life*.”

“Not everyone, Aaron,” Gold said flatly. He always called Rabbi Shapiro by his first name, which made some think they were close. It wasn’t friendship; it was defiance—an intentional lack of respect. Maybe it was tit for tat, since Rabbi Shapiro called him Steven, not Dr. Gold. It was unclear which of them had started it.

“Sacks wrote: ‘Faith is not belief that God will do what we want. It is the belief that God will do what is right.’ That struck me

as painfully naïve—especially coming from the Chief Rabbi of the United Hebrew Congregations of the UK and Commonwealth.”

“I’d have thought he would have appealed to you, Steven. He said: ‘Rationality alone can’t answer existential questions; we need both hemispheres of the brain: analytical and integrative.’”

“Yes, but he also said, ‘Faith is not certainty. It is the courage to live with uncertainty.’ Sounds like a cop-out.”

Take that, Shapiro. I remember more than you think, you condescending asshole.

Laura—newly divorced after decades of quiet humiliation—said softly, “I agree with Deborah. I’d love a romance.”

“I’m sure you would,” Lenny muttered to Joel with a grin.

Rabbi Shapiro rose, smoothing his shirt. “All right, Lenny, enough of that. This is a temple book club—we’re here to explore religion, to learn something.”

Perfect timing.

“Then I’ve got the perfect pick. I’ve been meaning to read it—and I’m guessing none of you have.” Gold looked around at everyone in their chairs. “Why do we assume God is good—with all the evil and suffering in the world?” He leaned forward. “I’ve got a book that might help us face some tough questions.”

David grinned and leaned forward. “Okay, Dr. Gold. What is it—or is this twenty questions?”

Gold smiled, eyes gleaming. “*The God Delusion*, by Richard Dawkins.” He held up a fresh paperback.

Rabbi Shapiro’s voice cracked across the circle. “Absolutely not.”

David perked up. “Why not Rabbi Shapiro? It sounds fascinating. I actually listened to *The Selfish Gene* audiobook. Dawkins is brilliant—great writer and a great narrator.”

Rabbi Shapiro shot him a side glance. “No—we agreed our selections would have religious themes.”

Gold jumped in. “Uh, excuse me, Aaron—religious themes? The God Delusion? Can’t get any more religious than that. Afraid because it challenges religion? We’re here to learn, to discuss, aren’t

we? Israel literally means ‘to struggle with God,’ doesn’t it? So why be afraid to wrestle with the questions?”

Rachel shifted beside him, fingers worrying the edge of her notebook.

He turned toward Shapiro. “I’m surprised you haven’t already read it... or have you?”

“No,” the rabbi said flatly. “I don’t need to be brainwashed by Dawkins, Hitchens, or Harris. I’m not fascinated, or brainwashed, by these ‘new atheists.’”

Christ—it’s my dissertation chair all over again.

“No, of course not. Right. “Better, then, to be brainwashed by anonymous redactors—four major contributors to the Pentateuch, each from different centuries with their own agendas—and then more centuries of edits and revisions.”

“You sound pretty cynical,” Deborah murmured.

Of course I do.

“And angry,” Joel muttered, still scrolling.

I am.

Shapiro gave a small “harrumph,” stood, and crossed to the buffet table for a water bottle. Seeing his belly protruding from under his salmon-colored shirt, he sucked in his stomach and struggled to fasten the bottom button. He said, “Steven, you dismiss God too easily—as if millennia of thought and experience meant nothing.”

Dismissive prick.

Gold felt both called out and slighted, discounted by Shapiro. Clearly angry, face flushed red, Gold called to Shapiro as he walked away. “I think it was Stephen Roberts, a historian, who said, ‘we’re both atheists, I just believe in one fewer god than you do.’ Think of your first commandment, Aaron. You dismiss all the other possible gods, from thousands of years of history. I simply add yours to that list.”

“My first commandment? My God?... My God.”

Rachel reached over, resting her hand on his leg. She

whispered, “Steven.”

Ignoring her plea for restraint, he rose and walked to the buffet table as well. He stepped in front of Shapiro, blocking his return to the circle. “I don’t dismiss belief—I question its ontology, its very being.”

Brian’s eyebrows shot up, then settled. He remained still.

Face to face, Shapiro stared directly into Gold’s eyes. “That’s wordplay. A dodge.”

“No. Philosophical hygiene—scrubbing the metaphysical muck off faith before it festers.”

Brian, Jill, and Deborah nodded, pretending to understand.

Rachel shot Kristen a small, mortified smile that asked for rescue.

“You know *Meinong’s jungle*, Aaron?”

“Yes, Steven, I’m familiar with the argument.”

Lenny raised his hand like a kid in class. “I’m not!” he said grinning.

Gold explained. “It’s like a mental zoo filled with animals that don’t exist. But everyone knows what they are.”

Brian said, “I don’t get it.”

Gold turned back toward the circle of chairs. “Unicorns, Brian—we all know what they are, what they stand for. But they aren’t real. Same with Pegasus, dragons, trolls. And... God—we read, we pray, we preach—but there’s no proof that He exists.”

Lenny turned to Brian, laughing, and whispered, “Sorry you had to find out this way, Brian, there’s no Santa.”

Gold continued. “Maybe God’s a unicorn—vivid, meaningful, but imaginary nonetheless.”

“Steven,” Jill said, “just because something isn’t real doesn’t mean it’s meaningless.”

“Exactly. The jungle is meaningful—that’s what makes it dangerous. Meaning doesn’t require reality—it requires need. Take the first commandment: ‘Thou shalt have no other gods before Me.’ That’s not omnipotence speaking—it’s insecurity. Yahweh sounds

less like a god than a father terrified of being replaced.”

Shapiro frowned. “Or a father trying to keep a family from tearing itself apart.”

Gold nodded slightly. “All too human. That’s the problem.” He gave a wry smile. “When your god starts looking that much like your father, maybe it’s time to admit we created Him in our own image—and then forgot the joke. That explains His behavior. Especially His bad behavior.”

“You think that’s clever, Steven?” Shapiro said. “Or comforting?”

David seemed interested in the intellectual sparring.

“Well, Aaron, who tells us what God is, what He wants, why He does what He does? None of us see Him. None of us talk with Him—not since Abraham, Moses, and a handful of prophets. We’re told what He meant, what He means, and how we should think about it, based on hundreds of years of rabbis’ writings. Rabbis who are also human...” He paused, eyes scanning Shapiro up and down. “... all too human.”

“And on the Eighth Day,” Gold said softly, “man created God.”

Shapiro responded angrily, taking the challenge. “What’s that, Steven?”

“We needed God to explain lightning, death, desire, dreams, and the ache of absence. So we invented Him in our own image. Male. Jealous. Angry. A king. A father. A judge. Not because He is—but because we were.”

Maybe what terrifies me most isn't that we created God...

but that He created us just like Himself: lonely. flawed. and desperate to be loved.

“I’m saying, Aaron, that religion’s not timeless. It evolves. Just like people.

“You ever notice how the God of Israel doesn’t just ask for love or devotion—he demands exclusivity? Not respect. Not reverence. Obedience. Loyalty. Absolute.

“The First Commandment—‘You shall have no other gods before Me.’ It’s a covenant. A relationship. A marriage contract—but not a healthy one. It’s the kind of relationship where one partner monitors your phone, tracks your location, forbids you from seeing anyone else. Not because he’s whole, but because he’s afraid.

In ancient Israel, Yahweh tolerated polytheism. Then suddenly, monotheism became sacred. It happened around the same time marriage for the Hebrews shifted from polygamy to monogamy.”

“You’re saying society shaped God, not the other way around?”

“Look at it, Aaron—theology is a mirror. And sometimes a funhouse mirror. We think we’re worshipping the divine, but really, we’re staring at ourselves—our fears, our rules, our needs—reflected back in gold leaf and flame.”

Jill let out a polite chuckle, eyes fixed on her bracelet so no one saw her confusion.

“Look around. Zeus never said, ‘You shall have no other gods.’ Odin never demanded exclusivity. They shared power—fought, yes—but never denied each other’s existence. Only Yahweh demanded monogamy. Why? Because deep down, he knew he wasn’t the only one at the table. And worse—he feared being the least.”

“Pagans,” Shapiro muttered. “Myths and legends, not religion.”

Gold smiled, as if expecting that retort. “It’s all the same. The ancient Hebrews lived among polytheists. It was a way of setting boundaries—of identity. Or maybe projection—an insecure tribal deity clawing his way up the divine food chain.

“You think Yahweh wasn’t aware of Baal, Marduk, Aten? Of course He was. That’s why He kept insisting He was better—‘There is none like Me!’—shouting into the void like a child who knows the others run faster.

“It’s psychology masquerading as theology. Yahweh feared being compared. Measured. And found wanting.”

Shapiro clapped, disingenuously. “Fascinating lecture Steven, so you’re saying God has an inferiority complex.”

“I’m saying even gods could use therapy.”

Shapiro shrugged, smirk barely contained. “I’m no psychologist, but that sounds a lot like projection.”

Walking back to his chair, Gold shook his head slowly. “I’m just saying we stretch. A book club is meant to help us widen our horizons, not close shutters. We need to step outside this echo chamber—hear a voice we don’t already agree with. “Open our eyes. It’s not on Dawkins to prove God doesn’t exist—it’s on rabbis,” he said, glancing at Shapiro, “to prove He does.”

Rachel leaned over and whispered, her eyes reddened. “Steven, calm down. You’re embarrassing me. Please, sit down.”

Shapiro returned to the circle and narrowed his gaze. “You sound angry, Steven—like you came here with an agenda.”

You got that right.

“Maybe I did.” Gold didn’t sit, he straightened up, shoulders squared like a man about to testify. “Not every line in the Torah was spoken to Moses atop Sinai. That world—3,000 years ago—was brutal. Primitive. We know more now. About nature, science, suffering. Ethics. Compassion. The Torah gestures toward them... but often falls short.”

Rabbi Shapiro folded his arms. He asked, “How, exactly?”

Gold hesitated, heart pounding in his throat.

He hadn’t planned to go this far. “How tradition can twist scripture into a weapon—like claiming the Torah forbids abortion or suicide.”

Rabbi Shapiro’s brow rose. “Actually, it doesn’t—at least not explicitly. *Exodus* treats miscarriage as a civil case—a fine, not murder. Suicide? Not mentioned. Maybe a poetic ‘choose life.’ The hard lines came centuries later.

What?

Gold stared, heat rushing to his face.

“Rabbis building fences around fences. Then why, Aaron”—Gold’s voice climbed—“did you tell a dying old man that the Sixth Commandment forbids suicide?” That easing his own death was a sin against God?”

The room froze. Chairs creaked; then silence.

Gold's fists tightened in his lap. "And why would you tell a seventeen-year-old girl—raped and terrified—to blindly obey her parents instead of her own heart?"

Rachel bowed her head, fingers tight around her necklace until the chain bit her skin. Kristen reached over, putting her hand on Rachel's lap.

Deborah and Jill looked away. Laura's eyes brimmed; she stared down at the floor. Joel kept scrolling.

Hiding behind his Dodgers cap, Brian mouthed to Lenny, "What's going on?"

Lenny whispered, "Something about Gold's father. Later." He leaned back, smiling like a spectator with ringside seats to someone else's ruin.

Without realizing it, both men had risen again—now facing each other across the circle.

Rabbi Shapiro's voice trembled slightly. "Your father told me things he couldn't tell you. Where were you, Steven? You weren't there—you couldn't understand."

What did he tell you that he couldn't tell me?

Gold froze. For a moment, Shapiro's voice became Light's—calm, devastating, like Job's friends: certain and wrong. They hadn't been there. They never are.

A flicker of Gerald—his father on the hospice bed, too weak to lift the glass.

His breath caught. Fists curled. Voice low, trembling.

Rachel glanced at him, alarmed by the sudden change in his face—color drained, lips parted, trembling.

"Don't you tell me I wasn't there, Aaron." His voice was a hiss. "I held his hand. Watched him vanish in inches. Heard him beg for an end he called mercy."

He stepped forward—close now. Inches from Rabbi Shapiro's eyes.

Rachel reached up, but Gold pushed her hand aside.

*Even rational men commit irreversible acts.
Sometimes they know it before the first step.*

No one moved. The silence tightened like a drumhead—ready to split.

Deborah and Jill both flushed red. Kristen's shoulders trembled. Joel buried his face in his phone. Brian peered from beneath his Dodgers cap and mouthed something to Lenny.

"What? What the hell?" Brian whispered.

"Gold's dad. I'll fill you in after," Lenny whispered, then turned back, grinning like a man with ringside seats at a prize fight.

The two men had been inching closer—almost without realizing it. Rabbi Shapiro raised a hand and pressed it to Gold's chest. "What now—going to hit me?"

If we were alone, I might.

Gold's eyes burned. His hands trembled.

Rabbi Shapiro's eyes widened, but he didn't blink. He'd faced threats before—growing up in an antisemitic neighborhood, he'd faced down plenty.

He knew himself.

He knew his God—and he never blinked.

And suddenly, Gold saw himself—from the outside. Saw Rachel, the others.

The heat. The shame.

This wasn't strength. It was surrender—to darkness.

Guilt surged. Too late. The line was crossed. No taking it back. No rationalizing—not to them, not to himself.

What the hell is wrong with me?

Everyone was still. Faces brittle with discomfort—frozen in place.

Unwilling witnesses to a war they didn't ask for—one they'd never understand.

Gold held his gaze a second too long.

"Your father would've wept for what you've become."

“Fuck you.”

“Steven!” Rachel gasped.

“And fuck your God.” The words burst out louder than he intended—a blasphemous thunderclap that rattled the stained glass.

Then nothing.

He shoved his chair back and strode out of the ring. The sanctuary door slammed—a gavel, a sentence.

All eyes turned to Rabbi Shapiro. He exhaled—slow, controlled.

Silence lingered like smoke after a fire—heavy and thick with shame.

CHAPTER TWENTY-THREE

Sometimes Light Hides in Shadows

There is no dialogue so sharp as the one that hides behind silence.
— Franz Kafka, *The Blue Octavo Notebooks* (1917–1919; paraphrased)

Some are guilty, but all are responsible.
— Abraham Joshua Heschel, *The Prophets* (1962)

The righteous man accuses himself in a quarrel, but the fool always blames the other.
— Proverbs, KJV (1611; paraphrased)

Saturday, afternoon

RING... RING

A jagged rainbow pulsed behind Gold's eyes. He winced—the migraine had started forty-five minutes earlier, jagged lines cutting through his vision. He blinked; the center remained blind, a smear of blur.

RING... RING

He reached for his phone. *Caller Unknown*

Probably a telemarketer. Let it go to voicemail.

RING... RING

Gold ignored it and lay back down.

It had only been a couple of minutes before the phone rang again.

RING... RING

Caller Unknown

He checked, but there'd been no voicemail before.

Again?

RING... RING

Fuck it.

“Hello?”

“Hi, Dr. Gold—it’s Samael.” The voice came fast, breathless. “Sorry to bother you on a Saturday, but I was wondering if I could see you today. It’s urgent.”

Urgent? I wasn’t sure I’d ever see him again—and part of me had hoped I wouldn’t.

Gold sat up. “Hi, Samuel. I can talk now, if you’d like—what’s going on?”

“Thanks, but I’d rather see you in person. I’m... scared.”

Scared? That doesn’t sound like him. Maybe his father really is a drug lord.

“I don’t normally see patients on weekends...”

Light’s voice dropped to a whisper. “He knows.”

Shit.

“He?”

“My Father—God.”

Okay. Still playing the part.

“Dr. Gold, I really need to talk. This is a crisis. I’m sorry for storming out last time—I was just... angry. Please.”

Crisis? Every patient calls it that. But most crises fade—regression to the mean. Even tsunamis return to ripples.

Except the ones that don’t.

Stay grounded. No guilt-tripping. It’s just dinner and a movie—nothing more.

“Alright—give me a few minutes to make some calls. I’ll meet you at the office in half an hour.”

Gold heard a sharp exhale—like relief spilling out. “Thank you, Dr. Gold—I really appreciate it.”

He ended the call and sat motionless, heart starting to pound.

*Wait—if he believes God’s his father, then of course
He knows. God would know everything. Is the logic of
his delusion cracking? Something’s shifted. There’s
panic in him now—fear, not defiance.*

He hadn’t been sure he’d ever see Light again after Thursday’s session. The thought brought relief—perhaps even a flicker of happiness.

He grabbed his phone again. “Hey Siri, call Rachel—mobile—on speaker.”

The call connected—clattering dishes, children yelling in the background.

“Rach, can you hear me?”

“Hi, Steven!” Rachel’s voice strained above the background noise. “Kristen and I stopped for frozen yogurt after tennis—food-court madness. Everything okay? Did you take the Advil? How’s your head?”

“It’s better—the aura’s gone.

“One of my new patients called—he’s in crisis and needs to see me. I’m heading to the office.”

“You never see patients on the weekend, Steven.”

“I know—but he needs me.”

Rachel’s tone changed slightly.

“Steven, I’m worried. You’re obsessing about a patient again. We hardly see each other any more. And you shouldn’t drive if you still have—”

“Migraine’s gone. Really. I’ll be home by five-thirty.”

She hesitated. “Kristen and Bill would love to join us tonight.”

“Sounds great—I’ll text when I’m done.”

“Steven—?”

“Rach? Rach? Not sure if the call dropped—if you can hear me, I’ll be home by five-thirty. Love you.”

He ended the call.

*I should've warned her I'd be late. There's no way
I'll keep this to a fifty-minute hour.*

Gold entered through the patient exit, bypassing the waiting room. On his Ring app, he saw Light pacing—khaki slacks, red polo, bright white sneakers—head down, spinning his ring like a dial he couldn't stop turning.

He glanced at himself—slightly wrinkled white Brooks Brothers shirt, Levis, Nike Airs.

He said it was urgent—so I rushed over.

Gold opened the reception door.

“Hi, Samuel—come in.”

Light looked harried—brow knotted, shoulders high—and moved straight to the couch.

Gold started toward the club chair, then reconsidered and sat at the opposite end of the couch.

*Make him feel safe. Oldman always does this—less
structure, more connection.*

Light fidgeted—shoulders twitching, breath shallow—twisting the ring as if he couldn't unscrew it from his finger.

“He knows... He's upset.”

He's spiraling. Panic attack?

“Okay, Samuel—slow down. Breathe with me, center yourself. No rush; take all the time you need.”

I knew already—this wouldn't only be fifty minutes.

Gold had only seen Light a few times, but this was different—out of character, unraveling fast.

Do I break the frame?

Gold inched closer, laid his palm gently against Light's chest. It pounded like a machine—relentless, terrified.

“Close your eyes. Relax. Now—follow my count. Inhale

slowly and deeply... one, two, three—through your nose. Out... four, five, six.

“Again. Picture deep blue oxygen sliding in through your nose. See the color swirl inside... one, two, three.

“Now exhale—slowly— a pale red mist through your lips... four, five, six. Watch the color fade, the heat drift away. Hear only my voice.”

Light’s breath caught, then steadied.

They continued through four slow cycles.

Gold kept his hand on Light’s chest, felt the hammering slow. No more jolts with each beat. The ring had stopped spinning—so had he.

Light’s hands—palms up now—rested loosely at his sides. Quiet.

“Good. Just my voice—nothing else.”

*Don’t rush. Keep him cognitive—make him think.
It’s hard to feel when you think.*

Logic steadies feelings, lets you control emotions.

Anchor him in language.

“Samuel, earlier you said ‘He knows.’ But God’s omniscient—He’s always known, hasn’t He? Even before you did. So there’s no surprise, no reason to panic.”

Let that settle.

Okay—he’s collected now. Play it out, see what purpose the delusion serves. A defense mechanism isn’t denial—it’s architecture. A dam built not to deceive but to hold: not memory, but emotion—tidal, overwhelming. Break it too soon and the patient drowns. He needs a strong ego to survive the flood. Is he ready? Does he have the structure—the integrity—to endure what breaks through?

Light opened his eyes—his expression softer. “Thank you, Dr. Gold. That helped. I’m okay.”

“Good. Then His knowing shouldn’t shock you—you can’t keep secrets from an omniscient God.”

Gotta be careful. He might have seen that as a challenge.

Light nodded slowly. “It’s more nuanced than that, Dr. Gold.”

He took a slow breath.

“Remember when I told you the Bible got it wrong? Not entirely—just refracted. It isn’t purely the word of God or of Moses; men and women added their truths—and their agendas.”

Gold frowned, puzzled.

“*Psalm 139* and *First Samuel*—people read them as proof of God’s omniscience, that He knows every word before it’s spoken, every thought before it forms. But that’s not the reality. It isn’t surveillance—it’s depth. Intimacy.”

Reality? He’s talking about reality?

“Think about it—those verses apply to you too, Dr. Gold. Aren’t they?”

More Bible study.

“Sorry, Samuel. I told you—I know Genesis and Exodus, but it pretty much ends there.”

Light smiled faintly. “Of course. Sorry—it says:

*“O LORD, Thou hast searched me, and known me.
Thou knowest my downsitting and mine uprising.
Thou understandest my thought afar off.*

Thou measurest my going about and my lying down, and art acquainted with all my ways. For there is not a word in my tongue, but, lo, O LORD, Thou knowest it altogether.

And

...man looketh on the outward appearance, but the LORD looketh on the heart.

“But the same could be said of a therapist—or a spouse.”

Gold said, “True. That kind of knowing is earned—it’s empathy—not magic. Perception. So... God’s not really omniscient?”

Light raised up a hand to pause him. Gold’s eyes caught the ring.

Hmm... it doesn't seem as bright as last week.

“No—He is. Just not the way you think.”

“Think of Michelangelo—when he chose a block of Carrara marble, he already saw the figure within—David, Moses, the Pietà. He didn’t create them; he recognized them trapped in stone, and freed them.”

Gold stayed silent, fingertips pressing together in thought.

I've heard that metaphor before.

“But marble has faults—cracks, veins, fissures—imperfections he had to carve around. No mistakes allowed.

“He didn’t know exactly where they lay—but he knew they existed.” Light opened his hands in offering, as if to prove it.

“So he worked with what he had—accepting it would never be perfect.”

Gold nodded. Slowly.

“I told you—God’s an artist... and a narcissist. Angels, we were perfect, but bound to obey. But then came man—free will—and the game was no longer rigged for Him to hear only what He wanted.

“Free will—those fissures, the pits in marble—flaws. Unexpected.

“Like paint spattered—dust, grit, bits of debris—onto a perfect palette. You start a masterpiece and realize the colors have shifted, the paints corrupted; the vision’s no longer what you imagined.”

“Sometimes light hides in shadows, Dr. Gold—not to deceive, but to survive.”

He let the silence hold.

Interesting... So free will let man worship God—or not. Even criticize Him—something angels never could.

“Voltaire said, *Le mieux est l’ennemi du bien*—the perfect is the enemy of the good. God is perfection itself; imagine the prison of flawless expectation He inhabits—an artist trapped with flawed materials. And with free will, everyone becomes a critic ... or worse, a co-creator.”

“Imagine a genius—composer, painter, writer—whose work is open-source. Free will lets anyone riff on the melody, repaint the canvas, rewrite the play—swap the murderer, invent a new lover.

“Monday-morning quarterbacks questioning every move. Interesting at first—maybe even thrilling—for a while.”

That would drive me crazy.

“Malevich, Mondrian, Pollock, Warhol—all originals no one saw them coming; that surprise is what made them art.

“Not technical difficulty but historical bravery—cultural timing, conceptual shock.

“They weren’t hard to execute—anyone could have made them. Eventually, everyone did.

“Each became the new style—until the next arrived. Fashions never stay fashionable.”

Interesting... never thought of it that way.

“When you know someone too well, you anticipate every thought, every move. It kills surprise—and eventually, it kills joy.

Gold added, “Yeah, I get it. I was furious at Duchamp’s *Fountain*, Serrano’s *Piss Christ*—even Rauschenberg’s *Cardboards*, nailed to the wall. Ridiculous.”

“Exactly—and that’s what happened to God. He got angry.” Light shook his head. “Free will didn’t fix it—not for long. This wasn’t *Groundhog Day*. Cattelan’s *Comedian*—a banana duct-taped to a wall—hailed as brilliant and celebrated for its absurdity—sold for \$150,000.”

“Well, God saw it coming—anticipated it all—and it broke

Him.”

Light continued, voice softer. “So yes, Dr. Gold—God is omniscient, just not as you imagine. Not all-powerful. Not in control.”

Light lowered his voice. “After a while, you know what your children will do before they do it. You know they’ll disobey, fail ... and you still love them.”

And we’re all God’s children.

*And he had to let us grow up, even though he knew
we’d make mistakes*

“But it gets worse,” Light continued, “When you know everything that’s coming—sorrow, disappointment, illness, death.

“Imagine parents told their child has a heart defect that will take her before ten. Or a glioblastoma no surgeon can touch. A drunk driver kills their child. A husband hears his wife of thirty years will never know him again. A young woman told she can never bear a child. A man forced to end his father’s suffering.”

Gold froze—swallowed hard, throat tight.

How could he possibly know? No.

Light went on. “He knows—He anticipates.” He stared, as if into a past long ago, or a future, not yet here.

Like the Nazareth song—‘Love Hurts’:

Love hurts, love scars, love wounds

And mars, any heart

Not tough or strong enough

To take a lot of pain, take a lot of pain

Love is like a cloud

Holds a lot of rain

Love hurts... ooh, ooh love hurts.

Gold murmured, “Love hurts.”

Light smiled. “Exactly, Dr. Gold—you understand perfectly.”

Gold looked up. “But why couldn’t God have made everything perfect? Why must people die? Why doesn’t He hear their prayers?”

Oops... facilitate, don't enable. It's all delusion.

“Could He have made it perfect? Is any artist ever satisfied? Tell me, Dr. Gold—how many times do you revise a story or book before you’re truly done? Each pass whispers, I could make it clearer, better, more alive. But man is flawed—so why not believe even God could go mad with perfection?”

“Remember, He made us—angels—perfect, yet we couldn’t give Him what He craved: worship, prayers, thanks. He needed man.”

Makes sense. Even God needs meaning.

“But free will changed everything—problems He never anticipated.”

“Why must people die? Why are lives so brief?”

“Because without death, life would be a game with no clock. No urgency, no stakes. Imagine basketball without a shot clock or chess without time—endless moves, no tension. Time creates need, the pressure to act before it’s too late.”

Untimed Pictionary or Charades—endless, pointless.

A fully-formed delusion... but what's beneath it?

“And prayers? He can’t answer them all—most cancel each other out. Winners thank Him for touchdowns and Tony Awards, as if He’s tipping the scales in their favor.

“Do you really believe He commanded the Israelites to massacre the Amalekites—men, women, and children? God doesn’t take sides; the real question is who’s on His.”

Not the atheists.

“He’s jealous, yes—but do you really think He wanted anyone who worshiped another god—or a rebellious child, or someone who worked on the Sabbath—to be put to death?”

“The Holocaust. The Armenian, Cambodian, Circassian,

Incan massacres—the hate, the wars. None of that was God; that was man. Free will.”

That’s true.

“Man fears a dystopian future while ignoring the dystopian present he’s already built.

“No wonder God stopped listening. If He watched too closely and saw how wicked man’s become, He’d order me to punish mankind again—like Job. Or He’d send another Flood, fire this time. He promised never to destroy all mankind again, but He only promised not to use water. Signed it with a rainbow. He splits hairs—He’s killed plenty of people in floods since, just not everyone.”

Gold asked, “So God’s not truly omniscient?”

Wait... too late. Feeding the delusion again.

Light looked deflated, struggling to hold his point together.

“Dr. Gold, I saw Dune on your shelf—have you read them all?”

“Yes— and I’ve seen the films. The books win by light-years.”

“In *Children of Dune*, Princess Irulan says, ‘To know the future absolutely is to be trapped in it absolutely.’”

Gold nodded in recognition, then tilted his head. “So God’s trapped by His own future—the one He created.”

Light shook his head. Disappointed. “Let me find the right words so you’ll understand.”

“Think of God as a writer—the author of life. There are two kinds of writers: pantsers, who improvise, and plotters, who plan it all. Either way they learn the ending. But knowing doesn’t help; it hurts—the weight of threads, characters, flaws you see coming.”

“But He’s God.”

Light leaned forward, his eyes catching the glare.

“The future isn’t a gift, Dr. Gold—it’s a sentence. To see it is to be trapped in it. Indifference might soften the blow—but it kills the story.”

I’ll stay in his delusional metaphor.

“I know that prescience,” Gold said, “like instinct or intuition, isn’t prophecy. It’s pattern recognition. If I can predict the ending of a book or play, that doesn’t make me responsible for it. But God—He’s the author. He is responsible.”

“Once He created free will, the game changed—endless possibilities. Even a quantum computer can’t predict what’s next; it can only project probabilities. But this is different. God knows. He’s the parent who knows His children are dying and can’t save them. He sees it all—everything that was, is, and will be.

“And that’s His curse—omniscience.”

Gold leaned forward. “Free will was His choice, His creation. So even if He’s no longer writing the story, He set it all in motion. He started it. That makes everything His ultimate responsibility. His blame. His guilt.”

What does God do with guilt?

Withdraw? Hide? Isolate?

“Exactly. And knowing it all—that’s His torture. Every prayer is another torment He can’t bear, can’t escape.”

Light’s eyes filled.

“If He could, He’d blind Himself like Oedipus. But even then, He’d know. Prescience or omnipotence—it doesn’t matter. Through free will, God damned Himself to the fate of Sisypheus and Prometheus—eternal torture, fully aware, inescapable.

“You can’t begin to imagine the horror that lives inside the mind of God.”

Never considered that. The mind of God—horror.

Light’s voice steadied even as tears dropped onto his ring—his fingers gripping it tight.

“After our last session, it hit me—I couldn’t stop thinking. The anger, the blasphemy, the ache. Something changed. I felt different.”

Gold listened.

“I realized—I’m not angry at God.”

I am.

Gold drew a slow breath. “Have you ever considered forgiving Him?”

Light blinked, uncertain. The question seemed to land somewhere deeper than either expected.

Two sons trying to forgive ghosts.

Hoping those ghosts might forgive them in return.

But ghosts can't forgive; they only haunt.

We have to forgive ourselves.

Light lifted his hand, slid the damp ring from his finger, and clenched it in his fist.

“I pity Him.”

Gold looked up—Light’s blue, tear-filled eyes locking into his.

“The pity is that man no longer needs God—but God still needs man.”

Wow. I didn't see that coming.

Light looked down, slid the ring back on, and wiped his eyes and nose.

“He’s not punishing us—He’s enduring us.”

A silence hung between them—dense, almost holy.

Gold whispered, “Why?”

Light didn’t answer at first. Then—“Because even He—God Almighty—still has hope. He believes.”

He believes?

“But God has no one to pray to... He knows.

“Man has prayer—call it fantasy if you wish—but man has something: hope. It’s universal. Everyone wants a hand to hold when they face that cosmic finality—when they walk into the unknown at life’s end.”

Gold nodded. “Yes. Man’s a social animal. Even alone, he seeks the comfort of another—physical or spiritual. We need each other. Even the hard solipsists convince themselves there’s no

independent God—but at death’s edge, they reach out—or in—to speak to Him.”

“Maybe we’re all theists in the end—devout or disillusioned, pagan or deist, even misotheist—but we’re all reaching. Outward. Inward. Toward something.

“Everyone prays when their soul is bleeding—when they’re alone in a foxhole, real or metaphorical.”

“But God, Dr. Gold—He has no one to reach for. That’s why He needs man. He doesn’t want to be alone. That was the whole point of creation.

“Man isn’t the only social being—God needs us too. I realized He’s been reaching out, but every time... His hand came back empty.

“His soul yearns for connection. Imagine His nightmare—eternal, unending.

“His horror, Dr. Gold, is hope itself. He knows the child will die of glioblastoma, the mother prays in vain, the war and cruelty continue.

“And still... He hopes. That man might surprise Him—that the ending He knows is coming might change.”

He looked down. “But the ending always comes ... He knows.”

What ending? No—don’t interrupt him. This catharsis matters. He needs it ... maybe I do too.

Light stared at the floor. “‘Hell is other people.’ That’s God’s hell too.

“People think I’m the monster—Satan.” Light said softly. “But they’re wrong.” He turned to Gold. “It’s God.”

God’s the monster?

Gold stiffened. Puzzled.

“Frankenstein’s creature never asked to be created or abandoned. He said, ‘I ought to be thy Adam, but I am rather the fallen angel... Misery made me a fiend.’”

Light’s eyes shimmered again.

“That’s not me. I am Satan. That’s God—the real monster. Not as Milton made me say ‘Evil be thou my good,’ but because of pain—of blame. He’s isolated, omnipotent, utterly misunderstood ... alone.”

“In our first session you told me about two kinds of guilt. Now I see that God is guilty—of the second kind. He didn’t do anything wrong...”

God suffers from neurotic guilt.

Light paused, bowed his head as if in prayer, then lifted his gaze until his deep blue eyes locked with Gold’s.

“I did,” he said. “Not by suggesting He create free will, or by using it myself—but by blaming Him for evil. By ignoring His pain. By refusing to understand Him.”

“I’m His son...” Light’s breath hitched. “And I deserted Him.”

Let it linger. Don’t spoil the moment. He needs to feel this.

“And that’s the first kind of guilt, Dr. Gold—true guilt. He needed me and I left Him. I took away His son—myself. In a way ... I killed Him.”

The delusion doesn’t matter anymore. This is the work—guilt over abandoning his father. Father as God. Until we grow up, we believe our fathers are God. Even as adults we cling to that belief—fuel for the psychic struggle.

They sat in silence.

Then, almost gently, Light added, “That’s what I meant earlier, Dr. Gold. When I said ‘He knows,’ I should have said ‘I know.’” Light slid off the ring for a moment, reading the inscription. “He’s known all along.”

Gold studied him. “You made it sound like a threat.”

Light nodded slowly. “It was—I felt threatened... guilty.”

He placed a hand on his chest. “His pain... the unimaginable torture.”

Maybe that's why he forbade eating the Tree of the Knowledge of Good and Evil—the horror of knowing.

Delusion or not, he's working through it—at arm's length, but working.

“He knows what we say, what we think. He's no cosmic judge.”

He's judged Himself... and found Himself guilty.

“And deeper still—He knows because He feels it. Every scream, every loss, every regret. He doesn't just see them; He absorbs them into His being”

The screams are his own... and he can't turn them off. Just as I can't forget my father's deathbed.

“He's not omniscient the way people imagine... He's prescient. Like Paul in *Dune*. He sees every branching path and must watch us choose wrong, ruin His masterpiece.

“That's the worst part—He hopes. He waits, and He watches the pain unfold anyway.”

“Omnipotent? No... the opposite. He watches, helpless, as we keep playing on the train tracks—ignoring his pleas to behave, for our own good.”

He wants to stay in the fantasy. No one wants to see the small man behind the curtain ... but sooner or later we all do.

Another long pause. Then Light whispered, “He's not punishing us.”

His voice trembled. “He's enduring us.”

Gold didn't speak.

Light looked down again, then softly said, “And He's breaking.”

Gold sat frozen.

“He's enduring us... He's breaking.”

The words echoed through his skull, his soul—

We're all breaking.

We're all guilty.

Not rage.

Not judgment.

Compassion.

He glanced at Light, whose breathing had slowed, his voice now fragile, almost reverent. What unsettled Gold most was how true it felt.

He heard Rachel's voice: *You've been obsessed with this patient.* And he had—obsessed, enchanted, disturbed.

He forgave God. Can I?

Or, do I need my scapegoat?

And yet now... was it therapy? Was he treating a delusion—or receiving a revelation?

Was Light insane—or simply human? Gold didn't know. Maybe that was the truth at the center of it all: the unbearable not-knowing, the shadow where everything hides.

I've spent my life dissecting suffering—trying to map and contain it. But maybe....

Maybe it isn't meant to be understood... maybe it's just meant to be shared.

Light wasn't smiling or gloating; he looked spent—hollowed out by empathy.

Maybe the dam didn't break today—but something shifted. The wall between knowing and feeling can't hold forever.

Gold exhaled—slow, uncertain.

Cracks forming in the dam. But whose—his... or mine?

Am I helping him... or is he helping me?

A Question of Balance

CHAPTER TWENTY-FOUR

Myself Am Hell

*Which way I fly is Hell; myself am Hell;
And in the lowest deep a lower deep
Still threatening to devour me opens wide...
— John Milton, Paradise Lost (1667)*

*I ought to be thy Adam,
but I am rather the fallen angel, whom thou drivest from joy for no misdeed.
— Mary Shelley, Frankenstein; or, The Modern Prometheus (1818)*

*I am part of that power which still
produces good, while ever scheming ill.
— Johann Wolfgang von Goethe, Faust, Part I (1808)*

*And yeah, yeah, God is great
Yeah, yeah, God is good
Yeah, yeah, yeah-yeah-yeah
What if God was one of us?
Just a slob like one of us
— Eric Bazilian, lyrics from “One of Us,” recorded by Joan Osborne on
Relish (1995)*

Saturday, late afternoon

He’s breaking again—and I’m just watching.

Gold leaned forward, elbows on knees.

*Stick with the delusion. It’s not enabling—it’s
treatment.*

“You think He’s gone mad?”

“He has, Dr. Gold. And He knows it. Camus said, ‘There is but one truly serious philosophical problem—the question of suicide.’”

Gold nodded, distracted.

But Shapiro said no. God said no. I was trapped—between the Fifth and Sixth Commandments.

Wait. Camus? Is he saying God's considered suicide.

Light continued, his voice softening. "That's the question God asks Himself—every day. He sees everything. Hears every prayer, every scream, every child who dies. Every mistake He can't stop."

He paused, voice barely above a whisper. "And He can't end it. There's no higher God to pass the reins to. No Zeus. No Quetzalcoatl. The rest—gone. Mencken said it, Nietzsche too. We killed them... or they simply left."

"Even as an atheist—or a non-practicing Jew—you know the *Shema*."

Gold nodded.

Of course: *Shema Yisrael, Adonai Eloheinu, Adonai Echad*.

I still whisper it most nights—faith by muscle memory.

"Hear, O Israel..."

My mother's voice teaching me the words? Maybe. Her hand on my shoulder, guiding my lips through each syllable.

Is that a memory... or a wish? I haven't heard her voice in years.

"Parse it carefully, Dr. Gold. 'Hear, O Israel: the Lord our God, the Lord is one.' It never denied other gods—only declared Yahweh supreme."

Light leaned back, eyes closed.

"But my Father... He stayed. He couldn't stop hearing the prayers. The pain."

Szasz said, "If you talk to God, you are praying. If God talks to you, you have schizophrenia."

God hearing what He can't silence. Men, women, and children—His children—all pleading, cursing, praying. That's His hell.

Gold leaned in again—fully engaged. “You really think He’s gone mad?”

Or have you gone mad? Have I? I’m being seduced again—walking right into his fantasy.

“Of course. Imagine it, Dr. Gold,” Light said. “Not fire. Not torment. Just... knowing. Hearing, seeing, feeling. Every death. Every failure. Every cry in the dark. Forever.”

Eyes closed, Light’s voice dropped to a whisper.

“Omniscience—that’s His hell.”

Mine too. I knew my father was dying.

“He is Sisyphus, Prometheus.”

A long silence passed between them.

Light opened his eyes.

“You know the sculpture of Moses? Michelangelo’s? The one with the horns?”

“Yes. Of course.”

“Those horns shouldn’t have been there. The word was mistranslated. Qeren. It meant rays of light.”

“I know.”

Light looked pained. “If Michelangelo had known, he’d have smashed it—destroyed his own masterpiece for its imperfection. Even his slave in the corner there—unfinished—because none could be perfect. Too many fissures. Too many pits in the marble.”

“But maybe, Samuel—maybe Michelangelo meant the Slaves to be unfinished. We’re all struggling, aren’t we? Each of us trying to free ourselves.”

“I guess what I’m saying—Sartre called it being condemned to be free. Maybe that’s what the Slaves symbolize.”

What am I saying?

“Maybe there’s no such thing as perfection. You’ve said God was perfect, the angels perfect—but here you are, an angel, and you say you’re guilt-ridden and miserable. And God, you say—He’s gone mad.”

Did I say that? Did I make any sense?

“Well, God insisted on perfection and He destroyed mankind, because they were imperfect. He had to start over. He couldn’t bear to look at what He’d made.”

Gold inhaled slowly.

I guess not.

Light continued. “Free will was supposed to help Him—to earn the praise He craved. But it failed—made everything worse. Too many voices, too many brushes on the canvas.

“You can’t edit perfection by committee.”

No, that’s the path to chaos.

“But that was never the point of His art, Dr. Gold. It wasn’t about perfection—it was about being understood.”

What?

Gold met his eyes.

Light smiled faintly, almost sadly.

“And that’s why I forgive Him.”

Gold blinked.

“I forgive God because I realized He’s trapped—powerless. Damned. A prisoner of His own knowing.

He’s tried—again and again. But each time... He failed.”

He touched his chest, as if sharing God’s pain.

“I failed too.”

Gold nodded slowly. “Milton was right—

The mind is its own place, and in it self

Can make a Heav’n of Hell, a Hell of Heav’n.”

Light’s voice dropped to a whisper. “But he gave me the wrong line.”

Gold looked up.

“Gave you the wrong line?”

“*Myself am Hell*,” Light said.

“Not me. Not anymore. It was for the longest time. But no.
The truth?

Hell isn’t mine... it’s His.”

Gold stared at him.

No words—just the truth. Something he could never unsee.
Or unhear.

Like God. He knew.

Light took a slow, deep breath.

“God’s mind is Hell. And the only way out... *was madness.*”

*What does the world look like when God’s gone
mad?*

CHAPTER TWENTY-FIVE

Does God Cast a Shadow?

Better to reign in Hell than serve in Heaven.

— John Milton, *Paradise Lost* (1667)

You shall know the truth, and the truth shall make you mad.

— Aldous Huxley, *Complete Essays: Volume II* (1926)

What we call reason is often nothing more than the defense of deeply buried fears.

— Paul A. Cantor, *Literature and the Economics of Liberty* (2009)

Saturday, late afternoon

God... out of His mind?

“He gave this to me.”

Light slid the ring off his finger.

“He trusted me. He loved me.”

He extended his hand, offering it to Gold.

“At least He used to. But it wasn’t really love... it was need. He needed me. That’s why He gave me this—to remind me.”

God needed Satan. A father needs his son. And sometimes that need is a burden.

Gold sat upright, accepting the ring as though it were a fragile robin’s egg.

He remembered its weight—but now it felt heavier than mass itself, as though gravity strained to tear it from his hand.

He examined it carefully—his fingers tracing the pictographic markings with almost tender precision.

No. Not now. He needs my attention.

But he handed it to me.

“Samuel, you told me before you didn’t know what it said. I find that difficult to believe. It must hold great sentimental value—being from your father.”

“I didn’t lie to you, Dr. Gold. I only said that ‘no one’s been able to translate it.’”

Did he?

Light’s breathing quickened—uneven, ragged—betraying an ache beneath the words.

“You don’t have to tell me—but if you did, it might help me understand your relationship.”

He nodded toward the ring. “You still wear it—it clearly means something.”

I may have overplayed the guilt card.

Light reached out—breathing frantic and shallow—like a diver fumbling at the valve of an empty tank.

That hit a nerve.

Gold returned the ring, noting panic in Light’s eyes—locked on it like a lifeline.

He snatched the ring and slid it back onto his finger in one motion.

His breath steadied—still thin but calmer now; as oxygen returned, his trembling subsided.

Spinning the ring like a talisman, Light murmured, “I was always by His side.”

He twirled it again, eyes distant, “I was His favorite...

“The one He listened to. The one He confided in. The one He trusted.”

Me too.

“Samuel, I know how that feels. That was me with my father.

“Every father is a god—until the son grows up and sees the man beneath the myth.

“And eventually... we all do.”

Light shrugged. “I’m to blame for this. I planted the tree.

“I never knew it would choke the garden—that its roots would twist through Eden like a weed.

“I destroyed His plan. He’s right. They’re all right. I am Satan.

“I’ve been responsible for the deaths of billions of souls—I destroyed Him.”

He means it metaphorically. A fictional belief isn’t necessarily false—just one we’re afraid to disprove.

But what if he’s right? What would it mean if God could be destroyed? Can God be killed?

I killed my father.

Light turned the ring, muttering strange syllables, then whispered—his voice breaking—

“Find peace in heaven. Your loving father.”

So that’s what it says, “find peace in heaven”—a desperate plea from a concerned, helpless father to his rebellious son.

Gold handed back the ring.

Light’s eyes welled. “I... I abandoned God... my Father.”

Or did he abandon you—like some fathers do?

“Or did He abandon you? You said He *used to trust you, love you*, but that now He *needs* you. I can see your pain. But you’ve turned that pain into guilt—blaming yourself, as children often do when their parents are angry.”

Light bowed his head slowly. His bright blue eyes sank into shadow—like black holes swallowing the light.

“I don’t deserve to wear it anymore. This is my doing—it began with me. I am the evil one, after all.”

A tremor of fear ran through Gold. The hair on his neck and arms bristled; a clawed hand seemed to tighten around his throat.

Jesus... for a moment, he actually looked like Satan.

A small tilt of Light's head caught reflections glinting from his dark, hollow sockets. His head snapped back, teeth bared—feral. A guttural howl tore up from Light's chest as he ripped the ring from his finger. Then—jaw locked—he hurled the ring, God's supplication. The ring struck the leg of Gold's desk with a dull metal clunk—then silence—before vanishing behind Hadrian's Wall.

Spent, Light collapsed against the couch, shoulders sagging in defeat.

The room held its breath. Gold sat in disbelief—silent.

God's prayer to His son—cast out, buried behind Hadrian's Wall. A border meant to keep out madness. It failed.

He's in pain—and I'm treating it like Romantic Literature 101. Say something, dammit.

"Samuel. You're not evil. You just had a misunderstanding. That's normal—between fathers and sons.

"Don't let your anger blind you—or bind you.

"Communication is key. Unspoken words fester like infection. Guilt is the fever.

"It's a shared guilt. You and your father are both infected—because neither of you said a word."

My mother and I were infected—and we infected my father.

"Take responsibility for your part—but it isn't all your fault.

"Relationships are never one-sided, even when they feel that way. Both people are complicit, even when the power between them seems uneven."

"One cannot take if the other is not willing to give—even if it feels stolen."

It was my fault. Too proud, too sure I was right—so fucking stupid. I never got to say goodbye to her. I never really knew her. She never said anything that mattered. Or did she, but I was so hurt at never being hugged, I couldn't hear it?

And him? Did he really ask me—or did I make him ask?

I'm the evil one.

“Yes. Many unspoken words—ever since that first bite.”

Light exhaled slowly, the tension draining from his face.

“It’s odd, Dr. Gold. You’re the atheist—self-proclaimed.

“Yet you think about Him constantly—talk to Him every day, pray to Him every night, curse Him for everything that didn’t unfold the way you wished.”

Does he know all my disappointments? How?

“You’re angry at Him—for how you imagine He pulls the marionette strings. You can’t accept fault or chance—so you blame Him. The universe *is* more random than people think.

“Now I see the weight people’s prayers—and curses—have laid on Him.”

His breath caught.

“You’re right, Samuel. I have been angry at God. I didn’t realize it, until you said it. I guess I feel guilty too.

“Logically, I don’t believe. I still say my prayers every night—ones my mother taught me.”

“I tell myself it’s just tradition—a memory of my parents. But maybe. Maybe it’s because we’re all hard-wired for certain behaviors and fears—like the fear of the dark.”

Gold drew a deep breath.

Both my parents believed. Rachel still does.

“Belief may be like hypnosis—subtle, creeping, never complete, yet always present. Maybe belief in God works the same way. I don’t want to admit it, but as you pointed out—my anger at Him proves I believe.”

Do I? Or do I just hate the thought of a random universe?

No control, no rules, no order?

Light's demeanor shifted. He raised one knee onto the couch, turning fully toward Gold.

"Yes. You downplay it—intellectualize it—but you can't ignore it. You say you're angry—at God, at religion. Why?"

Gold felt heat crawl up his neck, flushing his skin a pale rose.

"I guess I don't want to think—or admit—that I'm alone.

"When I ki... when my father died, Rabbi Shapiro tried to comfort me—but he was part of the problem."

"In what way?"

"My father was dying—he wanted to end his life before the disease could. But Shapiro said his life belonged to God, not to himself. He preyed on that delusion—condemning him to needless torture, physical and psychological."

Light sighed. "Man misread Him—twisted His whispers into laws. It was never faith. It was always power."

Light's tone sharpened. "The clergy are always the troublemakers. When they're not starting crusades or burning witches, they're sowing doubt."

He leaned forward. "They forged manacles of the mind. Blake saw it—

*"In every cry of every Man,
In every Infant's cry of fear;
In every voice: in every ban,
The mind-forg'd manacles I hear."*

Preaching to the choir:

"Every priest with a collar, every imam with a fatwa, every rabbi with a microphone—and every televangelist with a Rolex—God, every one of them thinks they speak for Him."

"They hijacked His whispers—turned them into laws, twisted His love into threats. It's not faith—it's fucking control."

"I've watched them parade their robes and doctrines while people scream in pain. Not one listened."

"Shapiro? Sanctimonious bastard—sits on his throne of

Talmud and tells a dying man his suffering is holy.

“That’s not God. That’s not mercy. That’s sadism dressed in scripture.”

Gold nodded vigorously. “That’s exactly how I felt. He says a man’s life belongs to God? Then why doesn’t he feel that weight—why doesn’t he scream for God’s help when the pain becomes too much?”

“I told you before—if God could, He’d take His own life. But Shapiro, and the rest of them—they’d never let Him.

“Shapiro speaks like God’s mouthpiece—but all I hear is venom. I hate him. I hate what he represents. They’ve turned God into a tyrant to preserve their own power. No thought of how God felt.”

God has feelings? I guess so. I hadn’t considered it before.

We made Him too well.

“And on the eighth day, Man created God in his image.”

Light’s voice darkened. “If I’d been there, I would have torn those false words out of his throat.”

Shit. I fueled this fire—and now it’s burning beyond my control.

“Samuel, we may be going too far. I agree the clergy has twisted God’s words, usurped his power, but Shapiro isn’t to blame for my father’s death.”

I am.

Light was coiled tight—a frenzy barely contained.

“They twisted His words—in their own tongues—to suit themselves in holy garb. They abused free will more than anyone.

“Even while Moses carved God’s words, Aaron panicked—afraid of losing influence. So he made the golden calf—not from devotion, but desperation. He wasn’t serving God; he was serving himself.

“Just like Shapiro.”

*He's escalating. I've got to calm him down.
Control this.*

Light continued, "God would never stop someone from choosing their own end. He'd help them look inward, ensure their clarity. But terminal? Suffering?" He shook his head. "Of course not. He'd let them go—He'd understand.

"I told you—if He were free, if He truly had free will, He'd take His own life."

Gold blinked. "What?"

Light held Gold's gaze. "If He had free will... He'd end it."

"Samuel..." Gold's voice thinned. "Are you saying God doesn't have free will?"

Light raised a hand for silence.

"He sees it all—every war, every scream, every mistake He can't stop.

"You call that freedom? That's not free will—that's a prison of prescience—the paradox of omniscience.

He sees every outcome, every tragedy, every unspeakable thing—yet He must let it happen. Because if He intervened, the design would unravel.

That's not freedom—that's a prison of knowing."

*What—was Gene Roddenberry a prophet? The
Prime Directive is God's command.*

Light smiled faintly.

"The moment He whispered 'Let there be,' He wasn't creating—He was sentencing Himself.

"Like a painter who dips the brush—not from inspiration, but compulsion.

"Each stroke—irrevocable. Each flaw—permanent.

"He can't erase the canvas without erasing the world.

"He's tried painting over it—masking the wounds with beauty. But like veins in marble, the cracks of free will distort everything.

"Even God can't paint over chaos."

So maybe that's why He's forgiving.

His delusion is spreading—roots digging deeper.

And I'm being selfish.

I tell myself it's connection, insight—but I know better. I enjoy the art and philosophy. And that's not helping him.

I don't think I can help him. He needs a psychiatrist—maybe medication.

I don't know what his real problem is. We're just dancing around it.

As much as I've enjoyed the music, I'm a lousy dancer.

Time to let him go.

"I'm sorry, Samuel, but I can't accept that you're the biblical Satan."

"I told you, Dr. Gold—the Bible got most of it wrong."

"Regardless, I think you're delusional and you need help I can't provide."

"So your belief trumps mine? You say the burden of proof lies with me—to prove there's a God—because you can't prove a negative, right? That there's no God."

"But here I am, Dr. Gold. Doesn't my being here prove I exist?"

He's ready for this. He has to be.

"Samuel, you're here—that proves *you* exist. But it doesn't prove He exists. You're not an angel of God, Samuel. It's a delusion. That identity is your psyche's way of processing trauma—colored, inflated, mythologized. You've wrapped your pain in a persona—a wronged Satan."

How can I explain this to him?

"Have you heard of Alexius Meinong? Early twentieth-century Austrian philosopher. He proposed something called Meinong's Jungle—a place filled with things that don't exist, yet still

have properties.”

“Unicorns. Santa Claus. God... Satan.

“Things don’t need to be real to be vivid.”

Too abstract?

Light smiled.

“So I’m the Easter Bunny—living in the jungle.”

“No. I’m not saying you’re unreal. I’m saying you’re not the Satan. Knowing the profile doesn’t prove the person.

“You’re intelligent, charismatic, angry at God—just as you say I am. And I think you’ve idealized your relationship with your father—as God and Satan. But that’s not the same as being evil incarnate.”

Is he playing—or does he really believe he’s Satan?

“Samuel... of course you’re real enough. You’re just not Satan.”

Light leaned back, smiling, eyes gleaming.

“Close enough for therapy.”

“Samuel, I’m sorry...”

“No need to apologize, Dr. Gold. I’m able to understand this better than anyone else. I don’t think you’ve been listening. I’ve told you, I’m not evil. I was the hand of God. I was charged and convicted for crimes not my own. I know what I know.

“I know God. It’s hard.

“I told Him He needed to speak to everyone—not just Adam, Cain, Noah, Abraham, Isaac, Jacob, and a handful of others.”

Light glanced down, as if recalling a memory.

“We should never have left Him. He needed us—both of us.”

Both of us?

“Both of us?”

Am I living a rerun of Star Trek—‘Who Mourns for Adonis?’ God made obsolete?

“Samuel, what do you mean—‘both of us?’”

“As you know, Dr. Gold, God has only spoken to a few. I see now He sent me to you—because He wishes to speak through you. The way he did with Abraham.

“He needs to reach mankind. He needs help. He knew I’d find someone—a new prophet—through whom He could speak.

He really believes this. This isn’t metaphor—he means it literally.

A prophet. Not a therapist. Not even a man. He sees me as scripture—as vessel, burning bush, oracle.

That’s not transference. That’s insanity.

“I think this might all be part of His plan.”

And I didn’t stop him. I let it happen. Did I make it happen?

I deluded myself into thinking we were helping each other. But this—this is delusion. I’m no longer part of the cure. He’s gone off the deep end—and I never taught him how to swim. I don’t know if I can.

Now I’m complicit in his delusion.

I wanted to understand him—to reach the root and help. But this isn’t about help. It’s about belief. And belief... is contagious.

“Samuel... I’m sorry. I can’t keep going along with this.

“I don’t think I am the one who can help you. But I know one of the best psychiatrists in the country—I’d like to refer you.”

I feel guilty... helpless.

Gold’s eyes filled.

The lights dimmed for an instant, or maybe Gold only imagined it.

“Samuel... I can’t help you. This isn’t therapy anymore.”

Light’s head drooped—resigned, hollowed out. His eyes welled too.

His head tilted, as if listening to someone only he could hear.

“You’re wrong, Dr. Gold,” he whispered. “It’s always been therapy.”

He whispered, voice fraying, “I thought you were the one. I thought you understood.”

He stood slowly. Reached into his jacket, withdrew a gold money clip, and counted out ten crisp hundred dollar bills. He placed them gently on the couch.

“That’s all right, Dr. Gold.”

He extended his hand for a shake.

Gold rose quickly. He noticed Light’s ringless hand, but said nothing. Instead, he pulled him in for a brief hug—then, realizing what he was doing, awkwardly patted his back before stepping away.

“I wish you the best, Samuel. I’d love to give you this referral. I think he can help you—help you find yourself and what you’re looking for.”

Light’s eyes filled; a tear slid down the bridge of his nose and pooled at his cheek.

“We’re all searching for ourselves, aren’t we, Dr. Gold? I may have found what I was looking for.”

“Maybe we both did. You can’t hide forever, Samuel.”

“Sometimes the best place to hide is right in front of someone. I should know—I’ve done it all my life.

“I know you think you’re doing the right thing—but you’ll be sorry. I swear it.”

Sorry... why? Jane said the same thing the other day.

Light said softly, “I fear you’re making a mistake.

“Decisions often carry unintended consequences.”

He winked.

A threat?

Light turned slowly—like a man leaving the ruins of a cathedral.

“Goodbye, Dr. Gold. God bless.”

The door closed, his cologne lingered—sweet, metallic, impossible to forget.

And now he was gone. No lifeline. No surface.

Only the ring—left at the bottom of the pool.

Gold heard footsteps fade, the elevator ding—and then silence.

A silence so complete it seemed to have weight.

No hum. No traffic. No breath.

*He's gone. And something's changed—in this room,
in me.*

Not peace. Not clarity. Just... silence.

I hope I helped him.

He helped me.

"You can't hide forever."

He walked slowly toward the desk. The desk chair sat slightly askew.

He'll be back. For this.

He knelt, searching behind the desk leg—where the ring should have been.

Nothing.

No echo.

Where is it?

He checked under the desk, then beneath the chair.

Nothing.

Gone.

He rose slowly, unease coiling in his gut.

And then—he saw it.

A jolt of recognition tore through him—sharp and visceral.

There—on the notepad beside his blotter. Faint marks etched in pen—angular, ancient. Drawn with his own pen—

CHAPTER TWENTY-SIX

Darkness Visible

*No light, but rather darkness visible
Served only to discover sights of woe,
Regions of sorrow, doleful shades, where peace
And rest can never dwell, hope never comes
That comes to all.*

— John Milton, *Paradise Lost* (1667)

*Midway in our life's journey, I went astray
from the straight road and woke to find myself
alone in a dark wood.*

— Dante Alighieri, *Inferno*, Canto I (c. 1320), trans. Allen Mandelbaum

*The truth does not change according to our ability to stomach it.
— Flannery O'Connor, *The Habit of Being* (1979)*

Saturday, late afternoon

What the hell?

Gold dropped to his hands and knees, crawling across the office, head swiveling side to side until dizziness overtook him.

*How's that possible? Did he grab it without me
noticing? I saw him throw it—I heard it hit the floor,
rolling.*

Jesus.

He stood—swaying like a bobblehead as nausea rose. Off-balance and queasy, he collapsed into the chair.

He glanced at his notepad.

How could he?

*Did he scribble it when he stood? Before I hugged
him?*

He must have. Yeah.

The cash is still on the couch. So I didn't hallucinate it. Better check.

He walked over and picked up the stack—ten crisp hundred-dollar bills, as if they'd just been ejected from an ATM.

Well, that's real.

He folded the bills and slid them into his pocket.

So where the fuck is the ring? He wasn't wearing it. I shook his hand—I'm sure of it.

He circled the office, scanning every corner—behind the chair, the statue, the credenza—anywhere the ring might have rolled.

Where could it be?

He crouched again to check under the desk. He switched on his phone's flashlight, searching for a sparkle—a glint of reflection.

Nothing. Just a paperclip and a quarter.

Nowhere. Gone.

Where the hell could it be?

He crawled to the couch and checked beneath each cushion.

Nothing.

Maybe he grabbed it when I wasn't looking. Yeah. He wouldn't leave without it. No way in hell.

He must've picked it up—scribbled the note before he left.

Maybe when I was lost in my thoughts... self-disclosing.

Gold pushed himself up and sat on the couch. He leaned back, still dizzy, and let out a long, low exhale.

Only three sessions—but it feels like a lifetime.

There was a connection. An excitement. I felt I knew him.

Something essential has been torn away. Hard to believe I won't see him again.

I'll miss him.

He swiveled his legs onto the couch, scooted down, and put his head back.

So God's an artist. Maybe He rushed this piece.

Deadlines are never kind to creators. Maybe He could've used a few more days at creation.

Ha. Rachel would call that blasphemous.

Ah, Rachel.

How can I brighten the paints on your palette?

Taking off his glasses, he brushed away a speck of dust.

Maybe Light was right—free will breeds unintended consequences. Maybe it's all just collateral damage—bad luck masquerading as moral failure.

And maybe Nietzsche wasn't entirely wrong. Not dead—just distant. Withdrawn. Silent. Paralyzed.

Or maybe God just found Himself being. Mary Shelley—the monster never asked to be born. God created man as an afterthought. Man wasn't His plan—he was His need.

You want meaning? There it is—God needs us.

And who knows, maybe He does care. But maybe He's just too afraid to get His hands dirty again—to pick up the chisel.

He swapped his crossed legs.

I should've asked Light about the angels—how involved they really were. He said the tree was his idea. His fault. You can't edit perfection by committee. But start again? There's no Noah this time. Or was that the message? Was I supposed to be Noah?

I actually hugged him. What the hell was I

thinking? The only other men I've ever hugged—Bob... and my dad. Twice—once after the accident, once more at her funeral.

Funny. I can't remember ever hugging her—or her hugging me. Must have—as a kid, at least.

Why can't I remember?

Or why won't I remember? Am I angry? Hurt?

A brief stab of light made Gold wince and turn his head.

Wow. Light got mad at Shapiro. Called him a "sanctimonious bastard."

What were his words? Oh yeah—"carve those false words out of his throat." Ha.

For a minute I thought I might have a duty to warn Shapiro. But he doesn't even know him.

He sure hates the clergy. He blames them.

The way I blame God?

What was his game? Light... Satan.

My dreams and feelings since I started seeing him—I actually believed him... a little.

He turned on his side, looking at Rachel's painting.

The art discussions were interesting—but I didn't like his comments on Rachel's.

He didn't know it, but he was right. How the fuck could he see that—just from glancing at her work for a few moments?

Maybe he is Satan.

Gold noticed it was getting dark outside.

Shit. It's getting late. No daylight savings anymore. Why the hell don't we just leave the clocks back? Gets darker earlier anyway.

Wow. I can count the number of times I hugged my

dad. That's not good.

He's gone.

Or is he? Maybe that's the trick. Maybe he really is Satan.

A couple of times... I almost believed him. I wanted to believe him.

"Satan's not going to show up with horns and a red cape."

If he is Satan—and we're so alike—what does that make me?

No. Samael Light is gone.

I don't think I'll ever see him again.

Gold sat up on the couch, leaned under to look at the floor once more.

Or his ring, evidently—but I don't know how.

He stood up.

But the silence feels like him.

Not peace. Not certainty. Something left with him—something I can't name. The weight of absence. The awful clarity of darkness made visible.

Gold went to his bookshelf and pulled down *Paradise Lost*. He flipped past the Book I argument, stopping at line 63, and read softly:

*"No light, but rather darkness visible
Served only to discover sights of woe,
Regions of sorrow, doleful shades, where peace
And rest can never dwell, hope never comes
That comes to all; but torture without end."*

Quite a contrast from Jane—banging on the door like the devil herself.

One claims to be Satan. The other might actually

be the devil.

Maybe I'll check the Ring cam—just in case she came back. She was furious.

Great timing, Bob. Where the hell are you when I need you?

Maybe you had a duty to warn... me.

RING... RING

Gold saw Rachel's face on caller ID.

God, she's beautiful.

He picked up the phone. "Hi Rach. Just finished up. I'll be home in twenty."

"Steven, I canceled with Lisa. Just not feeling great—maybe PMS or something. I don't know, just not in the mood. I told them we'd reschedule."

She always gets a little blue before her period—but lately she's been off. Stress.

"I'm sorry Rach. Want me to pick up something up—dinner or something? I could swing by the market."

"No... I don't know... I'm just off—not really crampy yet, just moody. I might just have some soup and lie down for a while."

It's always a reminder—of what she can't have. Her fucking parents. Shapiro. She wanted that baby. It would've been hard—but she wanted it. And now she can't.

She feels guilty... and punished.

"You sure? I'm already out—can grab anything if you want. Chocolate?"

"I'm sure. I'll just relax. Watch something, probably crash early."

"I'm sorry. But you're probably glad to miss that movie. And I know how much you hate Bill."

Gold laughed. "I don't hate Bill, but I'm fine skipping the

movie. Besides I figured they'd come back to play Mexican Train or Hearts. Bill would talk, during the movie—about football—and I'd have to pretend to know who the hell he was talking about.

"I just feel bad for you. Hate seeing you like this."

"I'll be okay. Just come home whenever. Love you more than anything."

Does she really? I hope so. I need to deserve her.

"I love you more than that."

"Bye, honey."

She hung up.

Why do I always say that? Love isn't a competition. But lately, it's felt like we've been on different teams—we just don't talk like we used to. We talk to each other—not with each other. We circle around our feelings, orbiting instead of meeting. We don't share—we hide.

I'm still afraid to bring up the rape. The abortion. And I know it's always there—every day, every night. Like the Tell-Tale Heart—that ceaseless beating, "louder—louder—louder!"

We haven't made love in... shit, I can't even remember.

I know I'm right about the necklace—but I can't say anything. I don't want to bring it up. I know she's always thinking about it, but she'd feel more guilty, knowing I was too. I don't want to hurt her. I love her. But we're not us anymore.

We've lost each other. We've lost ourselves.

I should be talking to Bob—or someone. Anyone. Shit, if Light hadn't left, I'd probably be asking his advice.

But all I do is talk to myself. I didn't even tell Bob about her rape until Thursday. That says it all.

It's not that I don't trust him. Maybe I don't trust myself.

I've been hiding from myself.

It's getting harder to maintain the "famous Dr. Gold" façade.

He tore off the page, folded it neatly, and slid it into his pocket.

He grabbed his car keys and headed for the door, walking down the hallway toward the elevator.

Take the stairs. I could use the exercise.

Reaching the lobby, he headed to the parking elevator.

It's not too dark yet. I'm wearing jeans and tennis shoes. Rachel wants space.

I'll walk home. Just a mile and a half. Good exercise. Time to process Samael Light.

I'll grab the car tomorrow—it's safe in the parking structure.

He stepped out onto Wilshire Boulevard and began walking toward Holmby Hills.

At the crosswalk, he pressed the button and waited, glancing back at the sanctuary—its stained glass windows glowing like distant embers. The Havdalah service marking Sabbath's end had finished twenty minutes earlier. He watched some of the congregants walking out of the synagogue.

Samael Light. Never did find out who referred him. Said something about that Atlantic article. Who knows. Nice to get paid in cash—no paper trail. Barely two thousand.

He intimidated me at first. Flop sweat—odd reaction. Criminal appeals. Sounded like he wanted help with an appeal—to his father. I think what he really wanted was forgiveness—from his father.

But what he really needed was to forgive his father. That's where the emotional logjam was. We all need to forgive our parents.

Even me.

I guess.

He waited for the traffic light to switch to walk.

*This light's taking forever... or I'm just impatient.
Days are shorter in the fall. Time races by faster.*

Finally.

He stepped into the crosswalk. The headlights burned his eyes. He blinked—the cars hadn't moved, but somehow the world had shifted. The air felt cooler. How long had he been standing there?

Gerald didn't hit me. Didn't scream. He just wasn't there in the ways that mattered. He saw my grades, not my sadness. Quoted facts, not feelings. He stood beside me at my graduation like a cardboard cutout of pride—but never once asked me who I loved. What I feared. Who I was.

And I never forgave him for that. Not really.

But what did Light really want from me? First justice. Then forgiveness. Then... redemption?

And what did I offer? A couch. A goddamn hug.

"Hypocrites" he'd called them. Just in case believers. Hedge your bets. Strong views on religion. Maybe his father's piety—drug lord or not—had turned him off. Saw his father as the hypocrite. Who knows. But he sure has it in for anyone in the clergy. Wonder what happened there.

"Carve the words out of Shapiro's throat." Who says that? Maybe he was deeper in his father's business than I wanted to know—maybe too deep to handle, hence the delusion. Said he was responsible for many deaths. Makes sense if it was drugs. If he'd seen them—or, shit, if he'd done them? He seemed too cultured, too rational for that... didn't he?

What the hell am I thinking? The guy called himself Satan.

Time passed slowly. The air had cooled. Sidewalks shimmered with leaf shadows under soft streetlight.

“Midway in life’s journey, I went astray...”

He said it under his breath, almost without meaning to. The line had haunted him since grad school.

Dante. He knew all about hell—the real-life Beatrice died young, without ever loving him; exiled from his beloved Florence; left to struggle in obscurity.

“...lost the straight path, and woke to find myself alone in a dark wood.”

He looked up. Tall, majestic trees lined the street, stretching ahead like silent corridors.

It wasn’t a forest. It wasn’t even night. But he understood.

Not completely lost. Not entirely found.

It was fully dark by the time he got home. He unlocked the door, disarmed the alarm, and went straight to the bedroom.

Smells like a deli.

Rachel lay propped up in bed, asleep, shadows from the TV flickering across her face like an old film reel. Marianelli’s *Pride and Prejudice* score whispered through the room.

Rach, you should’ve spoken up at the book club. Could have been another vote for Jane Austen.

His old fraternity T-shirt sagged at her neck, giving her the look of an oval portrait—a daguerreotype vignette. The strip of baby blanket she used as a sleep mask had slipped, draping her cheek and casting a soft shadow across half her face.

She’ll be pissed if she wakes without brushing—mascara smeared on her pillow.

She really doesn’t need any makeup. God, she’s beautiful.

“God?” Maybe Light was right—I do talk to Him more than anyone.

He turned on the bathroom light, closed the door halfway, then crossed to the bed. Gently he lifted the remote from her hand and switched off the TV. Setting it on the nightstand, he picked up the soup bowl; the spoon clinked, and Rachel stirred.

Shit.

Eyes still closed, she pulled the fabric back over them, then tugged a pillow from behind her head and tossed it aside—hitting Gold on the shoulder. The bowl and spoon clinked again.

Crap. Don't wake up. Don't wake up.

Holding the fabric as she turned, she curled loosely on her side and drew the comforter over herself.

She's cold.

He moved to his side of the bed and nudged the thermostat up to seventy-one. On his way out, he switched off the bathroom light, then eased the door closed behind him—quietly, carefully.

CHAPTER TWENTY-SEVEN

To Fathom Hell Or Soar Angelic...

There are things known and there are things unknown, and in between are the doors of perception.

— Aldous Huxley, *The Doors of Perception* (1954)

To fathom Hell or soar angelic, just take a pinch of psychedelic.

— Humphry Osmond, letter to Aldous Huxley (1956)

Saturday, late evening

Gold walked to the kitchen and rinsed the soup bowl before setting it in the sink. Then he opened the refrigerator door, scanned it briefly, and closed it.

Not hungry. Dazed and confused—that about sums it up.

At the kitchen table, he typed “*Dazed and Confused*” into Spotify.

I thought it was Led Zeppelin. Jake Holmes?

He hit play on the original Jake Holmes version.

I'm dazed and confused, is it stay is it go?
Am I being choosed? Well I'd just like to know
Give me a clue as to where I am at
Feel like a mouse and you act like a cat

I'm dazed and confused, hanging on by a thread
I'm being abused, I'd be better off dead
I can't stand this teasing, I'm starting to crack
You're out to get me, you're on the right track

Yeah, I'm dazed and confused and it's all upside down

Am I being choosed? Do you want me around?
Secrets are fun to a certain degree
But this one's no fun 'cause the secret's on me

*Nothing like Led Zeppelin's version. I thought it
was about an acid trip.*

*Cat and mouse—that's exactly how I felt with Light.
And he tells me I've been chosen.*

*Jake, you nailed it. Save this to my favorites.
Exactly how I feel—dazed and confused.*

*Rachel and Bob always say I'm out of touch. That I
hide. What am I avoiding? What am I missing?*

Maybe Bob already gave me the key.

*"Yer overthinkin' everything. You ain't never left
your own head. It'll let ya relax. Everything'll make
sense, an' feel comfortin'."*

*Am I brave enough to try? I've always wanted to.
Bob said to wait until he got back next week. But he
also said it's safe.*

Psychedelics had always fascinated Gold. He'd read that a microdose experience could mimic the visual auras he experienced every few months. But he'd always been afraid—raised on scare headlines and *Reefer Madness* rhetoric. He never experimented.

While his high school and college friends drank and dabbled—marijuana, ecstasy, cocaine, mushrooms, LSD—Gold abstained. As his own dissertation concluded: They were normal. He wasn't.

He advocated for safe, recreational drug use—but excluded himself. He held back. Always worried he'd be one of those fringe cases—one bad trip away from permanent psychosis.

Now, in his forties, the world had changed. Marijuana and even psychedelics had been decriminalized. Psychiatry had followed suit. The generation raised with these drugs had reentered the system—shifting the norms, shaping the science.

Psychedelics—psilocybin, MDMA, ketamine, ayahuasca, LSD—were being studied for treatment-resistant depression,

addiction, anxiety, PTSD, even cluster headaches. The results, though early, were promising.

More than anything—he trusted Oldman.

Bob's known me long enough—and well enough not to suggest something I can't handle.

But I haven't told him everything.

Hell, I haven't even told myself everything.

Maybe that's why he's suggesting it—so I'll relax the reins and loosen up. Become part of the world, instead of standing on the sidelines analyzing it.

He stood and opened the top kitchen cabinet. Reaching to the back, he pulled out the Ziploc and placed it on the table.

He sat down, hesitant—staring at the bag like it was Pandora's box.

Maybe Bob wanted me to do this on my own. Face my fear. Why else give it to me right before leaving town? Maybe he's testing me—seeing if I have the guts to step out of my comfort zone without being pushed. Grateful Dead or Pink Floyd?

He lifted the baggie, turning it over in his hands, inspecting the dark shapes inside.

I think I'm ready.

He opened the Ziploc and gently picked up one of the mushrooms. Dark purple, almost black—featherlight and fragile, though the cap held to the stem.

Jesus—it smells like mold.

Ha. Genius: that's exactly what it is.

His pulse quickened. His breathing too—more animated now.

He sealed the bag and set it aside.

Should I tell Rachel? No—too much to put on her. She hasn't been in the greatest place lately. I haven't

really been there for her. Not the way I should be.

I feel like I've been losing her for years—ever since she told me about the rape and the abortion.

What the hell is wrong with me? I was never willing to deal with it. Why? She trusted me—and I deserted her. I abandoned her. She was... is the best thing that ever happened to me. And I ghosted her—emotionally, completely.

She was there when my mom unraveled. When my dad was dying.

Where have I been when she needed me? Gone. AWOL. I haven't been there for her—at all.

He picked up the baggie, turning it in his hands, examining it closely.

Shit... it's like I blamed her for her rape. She deserves so much better.

We were talking about Rachel when Bob said, 'Time for something different,' and handed me the mushrooms. He knows I need to do this.

I should wait for Bob. I'll need a guide—just in case.

It's a microdose, it's safe.

"Yer overthinkin' it all. It'll feel comfordin'."

Excitement and fear coursed through him.

For some reason, his thoughts slid to Jane.

That tattoo.

He'd always found Jane's tattoo, just below her bikini line, seductive and mysterious. An image he'd always remembered, savored—even called upon while masturbating. And afterward—always shame. Guilt.

Desire never comes clean.

He first saw it at the engagement party once they'd been properly introduced. She was reaching for a gravy dish in the top kitchen cabinet. Her navel piercing below her knotted crop top had already caught his eye. She leaned over the countertop—perched on her toes, straining, reaching—her shirt stretched, baring the soft curve beneath one breast. There it was: just above her low-rise jeans, her red thong strap underlining the word—

危机

He chuckled aloud.

She laughed so hard when I asked who 'Peter' was. "It's Chinese," she said. "It's pronounced weiji. My sponsor used it in group once. It means crisis—but it's made of two characters: danger and opportunity. I got the tattoo when I got out of treatment."

Danger and opportunity—that's Jane. Ever since we first met.

He held the bag up to the light—dusty mushroom stems and caps. He flipped it over.

Two sides of the same coin.

Jane and Rachel, in a way.

Maybe it's my turn to risk one for the other. Time to take a small step out of my comfort zone. Will it be a turning point for me? Or will I just puke my guts out and get a headache.

Bob said, "Everything'll make sense, an' feel comfortin'." He said he'd hold my hand when he got back. But he also said it wasn't dangerous—after all, it's just a microdose.

He set the Ziploc on the counter. Grabbing the teapot, he filled it from the instant hot faucet.

"Everything'll make sense, an' feel comfortin'"

He took a mushroom out of the bag and crushed it between two spoons, then stirred it into the water.

I should let it steep for a few minutes.

He glanced at his watch. After a moment, he opened the teapot's lid—then gagged at the smell.

I doubt tea will hurt it. At least it'll smell digestible.

He dropped a peppermint teabag, then three long squirts of monk-fruit sweetener.

That should do it. He doesn't sit with his trial patients when they take it—I'll be fine. It's a microdose.

He checked his watch again—barely a minute had passed, but he was too excited to wait. He poured the liquid into a coffee mug.

He took a sip—carefully, so as not to burn his mouth.

Shit. That's hot.

He dropped in an ice cube and added three more squirts of monk fruit. He blew gently and tried again.

God, that's foul. Just do it.

He drank the entire mug and set it down in the sink.

Ugh. Who first thought, "Let's eat these mushrooms—or better yet, make tea and drink this shit?"

Okay, let's see.

Nothing. He opened Spotify and started *Dark Side of the Moon*, but there was no synesthesia—no tastes, no smells from the music. The fruit in the basket stayed dull. No flash of insight. Nothing

It reminded him of Oliver Wendell Holmes's account of trying to get high on ether—nothing but the lingering stench of mold and peppermint.

In The Teachings of Don Juan, Castaneda took six or seven peyote buttons, didn't he? Oldman said he's had this for years. Maybe it's gone bad—lost its potency. It smells like it has. Maybe the whole baggie

was one dose. I probably used too much water or the melting ice cubes diluted it—it needs more.

Gold grabbed a glass and dumped in the entire baggie. He crushed the rest of the mushrooms until they looked like dirt, laced with twigs, then emptied the powder into his mug. He added hot water, two peppermint teabags, and gave five full squirts of monk fruit.

I can't swallow this.

He pulled a small strainer from the drawer and poured the tea into a clean mug.

This'll still taste like crap. But it won't get stuck in my teeth.

He grabbed a lemon from the wicker basket on the counter.

Maybe this will help... sweet lemon crap.

He stabbed the lemon repeatedly with a fork, squeezed the juice into the mug, then dropped in an ice cube. When the ice melted, he drank the entire mug and sat down at the kitchen table.

I wonder how long it'll take.

Gold sat at the round kitchen table.

We used to eat breakfast here. I'd skim the news while she worked on the crossword.

I'd laugh because she always asked for clues, and when I'd say, "just Google it," she'd scowl and call that cheating. Good times.

What happened to us? So we couldn't have kids. We had each other—until we didn't. I'd grab coffee in a thermos and leave before she even stirred. She would... Hell, I don't even know what she did. I was so selfish.

Gold began to cry—quietly, without warning.

What the hell happened? She was so young. Beautiful. Excited to start our life together.

Our honeymoon—Van Gogh Museum in

Amsterdam, a picnic in the Bollenstreek, where we made love in a vast tulip field and were nearly arrested for trespassing, crushing flowers as we ran—naked, laughing, our clothes in our hands. Rachel’s socks flew behind her like petals in the wind.

Swimming in Capri. Rachel said, “let’s swim to the Blue Grotto.” The Carabinieri turned us away, laughing as she splashed me when I yelled “I told you so.”

The balconies in Venice, spotted with flowers and small gardens. I gave the gondolier 70,000 lire to wait until the churchbells rang—so we could kiss beneath the Bridge of Sighs—just like in ‘A Little Romance,’ her favorite movie.

She was so beautiful—Rachel herself was light, my light. The sunlight, the colors, the sweet honey smell. Weird—I smell jasmine. Salt water.

That’s when the floor softened beneath him.

That’s it. The smell. It’s the mushrooms, right?

Excited, he jumped up from the table. The room seemed to rise with him. He turned up the music. The phone display pulsed, and the app icons jiggled—dancing to the beat.

He laughed—sudden, bright, childlike. Floating toward the living room, slightly queasy but buoyant—he stopped when he saw the hallway mirror. He stared.

His beard shimmered. It seemed to breathe. The face was his—but not only his.

It pulsed with something older—wiser—lighter.

He chuckled with each rhythmic rise and fall.

His eyes glowed. Rings of light around his pupils. Familiar.

Those blue eyes... I’ve seen them before.

Almost...

The thought vanished before it could take shape. He was distracted by colorful sparks flashing by. He leaned in closer,

searching his own gaze.

*I'm not afraid. I thought I would be. I thought I'd
make myself hallucinate—turn into a monster.
Something bad. But I feel fine.*

*Maybe, if I look deep enough, I'll finally see what's
been hiding in me all along—in my shadows.*

He stared at his reflection—deep quiet, steady. Embraced by the music. The smells. The joy. Feelings long forgotten, some completely new. Something long buried or newly born, rising to the surface.

He wasn't escaping. He was arriving.

And maybe—for the first time in his life—he wasn't afraid.

CHAPTER TWENTY-EIGHT

I'm Here Too

Love looks not with the eyes, but with the mind....

— William Shakespeare, *A Midsummer Night's Dream* (c. 1595)

I am in you and you in me, mutual in divine love.

— William Blake, *Jerusalem: The Emanation of the Giant Albion* (1804–1820)

Sometimes, when we reach deepest into another, we find ourselves waiting.

— Steven Gold, *Journal of Existential Psychodynamics* (Fall, 2022)

Saturday, night

Gold stood at the edge of the bed, waiting for his eyes to adjust to the darkness. Each blink ignited tiny fireworks—phantom bursts flaring beneath his lids. The mushrooms had fully taken hold.

A fluorescent blue mist trailed each exhale, luminous and unreal. The Persian rug tickled his bare feet—static sparks leaping from his toes.

He giggled—childlike—then lay back naked atop the comforter, unguarded.

He tapped the watch light, flinched momentarily at the large glowing eyeball he saw on his wrist, then slipped it off and set it on the nightstand. It seemed to watch him.

The room was hot. In the dim light that washed the room, he thought he could see faint red waves rising, squiggles, swimming up from the floor. He turned toward Rachel—her covers kicked aside due to the heat in the room.

She faced away, her side a slow tide rising and falling. He lay, enchanted. Each exhale sent shimmering yellow waves into the air—soft vibrations underscored by a low cello pulse only he could hear.

My Rachel... the light of my life. I miss you. I miss

us.

Her hair cascaded down across her shoulder and onto the pillow. Silently, he slid his fingers underneath—her golden hair shone brightly, glowing warm in his hand. He stared at it for what felt like minutes but was actually just a few seconds.

He leaned closer, breathing her in—jasmine, salt, memory. He saw beautiful deep purple waves emanating from her hair, drawn into his nostrils—comfort, peace.

*Rachel my love... I'm sorry. I've neglected you—
neglected us.*

I'm ready for honesty—ready to love again.

If you are.

If you'll forgive me.

If you'll have me.

“Are you? Can you? Will you?” he whispered.

Rachel stirred. Moaned quietly. Turned to her other side—now facing him directly. Reacting to the heat, she slid off her shirt in her sleep, dropping it on the floor.

His hand reached for the thermostat above the nightstand, the dial a fluorescent blue jellyfish floating on the wall. As he touched it, “71” glowed brightly, sending stinging pulses to his eyes. Quickly turning away, he accidentally turned it down to “63.”

He turned back over—facing Rachel. He saw notes drifting through the air as the Tchaikovsky's *Waltz of the Flowers* bloomed in his mind. He thought of Disney's *Fantasia*, visualizing the autumn fairies floating about, touching items on the dresser and Rachel's nightstand with their wands. They turned to vibrant oranges, reds, and browns. He saw bright autumn leaves scattered across the foot of the bed. But then a cool breeze came from the vents. The leaves blew away as frost fairies began skating across a frozen lake at the bed's edge.

Rachel curled inward, arms tucked against her chest. He stared at her now-bare breasts. In the cooling air, her nipples lifted—tender rosebuds brushed with frost. The soft curves, dimpling in the breeze, seemed to invite him—yet fear his touch. Looking down, he

saw himself—an artist’s brush dipped in violet, aching for her canvas.

He rolled onto his side and pulled the sheet up over them both. He draped his arm over Rachel’s breasts, shielding them from the cold. The sensation of her skin against his was a visceral pleasure unlike any he had known.

His face nuzzled, now against hers. He inhaled her perfume—truffle, dark florals, woodiness—her breath brushing his cheeks like gentle waves. Her body pulled at him—urgent, inevitable. He felt it, tugging at his solar plexus, his heart, his soul.

“Rachel... my one... my only. I love you so much. I need to touch you. I need to see you—from the inside. I need to be you... be us.”

She stirred, half in dream, half awake. “Steven... ?”

“Yes, my love.”

“What are you doing? It’s freezing. Are you...?”

“I’m a little high—high enough to see our world from above... the wreck I’ve made of us.” He paused. “I’m so sorry. I love you more than anything. Please forgive me. I don’t know what I’ve become... or who I’ve been.

“All I know is... I love you. I know I don’t deserve you. But I want to... I will.”

They lay face to face, bodies aligned as though remembering how to fit. His words stirred her. The heat of his longing pressed against her, undeniable. He gently caressed the undercurve of her breast and brought his mouth down to meet it—soft against soft. Her nipples tightened; the hairs on the back of her neck rose. A tingling sensation, like unseen arms encircling her ribs, rippled down through her navel into her soul.

His lips found hers again, gliding softly, pleading for entry. When their tongues met, they moved like dancers—gliding in time to the ballet still playing in his head.

Her hands wandered—discovering, beckoning. She leaned back, open, waiting for him to engulf her with his love. But instead, he paused, choosing to worship.

Slowly, reverently, he journeyed downward along the soft landscape of her body to the hollow of her navel. The warmth of his

beard against her belly only deepened her desire. It felt as though each part of her body was being read by a blind man—his lips translating sensation into meaning—into love.

She gasped as he eased her panties down. She lifted her hips in acquiescence. Her breath hitched—ripe with longing, edged with awe.

Then, unexpectedly, she felt his lips again—lower this time, gentle and unhurried. A silent question. An invitation.

He kissed her where her soul felt closest to the surface, treating her with the same reverence he'd given her mouth. He tasted her—salty, citrus, utterly her—and she trembled. Her soul dissolved into liquid light, electricity threading her limbs like starlight.

Her heartbeat echoed—not in thuds but in color, each pulse a flare behind his eyes. Fireworks burst from silver tympanies—each note reverberating through his chest, echoing inside his head.

“Steven... “ she gasped. “I need you inside me. Now. Please—don’t torture me any longer.”

He rose slowly, tracing her body with his lips—a pilgrimage of warmth and reverence. She opened for him—not just her body, but something deeper.

As he entered her, a soft gasp escaped both their mouths, as though they had stepped into a place beyond language.

They had chased every possibility once—IVF, surrogates, even adoption—but grief had reduced every conversation to ash. It wasn’t that they dismissed any of it; they simply couldn’t imagine beginning again with another’s hope while their own still ached unburied.

Tonight was different—not a plan, not a procedure, just the fragile miracle of wanting, together.

She had once shied from his gaze, covering herself as though beauty were something to apologize for.

Her artist’s eye, so attuned to symmetry on canvas, could not forgive the small asymmetry of her own body—her left breast a little smaller, a secret imperfection she once confessed as a flaw.

He’d only smiled, tracing the curve with reverence. To him, that imbalance made her real, human—proof that beauty lives in the

irregular, not the ideal. He had seen only grace.

Of all bitter passions, shame is the most seductive.

Tonight, she let him see her—completely.

This was love—not making love, but sharing being; becoming one.

He looked into her eyes, and for the first time in years, saw no distance there.

They moved together—not with urgency, but recognition—as if their bodies had always drifted in this tide.

This is what it means to return. To come home.

Their breaths grew ragged, their bodies arching in time to music only they could hear. Colors swirled behind his eyes—violet, gold, soft orange. Her fingers gripped his back. She was nearing, trembling beneath him like a struck string.

Eyes closed, he felt her—the essence of her—from within. He merged into her—became her.

“I love you,” he whispered, voice breaking. “I’m here. I’m yours.”

Her love—your love—my piece of mind.

As they climaxed—her name breaking from his lips, his soul flowing into hers—something broke open, something took root.

I'm here too, Steven. I've always been.

He didn’t know if it was her voice or his own, only that it filled him and stayed.

CHAPTER TWENTY-NINE

The Birth of a Man

If the doors of perception were cleansed, everything would appear to man as it is, infinite.

— William Blake, *The Marriage of Heaven and Hell* (1790–1793)

Every poem is a birth.

— Hélène Cixous, *The Laugh of the Medusa* (1975)

The primary importance of psychedelic drugs, as far as I'm concerned, is that they give you access to a mode of consciousness that's completely different from the mode of consciousness we operate in every day of our lives.

— Aldous Huxley, *Moksha: Writings on Psychedelics and the Visionary Experience* (1977)

Saturday, late night

Gold lay in bed—relaxed and comforted—Rachel's rhythmic breathing at his side. Or was it his own?

She lay asleep, the white sheet partially covering the temple where he'd been worshipping.

Each exhale created a swirling spiral, like Van Gogh's *Starry Night*.

Hints of jasmine, salt water, and crashing waves all embracing him like a mother's gentle caress.

Heaven—my heaven. Peace, at last.

Bob... you were right. It all fits, it makes sense. It's beautiful.

Knowing he would not be able to sleep for a while, he went to the room once meant to be a nursery, now an office.

I need to thank her. Tell her how much I love her.

*Just as Milton wrote *Paradise Lost* "to justify the ways of God to man," I must justify my sins—my*

failings, my choices—to Rachel... and to God.

He sat at his desk, took a pad of paper and started to write, accompanied by soft music playing in his head.

Time passed—fifteen minutes or five hours. He wasn't sure which.

He put his pen down and read what he wrote:

The Birth of a Man

*I
While young and strong and innocent of life,
I never knew fear nor trepidation;
Not conscious of dread, nor even of pain,
Deficient in all realization.
Vain, in my pursuit of love, unaware;
Yet sensing a void from deep in my being,
Feeling emptiness grow while I stood still,
I sought to fill the void with life's meaning.
Thus I recount how my journey began—
The search for love and the birth of a man.*

*II
In earlier years, when trouble was naught,
Pleasures were sought, but none taught an answer.
The world it seemed was just an extension,
Time there was not, nor burden of questions.
Happiness neither existed at all,
Trapped by the wall, none but my reflections.
Yet soon, from my heart, a voice did cry out
Then loudly did shout as it shook to warn,
Of a stranger within who raged and stormed—
Thus, childhood ended, man fought to be born.*

*III
Creativity fought explanation
For the terror the stranger awaken'd.
Still pools of reflection, now exhorted,
Disturbed from their slumber and distorted.*

*Curiosity forged fabrication.
The waters of life lay stagnant and dark,
And fear hid in the shadows of pleasure,
Not then could e'en a remnant be measured.
The birth of the stranger now seem'd reversed,
Existence pervers'd, he sought credit first.*

The stranger... not gone.

Just unnamed.

IV

*Yet in that fall, that beginning of man,
There was a birth, a novel creation.
The future was born and cried to be planned.
Though we know birth and death walk hand in hand,
Kronos, wing'd ghost, awaits coronation,
Murdered this child with anticipation.
Inflated with pride, he choked on the chyme,
His soul slith'ring out of rot deep inside.
The stranger now damned, e'er shackled to time
Stares back with black eyes of one who has died.*

V

*But I, unlike others, did recognize
The stranger within but gave him no name.
Our dual identity I'd not profane,
Though I had seen others do just the same;
Destroying themselves, believing their lies
And finding then that they had indeed changed.
Denying their nature, they could not find
That passion must coexist with the mind.
And being thus separated they fell,
From themselves estranged—to their living Hell.*

VI

*Rather than fall, though they'd call it a step,
Forsaking all, though alone I then crept;
I sought not answers, nor made suggestions,
I merely wished to learn the right questions;*

*Living life 'neath the sword of Damocles,
Drawing strength from mem'ries of Hercules.
"Indeed," you say, "fanciful adventure!"
And yet, in response, I would remind you,
"Tis you trod on, a servant indentured,
On paths so crowded that none may find you."*

VII

*Protected, you think, surrounded by walls,
Believing you're free, in your innocence;
Resigned, you're blind—you are no man at all,
Enslav'd by walls built from your ignorance.
Your slumber disturbed, you call me quer'lous.
I seek only truth, though often blaming.
Paths in our lives may seem dark and per'lous;
We live through action—what sense complaining?
Not what we mean when we raise our voices,
Condemned to act, our lives naught but choices.*

VIII

*Yet precisely these choices, which define
Us as men, express our freedom sublime.
Yes, limits exist, but not to the mind.
In seeking true love, we search throughout time.
Our need for balance to render us whole,
We wander, we search—still empty in soul.
We cannot shirk or shake off our burden;
Doomed, sol'tary, no counsel is heard in.
What then the purpose, and what then the plan?
Whence comes the impulse to become a man?*

IX

*Struck by Jove's bolt! Shadows all disappeared.
Recesses, crevices, all became clear.
The purest of Light, not clouded by sin,
As by lodestone, mesmerized I'm drawn in...
Two pools of clear blue—a Siren's sweet song?
Could this new feeling truly be trusted?
Floating with joy, as if fairy-dusted?
Faint echoing screams from Phobos within*

*Warn me of losses that I may soon face,
Los surely dies, if this draw I embrace.*

Rachel.

(No—Light.)

X

*No shadow was cast, Light filled the abyss;
Illuming my soul, made whole from its parts,
A novel sensation, ne'er before felt—
An ease, a comfort, a calm deep within
I felt life begin, by sharing my heart.
Exudious joy, momentous gestalt,
Intentful direction, now visibly seen,
An auspicious start... a new beginning.
Clear path ahead, a new self to exalt.
Bright Light now inside, n'er e'er shall we part.*

XI

*No Faustian bargain, no loss of soul,
You found me hollow, your love made me whole.
My Galatea—my gift from the gods.
Penelope incarnate—is this real?
Your Light from within, how you make me feel.
No more need I hide, fear, or take cover;
More than just friend, much more than a lover.
My joy, my meaning, my long missing piece.
My partner, my lover, my best friend too,
The fright'ning fear that I don't deserve you.*

XII

*Like cunning Ulysses, I have great flaws—
An oft quick temper, stubbornness, and pride,
Untrusting, mauvaise foi, I try to hide
And bury my shame, pretending I tried—
Lest I confront truths I had long denied.
Psychic vermin gnawed me in its jaws,
Tearing my mind, heart, and soul as it gnaws,
Like Prometheus, e'er torn by its claws.*

*Fearing to face all my faults deep inside,
Your angelic Light has helped them subside.*

This is the part I used to avoid.

XIII

*Those who don't know you, might think that this sounds
Absurd and beyond reality's bounds.
But those whom you've touched, e'en those barely met,
Have felt your Light's warmth, and know that you care,
Best person I know, e'er willing to share
Their sorrow, their burden, their joy, their pain,
You empathize, but seek not any gain.
A true angel—Silverstein's Giving Tree
And never asking "What's in it for me?"
As you share yourself so generously.*

XIV

*My heart made whole, I vowed myself to you.
Our souls, our lives, our beings intertwined,
Together, forever, heart, soul, and mind—
A Gordian knot no force could unbind.
When Atropos moves to sever my thread—
When my sand has run out and I am dead,
Fear not, like Baucis and Philemon, we
Are bound as one, ne'er to be parted.
Lachesis would ne'er allow her sister
To cut short our life, just having started.*

XV

*We've more mem'ries to make, more joys to share,
Paths to explore with those for whom we care.
Our children, their children, so much more to see,
Sharing their dreams, finding out who they'll be.
Their lives are not simply our legacy,
Yet in them lies our immortality.
Let's treasure our time, small handful of sand,
Knowing life's precious—it laughs as we plan.
My searching has ended—I gave you my heart.
Sphinx's riddle is solved, here stands a man.*

If anything remains...

XVI

*Ere Light dims to black and darkness surrounds,
The gleam in your eyes—naught is more profound.
You filled my life's void, gave me direction,
You shared your Light—your pristine reflection.
But when all is done, what then will survive?
Zephyr scatters our dust, blows ev'ry grain.
Ozymandias asks: what will remain?
Perchance these verses—my thanks for your love.
In one single grain, an eternity,
My love, our love, outlives infinity.*

*It's not Milton, not Coleridge. But it's honest. It's
true. It's me.*

Maybe it's a prayer. Maybe a confession.

But I know I meant every word.

The psilocybin was wearing off.

I'm tired.

He turned off the light and went to bed.

CHAPTER THIRTY

The Sound of Blood Crying Out

*Perhaps everything terrible is in its deepest being something helpless that
wants help from us.*

— Rainer Maria Rilke, *Letters to a Young Poet* (1904)

*Even things that seem completely forgotten are present somehow and
somewhere, and have merely been buried and made inaccessible.*

— Sigmund Freud, *Constructions in Analysis* (1937)

We all have shadows. The trick is to learn how to dance with them.

— Steven Gold, *The Journal of Existential Psychodynamics* (Winter, 2024)

Saturday, midnight

That night, Gold dreamt—as he often did.

He walked with no clear direction. Each footstep crunched softly, his feet sinking to the ankles. Ahead, an endless sepia sea of sand stretched toward a mirage of horizon. A sharp scent of salt water stung his nostrils. The dunes rippled like drops disturbing a still pond—concentric patterns over a vast, breathless expanse.

His bare feet burned—as if on fire. He looked down and realized:

I'm naked.

Wings flapped overhead. He looked up—the sky a deep cobalt blue. A raven sliced through it, cawing once as it crossed above.

A disembodied, resonant voice bellowed, “Follow.”

I know that voice.

He obeyed—instinctively.

In the distance, two pillars rose, growing taller with each step. When he reached them, he saw they were immense legs—stone-carved, monumental. Each nearly eight feet wide and thirty feet high.

He stood between them, squinting into the blinding sun. Far above—knees, then nothing—the remnants of a once proud colossus.

A bluish-green ring hovered in his vision—an afterimage seared onto his retina by the merciless sun.

The raven wheeled above and cawed again.

He turned as it alighted upon a colossal severed head—half-buried in sand, tilted as if resting on a pillow. Its features weathered by time, were strangely familiar.

The Colossus of Rhodes? Ozymandias?

Ten feet away, a stone marker jutted from the dune, etched with symbols he almost recognized.

The writing on the ring?

The raven side-hopped along the shattered crown, head cocked nearly horizontal, as if deciphering a mystery. Its eyes fixed on Gold. Suddenly the raven leapt and flew to the marker.

“Approach,” the voice commanded.

Gold stepped toward the fallen face, enormous and half-buried.

Before it burned a thorny acacia—bright, unconsumed. No smoke—only silence.

A burning bush?

Is this the face of God?

He took a hesitant step closer.

Then recoiled—springing back in shock.

Despite the erosion, the statue’s face was unmistakable—terribly familiar.

Dad?

He paused, fighting to compose himself.

Every child sees his father as God.

The raven lunged toward him—hovering midair, its wings beating like a frantic heart. Its eyes—dark sapphires, unblinking, intelligent, knowing. Then it returned, back to its perch on the

monument, shrouded in shadow.

It spoke—not in any bird’s voice.

“You recognize me.”

Gold did not flinch.

“I do.”

“And yet you’re not surprised. Not afraid.”

“No. Should I be?”

“You once feared the unknown—anything beyond your control. You’ve changed; I hardly recognize you.”

Suddenly aware of his nakedness, Gold covered himself.

Wait. This is a dream.

He lowered his arms, then raised his hands—staring at them as if they might dissolve.

The raven laughed—a guttural, echoing caw. Its gray, reptilian membrane slid across one eye as laughter filled the air without walls.

“You are embarrassed.”

Stay with it.

Control it.

“I don’t fear you. I know you, Samael.”

As he spoke the name, lightning split the empty sky—blinding light cleaving the massive head in two.

“You never knew me. Or your father. Or your mother.” It paused—then, softly: “or Rachel.”

A violent jolt raced down his spine; he shuddered.

Stay calm.

“You never even knew yourself—not until I became your mirror.”

Total silence.

Gold stood tall in his nakedness—unashamed, defiant.

“But I know you.” Gold said, stepping forward. “Step out

of the shadow, Satan. Show yourself.” He commanded.

A crash shattered the still air. It was as if he’d walked through a mirror—jagged crystal shards exploding, hanging weightless, then falling through him like light through mist.

A gray wash bled down from above, veiling the horizon in a gauzy shadow.

From beyond the wall of fire and mist came voices—ancient, aching.

“Why am I not as thou art? Why did He reject my gift—yet accept thine?”

A pause—then a quieter voice, almost pleading:

“What have I done to thee, my brother?”

Gold’s heart lurched; he needed no faces to know them.

Cain and Abel.

Blackness.

Then—Gold’s office. Everything blurred in black and white until color surged—red, yellow, orange, green, and purple.

A migraine aura? In my dream?

His vision flickered, strobing between worlds

Statues—familiar, wrong.

The Serenity bust on the shelf—Rachel. Not stylized now but real: flawless skin, symmetrical features, long blond hair framing her delicate neck and the infinity necklace with its blue sapphire solitaire. Beautiful, unreachable. Watching him. Judging him. A moan drew his gaze to the bronze in the corner—Jane, nude, one hand resting on her breast, the other between parted legs, eyes locked on him in rapture.

A low chuckle from the wall made him turn—the Newton print alive, naked, hunched, one leg grotesquely scarred: Bob.

And Nebuchadnezzar—face twisted in eternal anguish—Shapiro: bearded, wild-eyed, condemned.

Muffled screams drew him to the Moore print—its open mouth revealed itself as his mother, Deborah. A grinding crack of stone turned his eyes to the Michelangelo slave: Gerald, torso arched,

lips half-formed, face locked in silent pain.

A discordant hum—harp strings behind him. He turned slowly.

Hanging on the wall: the enormous Pollock *Lucifer*.

But it moved—writhing, a living mesh of white lines. Not paint at all.

A web.

Gold stepped closer, staring, realizing—he was inside it.

The strands weren't random—they were constraints.

Trapped—a web of wires.

He leaned forward; his fingers met taut resistance—confirming the prison was real.

A prisoner of the very pattern he'd chosen.

I'm still dreaming.

A flicker of awareness.

Still under.

The tea. The psilocybin.

This is the vision. The descent.

He leaned in; the colored threads bit his skin. Each bead of paint pricked, drawing bright blood that deepened the design's cruelty.

Behind Hadrian's Wall, in the chair at the ebony desk, a figure sat.

Still. Dark. Just beyond the weave.

Gold straightened, squaring himself.

"Satan!" he shouted.

He clenched the colored strands—bright as barbed wire—around his fists.

"Are you watching? Enjoying this spectacle?"

The figure didn't move, didn't speak.

"You tricked me. You are the evil one."

The figure slowly shook its head—whispered something inaudible.

“Damn you Satan!” Gold cried. “You liar. You coward—damn you and your Father!”

A deep, resonant voice rolled from the rising figure: “I am not Satan.”

Blinding light burned brightly from the figure.

“God?”

He pointed around the office. “You let her be raped.

You killed her child—then killed her spirit.” He spat.

“All of them—Rachel, my father, my mother, Jane, Bob, even Tommy—every one. Every goddamn one.

“You killed them all.

“In body, mind, spirit.

“How does a Father kill His own children?”

The response, a soft, clear whisper, no longer a deep booming voice—“Free will. I did nothing.”

Gold broke down, shouting through tears, “Fuck you! You did! You watched! You stood by and did nothing! What kind of Father are you?”

The words echoed back: What kind of Father are you?

“A Father should not abandon his children.”

Still... just silence.

The scene shifted—he was back among the desert dunes, beneath a moonless sky. No stars. *Darkness visible.*

Then a golden ladder blazed upward, vanishing into darkness beyond sight. The fiery figure turned from Gold and began to climb.

“No!”

Gold, still in the painting, shook the web cage. It crashed from the wall, shattering like glass. He now stood on the sand.

He lunged at the figure, grappling him to the ground.

“Why? Why do you do nothing?”

The figure rose, its fire extinguished.

It looked at Gold—not with anger, but with sorrow.

His eyes were gentle—ancient.

“What have you done?” it asked.

“The blood on your hands cries out to me.”

Gold looked at his hands. Light’s ring gleaming on his right middle finger, as if it had always been there. Blood dripped between his fingers.

The words struck like thunder—yet not in anger, but in grief.

What have I done?

Gold froze, trembling.

“What have you done?”

The words didn’t accuse.

They mourned.

And then—

A whisper.

“His blood cries out.”

Gold stood before the figure in white—its face radiant, ancient, sorrowful.

It began to climb the endless ladder, slowly, deliberately.

God.

“You abandoned us!” Gold cried upward, his voice breaking.

“All of us—not just Rachel, Jane, my mother, my father, Bob... all of us.

“All mankind.”

The raven descended, alighting on Gold’s shoulder. It cawed twice—the ring now glinting around one leg.

“Even him—Samael. Your son.

“You made him the scapegoat for everything You could not bear to face.”

The figure halted on the ladder. For a long moment He said

nothing.

Then His gaze shifted to the raven. It shimmered—becoming
Samael Light: wounded, ash-covered, uncertain, waiting.

The figure looked down upon Gold.

“You blame Me,” He said gently.

“Blame to distract from your choices, your actions... not
mine.”

Then He turned His gaze to Samael. “So did he...

“You made me your scapegoat.”

The silence stretched—limitless.

The dream itself held its breath.

The figure said, “My son, find peace in Heaven.”

Their eyes met; Samael nodded.

He climbed one step.

Then another.

Then another.

Up the rungs.

Higher.

To the top.

At the threshold, the figure hesitated—then reached down
and extended a hand.

Samael reached up and grasped it tightly.

He stepped forward.

And for the first time since creation,

Satan and God embraced.

Gold wept.

And slept.

A Question of Balance

CHAPTER THIRTY-ONE

Exudious Joy

*When love loses its footing,
obsession tries to take its place—
but it never fills the hole.*

— Steven Gold, *Personal Notes on Rachel*

The brighter the light, the darker the shadows it attracts.
— Steven Gold, *journal entry (unpublished)*

Sunday, mid-morning

Gold woke rested, strangely buoyant. A slow smile spread across his face. His sleep had been deep, unbroken. He felt whole—so whole it almost felt borrowed.

He reached for his dream journal—blank. No entry.

Huh? I dreamed... but didn't wake? Maybe the mushrooms.

Rachel's side of the bed was empty. The bedside clock read 10:12 am—late, even for him.

The smell of bacon. Coffee. And Bill Withers' voice—warm, effortless—drifting in from the kitchen.

It is just the two of us. I feel light. Happy. Last night was amazing.

He brushed his teeth, slipped into a T-shirt and jeans, and headed to the kitchen.

Rachel stood at the stove in his white dress shirt—two red dots on one rolled sleeve, bare thighs, black silk glinting beneath—swaying to Grover Washington Jr.'s saxophone solo.

She looked like a stranger. No—someone rediscovered. A version of her he'd misplaced and mistaken for gone.

Luckiest man alive. Don't fuck this up again.

He slipped behind her, arms encircling her waist, lips brushing her neck. Her scent stirred something ancient—deeper than lust, older than reason. He remembered the feeling of their souls merging last night.

“Hi honey. You slept late. Sleep well?”

“Like a rock. The mushroom tea Bob gave me... whatever it was... definitely helped. I feel incredible—never better.”

He heard himself and almost didn't trust it.

“You?”

“Fantastic. I wasn't sure if I was dreaming—it was... wonderful.”

She giggled—an unfamiliar sound, bright and disarming. But good. “I've never felt like that before. I didn't know it could feel like that.

I want to paint it—Exudious Joy. Colorful, abstract, tulips. Every color in the rainbow. That's how I felt”

‘Exudious.’ She read my poem.

“I love you so much, Steven.”

“And I love you.”

She smiled—drawing in her shoulders, clenching her fists to her chest, and squeezing her eyes tightly shut.

“And then I saw the poem you wrote. I don't understand all the references—but I love it.”

*Children—oh God. I actually put that in there.
What was I thinking? Did she see it? Did it sting? Did
it remind her? Christ, how could I have been so
careless? Please—please—let her have read past it
without noticing.*

She rose on her toes, hugged him tight, kissed him—then he lifted her, spun her once, pulling her into a long, hungry kiss.

*She didn't catch it—thank God. My pen's braver
than I am... or just reckless.*

Gold caught a glimpse of his reflection off the stainless steel oven hood.

Hair's still gray, but the crow's feet softer. Better than Wednesday. Mushrooms? Sex? Love?

"I love you, Rach. I'm sorry—for being difficult, for not being there. Headaches, distractions, work—I disappeared. I think I need a break."

He hesitated. "Even Bob noticed. He gave me a microdose of psilocybin."

Rachel's eyebrows jumped. "What?"

"I took it last night. It cracked something open. For the first time in a long time I felt alive again, like the man you fell in love with. I've been selfish, scared, stupid. But last night... I saw clearly. I'm changed... or at least changing. I want to be *me* again. The me you married. The me you signed up for."

"Thanks, Steven. I appreciate it. It's been hard for both of us."

She placed bacon and an omelet on a platter, carried it to the table, and divided the food. He pulled his chair closer; she smiled.

"I haven't been myself either. At first my art was joy—I was so happy being Mrs. Doctor Steven Gold."

She smiled, then the smile slipped, as if it cost too much to hold.

"But when I couldn't carry, it became a fog I couldn't lift. We tried so many times, each ending in pain, failure, regret. Reminders of the attack and the many things it took away."

That rape destroyed her. Her innocence. Her trust. Her body's sense of safety. And then everything that depended on it.

They both wiped away tears—their own, and each other's.

"Rachel, I..."

Rachel took Gold's hand and kissed it. "Shh. I don't want to live in an 'if only' world of regret. You've said living in the past always has you looking back, instead of ahead. You're constantly stumbling through your life, not knowing where you're headed. Not

knowing where you are until you've passed it. That's no way to live. We need to enjoy life."

If I ever said that, I need to start listening to myself. I need to encourage her, cheer for her more. Everyone needs support. And, more than anyone I know, she deserves it.

She giggled. "I sure enjoyed last night." She blushed. "And I'm enjoying us, right now.

"I know that has been hard for you. It was difficult—Deborah fading before your eyes, then Gerald so sick. You were a good son, Steven."

Was I?

"But not a good husband. I know I wasn't. I haven't been... for a long time."

"Steven..."

"No—I wasn't. I was like my dad—too busy with work to see you, to see what you needed. When your parents died..."

Gold began to cry.

Crying. Not embarrassed. Not ashamed. Honest. Alive.

"I'm sorry. I wasn't there for you." His breath hitched. "You lost both parents in three days—an orphan overnight. And where was I? Buried in work... conveniently avoiding it. I'm so sorry."

Rachel hugged him, holding back tears—as she'd learned to do.

"I had..."

Gold snorted softly.

"Well, I had Jason. And my girlfriends. Kristen was an enormous help. And you were there."

She's protecting me—from my guilt.

"I know I wasn't. No need to lie. I was wrong—and I understand now."

"You had your hands full with your parents. I know how hard

it was for you and Gerald with your mom.”

She's always there for me. I don't deserve her.

“Honestly, Rach—before she disappeared, she was already gone. My father—controlling—insisted on doing everything himself, his way. If he’d accepted help, she might not have died—at least not like that.

“At first, I worried she was locked in—all there, unable to speak. But knowing how he’d treated her, I wondered if she locked herself away, and threw away the key herself.

“I didn’t speak. I didn’t stand up to him... *honor thy father.*

“I didn’t fight for her—the way you did for...” he cautiously whispered, “David.”

A jolt ran down Rachel’s spine. She shivered and reached for her necklace, fingers finding the chain as if it could hold her steady.

Her eyes closed tight, fighting a flood.

Don't rush this. She's not ready to go there. I can't blame her. Change course.

“I never told you, but I’ve always wondered if she knew what she was doing—if she wanted to vanish completely. There were times with him when I did.

“When my dad got sick... part of me was happy, thinking it was divine justice. We never spoke. He just waited, while I did everything I could to save him.”

Did I?

“I don’t know if he wanted to die out of guilt or just to stop the pain. I felt abandoned—and guilty—for my thoughts.”

Rachel leaned over, hugging him tightly, pressing his head into her shoulder. “I’m sorry, Steven... so sorry. You should have told me.”

“I know... but you’ve always been perfect. I was ashamed—embarrassed—by those thoughts. I couldn’t tell you.”

Rachel’s expression hardened; her brows furrowed.

“Perfect? Far from it. The thoughts I had... I can’t even

share. ‘Don’t be like Jane.’ ‘Set an example for Jason.’ ‘You can do better than that.’

“All I ever heard was: not good enough... keep trying, be better.”

Gold’s eyes dropped. They reflected the pain of real empathy.

My God. The pressure, the pain. I never heard... or wasn’t listening. How did I not see it—I face it all the time with my patients.

But with Rachel, I closed my eyes... and ears.

“And then...” Rachel bit her lip, looking down, lost in deep thought. She began sobbing, pulling her necklace chain through the infinity symbol like a rosary.

Rachel. I know.

“Steven... I wanted him so badly. I wanted to be the parent I never had. To love him—unconditionally—like I never was.

“Just because it was...” her breath caught and hitched, “rape... that wasn’t David’s fault.”

I can’t imagine the pain, the choice she had to make. The courage she had for the choice she wanted to make and the pain for accepting the one she was forced to make.

“I fixed up a nursery, with his name in blue block letters—David. I had a beautiful blue receiving blanket...”

She began sobbing, gasping for breath.

“I loved him... would have loved him.”

Gold took her hand, squeezing tight.

“They said, ‘No. It will ruin your life. You could be a physician, an attorney—anything you want... but not as a young single mother.’

“It,’ they called David ‘it.’ ‘Anything I want.’ I wanted to be David’s mother. They wanted a doctor or lawyer. Someone that could redeem them in their friend’s eyes from the fall from grace they felt because of Jane’s troubles.

“‘You won’t listen to us? Will you talk with Rabbi Shapiro?’
I said yes, thinking he would value life.

“He was kind, gentle—but already decided. ‘It will ruin your life. It’s not a person yet.’”

She swallowed, as if the words still tasted like metal.

“He spoke of the abortion as if it were mercy—as though killing love could be a mitzvah.”

Fucking Shapiro.

“You’re too young. It will ruin...”

Tears rained down, falling from her trembling lips, sputtering with gasps and sniffing.

“My parents and Rabbi Shapiro... they talked me into... abandoning him before his first breath.”

Rabbi Shapiro seemed so kind, gentle when he said it. ‘Rachel, it’s the merciful thing to do. Don’t bring it into a world in turmoil, sentenced to a life of shame and embarrassment.’

Now I know he was speaking for my parents, not for David. He said it, like it was mercy. Like killing love could be a mitzvah.

“They kept saying ‘it’... but it was my son, Steven, I’d already given him a name—David... dearly loved.”

Gold’s chest tightened.

“They took David away from me. And now I can’t ever have a child. I know you wanted a family.” She choked.

“I did. But I’ve learned I don’t need a child—I need you more.” He swallowed. “I can’t live without you, Rach.” His voice cracked.

“I know the drawing in your closet—the unfinished one in the black frame—is titled *David*. And your necklace—the blue sapphire—that’s David, isn’t it.”

She stared at him. “What? How could you know? I’ve never told anyone.”

“I know, I know. Rach... I’m so sorry.”

Tears, mixing with glistening threads of regret, poured from her eyes and nose. “It’s not fair to you.”

“I didn’t care then and I don’t care now—just as long as I have you.

“I knew when we married, that we might not have children.” His eyes full.

They sat in silence, music from the kitchen still playing faintly.

“Let’s start traveling again,” Gold said softly. “Like we used to. I was thinking about our honeymoon—how happy we were.

We’ve got enough money. We can be those newlyweds again. Let’s have every night be like last night.”

Rachel gave a wet laugh. “That works for me. I love you so much, Steven—I can’t imagine taking a breath without you. I couldn’t... I wouldn’t.”

He pulled her close. “You won’t ever have to. I’m sorry. It’s like I tricked you into marrying me, then I left you alone with your sadness.” Not because we couldn’t have kids—because I was a child. Immature, selfish, hiding in work instead of building a life with you. Because... I was hiding from myself. I always had. I didn’t even know who I was. I just know that you were, and are, the light in my life and I need you.”

“I did feel alone,” she admitted. “And worse—when I found out you and Jane... *knew* each other before me... I thought you regretted choosing me. That you wanted her.

“She’s beautiful, exciting, and—Steven, she swore it was you who got her pregnant—said she could give you the family you wanted.”

How can I convince her? How can I make her understand how truly fucked-up Jane is—without sounding like I’m defending myself?

“Rach, honestly I...”

“I know Steven. But she swears... And I see the way you stare at her.”

“Rach, I swear—on my life—on God—I never slept with her.”

Swear to God? Am I being hypocritical?

“She kissed me once, came on strong—borderline assault. It

was long before we met. And, it completely turned me off. Her child, not mine.

“What can I do to make you understand I’m telling you the truth?”

Rachel wiped her tears again, blew her nose into a tissue.

She studied him. “I believe you. But I know you found her... find her, attractive.”

He put his hand on her arm, interrupting her. “Rach. She was attractive—still is, I guess. Yes, she is. Okay.” He exhaled. “But inside? She’s a train wreck—an accident waiting for a place to happen.”

Don’t let on she’s seeing Bob.

“You don’t need to be jealous. I have no interest in her.”

Stop staring for a glimpse of her damn tattoo. Get her out of my head—out of my life.

“I know she’s had a rough life, but that’s her doing, her choices. She constantly makes bad decisions—she doesn’t think. She’s a pistol with a hair trigger—always shooting herself in the foot. She hurts everyone around her. She’s unpredictable. Dangerous. That’s not attractive.

“I can’t believe you two are sisters.”

Jane—danger and opportunity. That tattoo sums her up. She was a dangerous opportunity when we first met. I avoided it, but I’m still paying for having crossed paths.

He reached over, wrapped his arms around Rachel, and hugged her hard. Then he held her back, at the shoulders, to focus directly into her beautiful blue eyes.

“She could never hold a candle to you. You’re everything I ever needed.”

“Thank you.” Rachel gave Gold a kiss. A simple peck first, then another... she lingered. He felt her soft lips, still wet from her tears. He melted into her, falling into her soul again.

Is this the mushrooms? Or just me—finally real,

finally feeling love? Have I changed?

He slid his hand along her waist, fingers brushing the buttons of the shirt she wore. “You really are the piece that completes me—like Shel Silverstein’s *Missing Piece*, like that line in *Jerry Maguire*. I needed you all along—I just couldn’t see it. I was afraid to be open, to be vulnerable, to share—to trust. I’ve been so closed, so afraid, so angry.”

She smiled while kissing, leaned back to give him room. One breast partly exposed, he began gently caressing her breast. Pulling the shirt to the side, he placed his lips against the side of her breast, savoring the soft skin, breathing her in—a faint trace of her perfume. Her nipple hardened under the feel of his soft lips, and his breath. Sighing with satisfaction and desire, she reached her hands down, softly stroking his now fully erect penis.

“Rach, last night... it was like a blindfold fell away. Not sexually—psychically. Without you, there’s nothing—no desire, no meaning, no reason.”

Her chair squeaked as she scooted it back, allowing her room to lean her head forward, into his lap. His breathing hitched with excitement and anticipation, but then he lifted her upright.

“I’d love you to—but I haven’t showered and right now... I just want to talk. I’ve been selfish for years—but now I see it clearly. It’s like I’ve been someone else.”

Her eyes filled. “Steven, I love you... so much. I’ve missed you. I kept thinking it was me—or Jane—or that you’d stopped loving me.”

Look what I’ve done.

“I was unhappy. But because I missed us. I wrote the poem for you—and for me. To understand myself. To change. We can read it together later.”

*What am I saying? Read it together? She’ll see
that line about children—God, why did I write that?
Don’t freeze. Don’t ruin this.*

A wave of nausea rose in his throat.

“Let’s do that—read it together.” Another tear traced her

cheek, hope—sparkling as it caught the sunlight.

She is the light of my life. She's so beautiful. I feel so guilty that she ever doubted me... that I ever hurt her.

“Steven, I don’t know where you’ve been the past few years.”

She wiped the tear away.

“I’ve felt... I’ve been so alone, so sad—it physically hurts. My life’s been so dark and cloudy these past few years. But last night... this morning I see you again, the man I fell in love with—the man I’m in love with.

“Honestly... I was scared. Friday at the Book Club—I didn’t know who you were, or where Steven had gone. That’s happened a few times. You weren’t yourself—almost possessed.”

The kitchen lights flickered—just once—as if a shadow brushed the doorway. He looked up, uneasy, without knowing why.

RING. RING. RING.

She looked, as if to dismiss it. “Go ahead,” Gold said.

“It’s Kristen.”

“That’s fine. Take it.

“Alexa, stop.”

Rachel answered. “Hi Kristen. No, that’s fine—we’re just having a late breakfast. You sound shaken—what’s wrong?”

Her smile collapsed. Color drained from her face.

“Oh my God... when? What happened?”

Gold looked up from his plate, concerned. He whispered, “What? What happened?”

“Okay, I’ll call Karen, she must be beside herself. Thanks Kristen. I’ll call you later.”

Rachel lowered the phone, face ashen.

“Oh my God.”

“Rach, what happened?”

“It’s Rabbi Shapiro... Steven—he’s dead.”

“Murdered.”

Gold blinked. Inside, everything went still.

Murdered.

CHAPTER THIRTY-TWO

The Brighter the Light, the Darker the Shadows it Attracts

Sunday, midmorning

*I used to think evil announced itself through intent.
Not anymore.*

*Plans are invisible. Meaningless.
You only see action.*

Sunlight burst through the French windows, flooding the table. They sat in two Windsor hoop-back chairs—side by side, yet already worlds apart.

“Murdered?”

*Rachel used to feel safe tucked behind the tall ficus
hedge in Holmby Hills. Not anymore. This will hit her.
Privacy isn't protection.*

“That’s what Kristen said. He never came home after the Havdalah service last night. Karen panicked—called the temple. Lucien went to check. Found him. Dead—‘posed like Jesus on the cross.’”

*The brighter the light, the darker the shadow it
attracts.*

Gold studied his reflection in the gleaming side of the toaster.

Strange. Detached. Curious—not horrified. Out

of body.

Didn't like him—didn't want him dead. Had wished him dead once.

Strange... not really surprised. Indifferent.

Rachel shoved back from the chair and paced the kitchen island's perimeter. "Steven, do you think it was an antisemitic attack? Kristen didn't talk to her—Karen just left a message. Oh God. How's she even coping? Robbie and Tiffany—my God—their father... murdered. And posed like that. Like Jesus on the cross?"

Rachel spiraled. Gold stayed rooted in place.

"I have to call Karen. I can't. My God. Steven... how could this happen? Who would do such a thing? Why? Posed like Jesus? What does that even mean?"

Finally—like waking from a trance—Gold rose and pulled Rachel into his arms.

After services last night—Light storming out, spitting: "It's not faith—it's fucking control." He'd named him—"Shapiro, sanctimonious bastard." Cursed rabbis, priests, and imams alike. "I'd have carved those false words out of his throat."

He'd twitched—like spiders scuttling beneath his skin.

Shit.

Did Light do this—for me? In my name?

Christ. I feel like there are bugs under my skin.

He'd said he'd murdered before.

Before leaving, he'd warned: "Decisions often carry unintended consequences."

Shit. Should I have reported it? No explicit threat—but the timing. And the temple's just up the street.

Rachel's breathing quickened. She pushed him away, pacing again, head swaying side to side—like a moored boat caught in a sudden squall.

“Steven... do you think there could be another Holocaust—here?”

He rubbed his temple, eyes flicking toward the window. Sunlight bled through the blinds, striping the floor in gold.

“Holocaust? No. Probably just some antisemitic zealot. It’s always been there. Always will. The temple’s been hit before.”

Holocaust? Another fanatic blaming Jews for killing Jesus—again?

If the story’s true—if God’s omniscient and omnipotent—then the crucifixion wasn’t an accident. It was the plan. Jesus knew it, accepted it. Without betrayal, trial, nails—no salvation.

So who’s guilty—not the Jews, but God Himself.

Easier to damn the children than the Father.

Rachel stopped pacing, watching him as if weighing whether to speak again.

Why couldn’t You just forgive? Turn the other cheek—no blood required.

He gripped the kitchen counter, palms flat to the marble.

The Romans did the killing. Crucifixion was their punishment—public, slow, meant to humiliate and warn. The Sanhedrin couldn’t pass death sentences—especially not on Passover or the Sabbath. Jewish law didn’t execute would-be messiahs. Blasphemy had a narrow definition—this didn’t meet it.

Rachel’s hand brushed the back of a chair, her knuckles white.

He crossed back toward her.

The trial at Caiaphas’s house—couldn’t have happened. It would’ve been illegal.

Conflicting witnesses. No appeal. Even his so-called confession—“You say that I am”—wouldn’t hold up anywhere, then or now.

If it happened at all, Rome punished sedition—as they always did. And if God planned it, every drop of blood was His—on His hands. Judas damned for fulfilling prophecy—obeying orders, just like Light claimed.

“But Judas and the Sanhedrin had free will,” some argue. Did they? If the script was written from the start—how free was anyone? Was Eve free in Eden—or Jacob, wrestling in the dark? Not many are willing—or able—to wrestle with God. Judas couldn’t.

Rachel turned toward him, eyes sharp now—trying to catch his meaning before it slipped away.

Judas may have struggled, but he only followed orders—from God.

Did he have free will? Could he have said no? Should he be blamed like the Nazis for “just following orders”? Judas followed God’s divine plan; the Nazis, Hitler’s psychotic master plan. No comparison—so why the blame?

The machinery of blame and obedience—hauntingly familiar.

The lie endures. People keep killing for it. Lies make better legends than truth—legends harder to kill than men.

“Could there?” Rachel’s voice pulled him back.

“No. This was just some lunatic. You don’t need to worry. The police will figure it out.”

But will they?

He glanced at the blinds. The light had thinned and cooled, striping the carpet like prison bars.

He needed to pull her—and himself—back from the edge.

“Rach. Sit down. Let me get you some tea.”

He rinsed the teapot thoroughly, fingers trembling just slightly.

I don’t need anything getting into her system right

now.

“Alexa, play *Gold’s Classical Reading Playlist*.”

That should help relax her.

She looked up, blotting her tears with a napkin.

He felt a dull pain in his lower throat—a tightness—like he was being slowly choked.

I hate seeing her cry.

“Steven, please sit with me.

Promise me you’ll never leave me. I can’t imagine living without you.”

He hugged her tightly.

“Won’t happen. Promise.”

“I don’t know what I’d do. Poor Karen.”

“Here.” He poured from the teapot into the mug. “Here’s some Honey Lavender Stress Relief tea with extra honey. Let it cool off.”

She blew on the mug.

Her breathing slowed, syncing with *Vladimir Spivakov’s* violin as *Spiegel im Spiegel* by *Arvo Pärt* unfolded.

Spiegel im Spiegel—‘mirror in the mirror.’ The music’s working.

Gold gripped the counter, knuckles white. He pictured the sanctuary’s *ner tamid*—the eternal flame above the ark—casting its restless shimmer into the dark.

The rabbi, posed... What would Lucien have found? Would he have understood? What would he have seen?

CHAPTER THIRTY-THREE

Thou Shalt Not Kill

Nothing can be hidden from the superego. Not even thoughts.
— Sigmund Freud, *Civilization and Its Discontents* (1930)

Thou shalt not kill.
— Exodus 20:13, KJV (1611)

“But the Emperor has nothing at all on!” said a little child.
— Hans Christian Andersen, *The Emperor’s New Clothes* (1837)

Innocence, once lost, cannot be restored.
Darkness, once fallen, cannot be light.
— John Milton, *Paradise Lost* (paraphrased)

When you are gone,
When you move on.
When the wind whispers your name,
What memories of you will remain?
— Steven Gold, *Eulogies & Headstones* (unpublished)

To understand who a person really was, what his or her life really meant,
the speaker for the dead would have to explain their self-story—
what they meant to do, what they actually did, what they regretted, what they
rejoiced in.
That’s the story that we never know, the story that we never can know—
and yet, at the time of death, it’s the only story truly worth telling.
— Orson Scott Card, *Speaker for the Dead* (1986)

Yesterday— Saturday, 9:30 pm

Behind silver-rimmed glasses, his wide, unblinking eyes reflected the golden shimmer of the synagogue’s *ner tamid*—the eternal flame burning above the ark, keeper of the sacred scrolls.

Flickers danced across his pupils, as if watching something no

one else could see.

His lips parted slightly, caught between thought and speech—holding back a revelation too sacred, or too dangerous, to name.

The familiar lines of his face—once lit with warmth and wisdom—were unreadable now. His expression offered neither peace nor resistance, only the quiet gravity of surrender.

The silence hung heavy in the sanctuary—thick with waiting. The kind that once preceded his unraveling of hidden meanings—or the calm before graveside eulogies.

But this silence stretched—beyond reverence—into something unspoken.

This was a silence Rabbi Shapiro would never break. Whatever thoughts he held would remain unspoken—forever. Or perhaps another would speak them, at his own interment.

Flash—light split the darkness like a blade.

A police photographer's camera snapped—fracturing the stillness with mechanical precision.

Each burst revealed the sacrilege—before darkness, jealous and ancient, swallowed it whole.

Flash.

His pale skin and thick white beard glowed in the dim light—haloed by the blood pooling beneath his head, like a medieval icon.

Flash.

He lay cruciform, arms flung wide—not in defense, but in offering—as though for sacrifice.

Flash.

His salmon-colored linen shirt—still neatly pressed, its row of wooden buttons untouched—rested over dark jeans: a serene counterpoint to the carnage below.

The shirt had ridden up, exposing a pallid belly—the same stark white as his spotless Stan Smiths.

Flash.

His white yarmulke—knocked loose in the struggle—lay nearby.

Just inches away, the once-white silk had turned crimson—drinking from the slow, red stream winding down the gray-carpeted sanctuary steps.

Flash.

On the wall behind the *bimah*, dark red symbols pulsed with each flash—crude, finger-drawn shapes—summoned, then ashamed—more ancient than accidental. They vanished—recoiling into shadow as if unwilling to be seen.

For a moment, they left a ghosted afterimage—tears trailing from the shapes, as if the wall itself wept.

Flash.

A short thin rod jutted from the base of his neck—no wider than a pen, coated in blood—barely noticeable except for the cold, sterile gleam when light caught it. A silver chain hung from it, draped on the carpet like a blood-slick rope.

“Smythe! Turn on some goddamn lights!” Ryker barked. “And get some tape up—I don’t want anyone tripping and contaminating my crime scene.”

Smythe found the switches and flipped them all on. The shadows vanished as bright LED light flooded the synagogue.

Rabbi Shapiro’s body lay on the floor facing west, back toward the ark—the cabinet housing the sacred Torah scrolls. Between a smooth maple lectern and a table draped in white linen, the edge soaked up the blood pooling at his head. Two large silver candlesticks stood there—one upright, dimly flickering, the other toppled. The air-conditioning hummed to life; a faint smell of coffee drifted through the room.

Smythe stepped closer— careful not to cross the tape. “I ain’t no artist, boss, but it kinda looks like a painting by Margaret or Dolly.” His tentative chuckle died in the air.

“René Magritte, Salvador Dalí.” Ryker shook his head. “Not an artist, huh? I got news, Smythe—you’re not a comedian either.”

Ryker crouched beside the body, peering into Shapiro’s open eyes. He lifted his hat to shield the glare from above.

“What happened here, Rabbi? What did you see?” Another camera flash caught something reflected in the rabbi’s glasses. Ryker

writing.”

He turned to the photographer. “Jameson—get wide shots of the rabbi and that wall. Text me everything. I might know someone who can make sense of it.”

Ryker lifted the fallen candlestick, turning it under the light. “No blood. Doubt it’s the weapon, but dust it for prints.” He moved back to the wall. “Smythe, when Jameson’s done, check the back of the rabbi’s head—see if we’ve got a gunshot.”

“Wouldn’t the front of his skull be blown off if it was?”

“Not if it was a Saturday Night Special—a.22, maybe a.25 ACP. People would’ve heard it, though, so I’m betting no. But check anyway—wait.”

Ryker tilted his head, eyes narrowing like a hawk sizing prey. He crouched beside the body, careful not to touch the chain, following it up to the short rod protruding from the neck. “See that? Right side—low. What the hell is it?” he murmured.

“Jameson, you get shots of this yet? I want a closer look.”

Jameson fired off another twenty shots from every angle.

“Got ‘em, Ryker. You’re good.”

Ryker gripped the rod with a gloved hand and eased it free. A soft slurp broke the silence as a thin, ten-inch, blood-slick metal cylinder slid from Shapiro’s neck, the silver chain, dripping blood, dangling.

“What the hell is that—spear gun? Poison dart?” Smythe asked.

“It’s a *yad*—a silver pointer used to follow Torah text without touching the scroll. See the tip? It’s shaped like a hand, pointing a finger. Dark blood dripped onto the rabbi’s chest. Angle of entry suggests it pierced the jugular and traveled into the brain. Quick collapse—but he might’ve stayed conscious for a minute.” Ryker dropped the *yad* into an evidence bag.

Smythe’s smirk faded, eyes widening. “Jesus. Maybe it was pointing to a clue?” Smythe asked, in all seriousness?

“Yeah—pointing to the rabbi’s optic nerve, where he saw the killer.” Ryker mimed a quick upward stab with his left hand. “He knew whoever did this. Entry’s on the right—so I’m betting our

perp's left-handed."

"Smythe—you remember the Lennox Avenue murders? St. Augustine Parish, last year. Only a mile from here."

"Yeah, kinda. Still open, right?"

"Yeah. Johnson and Riley are still half-working it. That pastor—castrated, nailed to the crucifix. He was dead first, thank God. They found symbols on those walls too, but I can't recall them. Same radius—about a mile. Temple, no crucifixes, but maybe related. Pull the case file from Johnson when we're back."

"Wasn't a nun killed there too?"

"Yeah—outside on Lennox. Maybe our perp was a molested choir boy. Takes a real twisted rage to castrate a priest and nail him to a cross. Nun likely walked in while he was scrawling on the walls—never finished, chased her out, strangled her. We'll compare the details."

"Who found the rabbi?"

"Got the 911 here..." Smythe flipped open his pad. "Lucien Vega—the janitor. Rabbi's wife called the temple when he didn't come home on time."

"We'll talk to Vega—and the rabbi's wife. Doesn't feel like a satanic hit or antisemitic vandalism. Too clean. Feels personal. Find out if anyone had a grudge."

"You got it, boss." Smythe was already scribbling notes.

"Check if he kept a calendar. I want names from the past week."

"On it."

"Let's look again." Ryker returned to the wall. "The rabbi was staring right there when he died."

"Maybe he watched the perp writing it."

"From his expression—cadaveric spasm—he did. Eyes wide, fixed on that wall. Last sight frozen there, the instant he died. The killer posed him cruciform, facing the ark and the writing. He'd have stayed conscious a minute, maybe more. The bastard wanted him to see it—to die staring at it. He knew the rabbi could read it. This was personal."

“Sick fuck.”

Ryker kept his gaze on the wall, voice low, almost to himself.
“What’s it say... what the hell does it say?”

The writing faded into shadow as Ryker clicked off the
Stinger.

CHAPTER THIRTY-FOUR

Shadows Can't Hide Everything

I, not in deed, but in effect, was the true murderer.

— Mary Wollstonecraft Shelley, *Frankenstein; or, The Modern Prometheus*,
1818

*A normal human being does not want the Kingdom of Heaven: he wants life
on earth to continue.*

— George Orwell

I believed in reason. And now I am ruined.

— John Gardner, *The Wreckage of Agathon* (1970)

Sunday, early morning

Ryker had barely slept. Even in darkness, the wall stalked him—the pictographs vanishing whenever the Stinger's beam faded. Roger, his three-year-old yellow Lab, hopped off the bed and disappeared through the doggie door.

He grabbed his iPhone and headed for the bathroom. While shaving, he muttered at his reflection, "Who the hell poses a murder victim—makes them watch, dying, while scrawling on the wall? You have to be seriously fucked up to do that."

Roger padded in and stretched out on the cool tile. Ryker met his sad gaze. "Takes someone even more twisted to work with people who do that. Guess that's why Joan left. Just you and me now, buddy."

Roger's tail wagged hopefully, anticipating a walk. Ryker walked over to the closet, grabbing his gray pinstripe suit off the hanger. Roger let out a low, throaty whine and dropped his head—as if he already knew he'd be left alone.

A horn blared outside. Sliding his .38 into his shoulder holster, Ryker called, "I'm coming!" Smythe honked again, Ryker reached down, grabbing Roger's head in his hands and gave him a kiss on the head.

"Be good, buddy. See you at dinner. Go chase the

squirrels.” He turned on the TV, and walked out, locking the door behind him.

“What the fuck’s wrong with you? It’s Sunday—people are sleeping, or trying to.” He muttered, “Idiot.” His jaw flexed, then he turned away with a slow exhale through his nose.

“Listen Smythe, last night I got a call from the chief. This is priority one. He said get ready for an earthquake, wants answers before sundown. *‘Don’t get beat by the press,’* like that’s even possible. We’re going to have rabbis and other interfaith leaders demanding answers. The news’ll probably paint this as a serial murder, because of St. Augustine just down the street. It’s been a little over a year—find out where the fuck Johnson and Riley are with it.”

The Chief’s words still rang: “*Community’s on edge. I want answers before sundown.*” Ryker had been around long enough to know what that meant—skip the line, cut the red tape, move now.

“Gotcha boss. I called Lucien Vega, the janitor who found the rabbi. Voicemail. He’s out of town till tomorrow morning. Fishing somewhere, no service. But the rabbi had a weekly book club with some temple members. Got the list. Figured we could start there while we wait for Vega.”

“Good work.” Ryker’s tone was flat but approving.

“You think Vega might be the perp and skipped town?”

“It’s possible, but that’d point a finger right at him. You got the make and model of his car?”

“Yep, right here.”

“BOLO him—for questioning only, not a suspect. I doubt he’d be stupid enough to find the body, make the 911 call himself, and then take off.”

Smythe nodded, jotting it down as if he’d just been handed the keys to the case.

“Will do, Boss.”

I got the ME to rush his report,” Smythe said. “Finished it late last night—pissed that I called. Already posted it. Guess he’s used to sleeping in... cush job.”

“What time did you call him?”

“After my run. About six.”

“Jesus, Smythe—it’s Sunday. Normal people sleep in.”

Smythe proudly said, “Five-thirty run. Every day. That’s the key.”

He handed over a gray manila folder. “Here, I printed it for you.”

“Radio in the BOLO while I read this.”

Ryker slid the top page free, scanning as Smythe waited.

“Reads like a manual for efficient killing,” he said. “ME says the rabbi took a hit to the right side of the neck—the *yad* through the jugular, into the skull base, clipping the brainstem. Left-handed perp—came in from behind and to the right. Dropped hard, smacking the back of his head—the scalp wound bled like hell, adding to the pool we saw. No defensive wounds—either restrained or never saw it coming. Probably stayed conscious long enough to see whatever was on that wall.”

He stopped, finger resting on the page.

“Eyes locked in death—cadaveric spasm fixing them on the wall. Victim placed cruciform...”

Ryker looked up.

“Or he just fell that way,” he said. “Guy drops straight back—arms go out. Doesn’t mean someone posed him.”

He glanced back down.

“ME’s calling it personal.”

Smythe whistled softly. “No kidding. Think Vega’s left-handed?”

“We’ll find out soon,” Ryker said. “One way or the other.”

**LOS ANGELES COUNTY DEPARTMENT OF
MEDICAL EXAMINER—CORONER**

Preliminary Autopsy Summary – Homicide

Case #: 2025-04783-H

Decedent: Shapiro, Aaron Joshua

DOB / Age: 04-17-1956 / 69 years

Date of Death: 10-11-2025

Time of Death: 17:00-20:00

Location of Death: Temple Beit Or HaOlam, 50431
Wilshire Blvd, Los Angeles, CA 90029

Examiner: Thomas L. Carlucci, M.D.

Cause of Death:

Penetrating neck wound (right side) with vascular injury and penetration into brainstem; contributory blunt-force trauma to the occiput sustained during collapse.

Manner: Homicide.

Key Findings:

- Weapon: silver Torah pointer (“yad”), 10 in. length, tapered point shaped like a finger; recovered from wound channel (by Detective Franklin Ryker).
- Primary injury: entry ~4 cm below jawline, 2 cm behind front of right neck muscle.
- Path: through right internal jugular vein → into base of skull via foramen magnum → laceration of medulla oblongata.
- Secondary injury: occipital scalp laceration and underlying contusion from contact with hard surface during collapse; significant external bleeding consistent with scalp wound’s vascularity.
- Angle of penetration suggests left-handed assailant, striking from victim’s right-rear.
- No defensive injuries — likely restrained, surprised, or positioned at time of attack.
- Estimated time of death — 1700–2000 hours. Estimate is based on body temperature, rigor mortis stage, and fixed lividity. Indoor ambient temperature and clothing may have likely delayed cooling, increasing uncertainty. Final estimate pending laboratory analysis (vitreous potassium, gastric contents).

- Victim placed *cruciform* (arms out) facing ark and wall with markings.
- One of two large silver candlesticks on nearby table found overturned on carpet; no visible bloodstaining. Origin of displacement undetermined.
- Red liquid consistent with sacramental wine observed on adjacent rug beneath sanctuary table; no visible blood admixture. Spill pattern non-directional. Origin and timing undetermined.
- Markings resembling symbols, finger-drawn in suspected blood, present on north wall of sanctuary, within direct line of sight from victim's position. Significance undetermined.
- Estimated survival after primary injury: 45–90 seconds, with probable visual awareness during part of that time.
- Cadaveric spasm noted — facial muscles locked, eyes wide open, gaze fixed toward wall.
- No alcohol or drugs detected.

ME Observations:

- Positioning, weapon choice, and wall markings may have symbolic/religious significance.
- Victim likely saw wall markings during final moments; head impact occurred upon collapse, producing additional blood pooling near head.
- No signs of prolonged struggle, vandalism classification deferred to law enforcement.

Ryker slid the summary back into the folder with the full report and photos. “Thanks for printing all this out. I’ll read it all later. Let’s start working through your Book Club list.”

“I was only able to get hold of three, so far. Most went right to voicemail.”

“Okay, but first, coffee—Wake Up Café drive-thru—block ahead, on the right.”

Twenty minutes later, they parked in front of a sprawling,

single-story home with a beautifully manicured lawn—hydrangeas and lilies bordering a path of used brick that led to the front door.

“Mr. Dayan?”

“Yeah, that’s me. You can call me Lenny—everyone does.”

“Okay, Lenny. I’m Detective Smythe, and this is Lieutenant Inspector Ryker. We spoke on the phone this morning.”

“Yeah, you called early. I usually sleep in on Sundays.”

Ryker jumped in. “I apologize, Mr. Dayan. Given the nature of this horrible incident, we wanted to try to meet with anyone who may have important information regarding Rabbi Shapiro. People’s memories tend to fade, so Detective Smythe and I want to try to speak with important potential witnesses like yourself, as quickly as we can. We apologize for the inconvenience and interruption to your Sunday, but we really appreciate your valuable time this morning.”

Smythe nodded and winked an appreciative thank you to Ryker.

“Sure, no problem. I didn’t even know Rabbi Shapiro’d been murdered until you called. That’s horrible. How can I help?”

“What can I tell you?”

Smythe pulled out his pad and pencil, and took over the questioning. “We understand you’re in a weekly book club with the rabbi and other temple members.”

“Yeah. Been a member for a little over a month. I joined thinking maybe I’d meet someone. Turns out only a few aren’t married, but you can see why. Others are married, retired, or both. Not sure I’ll stick with it—reading a book a week’s a lot when you’ve got a day job... guess none of us will be continuing now.”

“We wanted to ask if you know anyone who might’ve had a beef with the rabbi. Anyone he didn’t get along with?”

“Gold.”

“I’m sorry? Gold?”

“Sorry, I should’ve said ‘Dr. Gold.’ He makes sure everyone knows he’s *a* doctor. But, between you and me, I think Ph.D. stands for ‘phony doctor.’ I mean sure, I guess he’s some famous psychologist or psychiatrist. But if I had a heart attack, I’d rather

have a real doctor than a shrink, right?”

“Yeah, makes sense. So why Dr. Gold? What do you know about their relationship?”

“Gold’s always challenging Rabbi Shapiro, on every book we read. A lot of the books are over everyone’s head, except for Gold, Rabbi Shapiro, and David Friedman, some college professor.”

“What exactly do you mean when you say Dr. Gold ‘challenges’ the rabbi? Can you give me an example?”

“Sure they really got into it last week, Gold wanted to read some anti-God book and Rabbi Shapiro got all bent out of shape. They argued, and then Gold went off on Rabbi Shapiro about his dad—and some girl who’d been raped...”

Ryker asked, “I’m sorry, whose dad?”

“Gold’s dad. Family was founding members of the temple. Gold’s dad died a couple years ago and Gold’s had it in for Rabbi Shapiro ever since.”

“‘Had it in for him,’ in what way?”

“Not sure. Last week they were quoting the bible or something. Gold’s pissed, says something about death—then it sounded like he accused Rabbi Shapiro of raping a teenager. They squared off, and I was waiting to see who’d swing first.”

Smythe asked, “Who did?”

“Neither. They just stared each other down, but Gold chickened out. TKO, I guess.”

“Anything else or any other incidents you recall?”

“No. That was it. They’re both always real snotty to each other. Gold just left. I’d been wondering what this week’s club was going to be like. But now... hey, you guys think Gold’s the murderer? How’d he do it?”

“No, we are just interested in speaking with everyone in the book club... including Dr. Gold. We can’t share any details of the incident. It’s an ongoing investigation.”

“Yeah, I get it. I watch *NCIS* and *FBI*—it never happens that fast in real life, does it? Be nice if you could solve crimes in sixty minutes.”

“Yes, but you’re right. It doesn’t happen like that.”

Detective Ryker handed Lenny his business card. “Thank you again for your time. You’ve been very helpful. If you think of anything else, that might be helpful, please call us at this number.”

“Sure thing.”

As they were leaving Ryker turned and asked, “By the way, what book are you reading this week?”

“A couple of people wanted a break from religious books, so we picked a James Patterson thriller—this one. Since I was up early, I started it. It’s pretty good.”

“Thanks again, Lenny.”

Buckling their seat belts Ryker said “You see that?”

“See what?”

“The book. Remind me how you made detective?”

“I’m just not a book club kind of guy.”

“James Patterson—*Deadly Cross*.”

“Jesus—like the rabbi was laid out?”

Ryker stared out the windshield a moment.

“I don’t know if it’s just a coincidence... or a breadcrumb. Guess we’ve got ourselves a nighttime reading assignment.

Smythe rolled his eyes.

“Who’s next on the list? I want to hear more about this fight... and Gold.”

“Laura Sharabi—she lives two blocks away.”

They pulled away, the car settling into a quiet hum. Another name on Smythe’s list, another door to knock on. Ryker kept his eyes forward, imagining the book club fight in his head.

“Thank you for meeting with us, Mrs. Sharabi.”

“Miss. I’m not married.” She smiled, eyes lifting to Ryker. “Please—call me Laura.”

Ryker said, “We’re sorry to bother you so early on a Sunday, Miss Sharabi.”

“Please, Laura.”

“Of course, Laura,” he said.

She smiled at Ryker. “I just can’t believe it. I saw Rabbi Shapiro last night at the Havdalah service.”

Smythe looked puzzled and asked, “Havdalah?”

Ryker said, “That’s the afternoon service that marks the end of the Sabbath on Saturday.”

She inched closer to Ryker. “Are you Jewish, Detective...?”

“Ryker.”

She gently tugged a strand of hair along her neck, curling it around her finger. “Would you gentlemen like to come in, maybe sit down and have a little something to eat?”

Ryker smiled politely. “No, thank you. We just need a minute of your time. My wife’s Jewish,” he added, a little awkwardly. “That’s how I know about the service.”

Her gaze began to drop toward his hand. He’d already tucked it into his pocket. “Oh. I see,” she said, her face soured, disappointed.

“Do you know of anyone who might have had a problem with the rabbi?” Ryker asked. “Anyone he didn’t get along with?”

“No. Everyone loved Rabbi Shapiro. He’s been the head rabbi for over thirty years.”

“Alright. Thank you for your time. If you think of anything, please call Detective Smythe—he’ll give you his card.”

Ryker turned and began to walk away when she added, “Actually... there was something—just a few days ago at the book club.”

He stopped and turned back. “Yes?”

“Well, there always seemed to be tension between Rabbi Shapiro and Dr. Gold. They both called each other by their first names, neither used the other’s title. Some people thought it was because they were close, but I always sensed they didn’t like each other.

“Anyway, at the last meeting, Dr. Gold and Rabbi Shapiro got into an argument. At first I thought it was over the book, but it seemed personal. For a minute, I thought they might actually hit each

other.”

Smythe jotted notes. “Really? Do you recall anything specific?”

“Well, I was shocked. Dr. Gold’s exact words. It’s embarrassing. Pardon my French, but he said, ‘Fuck you—and fuck your God.’”

Walking back to the car, Smythe smirked. “Seemed a little nervous there, Boss. And I noticed you didn’t say ‘ex-wife.’”

“You’re right,” Ryker said, stone-faced.

“And my card, not yours—that’s a first. Hmm...” Smythe laughed.

“Shut up.” But the corners of Ryker’s mouth twitched despite himself.

“How far to Gold’s house?”

“About three miles, but he’s number six on the list.”

Ryker closed the folder. “Well... he just moved to the top of our list.”

CHAPTER THIRTY-FIVE

Josef K

Someone must have been telling lies about Josef K., for without having done anything wrong he was arrested one fine morning.

— Franz Kafka, *The Trial* (1925)

The neurotic's problem is not that he feels too much guilt, but that he feels guilt for the wrong things.

— Karen Horney, *Our Inner Conflicts* (1945)

I cannot make you understand. I cannot make anyone understand what is happening inside me. I cannot even explain it to myself.

— Franz Kafka, *The Trial* (1925)

Sunday, midmorning

WIND CHIME ALERT

RING CHIME

The doorbell shattered the fragile stillness of *Spiegel im Spiegel*—like a mirror cracking in silence.

Gold flinched, pulse quickening

Odd—an undercurrent of dread, a lump rising in the back of my throat.

RING CHIME

Again—a hammer blow; harsh and insistent.

Rachel jolted upright; hot tea sloshed across the kitchen table.

“Rach—careful, you’ll burn yourself.”

He snatched napkins, blotting the spill before it reached her lap. She trembled—violently.

RING CHIME

“Who could that be on a Sunday morning?”

“I’ll get it,” Gold said, pushing back his chair.

“Don’t you want to check the camera? I’m scared.”

Fuck—she was just starting to relax.

From the hallway he called back, “Probably just a delivery—Amazon or something.”

Something was wrong.

RING CHIME

“Jesus—coming!”

Gold opened the door. A uniformed LAPD officer stood on the stoop, stepping aside to reveal two plainclothes detectives, the badges on their belts caught the light.

Must be here about Shapiro.

“Can I help you, officers? Is this about Rabbi Shapiro?”

Ryker—shifted Smythe aside with a glance. His eyes fixed on Gold, searching his face for tells.

“Are you Dr. Steven Gold?”

“Yes.”

“I’m Detective Ryker, LAPD Homicide. This is Detective Smythe. Mind if we come in for a few—”

He stopped when Smythe craned his neck past Gold into the house.

Smythe asked, “You mentioned the Rabbi Shapiro murder—that hasn’t even hit the news. How’d you know?”

Ryker’s voice hardened. “Hang on, Smythe.” He turned back to Gold. “Mind if we come in, Doctor?”

“Sure. I’m not under suspicion, am I?”

Smythe smirked. “Should you be? Kind of suspicious—something that isn’t public yet. Want to tell us how you ‘just happen’ to know?” His head tilted, eyes narrowing. “You knew the rabbi pretty well, right? Temple book club?”

The little one already thinks I’m guilty.

Ryker snapped, “Smythe.” They stepped inside; the uniformed officer stayed outside on the porch.

“Hang on a second,” Gold said.

Smythe pounced. “Second thoughts, Doctor? Something you need to tidy up first?”

“Yes,” Gold said, irritation edging his voice. “My wife and I were having breakfast when you barged in—she’s not dressed for company.”

Smythe muttered, just loud enough for Gold to hear: “Breakfast— that’s what he calls it.”

Ryker shot him a warning look. “Cool it, Smythe.”

If they weren’t police, I’d throw them out.

“Steven? Was someone at the door?” Rachel’s voice floated in, rising as she stepped into the hallway.

This might calm her —knowing the police are on it so fast.

Smythe craned forward again, nosing into their hallway.

Pushy little bastard.

“Wait—Rach! Get dressed,” Gold barked. “The police are here—they have questions.”

Rachel froze—two men in the entryway, the younger one’s head bobbed side to side, eyes hungry for a glimpse. She gasped and folded inward, one arm crossing her chest, the other hand darting down.

Smythe’s smile sharpened. “We’ll need to speak with her too.”

Little shit.

“The police? Oh God...” Rachel whispered.

Gold bristled. “She’ll get dressed first—if you don’t mind. She’s still in pajamas. We weren’t expecting guests.”

Ryker inclined his head politely. “Of course. Our apologies for intruding. We just have a few questions. People’s memories fade quickly—as a psychologist, you know that better than most.”

Smythe angled toward her, his voice oily. “She sounds worried, Doctor. Everything all right here?” Gold ignored him, eyes

on Rachel. “Go get dressed, Rach—then come join us in the living room.”

“Actually,” Gold added, turning back to Ryker, “I think you mean the *Dunning-Kruger* effect—people overestimate their accuracy, fill in blanks—”

Ryker nodded. “Exactly.”

“That’s why eye-witness accounts are often unreliable, unless interviews happen quickly. But we didn’t witness Rabbi Shapiro’s murder.”

“We’re not saying you did—we’re just trying to learn more about the rabbi, his friends and—”

Smythe cut in again. “And his enemies.”

What’s with this guy?

They stepped into the living room—minimalist, unapologetically high-end, a quiet but unmistakable statement of success. An eight-foot espresso leather sofa—softened by two muted Hermès pillows—anchored the room behind a smoked-glass table. Flanking it, two B&B Italia chairs in muted fabric echoed the pale oak floors. A Flos Arco lamp arched overhead, its brass stem casting warm light onto a Lalique crystal bowl—deliberately empty. A ten-foot Peter Burega oil dominated the wall—expressive blues and greens with rare flashes of crimson that drew the eye to each delicate brush stroke.

On a Holly Hunt side table stood one of Rachel’s bronzes—a beautiful ballerina in a thin chemise, hair pinned high to reveal the delicate architecture of her face. Perfect. Lifelike. Yet, on closer inspection—sorrowful.

Sixteen-foot ceilings crossed by bleached-oak beams lent the room a cathedral-like openness. Above the Stuv fireplace hung Rachel’s oil: a storm gathering over a tranquil lake, the sky bruised and pressing low. Somber grays, slate, violet-black—beautiful, dense with the stillness of grief. Like his office, the space both revealed and concealed—the storm was hers, yet could just as easily have been his.

Ryker settled on one side of the sofa, crossing a long leg carefully to avoid scuffing the coffee table with his Cole Haan

Oxfords. His gray fedora and pinstripes lent him old-world gravitas, as though he'd stepped from a black-and-white newsreel. He placed a business card on the coffee table.

Smythe, stocky and restless, dropped onto the opposite end of the sofa. He shifted constantly, his broad shoulders filling the room, his eyes darting like a terrier on the hunt.

Gold perched, on one of the lounge chairs—clearly uncomfortable.

“I’d offer you something to drink,”—he glared at Smythe—“but you won’t be staying long.”

“Sorry, Dr. Gold. Bad time?” Ryker asked.

“Do we make you nervous?” Smythe added.

“Nervous? No.”

Fine. Give it to him.

“Annoyed, yes—probably like your partner and everyone else forced to babysit you.”

Smythe shrank back a couple inches.

Ryker tried to hold back a smile, but amusement slipped through—clearly in agreement.

“Dr. Gold, I’m sorry to disturb you this morning, but I am curious—why you assumed we’d be here about the Rabbi, and how you already knew he’d been murdered.”

“My wife got a call earlier this morning—from the Rabbi’s wife’s best friend. They’re very close. She called about twenty minutes ago...” Rachel entered, having pulled on sweatpants, Gold’s shirt knotted at her waist.

“...just before you arrived.”

“Sorry—did I miss anything important?” she asked.

“Detectives—this is my wife, Rachel Gold.”

Both detectives rose; Ryker removed his hat as they introduced themselves.

Rachel took the facing chair across the coffee table.

Ryker sat again, placing his fedora beside him on the couch.

“Sorry to trouble you, Mrs. Gold—and for your loss. A terrible tragedy. We’ll get to the bottom of it.”

Gold shot Smythe a look of quiet disdain—the detective’s eyes lingered on Rachel a little too long.

I really don’t like this guy.

Rachel said, “Detective Ryker, I heard Rabbi Shapiro was posed like Jesus on the cross. Was he...” Her breath caught; she pulled a tissue from her pocket, dabbing carefully to save her mascara. “... tortured?”

“I’m sorry Mrs. Gold, I can’t share details about the crime scene. It’s an active investigation, and some facts need to stay confidential. There’ll be a public statement later this morning.”

“Do you think it was antisemitic—a hate crime?”

“We’re investigating all possibilities. Given the religious elements, we’ve brought in a Hate Crimes consultant to assist on the case.”

“Was there any...”

Gold glanced at his watch. “Rach, let’s let the detectives ask their questions—help them do their job.”

Smythe’s already written the verdict.

She nodded. “I’m sorry.” She sat back, dabbing at her nose with a tissue.

Smythe’s gaze dropped to Gold’s wrist. “You wear your watch on the right, Doctor—left handed?”

He answered coolly. “Yes. Not a crime, is it?”

Ryker cut in, “Of course not. Detective Smythe was just saying he wanted to get an Apple Watch.

“Mrs. Gold—there’s something on your sleeve... looks like blood. Did you cut yourself?”

“No, I didn’t.”

“Would you mind rolling down your sleeves?”

Rachel unrolled both sleeves. Red splotches bloomed across the fabric. Her face drained. She turned sharply. “Steven?”

What the hell?

“That’s my shirt she’s wearing, Detective.”

“Thought it looked like a man’s shirt. Dr. Gold, did you cut yourself recently? You’re in a T-shirt—no cuts or injuries I can see on your arms, hands or wrists.”

Gold raised his arms, palms up, turning them slowly—no injuries.

“No. No cuts, no injuries,” he said flatly.

Smythe asked, his tone thick with sarcasm, “Any idea whose blood that might be, then?”

Ryker said gently, “Mrs. Gold, would you mind changing into a clean shirt and letting us take that one—voluntarily, of course, just to rule things out.”

She looked to Gold—confused, scared.

“If you’d rather not, that’s your right—but it could help us clear this faster.”

Steven nodded. “It’s fine, Rach. Just change—let them take it.”

Blood on my hands—again.

“Careful taking it off, Mrs. Gold—we wouldn’t want anything spilling on it.”

“Smythe!” Ryker snapped. “I’m sorry, Mrs. Gold. We’ll get you an evidence bag—just place the shirt inside and seal it.”

“Steven?” She looked over, fear painted across her face.

“It’s okay, Rach—I didn’t do anything.”

Rachel disappeared down the hall.

Ryker asked, “Dr. Gold, you said you were home all evening—anyone who can confirm that?”

“My wife and I were home—we went to bed early.”

Smythe said, “Funny thing—we’ve got reports from a few temple congregants. Someone about your height and build was seen entering the sanctuary after services, head down like he was avoiding the cameras. Sound familiar?”

Shit—Light. My height, but darker hair—and no beard.

“No—it doesn’t.”

Ryker said, “None of them got a good look at his face, but each described someone with your build—between 6:15 and 7:00. Where were you then?”

“I’d finished with a patient earlier that day, then headed home from my office. I walk past the temple on the way—maybe someone saw me at the corner, waiting for the light on Wilshire. After that, I didn’t leave.”

“Didn’t say you did—just asking. We’re pulling your office building’s security footage tonight and canvassing neighbors for doorbell cams.”

“Good. That’ll prove I’m telling the truth.”

Smythe said, “Well, we’ll know soon enough.”

He’s enjoying this.

Ryker leaned forward, exhaling slowly, patience thinning. “Dr. Gold... anything you want to tell us before this becomes something else?”

“Sounds like I’m being accused. Am I a suspect—or charged with anything?”

Smythe kept his tone even. “Everyone’s a suspect—some just reek of it more than others.”

In over my head. This guy’s out to get me.

“I think I’d like my lawyer.”

“Thought so.” Smythe almost sounded pleased.

Ryker sighed; Smythe didn’t bother hiding his satisfaction.

“Smythe—get Officer Young.”

Ryker stood. “Dr. Gold, you’re under arrest on suspicion of murder in connection with the death of Rabbi Aaron Shapiro.”

Gold stood motionless.

Behind him, Rachel gasped—the evidence bag dropped from her grip.

The morning's dream curdled into nightmare.

"You have the right to remain silent. Anything you say can and will be used against you in a court of law..."

Rachel began to sob. "Steven—Steven."

Seeing her like this... this guilt is more than I can bear.

"It's okay, Rach—I didn't do anything."

But how did the blood get on my sleeves? When Light hugged me? Did he plan this? What am I saying?

Odd—I'm not nervous. Just curious.

But Rachel's terrified. Does she think I'd kill Shapiro?

Officer Young stepped forward. The cuffs bit cold and tight, wrenching Gold's arms until his shoulders burned.

I can't have them torturing her with questions.

As they led him toward the door, he looked back at Rachel—urgent, commanding: "I'll call Kramer—he'll send someone from the firm. Don't say a word."

Smythe pushed him from behind—out the door.

"I'm innocent—but words get twisted. Stay quiet, understand? Don't talk to anyone."

Shit, that might make her think I'm guilty. Maybe I should call Light—Legion Law, criminal defense. Said he specialized in wrongful convictions.

But what if it was Light? He's delusional—hates religion. That's not a crime.

They shoved Gold into the squad car—his head clipped the doorframe before it slammed shut.

No handles. Caged.

Rachel's collapsing, hands trembling at her sides.

Neighbors filled their doorways, manicured lawns turning into front-row seats.

It was.

He's my height, my weight. He threatened Shapiro. He was there. If he did it—if he framed me—he won't defend me. He'll let them convict me.

He wouldn't kill Shapiro. His story was just that—a story. Issues with his father... who doesn't have them?

His religious delusions—did he see Rabbi Shapiro as his father?

The St. Augustine priest—last year?

I'm innocent. Let the system work.

As Smythe slid into the front seat, Gold heard the iPhone's wind chime alert—muffled inside Smythe's jacket. Smythe pulled out the phone and studied Rachel's photo—Gold's lock screen. He grinned. "Won't be home for dinner, honey." He puckered a mock kiss. The alert chimed again—soft, chaotic, deliberate.

Smythe's convinced I'm guilty—but I know I'm innocent. I don't think Rachel does.

What was it the priest said in 'The Trial'— "The right understanding of any matter and a misunderstanding of the same matter do not wholly exclude each other."

CHAPTER THIRTY-SIX

Some Cells Don't Have Bars

I am free and that is why I am lost.

— Franz Kafka, *The Zürau Aphorisms* (written 1917–1918, published 1931)

Sunday, midday

The holding area's walls screamed NO SMOKING, yet the air reeked of cigarettes, bleach, and stale coffee.

AC vents hummed. Harsh white LEDs glared overhead.

Gnats buzzing inside my skull. A migraine building.

"Empty your pockets," the booking officer said, voice flat.

Gold set his keys on the steel counter.

The officer slid them toward a plastic tub without looking up.

"Detective Smythe already has my phone," Gold said.

He stared at the screen saver—Rachel.

The officer gave no sign he'd heard.

"Belt." The word cracked like a command.

Gold gestured at the drawstring on his sweats.

The officer glanced, unfazed. "Belt."

Gold tugged the drawstring free and dropped it on the counter. His sweats sagged—he caught them with one hand.

"Shoes."

"Officer, my pants won't stay up without the drawstring."

"Won't be a problem. You're changing anyway." The officer dropped a folded set of gray county-issue pants, shirt, and thin white briefs on the counter.

"You want me to change here?"

“Search room. Let’s go.”

The cinderblock search room was small, cold, and painted a sickly green. Another officer waited inside—gloved, impassive.

“All clothing,” the second officer said.

Gold hesitated. “Even—”

“Everything.”

This is their job.

He stripped down, the concrete floor biting cold under his feet. His underwear dropped into the property bag with everything else.

“Open your mouth. Lift your tongue.”

He obeyed.

“Arms out. Turn. Bend. Spread. Cough.”

Humiliation seared.

“Put these on.”

The briefs were stiff and a size too small. The pants hung loose, cinched only by elastic. The shirt smelled foul—someone else’s sweat mixed with industrial detergent.

“Glasses.” The word clipped like a blade.

Robotic. Guess you have to be.

“I need them to see.”

“You’ll get them back after photos.”

“Ring.” Harder than a blow.

Gold froze.

I’ve never removed it, not even for surgeries.

“It’s my wedding ring,” he said, softer than he intended. “I’ve never removed it—not since I put it on.”

“Touching,” the officer said, holding out a gloved palm. “Everything comes off. It’ll be inventoried and returned when you’re released.”

One more plea.

“But I’ve never—”

“Everything.”

Gold lifted his hand to his mouth, holding the ring to his lips. The metal was cold—as if it, too, were afraid. He kissed it gently and whispered, “Forgive me, Rach.”

He lowered his hand and twisted the band, feeling the groove it had carved over decades. It had always been loose—just never off his finger.

Can't really blame them. Nothing personal.

A visceral jolt. He hesitated, turning it over the last joint, peeking at the engraving—Our love exceeds infinity...—before forcing it free. For a moment it felt foreign in his hand, almost not his, before he dropped it into the officer’s palm. The engraving drowned in shadow.

A promise. A life. Gone.

Alone. Now I really am alone.

The officer tossed it into the plastic bag with his keys. It made a small, bright sound—too final.

Rachel.

I'm sorry.

“Stand on that line. Face forward.”

Flash.

“Turn to your left.”

Flash.

“Turn to your right.”

Flash.

The flashes weren’t bright, but felt eerily familiar—like déjà vu with a sentence attached.

The day blurred, a fast slide show.

Before being transferred to the Men’s Central Jail, downtown, Gold was told he could make three calls—his attorney, a bail bondsman, and a family member or friend.

The handset was cold, slick with someone else's sweat.

First call: Legion Law—to reach Light.

He closed his eyes, pressing the plastic receiver harder against his ear.

As it rang:

Shit. Sunday.

Still... they're criminal law. Someone will be there.

A flat, mechanical voice: "You have a call from an inmate at Los Angeles County Jail. This call is subject to monitoring and recording. To accept, press one."

One long tone. "Legion Law, Darryl Davis speaking."

"Hello, Darryl. This is Dr. Steven Gold. I need Samuel Light—it's urgent. Can you connect me?"

"I'm sorry, this is Legion Law, attorneys at law."

"Yes—Samuel Light, please. He's one of your lawyers."

"I'm sorry, we don't have a Samuel Light here. No—he's not one of our attorneys. Are you sure he's with Legion Law?"

"He transferred from back east, just a week or two ago."

"Maybe he's with another firm. You can check the State Bar site."

"I can't... not right now. I'm calling from jail."

"Hold on, I'll check for you."

Keyboard clicks over the line, then: "No. I'm sorry. No Samuel Light on the State Bar's site."

"Try S-a-m-a-e-l Light?"

"No. Neither Samuel or Samael. Are you sure he's an attorney? We have plenty of highly qualified lawyers here. If you tell me what's going on, I can recommend someone."

"This will sound insane—but... try searching for *Satan*."

"I was trying to help you—that's not funny. Goodbye."

The line went dead.

What the fuck? Was I being set up?

Call Rachel.

A flat, mechanical voice: “You have a call from an inmate at Los Angeles County Jail. This call is subject to monitoring and recording. To accept, press one.”

One long tone. Then Rachel’s voice—tentative, strained.

“Yes. I accept. Hello. Hello? Steven? Are you okay?”

Rachel was crying uncontrollably.

“I’m fine. You don’t need to worry. Please call Dennis Kramer and ask him to have one of his criminal attorneys come to get me out. He’ll know a bail bondsman and whatever else he needs to do.”

“Steven—the blood. I thought it was wine. What happened? Is it Rabbi Shapiro’s? Steven... what did you do?” She was inconsolable.

She thinks I killed him.

“Rach. I didn’t do anything. But they’re listening. I swear—I didn’t.”

“Call Kramer. Have him send someone down here to get me out.”

“Steven—it’s everywhere. Calls nonstop. Helicopter video—handcuffed, shoved into a police car. Every channel. Steven... I’m scared.”

“I’m sorry, Rach. I promise everything will be okay.”

“Deborah saw from her kitchen window. Kristen and Jill both called. But Steven—the blood? The blood—how did it get on your sleeves? They said it was Rabbi Shapiro’s. Steven, what did you do?”

She doesn’t believe me. Why should she? I don’t believe me. What explanation could there be?

“Rachel—don’t say a word. To anyone. I’ve got one more call—to Bob. You call Kramer. Promise me.”

“Okay, I promise.”

Shit. I sound guilty.

Am I guilty?

He hung up, then dialed Oldman.

A flat, mechanical voice: “You have a call from an inmate at Los Angeles County Jail. This call is subject to monitoring and recording. To accept, press one.”

“Hi, Dr. Bob Oldman here. Can’t take your call. Leave a message and I’ll get back—unless you’re a telemahketah.”

The line disconnected.

Shit.

The officer said, “That’s it. Three.”

“Please. He always screens his calls and wouldn’t recognize the number. But he’ll pick up on an immediate callback. Please.”

The officer held up three fingers.

He’s probably already on his flight.

“Three. Follow the blue line to the door.”

“Same number, please. He’ll pick up.”

The officer pointed to the blue line, heading down a short hallway.

Not his fault. But is it mine?

He clenched his eyes shut. The hum of AC, flicker of lights, clank of counters, phones, footsteps, shuffling papers—all of it vanished. The room’s din of fear and disappointment collapsed into silence.

Silence—like someone had pressed pause on his life.

I’m not afraid. I just feel bad for Rachel.

*Is this how Jesus felt—knowing the cross waited,
each step pulling him closer.*

Acceptance? Acquiescence?

What the hell am I saying?

I’m innocent.

The officer tapped his pen on the desk and pointed to the

blue line again. “Now.”

Is anyone ever truly innocent?

CHAPTER THIRTY-SEVEN

Haystacks

The search for a thing is always more precious than the thing itself.
— Jorge Luis Borges, *Labyrinths* (1962)

*He is still groping in the dark, searching for what is lost, while all the while
it is right in front of him.*
— Franz Kafka, *The Trial* (1925)

Where all think alike, no one thinks very much.
— Walter Lippmann, *Public Opinion* (1922)

The hardest thing to find is the thing we cannot name.
— Steven Gold, *Journal of Existential Psychodynamics* (Fall, 2026)

Sunday, midday

Exiting the back of the station, Ryker and Smythe crossed to their dark gray Dodge Charger in the secure lot. Ryker dropped his jacket and hat in back, slid into the passenger seat, file folder already in hand.

“You drive—I need to read this report.”

“Jesus!” Smythe yelped, jerking his hands off the searing wheel. “Hotter than fuck. Climate?”

“Climate,” Ryker chuckled, punching MAX A/C.

“Ninety-eight. I’m never leaving Redondo. Don’t care if it takes me an hour to get to the office. This is nuts.”

“Lucky we aren’t working Van Nuys. Ninety-eight’s nothing—probably still that at night. Bet it’s a hundred-twelve today.”

They adjusted their vents.

“We gotta roll. Chief ran it through the duty DA, judge stamped it fast. Still circumstantial—nowhere near enough for a filing, and he’s texted me twice already. Feels personal.”

BARK, BARK.

Ryker's phone barked.

Smythe jumped. "What the fuck?"

"That's my text tone for the Chief."

"Ha. That's great! He does look a little like a Doberman. He know that?"

"Yes and no. He's heard it, but no sense of humor."

Smythe muttered, "And you do?"

Ryker ignored him. "We came up together—he's not all bad. Bark's worse than his bite... unless the mayor or press lean on him. Then watch out."

Ryker glanced at the text.

"Good he's got Kontopoulos on this. My contact didn't recognize it."

"Kontopoulos?"

"Hate Crimes, top notch. Says he told her to drop everything and hop on this."

"You know her?"

"Met her once. Used to be FBI—field agent. I'll send her the pix. She might recognize them, or she'll know someone who will."

"Left the bureau for LAPD?"

"I think she wanted to stay in LA and have regular hours. Hang on let me text these. She's sharp."

"Ha. I'm sure she'll appreciate them on Sunday."

Ryker grunted, hit send, and flipped a page in the folder.

"Warrants are good. Office and temple video should hit tonight. Patrol's canvassing doorbells, but those won't trickle in till morning."

Smythe grunted. "So where first—home or office?"

"Home. If there was blood on his shirt, maybe some on his pants, shoes. I want eyes on it before anything moves. Office is locked—Reynolds is posted. Said there's a Ring camera on the

office door. We'll have to pull that."

Ryker scanned another sheet. "SID matched Gold's prints at the temple, but half the book club touched that *yad*. They're still working on the wall blood. One image guy—ex—Air Force targeting—says he can sharpen a few."

Smythe snorted. "When he's not zooming in on death or porn. Davis, right? Creeps me out."

"Whatever. Long as he delivers. I don't need another exam from the Chief." Ryker scrunched his nose. "Jesus, Smythe—what the hell did you eat?"

"Not me, Boss. SoCal Gas up ahead—I'll flag it."

"Make sure we get the janitor first thing in the morning. What time's he due back?"

"Due in at eight. Drives a 2004 Victory Red Chevy Astro Van—you can't miss it."

"No one can. Who the hell drives a red Astro Van?"

Ryker smirked. "Someone who doesn't care if he stands out."

"Or wants to? Hiding in plain sight?"

"Nah. Gold's our guy. Feels right."

"I grabbed the Lennox file. No leads, no writing on the walls—nothing like the temple. Riley says they're stuck. But that priest crucifixion—sick fuck, different MO."

As they passed the temple, Ryker said, "Slow down. I want a good look. He's only a few blocks away." He stared out the window. "What time did you really walk home, Doctor?"

Turning to Smythe: "When are we getting security footage from the office and temple? We need timestamps."

"Everyone says ASAP... so who knows."

"Office is locked, Reynolds is posted, so let's do the house first. Let him catch up on his sleep. With luck, video hits my inbox tonight. Doorbell canvass will take time."

"Boss, how you think Gold'll do in jail? Acts like his shit doesn't stink. He might be okay—till they transfer him downtown."

One night there, he'll need his own shrink."

Ryker clicked his lips. "If it was Monday, he'd be out on bail already. Until we get something hard, I don't know if a judge will hold him. But the way the Chief's pushing, who knows. Feels personal."

"Is the Chief Jewish?"

"Yeah, Smythe—his father was a rabbi. Rabbi McClosky!"

Smythe flushed. "I don't know, maybe his wife is... like yours."

"Ex-wife. No, I don't know what the deal is. But there is something."

Pulling up to the house, Ryker spotted SUVs and a van he recognized as SID. "So it'd probably take fifteen, twenty minutes to walk here from the temple."

BARK, BARK.

Smythe chuckled. "Dobie?"

Ryker shook his head disapprovingly. "Shhh, this one's the Chief calling. You head on in—I'll catch up."

Smythe shrugged, got out, and walked toward the house.

Ryker answered. "Ryker."

"Frank. I know you're doing your best, but any updates? Where do we stand?"

"Gold's processed, arraignment's set for tomorrow, two pm. Waiting on office and temple video—probably tonight. Patrol's checking neighbors' doorbells. SID's already at his house. Then Smythe and I hit the office—Reynolds is there."

"But Frank, why the fast lane? Feels like someone's riding the throttle."

"Mike, I'm only telling you because we've got history. This stays between us—I'm not on speaker, right?"

"No."

"Carol and I have been seeing Gold. Couple months now."

Ryker blinked. "Your wife?"

“Yeah. Marriage stuff. Nothing unusual, but... he’s good. Carol likes him. That’s why I’m telling you—I just don’t see him as our guy. Holier-than-thou, sure, but he knows his stuff.”

“Understood. Shit, maybe Joan and I could’ve worked things out if we’d seen a shrink... uh, psychologist.”

“Yeah. Look, I’m not saying sit on anything—I want this killer caught. But don’t give Gold the treatment. I asked they hold him here, not downtown. County would chew him up. I’m hoping something turns up that clears him.”

Ryker exhaled through his teeth, unsure whether to pity or distrust the man.

“Fair enough. If he’s clean, the video will show it and we can send him home.”

The front door stood ajar, SID tape stretched across the entry like a warning flag. Ryker stepped inside, cool air laced with the tang of bleach and something metallic—already disturbed, already catalogued.

It smelled like guilt scrubbed clean. He scanned the sterile activity—gloves snapping, bags sealing, muttered chain-of-custody numbers called out in monotone. Every move deliberate, procedural. Gold’s life being dismantled into plastic sleeves and paper tags.

“Looking for a fucking needle,” Ryker grumbled. “Smythe!” he shouted out.

Smythe, wearing blue gloves, was about to walk upstairs. He’d been waiting while an SID tech in pale coveralls finished shining a blacklight wand on the carpeted runner.

“Yeah, Boss. Just about to head upstairs and check the bedroom.”

Another tech worked the living room. Crouched by the sofa, he looked along the baseboards, clicking shots on his DSLR.

“Hey Ryker.” A third tech—Martinez, badge clipped to his collar—looked up from a kit spread across the dining table. Swabs, evidence bags, sterile vials lined up in neat rows. “We’re logging trace. Nothing obvious yet. But laundry room had folded pants, socks, and underwear. Looks like someone tried to help out the suspect.”

“Suspect,” Ryker corrected, his mouth twitching slightly at the corner. “She still here, Mrs. Gold?”

“Nah, she said she was going to a neighbor’s house. She looked pretty shook up. I hate having them around anyway.”

Upstairs, Martinez and two SID techs worked the bedroom. Flash after flash lit the hallway.

Ryker scanned the dresser in Gold’s closet. A black leather desk caddy held keys, a thin Tyvek wallet, folded cash. Above, a cabinet stacked with watch boxes—Rolex, Cartier, Audemars Piguet, Panerai. Three eyeglasses cases—two bifocals, one sunglasses.

He opened the top drawer—an unlocked jewelry drawer. Inside, some chains, cuff links, tuxedo studs, and a couple gold and silver rings. There was something tucked at the back, intentionally hidden, barely visible.

“Martinez, come shoot this drawer before I see what this is.”

Martinez snapped half a dozen shots, different angles of the cabinet and drawer. “There you go.”

Ryker reached back and grabbed the paper. Slowly unfolded it.

A Cartier receipt. Earrings. Nothing.

He dropped it back into the drawer and shut it. “Keep moving,” he muttered.

In the laundry room off the kitchen, another SID tech crouched by the open washer. A pair of dark slacks hung half-out of the drum, still damp at the seams.

“Detective,” the tech called. “You’ll want a look at this.”

Ryker joined him, arms crossed. The tech lifted the pants with gloved hands, draping them across a white evidence sheet.

“Guess someone cleaned up after we took Gold,” Ryker muttered.

“They were only run through once. Still smell of Tide. But look here—” He flicked on a portable UV lamp. The fabric lit faintly, threads glowing except for several dull, irregular patches along the cuff and thigh.

Smythe leaned in. “That blood?”

“Not visible to the naked eye. Could be detergent residue, could be hemoglobin. Hard to say in the field.”

Ryker stared at the shadowed patches. “Bag it. Lab will know. SID will hit it with luminol back at the lab.”

The tech said, “I didn’t see any bleach in the laundry room, so if there was any blood, it’ll still pop.” He slid the pants into an evidence sack, sealed it, and marked the label: Residence—Laundry / Slacks, Possible Blood Trace.

“Bag the socks and underwear too.” Inside Ryker’s chest, a tight knot coiled—evidence was piling up.

Ryker shrugged his shoulders and nodded. “Okay, upstairs—bedroom, closet,” he said. “Shoes, grab them all. Martinez, bring your wand. Check the closet. There was blood on his shirt—there’s bound to be more somewhere.”

Martinez grabbed his blacklight wand from the table. “On my way.” He muttered something in Spanish to the tech in the living room, pointed at the wet bar, then walked upstairs.

Ryker pulled a pair of blue gloves from his jacket, snapped them on, and followed him.

“Gold’s clients are athletes, celebs. High-end shit. Pays pretty good, listening to millionaires bitch about their wives. Guess I picked the wrong line of work.”

“Yeah Smythe. You’d be perfect—you’re so caring, nurturing. A real sensitive guy,” Ryker said with a smirk.

“Martinez, get a couple of your guys to really work the bedroom and closet. Smythe, see if there’s a home office up here anywhere.”

Martinez leaned over the bannister and shouted downstairs, “Rodriguez, you and Anders, bring a couple kits up here. Let’s get some photos right away.”

Flash.

A strobe burst from the hallway, echo lingering like lightning trapped indoors.

Flash, Flash, Flash.

Shutters as techs took photos of everything—the halls,

bedrooms, bathrooms, closets, sinks.

Flash, Flash, Flash.

It felt like a press conference.

Flash, Flash, Flash.

From deeper in the hall came a voice: "Ryker! You'll want to see this."

Ryker followed the sound into a smaller bedroom that had been repurposed into a home office. Anders stood at the desk, gloved hands hovering over an open notepad. On top, a single loose sheet lay across the page—unfolded, gouged deep with ink.

Ryker froze. The paper was stiff, creased from the fold, the marks carved rather than written.

$m \geq p$ မှာ p သည် ပုံမှန် ဖြစ်ပါက

Smythe craned over his shoulder. “Jesus Christ! Guess he’s not as smart as he thinks, Boss. Hard enough evidence for you, Mr. DA?”

Ryker blinked twice. “Bag it. Priority chain. SID.” His voice sounded flat, even to him.

Ryker's jaw tightened. He grabbed his iPhone and looked at the photos Jameson had sent.

The wall writing was cruder, smeared—but the symbols were unmistakably the same.

“Yeah. He’s our guy.

“What the hell does this say?”

The symbols stared back—mute, implacable, damning.

[illegible]

CHAPTER THIRTY-EIGHT

Violated

*“Villains!” I shrieked, “dissemble no more! I admit the deed!
Tear up the planks! Here, here!—It is the beating of his hideous heart!”*
— Edgar Allan Poe, *The Tell-Tale Heart* (1843)

What is discovered is never what was hidden—only what we feared would be.
— Czesław Miłosz, *The Witness of Poetry* (1983)

*“The mystery of human existence lies not in just staying alive, but in finding
something to live for.”*
— Fyodor Dostoevsky, *The Brothers Karamazov* (1880)

*You just call out my name
And you know wherever I am
I'll come running, oh yes I will, to see you again*
— Carole King, lyrics from “You’ve Got a Friend,” *Tapestry* (1971)

Sunday, midday

Rachel arrived home just as the final SID van pulled away. She’d spent the morning at Deborah’s—three doors down—avoiding the sight of strangers rifling through her life. From the kitchen window, Deborah and her husband, David, had watched Steven being led away in a squad car. Deborah had called immediately—no *schadenfreude*, no hint of glee, only sincere sympathy. David left for golf, insisting Rachel stay with Deborah until the police were gone.

She froze as the door clicked shut—the sound slamming in her head like a jail door. She felt violated—utterly alone. At first, the house looked untouched, but the threads of their life were already unraveling. She broke down sobbing.

Evidence of intrusion was everywhere—couch cushions crooked, paintings skewed. The silverware drawer hung half-shut, a single spoon catching light like an accusation. A gray smear of powder dulled the dining table—worse, somehow, than blood ever could be. Strangers had touched everything—peeling back the

surface of their lives with cold, clinical hands. The faint tang of disinfectant lingered where luminol had been sprayed.

Blinded by tears, she climbed the stairs.

The search signs in Steven's closet were obvious—evidence labels marked what had been taken. Bagged and removed. The shelves looked stripped bare—his watch, shirts, shoes, socks—all gone. The room looked tidy but vacant—like a hotel room after checkout, stripped of intention. Nothing felt theirs anymore. Drawers gaped like wounds; the overturned hamper bled clothes across the floor.

Shaken, she set the alarm, stripped and stepped under the shower. Fingerprint dust clung to every doorknob—each one pointing, shouting a single word: *murderer*.

Toweling dry, she noticed the bedspread and pillows tossed back carelessly after the search.

She sank onto the Persian rug, her back pressed against the bed frame. Naked, she hugged herself and shivered, sensing the walls had been listening all along. She folded forward, knees drawn tight to her chest, and cried.

“Steven... what happened? Why? This isn't you—how could you?”

She still felt unclean—the shame, embarrassment, guilt clinging like a second skin.

She closed her eyes, half-expecting an answer. The only reply—the hum of the A/C and faint bird songs outside. Would things ever be normal again? What would happen now—to Steven, to her? The world still sounded ordinary—but it wasn't. Not anymore. Not ever again.

She thought of last night—how impossibly perfect it had been. She'd felt things she hadn't in years—as if life itself had returned. But now, others had been in their bed; traces of violation everywhere.

She tore off the sheets, hurled the pillows into the hall, trying to tear away the contamination. One struck their wedding photo—the marble frame shattering against the hardwood beyond the rug.

She gathered the shards. “Steven... please come home. I need you. I need us.”

Blood welled from a nick where the marble had cut her finger.

“How could you do this?” she screamed, her voice shaking the room.

BUZZ...BUZZ

A low rumble broke her fury—continuous, insistent. She realized it was her phone.

“Hello? Hello?”

“Rach—it’s Bob. I just saw the news. What the hell happened?”

“Oh, Bob... Rabbi Shapiro’s been murdered—and Steven’s been arrested. He swears he’s innocent—I believe him. But Bob... there was blood on the shirt he wore yesterday.”

“Jesus—blood?”

“Steven wasn’t cut, it wasn’t his blood—so they arrested him. They tore through everything in the house. There are evidence stickers everywhere.

“You know him, Bob, you know him better than anyone, better than me. He couldn’t do this... could he?”

“Last night he said he took mushrooms. Do you think he could have...”

“Christ on a cracker—no, Rach! That’s not Stevie. He hated Shapiro, sure, but that ain’t our Stevie.”

After a pause, his voice softened—warm but tired. “How was he yesterday? And you holding up?”

She set the phone on speaker, slipped on panties, a T-shirt, and jeans, then sat in the bedroom chair.

“I feel like I don’t know anything anymore—like I don’t know Steven. He’s been different since he started seeing some new patient a few days ago. He even met with him yesterday afternoon.”

“Did he ever tell you anything about that patient?”

“No. He never talks about work. But this past week he’s been busier—distracted. Sometimes he’s not even there when we talk. And yesterday... he saw a patient on the weekend—first time ever.

“Last night, after he came home, he was... himself again. Not the old Steven exactly—just more present. With me.”

She pursed her lips, uncertain, clenched her eyes shut, then shared. “We made love, Bob. First time in a long time... years. I’m sure he tells you everything. But he was different, doing things we’d never done before—it’s embarrassing to talk about it. Maybe it was the mushrooms, but he was there—all there and... connected. You know how reserved and distant he can be. But last night... he was there, really there.

Oldman said, “Mushrooms can do that, bring some people outta their shell. I thought he’d wait until I was back.”

“After I fell asleep, he wrote me a poem—pages of it—like something out of Milton or Blake. I didn’t understand it all, but it was beautiful. He said it was about growing up—his own life’s journey. It’s called *The Birth of a Man*—about a naïve, fearless boy who discovers something dark inside him, a stranger he has to wrestle with. He wove in Prometheus, Ulysses, Penelope—other mythic names I barely know. But it wasn’t really about gods, Bob—it was about him. Divided, guilty, defiant. And then finding me—finding love—as what pulled him together, gave him a center. A love poem—his way of saying that through me he became whole. That our life, even our children, are his immortality.”

“Your children? Jesus... he musta been high.”

“He was—the mushrooms you gave him.” She shook her head, her voice catching. “I cried when I read it. It showed me how much children mean to him. And as much as I loved it, it hurt. It made me feel guilty—like such a failure. He ended it saying our love is his immortality—that love itself exceeds infinity. That’s what I had engraved in his wedding band.” She began crying again.

“You listen to me. You ain’t a failure—fah from it. He’s always tellin’ me how perfect you ah—says you’re his reason for bein’. I swear. He’s always thinking about you. He does love you. He’s just not the most expressive guy.” He chuckled. “But sounds like the mushrooms helped him with that.”

“Last night was so beautiful. This morning, perfect. We talked, like we used to. But then... he’s arrested for murder.”

“I dunno. Can’t imagine him killin’ anyone. Sure, he hated

Shapiro—lotta people do.”

“I used to be one of them. I’m sure Steven told you about my abortion, before we met. I blamed Rabbi Shapiro for that, trying to avoid my own guilt. But, in the end, it *was* my decision.”

“Yeah, but honestly, Stevie just told me last week. I nevah knew. I can only imagine how awful that was fuh you—bein’ so young. I’m so sahree, Rach.”

“I’m not mad he told you. I’m glad he did. It’s always been hard for him.

“For so long, I felt guilty, like it was my fault that it happened... the...” Her breath hitched. “The rape.”

“Don’t you evah. That wasn’t your fault.”

“I know that...now—but it took a long time. But the consequences of the abortion... that *is* my fault. Not being able to give Steven the children he wanted—obviously still wants. That’s my fault.”

“You were just a kid. You can’t blame yourself. And you had your parents and Rabbi Shapiro telling you what to do.”

“But Steven’s always said, we’re responsible for our choices... all of them.”

“Rach, you know Stevie. He loves his books, his aphorisms, philosophers. But life ain’t somethin’ you just read about—it’s something you do, you feel, you are. That’s why I gave him the mushrooms in the first place—to get him outta his head. I wanted the mushrooms to show him life ain’t black and white, it’s color.”

“I just feel like my decision... it’s wiped a few colors off our palette. You can’t paint a rainbow without all the colors.”

“Rach, I ain’t no artist like you—but can’t you mix some colors to make othas?”

“Yes, you can make green by mixing blue and yellow.”

“See, there ya go. So, maybe you can’t have your own kids, the way you planned, but there are a lot of ways to have kids these days, including adoption. Don’t let ya guilt hold ya back. Don’t give it that powa. It ain’t a thing—you just need to fuhgive yourself and live ya life.”

“Bob, I love you. You are our family. Thank you. I always felt so guilty, like a murderer. Oh my God.” Rachel started sobbing uncontrollably.

“What’s wrong?”

“Is Steven a murderer? I need him, Bob. What’s gonna happen to him?”

“I dunno, but it’ll work out. What did his lawyah say? Did ya call Krameh’s firm?”

“Yes. Kramer told Steven not to say a word. Eli Katz—one of the partners—handles criminal. We’re meeting him tomorrow morning. Arraignment’s at two.”

“I’m leavin’ the conference early—back tomorrah mornin’. Tell Katz to put me on the list—I’m Stevie’s therapist.”

“Thank you, Bob. You’re his best friend—we both love you.”

“Love you both. Can’t let you and Stevie go through this alone. Need me to write you a script to help you sleep tonight?”

“No. I don’t want to be foggy tomorrow. I’ll sleep. I’ve got a meditation podcast I listen to. I’ll read his poem and go to bed early.”

“Ha. Knowin’ how Stevie writes, that’ll shuh put ya to sleep! See ya tomorrah, Rach. We’ll all get through this... togetha.”

She hung up and went to her dresser. From the back of her underwear drawer, she pulled out a small box—one that had been opened during the search. She carried it to the window and lifted the lid. Inside was an old stained-glass mobile meant for a nursery.

She held one of the glass medallions up to the light. The sun caught it, scattering small rainbows across the carpet. She smiled. Then she began to cry.

CHAPTER THIRTY-NINE

In His Own Hand

Some lies are easier to believe than the truth.

— Frank Herbert, *Dune* (1965)

*A man is more a man through the things he keeps to himself
than through those he says.*

— Albert Camus, *La Chute* (1956)
(author's translation)

Give him a mask, and he will tell you the truth.

— Oscar Wilde, *Intentions* (1891)

What's past is prologue...

— William Shakespeare, *The Tempest* (1611)

Sunday, afternoon

The Charger's tires clunked over the speed bumps in the underground garage. Inside, the silence pressed heavier than the air itself. Ryker stared straight ahead—jaw tight, eyes fixed on nothing.

Smythe killed the ignition. "This might be a record. Chief's gonna love you now."

Ryker grunted, cracked the door—then shut it again. "Hang on, Smythe. Those symbols... we're missing something."

"Missing what? Boss, we've got him cold. Jury won't even need an hour—they'll be home for lunch."

Ryker muttered, "He's guilty of something—just not sure it's this."

"What are you talking about?" Smythe blew a sharp breath, shaking his head. "Jesus, Frank. Don't go soft on me now."

Ryker didn't answer. He shoved the door open, grabbed his hat and coat, and stepped out into the dim light.

The elevator carried them to the sixth floor, doors opening

onto a hushed, sterile hallway.

Reynolds sat slumped in a folding chair outside Gold's office—head tipped back, mouth open, snoring softly.

Smythe snorted. "Boss, give me a Sharpie—I'll make this guy famous."

"Leave him alone," Ryker said. "He's working two jobs—mother's hip, the insurance company's stalling, two kids in college. He's barely holding on."

"Oh—so that was the GoFundMe post in the duty room."

Ryker cleared his throat—loudly. "Reynolds."

The officer jerked awake, blinking, then shot to his feet. "Sir—sorry. Everything's been quiet. No one in or out."

"Good. Let's take a look."

Ryker jerked his head toward the Ring doorbell as they entered. Cool air met them—leather, citrus cleaner, and a faint undertone of dust. The door from reception to the main office stood wide; SID was already in motion—cables and cases sprawled along the hallway. Gloves snapped. SID techs fanned out, opening cases. The Nikon shutter clicked—desk, bookshelf, couch cushions. A small vacuum whined, drawing dust from the floorboards. Chain-of-custody numbers murmured like liturgy—solemn, rote, unquestioned.

"Looks like every shrink's office I ever hated," Smythe muttered.

"Bag your bias," Ryker said, almost smiling as he pulled his gloves tight.

Smythe circled the room, tapping spines of books—Jung, Kafka, Nietzsche. "Light reading." He smirked, and crouched near the couch.

"Hey, that statue over there—looks just like his wife, doesn't it? She's a fine-looking woman."

Ryker nodded. "Yeah. She's an artist. Couple of paintings and sculptures at their house were hers too."

Smythe pointed at the nude sculpture in the corner and smirked. "Guess she keeps him inspired."

"Okay, Smythe—let's focus. We've got..."

He was interrupted. “Detective—you’ll want to see this.” Miller’s voice called from behind Hadrian’s Wall.

Haven’t touched it—waited for you.”

“Thanks, Miller. Can I—”

“Yeah—got shots of everything before you guys got here.”

On Gold’s desk lay a leather-bound calendar, half-hidden in the top drawer. A loose sheet was tucked inside, edges torn jagged. Ryker opened it.

As Ryker flipped through the pages, one of the techs ran a gloved hand inside the drawer, then checked others.

“This is big—Gold’s office calendar.” He flipped through pages. “Saturday: Bible Study. In his own hand. No patients scheduled.”

Ryker’s shoulders tightened. Gold had told them otherwise.

Smythe barked a laugh. “Jesus—couldn’t script it better. His signature, his schedule. ‘Hi, I was here—killed your rabbi.’”

“Shut up,” Ryker snapped. He slid the calendar into an evidence bag himself, pressing the seal harder than necessary until the adhesive wrinkled beneath his thumb.

“Boss—that clinches it, doesn’t it? He lied. And, ‘Bible Study?’ Wouldn’t that be at the temple up the street? Shapiro’s Temple.”

He gestured toward a tech already bagging the MacBook.

Smythe leaned against the doorway. “Filter team’s gonna love this—files, clients, shrink shit—the whole nine yards.”

“Seal everything,” Ryker said. “We’re not getting this tossed on chain-of-custody.”

One tech muttered, “Moron.”

Ryker turned, brows raised. “What’s that?”

“Not you—him.” The tech jabbed a gloved finger toward the diplomas. “Doctor leaves his passwords on a Post-It stuck inside the top of his drawer. Idiot.”

Smythe laughed like he was at a comedy club. Ryker asked, “Can you get into his Ring with that?”

“Wouldn’t doubt it. Probably uses his birthday for his bank PIN. Guessing it’s just his laptop password. But, seeing this, he might have used one password for everything.” Smythe’s laughter faded; he looked down, a shade embarrassed.

“ID-10-T.”

Smythe frowned. “ID-10-T?”

The tech chuckled.

Ryker rolled his eyes and said, “Write it down Smythe.”

Smythe wrote, then tried to ignore the room laughing. “Ryker—we’re good to go, right?”

“Yep—warrants all clean. Grab the MacBook.”

“Okay—let’s fire this puppy up.”

The MacBook unlocked easily with the Post-It password. The tech opened the Ring dashboard in Safari—instant access. “Bingo. Didn’t even need a password. He saved them all in his browser. What’s his Ph.D. in, anyway?”

Smythe whispered to Ryker, “You’re not supposed to save passwords in your browser?”

The tech heard him and said, “It’s okay... as long as you don’t care who else uses them.” He laughed softly.

Ryker stepped into the waiting room, phone in hand.

“Mike,” he said when the Chief picked up. “Not looking good—symbols at the house, now his office calendar. No patients Saturday—he lied. SID’s pulling Ring footage; office and temple video expected tonight or early tomorrow.”

The Chief sighed on the other end. “Shit. Sounds like that seals it. I nixed the County transfer—he’ll spend tonight in local lockup. After arraignment tomorrow... no choice.”

“Frank—by the book, keep it all clean. Filters, seals, the whole kit. I don’t want this dismissed on a technicality. The news is all over it—they want blood.

“And I don’t want it to be mine.”

“Already on it,” he said.

Ryker hung up and stepped back in the office. The large

Pollock print caught his eye; he stared, transfixed.

“Ryker! You gotta see this!”

CHAPTER FORTY

Miranda Waved

Every word has consequences. Every silence, too.

— Jean-Paul Sartre, *Situations* (1943)

Convictions are more dangerous foes of truth than lies.

— Friedrich Nietzsche, *Human, All Too Human* (1878)

The whole is something else than the sum of its parts.

— Kurt Koffka, *Principles of Gestalt Psychology* (1935)

Sunday, early evening

“Detective Ryker, this is Lieutenant Daphne Kontopoulos from the LAPD Hate Crimes Division. I received your text and the Chief’s message. No need to apologize. I’d have responded sooner, but I’m out of town with my family.

“I ran your photos through our Hate Crimes database—no direct matches, but three symbols stood out. They resemble motifs I’ve seen in extremist iconography—a trident, a serpent, and a horned figure. Could be coincidence, but I can’t rule out a Satanic or hate-crime motive.

“At first I wondered if it was a constructed cipher alphabet—like the one the Zodiac Killer devised. I’ve forwarded several symbols to academic contacts for review. I’ll update you when I hear back. Call if you need me—I’ll answer if possible. Back late tonight.”

The voicemail ended with a flat click.

Ryker said, “So hate crime’s still on the table. Gold being Jewish complicates it—maybe misdirection, maybe just a personal grudge against the rabbi. Anyway—SID text just pinged back. Let’s see.”

SID AUTOMATED ANALYSIS —

SYMBOL RECOGNITION

Input: Wall inscription photo

- Symbols resemble ancient writing systems.
- Possibility: constructed/cipher script (modern).
- Recommendation: expert review required.

“Smythe, what about that magazine at Gold’s office—the one with the clay tablets on the cover? It was sitting next to that sculpture on his desk.”

Smythe snorted. “Yeah, I remember. Ugly as hell. You shot me a look.”

Ryker narrowed his eyes. “That’s the one. SID bagged it?”

Ryker dialed. “Miller? Ryker. That magazine from Gold’s desk—did you bag it? Good. Send me shots: cover and any pages with symbols, barcode visible for chain of custody. ... Forget the PDF. Send me the shots now—I need them before we walk in on Gold. If anything matches the synagogue wall, I want the ammo. ... Just the magazine. ... Thanks, Greg—I owe you.”

Smythe turned. “He say what magazine?”

“Yeah, *Israel Exploration Journal*. SID analysis mentioned cuneiform and hieroglyphics—could tie.”

“So I’m bad cop again? He already hates me.”

“Yeah. Just careful. Chief doesn’t want us to lean too hard.”

“What’s that about?”

Ryker shook his head. “No idea. High-profile murder—Chief wants it clean. That was fast—Miller just sent pics.”

Ryker opened the photos on his phone.

“Another hit. Article shows tablets with matching symbols—*Proto-Sinaitic*. Great. I’ll loop Kontopoulos—maybe her academics can translate.”

He hit redial, put the phone on speaker.

“Voicemail again. ‘Damn.’”

“This is Lieutenant Daphne Kontopoulos. Sorry I can’t take

the call. Please leave a detailed message.”

“Kontopoulos, it’s Frank Ryker. Update: It’s an alphabet—Proto-Sinaitic. One of Gold’s magazines, the *Israel Exploration Journal*, had an article on a turquoise mine in the Sinai Peninsula—same symbols. Smythe and I are heading to lockup now to re-interrogate Gold. Arraignment’s tomorrow. I know it’s late, but maybe you push this to your academics. It’d be great to know what it says before court. Thanks.”

Smythe muttered, “She might be rethinking that FBI gig.”

Ryker grunted.

Ryker and Smythe sat on one side of the metal table. The door opened. Gold shuffled in—gray county-issue shirt and pants, wrists cuffed.

“Sit here, hands on the table,” the officer said. Gold sat. The officer threaded a steel wire through the cuffs and locked it to the table ring.

“That’s not necessary,” Ryker said. “He’ll behave. Right, Dr. Gold?”

Gold nodded. “Of course. I’m not dangerous. And...” He looked into the mirror where he knew the camera sat. “I’m innocent.”

Fishbowl room. A mirror hiding watchers.

Not paranoia—just fact.

The officer kept working. “Sorry, Detective—you know the rules.”

Ryker nodded. The gesture was pure goodwill.

The room was small. Smythe paced, shoulders rolling. He swore pacing kept suspects off balance.

Ryker didn’t buy it—but it kept Smythe busy. Ryker preferred stillness—eyes locked, reading tells, the way Gold studied patients.

“Dr. Gold, do you want your attorney present? You know that’s your right. You told your wife not to talk—that was smart. But the fact she washed your clothes from yesterday while we were getting the warrant—that doesn’t help your case. No lawyer

would've advised that. Not if you're innocent. It just looks bad, you see what I mean?"

Smythe added, "Unless she used a lot of bleach, SID'll still pick up blood."

She probably washed them to keep busy—must be terrified.

Gold leaned forward, ignoring Smythe's pacing, and met Ryker's eyes. "I think I'm okay talking without my attorney. I assume you're recording from behind the mirror. You were probably going to say that—sorry if I jumped the gun. I don't have anything to hide."

Smythe shook his head behind Ryker, a silent don't-do-it.

"You're right—you are being recorded. Anything you say can and will be used against you in a court of law."

Can anything I say be used for me? Isn't the whole point to find the truth? Never understood that—so adversarial.

"You sure you don't want your attorney after all?"

"No, I'm fine. Shoot—poor choice of words."

Smythe glanced at the mirror. "Miranda *Waived*."

Ryker said, "We've got SID teams at your home and office."

"SID?" Gold asked.

"Scientific Investigation Division," Smythe said. "Crime scene work—DNA, prints, digital forensics."

Gold managed a faint smile. "Like CSI."

"Yeah, just like that," Ryker said, and Gold looked back at him.

"Anyway—given the evidence, you want to start sharing with us? It's not looking great, Dr. Gold. The more you cooperate, the easier this goes. When a case looks this clear-cut, the DA doesn't like wasting time."

"Neither does the judge," Smythe added.

"So—anything you want to tell us before I show you what

SID found so far?”

*What did SID find? What could they possibly find—
Light's ring on the floor?*

“No—nothing to tell. Was Rachel there when you arrived? Is she okay? She must be scared to death.”

Smythe said, “Yeah—and what’s strange is, you don’t look scared.”

I didn't do it.

“Like we wouldn’t find anything, huh?”

Ryker jumped in. “No, she didn’t stay—she left to go to a friend’s place while we searched.”

Rach. I keep letting you down. Forgive me.

He's right. I'm not scared. I should be.

*Charged with murder—anyone else would be
terrified. Why aren't I?*

“First off—we found this on your home desk.” Ryker slid his phone across the table—the photo of a note with symbols.

Gold offered a faint smile. “Yes—my patient left that at our last session.” He pushed the phone back.

“When was that session?”

“Yesterday afternoon—around three-thirty.”

“Dr. Gold, we’ve got warrants for your home and office—including patient files. Tell us which patients you saw yesterday and when. You’ve waived counsel but you still have the right not to incriminate yourself. And under California Evidence Code §1014 plus federal standards, you can withhold patient info without consent or a court order.”

Smythe dropped into the chair beside Ryker and swiped to Gold’s calendar on the phone.

“Want to show him, Boss?” He zoomed in and turned the phone toward Gold. “Saturday—no patients, just ‘Bible Study... in your own handwriting. Care to explain that, Doc?’”

Just then an officer knocked and stepped in. “Gold—call

from Legion Law. Your attorney?”

Finally—Light. But he won't rescue me, or he'd be arrested.

Gold lurched to his feet, cuffs clinking against the table.

The officer unthreaded the steel wire from his cuffs. “This way.”

He was led out to a desk phone on the counter.

“Hello—Dr. Steven Gold speaking.”

“Hello, Dr. Gold. This is Patrick from Legion Law. We’ve checked our records—no attorney, paralegal, or employee named Samael Light. But if you’re looking for counsel we can—”

Gold hung up. Silence.

He stared down. The phone’s dull receiver seemed to stare back.

Mocking me? Light's not a lawyer. He's a ghost. What is real anymore?

The officer marched him back, sat him down, re-threaded the steel wire, and snapped it shut.

Chains rattled—mock applause.

Still mocking me.

Smythe leaned in, voice casual as a knife. “You were about to explain ‘Bible Study,’ Doc?”

Ryker showed Gold the photo again: Saturday—no patients. Bible Study. “Want to walk us through that, Doc?”

“I did see a patient. I never write names in my physical calendar—only initials, for confidentiality.”

Should I tell them it was Samael Light?

Ryker kept his tone level, eyes locked. “We saw that. But yesterday—no initials, no patients. Just ‘Bible Study.’”

Smythe smirked, knife-thin. “So Bible Study’s your patient? You should’ve just written B.S.—because that’s all this is.

“Bible study—sounds more like something at the synagogue.”

Ryker stepped in, swiping to a photo. He showed Gold his phone. “This was on the synagogue wall.”

Smythe grinned. “Doesn’t take a handwriting expert to see that match.”

*If I tell them it was Light—no address, no phone,
they’ll think I’m lying... or insane.*

Maybe I am. Starting to wonder myself.

Gold rubbed the base of his ring finger—the pale skin where his wedding band had rested for years. The cuffs rattled against the desk.

Smythe leaned across the table, laser-focused. “Why no initials like everyone else, Doc? Why not? BS!”

Gold dropped his gaze. “Because... he paid cash. I didn’t want it showing as income. So I wrote ‘Bible Study,’ figuring no one would question it.”

Ryker’s gaze sharpened. “Alright, then give us the name.”

They already have access to all my patient files.

Gold hesitated, throat tight. “Sata...” He caught himself.

*If I tell them my patient is Satan, they’ll lock me up
in a psych ward instead.*

“Samael. Samael Light.”

Smythe snorted. “Samael? What kind of name is that?”

Gold swallowed. “It’s Hebrew.”

Ryker leaned in. “Spell it.”

“S-A-M-A-E-L,” Gold said. “But he told me to call him Samuel. Light’s his last name.”

“You got a number or address so we can talk to him?”

“No. He’d just moved here last week, and his phone was stolen at the airport.”

“Convenient,” Smythe said with a smirk. “And I’m guessing no address yet, right?”

Gold’s voice tightened. “I know how that sounds.”

Ryker said, almost gently, “Think how it’ll sound to a jury. You sure you don’t have any way to reach this... Samael Light?”

Gold shook his head. “But that’s the truth. He was real—he wrote the note. Wore a ring with those same symbols etched into it.”

Ryker sighed. “So there’s no phone, no address—nothing for a patient you claim exists... that you’ve been treating.”

Smythe’s grin spread. “So no alibi, and now you admit you cooked your books. Brilliant move, Doc.”

Color rose in Gold’s cheeks. “I wasn’t hiding a crime. I was helping a patient who didn’t want to file insurance. He paid cash. I shouldn’t have done it—but that doesn’t make me a killer.”

Mauvaise foi. Bad faith—in more ways than one.

Smythe leaned back, satisfied. “Tough argument with the rabbi’s blood on your shirt sleeves. DA’s gonna love this. Your alibi doubles as another crime. BS—that’s just what it is.”

Ryker, cut in, voice low. “That doesn’t prove you killed anyone, Dr. Gold—but the evidence is piling up. Your book club says you argued with the rabbi. Your calendar says Bible Study, no patient.”

Smythe slammed his fist on the table. “And blood! Motive, means opportunity, evidence, witnesses—you check all the boxes. And we even got the murder weapon.

“You lobbed the DA a softball—he’s gonna knock it out of the park.”

“I’m guilty of not reporting income—not murder. But I’m worried my patient might be. He said things about Rabbi Shapiro... not enough for a duty to warn, but enough to worry me. He said some things about Rabbi Shapiro... but not enough to trigger my duty to warn.”

Should I have warned Shapiro?

But I’d felt that way too.

Sweat gathered at Gold’s temples.

Smythe sneered. “Yeah—try pinning it on a ghost.”

Ryker interrupted. “What did he say about the rabbi?”

“He said—specifically—that he’d carve the false words out of his throat.”

Smythe muttered, “Yeah? Looks like you did.”

“No. Not me. He left upset and said, ‘*Decisions often carry unintended consequences.*’ It felt ominous.”

Ryker swiped to another photo on his phone. “Here’s the rabbi.” He handed it to Gold. The screen flickered, then stabilized on the image.

Oh my God. It’s real. It really was Light. His note—his handwriting.

“That’s blood?” Gold asked, pinching out to zoom up close.

Smythe answered, “Yeah—there, on the wall, and... oh yeah, on your shirt! The rabbi’s blood.” He mimed swinging a bat, adding a sharp pop with his tongue.”

Ryker leaned forward, swiped back to the wall photo. “What does it say?”

Gold blinked, baffled. “I wish I knew.”

What does it say?

Ryker took back his phone. “Dr. Gold, you absolutely sure you don’t want to revise your story?”

Smythe said, “With the testimony and the evidence, that’s murder one. You—”

“Not me. Sa...”

Don’t slip.

Why not tell them he thinks he’s Satan? Makes sense he’d murder the rabbi.

None of this makes sense.

“Samuel Light. I swear it.”

Gold tapped the photo. “He wrote that before he left my office. Same symbols on his ring.”

“His ring?”

“Yes—a ring from his father, same writing.” Gold slapped

both hands down, cuffs clanking on the table. Ryker and Smythe, both flinched. “Wait—I remember now. He said it meant, ‘Find peace in heaven.’”

RING. RING.

“Shit.”

Ryker stood, “Hang on—I need to take this.” He stepped out into the hall, Smythe trailing with a snort.

Ryker answered. “Ryker. Thanks for getting back to me so quickly, Lieutenant—Daphne. ... Interesting. He can read it? ... Yeah. ... Great. Appreciate it. ...”

Smythe whispered, “Bloody Cross?” He mouthed it more than said it.

Ryker covered the receiver, shot Smythe a look. ‘One more thing—*Bloody Cross* by James Patterson. Ring a bell? ... Really? ... Great. ... Thanks again. You too, what’s left of it.”

Smythe shifted, impatient. “What’d she say?”

“The Proto-Sinaitic tip helped. Evidently it’s the earliest known alphabet. She says she’s never seen it in a hate crime—not Satanic. There are only a couple dozen people worldwide who can read and write it. But the author of that article—a professor at Duke University—he translated it. Just like Gold said: *Find peace in heaven.*”

“Gold just checked another box, right Boss? What’d she say about *Bloody Cross*?”

“She’s actually read it. Loves all the Alex Cross books. It’s about a murderer, not religious. Revenge, control, psychic trauma. Coincidence? Or a seed someone picked up?”

“I don’t know, Boss. You don’t really buy any of this B.S., do you?”

“He’s still talking—claims he’s innocent. He’d be a fool to waive rights if he were guilty.”

“But the Ring video shows nobody but him at his office yesterday.”

“Could be—the stairwell bypasses that Ring cam. We’ll get SID’s footage pull from the building and synagogue later tonight.”

“Long shot, Boss.”

“He just admitted to tax evasion.”

“So would I to avoid a murder one charge.”

“I don’t know Smythe—something about him’s off.”

“Yeah—he’s a fucking murderer.”

“No. I mean, it feels like he knows more than he’s saying—almost like he’s protecting someone.”

“Sounds like you’re defending him. Doby likes this guy, sure, but he wants the case closed. Don’t forget—blood on Gold’s shirt. This is going down faster than an NCIS episode. Let’s take the win.”

“Maybe he helped B.S. and caught the blood himself. I don’t know. Let’s hit him with the Ring footage—see how he handles that.”

Gold sat chained to the table, the observation glass humming faintly behind him.

How the hell did Light just disappear?

A stray echo of Bulgakov’s devil—vanishing without a sound, leaving only absence... and dread.

The cuffs rattled. The walls seemed to breathe.

Psilocybin flashback?

Could I have done this?

If I close my eyes and open them—maybe the detectives dissolve. Maybe the chains are gone. Maybe the scene changes.

CHAPTER FORTY-ONE

Where Does a Ring Begin?

*We shall not cease from exploration,
And the end of all our exploring
Will be to arrive where we started
And know the place for the first time.
— T. S. Eliot, Four Quartets (1943)*

Sunday, late night

By the second night of detention, the questions had stopped feeling like questions.

The toilet flushed, echoing off concrete and steel. Gold lowered himself onto the cot, the frame pressing like bone through the thin padding.

The door was solid steel, painted a dull gray, with only a narrow slot and a wire-laced window the size of a paperback. The slot in the door—used for food or cuffing—rattled whenever an officer passed. It felt like a can of nails banging against his head, the start of a migraine.

Every sense was under siege.

He tried to shut it off with self-hypnosis. But once he grew used to the hum of vents, the coughs, the shuffle of officers' boots beyond the door, he would drift off—only for a moment.

When he turned onto his side, the sheets rasped against his skin like butcher's paper.

The stench of neighboring toilets leaked under the door—sour, unrelenting.

No ventilation. Hot, stale air. Sweat beading, then dripping.

The bland mint toothpaste clung like cobwebs he couldn't spit away.

*At least I'm not sharing this cell with someone else.
I can't imagine that.*

Light knifed through the slit in the steel door, piercing even his closed eyelids. His choice: the washcloth-sized pillow—cover his eyes or soften the cot's iron frame.

*Sartre was half right: hell is other people—
especially in jail. At least I can still joke. But why am I
not terrified—like Rachel must be? Rach.*

*They've taken my ring, but you will always be with
me.*

He got up, walked to the door, twisting his head to try to see down the hall toward the wall clock—11:47.

Sunday night, I wonder if Rachel's asleep yet.

*Even after years without making love, I could hear
you each night, feel your breath on my cheek, smell
your perfume, see your beauty.*

*Last night—love. Not just the mushrooms. Time.
Destiny.*

*But now? What am I doing here? What have I
done?*

He walked back to the cot and lay down. Curled in a fetal position, his hands tucked between his knees.

His lips moved before he realized it—the old words his parents had taught him came whispering out—

“Now I lay me down to sleep...”

He faltered—ashamed—but the rhythm carried him on.

“If I should die before I wake...”

Amidst the assault on his senses from every front, Gold dozed into deep sleep.

The glint of his wedding band blinded him. When his sight cleared, another ring appeared—thick gold, etched with ancient symbols, locked around his middle finger.

Sparks leapt where the metals met. Each flash seared his

nerves. He clawed at the ring, but it clung—heavier than bone.

The wedding band slid loose, but the marked ring held fast. Screaming, he bent his finger back—sinews cracking—until the ring tore free.

Silence. A bubbling stream. A patch of black orchids. Water trickling over moss-covered rocks.

Gold yawned and stretched; sunlight was warm on his naked skin. Rachel stood, backlit, bare and unashamed, radiant.

He reached for her hand. Their fingers intertwined as she lay beside him—smiling, her hair a halo of light.

Peace—at last.

CHAPTER FORTY-TWO

Tartarus

“But I’m not guilty,” said K. “There’s been a mistake. How can a person even be guilty? We’re all human, every one of us, here. One person can’t be more guilty than another.”

— Franz Kafka, *The Trial* (1925)

Guilt feelings so often arise in childhood, when we are made responsible for the feelings of others.

— Alice Miller, *The Drama of the Gifted Child* (1979)

The analysis is more difficult than any other. It paralyzes my psychic strength.

— Sigmund Freud, *Letter to Wilhelm Fliess* (1897)

In Tartarus, punishment is the mirror.

— Steven Gold, *Journal of Reflective Psychotherapy* (Winter 2026)

Monday, early morning

The DA hadn’t decided. That uncertainty had become its own form of confinement.

The clang cracked like a snapped branch. In his mind, birds scattered, the brook fell silent—Rachel vanished.

“Chow!”

The slot at the door slid open. A styrofoam tray peeked through: eggs congealed into a lump, a bruised apple, milk sweating condensation.

“Eat it while it’s warm.” The officer called out, waited just a moment for Gold to grab the tray.

“Sorry. Okay.” Gold leapt up for the tray—but the officer was already gone.

He was slightly dizzy from jumping up—but the migraine was gone. Or never there at all.

He glanced around the cell, muttered, “Guess *this* isn’t a dream.”

What time is it?

Carefully balancing the tray, he walked back to the door, craned his head to see down the hall. He blinked. But couldn’t make out the numbers. He set the tray on his cot. Grabbing his glasses off the floor, from under the cot, he blew off the dust. He looked down the hall—5:13.

No dawn, no dusk—only the same merciless LEDs. Even with the door closed, the air reeked of bleach and piss. The stainless-steel toilet crouched in the corner like an animal, watching him.

He sat on the hard bench, balancing the tray on his knees. His stomach turned. He examined the apple, but then set it back down on the tray.

Yesterday at this time—Just the Two of Us. Bacon. Coffee steaming. Rachel—my shirt draped across her shoulders. That world still existed, just beyond reach. A parallel life, untouched by this stink and humiliation. My shirt. The blood.

His stomach knotted.

What now?

When will they realize I’m innocent?

Will Rachel ever forgive me?

Was this my fault?

He recalled Ryker’s words: “We’ve gone through your iPad, Doctor. Phones, voicemails, cloud backups. Routine.”

Routine.

That’s what he’d said.

Routine.

Then Smythe—almost as an afterthought: *You sure there isn’t anything you want to tell us?*

Then silence.

No explanation.

No Jane.

No video.

No toothbrush. No razor. No mirror—just the sour taste of his own breath. Somewhere down the hall, someone cursed, then laughed—rattling the air ducts.

My head is pounding.

No choice. At least the apple might 'brush' my teeth.

He took a bite, half-expecting to find a worm. Three more bites, then set it on the tray and put it on the floor.

He stretched out on the cot, eyes on the ceiling, staring up at the lights, squinting.

I guess I should feel something for Shapiro. For Karen and the kids.

Perls wouldn't like me saying should.

I don't.

Should. There is no right or wrong—only what is. Accept it. Deal with it. Be it.

"I do my thing..."

Perls' Gestalt Prayer? I used to know it.

He stood, eyes clenched, summoning the page from memory.

I do my thing and you do your thing.

I am not in this world to live up to your expectations,

And you are not in this world to live up to mine.

You are you, and I am I,

And if by chance we find each other, it's beautiful.

If not, it can't be helped.

He sat.

Yeah. “If not, it can’t be helped.” If not.

There’s no “human bill of rights” when it comes to personal desire and feelings.

Facticity. Reality.

He stood up and started pacing again, four steps, turn, four steps...

The endless vicissitudes of life.

I feel like Sisyphus—only no one could ever imagine me happy.

My boulder... my whole career... trying to help people deal with feelings, with others’ expectations. The pain of not living up to them.

One of the first things Light said was, “I’m not happy. Honestly... I don’t think I ever have been.”

Have I ever been happy? Truly?

Rachel—I was happy yesterday.

He sat down on the hard cot. Stretching out, on his back.

Is this how Prometheus felt? Maybe it wasn’t his liver torn by the eagle, but guilt gnawing instead. The punishment itself—unfair, eternal.

Kafka—Not guilty, just a mistake. We’re all human. No one more guilty than another.

If existing is a crime, then I’m guilty. But that wasn’t my crime.

He sat up, tried to clean his glasses with his coarse shirt.

Byron—“Thy godlike crime was to be kind.”

What’s my crime?

I feel like Atlas—forced to bear someone else’s heaven.

“I am not in this world to live up to your expectations.”

It's okay just to be. Isn't it?

Facticity. Reality. The sentence we all serve.

Just be. No need to label it. To explain it.

Just be.

Mary Shelley's monster: "I did not ask to be made. I did not ask to be created."

"Damn—I wish I had my library here." He said it aloud, fists clenched.

This punishment is inhumane. This is Tartarus.

My feelings? Buried deep beneath it.

I wonder if this is how Meursault felt. At his mother's funeral. No grief, no sorrow—nothing. Just the sun in his eyes.

I guess it'll be hard on Karen—and those kids, Robin and little Tiffany. But maybe it's better they don't have to grow up him.

I don't know.

It feels like I don't care. Truth is—I don't feel at all.

Detached. Hollow.

Maybe a defense mechanism? Maybe something's wrong?

Or maybe... I really don't care.

Footsteps in the hallway. Gold jumped up and rapped on the slot.

The officer stopped, peered through the wired window, then flipped the hatch. Metal clanged.

"Yeah?"

"I was wondering... is there anything I could read? While waiting?"

The officer—bald and barrel-chested—barked a laugh. "Sure. LA Times. Wall Street Journal. New York Times. Whole

library cart's coming. Can I get you a café latte as well?"

"I mean—anything," Gold said quickly. "Doesn't matter what."

The officer smirked, softened a fraction. "Look, Doc, if I see a Bible lying around, I'll toss it through. That's all we keep."

Gold nodded. "Thank you. I appreciate it."

Gold pushed the breakfast tray under the cot and paced back and forth.

*What was Light's deal? I wonder what he's doing?
I wonder if he called again.*

*I guess I'm stuck here until this afternoon. Maybe I
can just fall back asleep.*

He sat down on the cot, lay on his side and closed his eyes. The light, unforgiving, kept him from falling back to sleep.

*I wonder if janitorial, or the police, found Light's
ring. I just must have missed it when I looked—I heard
it hit the ground and roll.*

*Strange he'd leave without it. I wonder if he
returned, after I left, to try to get it back.*

*What the hell did it say. It was obviously important.
He wouldn't just abandon it.*

*But he did abandon his father. Or "His Father," I
guess he'd want me to say.*

A metal clang. A book slid through the slot and smacked the floor, pages folding under the cover.

Gold bent, picked it up. The ESV Bible. Standard, at least in name.

Better than nothing. For now.

He propped himself against the pillow and opened it at random.

*"How long must I wrestle with my thoughts and day
after day have sorrow in my heart?"*

That's apropos.

He glanced back a page. Psalms, thirteen.

“How long, Lord? Will you forget me forever? How long will you hide your face from me?”

He flipped through Isaiah.

“For my thoughts are not your thoughts, neither are your ways my ways, declares the LORD. For as the heavens are higher than the earth, so are my ways higher than your ways and my thoughts than your thoughts.”

“As you do not know the way the spirit comes to the bones in the womb of a woman with child, so you do not know the work of God who makes everything.”

“Shall the potter be regarded as the clay, that the thing made should say of its maker, ‘He did not make me’; or the thing formed say of him who formed it, ‘He has no understanding’?”

Adam and Eve—a parallel to Prometheus stealing fire from the gods. Eve, Adam, and their offspring in perpetuity—all punished.

Justice? More like torture.

Shelley's monster questioning his maker, for his suffering. Hmm, was Victor Frankenstein the serpent in that story?

Paging back to Genesis.

“Then the LORD God said, ‘Behold, the man has become like one of us in knowing good and evil. Now, lest he reach out his hand and take also of the tree of life and eat, and live forever—”

“Knowing good and evil.” Yes—knowing that when You, Lord, do something, it is not always good. Your tree.

All suffering is Your responsibility. Why do religions worship You? Fear, I suppose.

And if man “became like one of us,” then You assumed the angels already knew good and evil. But knowing isn’t the same as choosing. Knowledge isn’t freedom—choice is.

“I will surely multiply your pain in childbearing; in pain you shall bring forth children. Your desire shall be for your husband, and he shall rule over you.”

“...Cursed is the ground because of you; in pain you shall eat of it all the days of your life; thorns and thistles it shall bring forth for you.”

“You are dust, and to dust you shall return.”

“He placed the cherubim and a flaming sword that turned every way to guard the way to the tree of life.”

Hiding more secrets.

Does anyone ever really read this carefully?

He let out a dry laugh.

Light would be amused—me in jail, reading the Bible. He’d say I’ve been jailed in my own mind for years.

Gold almost smiled, despite himself.

Footsteps. Keys. “Attorney visit. Let’s go.”

CHAPTER FORTY-THREE

Mirrors in a Hall of Mirrors

*Bad faith is self-deception—
the lie we tell ourselves to escape the anxiety of freedom and responsibility.*
— Jean-Paul Sartre, *L'Être et le Néant* (1943)
(author's translation)

*The superego torments the ego with guilt, regardless of whether the ego has
committed a sin or not.*
— Sigmund Freud, *The Ego and the Id* (1923)

*Therapy can become a mirror in a hall of mirrors—distortion mistaken for
reflection.*
— Steven Gold, *A Question of Balance: A Descent Into Madness* (2026)

*I cannot make you understand what is happening inside me.
I cannot even explain it to myself.*
— Franz Kafka, *The Trial* (1925)

Monday, midmorning

“Transport!” The officer’s voice cracked down the hallway, followed by the clang of keys shattering the stale silence.

Cold steel bit into Gold’s wrists, then his ankles. He joined a line of eight men—hollow-eyed, faceless—shackled in pairs, the chain between them forcing a slow, degrading shuffle.

The corridor stretched endless—lights flickering, buzzing like hornets. The air reeked of sweat and rot.

At the rear trudged the officer who’d delivered his breakfast, his bulk filling the hall. Black vest, radio crackling. Silent, watchful—more confinement than protection. Nothing here was soft: only walls and armor.

Gold’s was the only face that still showed signs of life. Oddly, he almost seemed amused by it.

Charon waits—but I have no coin to pay him. Am I

*damned to this line forever? If eternity is only this—
shuffling, shackled, faceless—then what difference
remains between life and death?*

*Will I be judged like Dmitri Karamazov—for the
murder of his father? Is this Yahweh's retribution for
the murder I've committed—of my father, my faith, or
myself?*

As he shuffled forward, he saw Light's face—watchful,
smirking—peering from behind a narrow cell window.

"Keep moving!" the guard barked.

Gold blinked, looked again—nothing but a shadow.

*No. Was it? It had looked just like him—or like the
part of him that never left.*

Poetic justice.

He smiled faintly—the only man alive in the processional.

*Why did you vanish? Because I said I didn't believe
you? Because I called you—and your Father—what
you are: a story I told myself when I couldn't bear the
truth?*

The trek to the door felt unending. The stench thickened.
The man shackled to Gold's right muttered into his chest, and the
rhythm of it dragged him back to his internship at County General's
psych ward.

BUZZ

The door swung open. Morning sunlight hit him like a slap.
Return from the River Styx. Bright. Alive. He inhaled deeply,
relishing the first breath of fresh, unfiltered air.

The van doors gaped open. He was shoved inside, knees
jammed against the man opposite, the air thick with stale breath and
sweat. The doors slammed. Locked. The world became a rattling
cage.

When the doors opened again, the prisoners were funneled
down another long hallway—cleaner, but no less sterile, painted in
bureaucratic beige.

Unshackling one man at a time, the officer finally thrust open a metal door and gestured him inside. It was a small, windowless room: bright LEDs, faint hum of AC. A table bolted to the floor, four chairs jammed around it. Barely enough space to turn.

Rachel rose from her seat beside Oldman and the attorney, eyes rimmed red.

“Steven!” Her voice caught—half gasp, half relief.

She started toward him on instinct. The officer at the door tapped the narrow window and shook his head. He stepped inside, seated Gold, and threaded a cable through his chains. “No contact,” he said flatly, before resuming his post. The attorney lifted a hand to hold her back.

She wore a charcoal Armani suit, a white blouse, and a tightly knotted Hermès scarf—the red slash of it a wound against pale fabric. Her hair was pulled back, revealing the clean symmetry of her jaw—beautiful, composed, sculptural. She wore no jewelry except her wedding rings and the faint glint of the infinity necklace peeking through the knot.

Her gaze dropped to Gold’s cuffed hands—bare where his wedding band should have been. She flinched, her breath catching as if she’d been struck.

*She sees. My ring. Gone. Is the covenant broken?
Have I lost her now? Does she see her husband—or
only a prisoner? A murderer?*

Gold longed to embrace her, to taste the faint shimmer of lip gloss. The familiar trace of Chanel No. 5 cut through the stale air.

Oldman looked out of place in courthouse gray—brown blazer worn soft, blue shirt frayed at the collar, khakis wrinkled like his laugh lines, Rockports polished just enough to show effort.

“Stevie, how’re you holdin’ up?”

Gold forced a smile. “Rhetorical, right? Hangin’ in there. Rach, I’m so sorry—but I swear I’m innocent.”

She reached across the table, fingertips brushing his—just enough contact, the officer at the door pretending not to see.

Belief? Or compassionate resignation?

“Dr. Gold, I’m Eli Katz.”

“As in Kramer, Katz, and Broderick?”

“Exactly. I head our criminal division. Mrs. Gold gave me some history, and I’ve got a few details from the DA, but that’s just the tip of the iceberg. I’ve requested the full file, but since it’s fast-tracked, they don’t have to show their whole hand yet. They’ve filed it as a straight 187—murder—with a § 12022(b) weapon enhancement for the instrument. That makes bail uphill. Plus there’s exterior synagogue video showing you entering, and the prelim says the blood on your shirt matches Shapiro.”

“I’m not a criminal, Eli.”

Except for tax evasion.

“I understand—and of course we’ll plead ‘not guilty.’ Right now, I just want to focus on bail. With arraignment in a few hours, we have to move fast.”

“What? You mean he could be held until trial?” Rachel’s voice cracked. She lifted her chin, eyes fixed on Gold. “Steven.” Her eyes filled. Oldman put an arm around her.

“I’m sorry. The DA’s going to push the two F’s—flight risk and fabrication. They’ll argue the washed clothes destroyed evidence, hinting he could have been the St. Augustine Parish murderer—likely to strike again.”

“I wasn’t destroying anything—I was just trying to keep busy. They dragged my husband from our home in handcuffs. And now...” She pressed her palms to her eyes, shoulders shaking.

Katz turned back to Gold.

Oldman said, “Didn’t they say the St. Augustine murderer was probably an out-of-towner?”

“Police had some evidence that suggested it, but their one lead vanished. Maybe it was a local who submerged, disappearing back into his normal life until now. That’s why the DA and police chief fast-tracked the case—pressure from the mayor and religious leaders. The news and socials are all over it, claiming the murders are connected.”

Chief McClosky and his wife—marital counseling.

Nice guy. Hands full with Carol.

Katz leaned across the table, lowering his voice in a futile attempt to keep Rachel from hearing. “They’re calling you the *Sanctuary Slayer*—and the *Devil’s Doctor*.”

Rachel shrieked. “No!” Her breathing spiraled into panicked gasps.

Devil’s Doctor actually fits.

Katz turned to Oldman, “Dr. Oldman, perhaps Mrs. Gold would be more comfortable waiting outside. We’re under a tight clock.”

“No—please,” she begged. “Steven.” She clasped his hand, her fingers whitening his.

The officer tapped the window and shook his head.

Katz leaned forward. “Dr. Gold...”

“Eli, call me Steven.”

“No. You need to be Dr. Gold. ‘Steven’ makes you vulnerable. We want the pedigree, the authority, the respect. Jurors don’t question doctors—they follow them. To most people, doctors are near gods. Sure you’ll get one or two jurors who will have an anecdote and hold it against you, but the majority of people find doctors’ education and personality unassailable.”

Even the Devil’s Doctor?

Doctor. Title as armor, shield, mask.

But does the mask still fit? What if there’s nothing behind it but cracks, shadows, mirrors?

“That’s why we’ve got to think hard. We’ve got to prove you innocent—right away. The media loved you, you were the *Celebrity Shrink*, shrink to the stars, but the media has no loyalty. They just want attention—and this is it. Media labels are hard... impossible to shake. Kevorkian was *Dr. Death* until the day he died.” Rachel shuddered.

Maybe the media can see behind the curtain.

Katz continued, “Your presence at the temple isn’t a problem

—I can handle that. You’ve been a member for years. Rachel’s family even longer. Weren’t you bat mitzvahed by Rabbi Shapiro?”

“Yes.” Rachel nodded quickly, searching Katz’s face for any trace of optimism.

Katz went on, “Okay, you argued with the rabbi at book club—right before the murder. I can frame that for a jury, but Judge Williams won’t be sympathetic. Even if I spin it as noting but a heated book debate, DA’ll argue motive, and Shapiro’s blood on your shirt could kill bail outright.”

Rachel’s muffled moan escaped through the crumpled tissue pressed to her mouth and nose. Gold sat back, eyes hollow, his glasses slipping down his nose.

They’ll say anything. Twist anything. A shirt, a wash, a glance—it all becomes evidence. Every act a crime. Every silence an admission.

Gold’s voice broke. “Then maybe I did it. Maybe I killed him and just don’t remember.”

“Steven—no,” Rachel cried.

He turned to Oldman, pleading. “Bob—could it be DID? Dissociation? Another part of me? I hated Shapiro—God knows I did. If the video shows me, if his blood’s on my hands, maybe his blood is on my hands. What else explains it?”

Oldman’s jaw worked in silence—the answer he wouldn’t give already there.

Rachel sobbed.

The attorney looked away.

“Bob...” Gold’s voice faltered. “I’ve been having lapses—a lot of them. You know how we joke—my memory’s shit without a photograph? It’s even worse now. I remember walking past the temple on my way home—but not going inside. But the blood on my sleeves... I can’t explain it. Maybe I am guilty.

“The headaches are worse—not just migraines but tingling, lapses. Could it be fugue states? Schizophrenia—Son of Sam, Loughner?

“He placed his hands, palms up, on the table. “I don’t know.

I can't explain it. I know I'm innocent... but maybe I'm not. I couldn't—wouldn't—kill Shapiro. Or anyone. But maybe I would? Bob, I know it sounds crazy."

Two things can be right. God and Satan. Creator and creation. Love and guilt. Me and him.

I didn't kill him.

But his blood is on me.

"And what's strange—I'm not as bothered as I should be. Not numb, exactly. Wrong. I know I didn't do it, but I feel... detached. This morning—in the cell—I tried to feel something for Shapiro. Anything. Pity. Sorrow. Guilt. Nothing came. Nothing. Sociopathy? Cleckley's *Mask of Sanity*?"

Oldman leaned forward, voice low. "Stevie boy... I know your headaches are bad—gettin' worse. We'll run tests, a full neuropsych workup." He reached across the table, his hand settling on Gold's arm—brief anchor in the sterile room. The officer rapped the glass, shook his head, a silent reminder he was watching.

"Dr. Oldman, here's my concern. If we float a psych defense now, Judge Williams treats it as a 1026—NGRI—and bail's dead. Jurors hear 'psych' and think: he'll snap again." He turned to Gold. "The DA will tie you to St. Augustine—maybe even slide in the *Sanctuary Slayer*. And Williams—any jury—will assume that, as a psychologist, you know how to fake an insanity plea."

"But Eli—is there any choice? If I did it and just can't remember, I'll be locked up until I'm 'cured.'" He looked to Oldman, defeated, solemn. "I've worked in those places. They're not pretty."

Rachel steadied herself, breath catching. "Steven... what are you saying? Yes, the headaches are worse. And sometimes you come home late, forget to call or text. But whatever this is—it can be fixed."

"Bob—if it's whatever Steven's saying—DOD—that can be cured, right?"

"DID," Oldman said softly. "And no—'cured' isn't the right word." He reached across and took Rachel's hands. She released Gold reluctantly, her eyes caught in Oldman's steady, calming gaze.

“Rach, Katz can explain better than me, but if Stevie’s found NGRI, he still goes to prison—just the psychiatric kind.”

“Like the one in *One Flew Over the Cuckoo’s Nest*? I’d be able to visit, right?”

Katz looked down, then met her eyes. “Mrs. Gold—that’s the movies. Reality’s bleaker. If we skip NGRI, maybe we find a procedural path to not guilty—but the blood is a hurdle.”

Gold looked at Oldman.

Bob’s thinking the same thing I am. He’s worked there too.

A warehouse of broken minds and broken men—some shattered beyond repair, some sharper than you’d like.

Oldman’s eyelids and the corners of his mouth drooped. Gold had never spoken to Oldman about where he’d detoxed, but he imagined it was the same—only more screaming.

Doors slamming. Scripture screamed through the night. Waiting in the pill line then a guard checks under your tongue. Sharing a dayroom with men who strangled strangers—or stabbed their wives—and knew exactly what they were doing.

Gold glanced back at Rachel.

Fluorescent purgatory—stripped of choice, of Rachel, of meaning. Camus said the only serious question is whether to kill oneself.

In a place like that, that question would echo down every corridor.

Rachel was downcast, unconsciously biting her lip.

I couldn’t live knowing I’d done that to her—the humiliation, the waiting, alone. No children. No family. Jason, cut off. And Jane... estranged. Crazy.

Steven—” her voice firmed—“you’re not a murderer. I know you.”

“Do you? Do I even know myself anymore? You saw me

lose it with Shapiro at the book club—I’ve never behaved like that before.”

She looked from Katz to Oldman, her words slicing the air. “He’s not a case file. He’s my husband.” Then she turned back to Gold, her fingers still brushing his, eyes locked on his. “I love you. I need you. I can’t breathe without you. Stay the man I know. Don’t let go again.”

*She loves me. Or just the reflection in her mirror.
Mirrors everywhere—each one reflecting something
different, a shift of angle, of light. Not grotesque
funhouse distortions, but a hall of mirrors: subtle,
almost imperceptible.*

Who does she see?

Which one is me?

Gold’s voice was low, almost lost in the hum of the room.

“Which one?”

His chest tightened, as if his own reflection were pressing a hand against his heart.

CHAPTER FORTY-FOUR

The Janitor

Where does a thought go when it's forgotten?
— Sigmund Freud (attributed)

The sage does not show himself, therefore he shines.
— Lao Tzu, *Tao Te Ching* (6th century BCE)

*No one notices the janitor until the floor is dirty. But he's always there,
watching the footprints.*
— Steven Gold, *Journal of Existential Psychodynamics* (Winter 2025)

*Until you make the unconscious conscious, it will direct your life and you
will call it fate.*
— C.G. Jung, *Aion: Researches into the Phenomenology of the Self* (1951)

A system is never the sum of its parts; it's the product of their interactions.
— Russell Ackoff, "Towards a System of Systems Concepts," *Operations
Research* (Vol. 21, No. 3, 1973)

Monday, midmorning

"I texted Konotopoulos Gold's translation. Her expert's confirming it. With everything we've got, I doubt the DA gives a damn what it says."

Ryker steered into the underground lot and nodded toward the red van. "There. Half-worried he'd vanished."

They climbed the stairs to the engineering room beneath the sanctuary.

Tall and thin, dark hair spilling from a backward LAFC cap, he wore blue coveralls with a white oval patch over his chest pocket—Lucien stitched in cursive.

"Mr. Vega."

Vega rummaged in a red tool chest, AirPods in—clatter drowning Ryker's first call.

“Mr. Vega!” Ryker barked—voice cutting through the metal echo.

Vega’s head snapped up, blue eyes locked on Ryker. He tapped his left AirPods to silence the music and smiled—teeth white and even, almost too perfect.

“Sorry,” he said—Spanish accent softened at the edges by something half French, half Caribbean.

“I’m Detective Ryker, LAPD, and this is Detective Smythe.”

“What can I do for you, Detectives?”

“We understand you were the one who found the rabbi?”

“Yes, after the evening service. His wife called—said he hadn’t come home. Sometimes he works late in his study, but I didn’t see him there. I checked the sanctuary—and there he was. Pretty scary, actually.

“It was dark—just the ner tamid, which is always on. The rest of the lights are on timers. They were all off.”

Smythe asked, “See anything off during the service—anyone acting weird?” Ryker followed. “Anyone staring him down? Looking angry?”

“No—nothing I recall. The other detectives asked me the same thing Saturday night. I didn’t see anything strange. Heard on the news they’d already pinned it on Dr. Gold—‘the Sanctuary Slayer,’ they called him.

“Wouldn’t have guessed that. I heard about the fight...”

Ryker said, “Can you tell us about the fight? Were you there?”

“No, just heard about it. Everyone was talking about it. I heard he told Rabbi Shapiro to go fuck himself. Not something you’d expect from Dr. Gold.”

“Why’s that?”

“Well, he’s a Harvard-educated shrink—a sophisticated guy. You don’t expect those guys to lose it like that. And his wife was there—her family’s religious, they were founding members of the temple.

“But honestly, Rabbi Shapiro rubbed a lot of people wrong.”

Smythe asked, "Did you ever have any problems with him?"

"No, he was always polite to me, but occasionally I'd hear arguments through the door of his study."

Vega's eyes widened. "So... this wouldn't be the first time?"

"We can't talk about ongoing investigations," Ryker replied.

Vega nodded. "I understand."

"Back to Saturday. Did you remember anything later, after you spoke with the other detectives?"

"No. Nothing really."

"After Saturday's service, would the synagogue doors opening out to Wilshire normally be locked?"

"Yeah, usually. But Rabbi Shapiro told me that he'd lock them before he left. Almost like he was expecting someone."

"And the Canfield entrance?"

"Those lock automatically at 8 pm

"I was just taking care of cleanup and replacing a couple air filters in the offices. I was just getting my things together, about to leave, when Mrs. Shapiro called."

Smythe was looking around the office and said, "Once the synagogue's Wilshire doors are locked, then the only way in would be through the office, right? Just wondering if anyone else might have seen anyone come or go."

"I was the only one here. After the synagogue doors are locked, I'd have seen anyone come or go through the office entrance. Wait—if you want, I can show you the video."

"Thanks, we already got the video—no one entered from the Canfield Street side; those doors were locked."

"We might have you take a look at the clip from the Wilshire side. See if you see anything that looks strange."

Vega said, "No—I meant the synagogue video."

Ryker perked up. "Video from inside the sanctuary? You installed cameras in there?"

"Yeah—well just one. The Board got nervous after the church murders down the street, so they had me install a camera in

the sanctuary—by the ner tamid, aimed at the bimah and congregation. I figured they knew—we talked right by the office monitors.”

“Boss—this could have the whole thing. Total slam dunk.”

“I thought the police would’ve gotten that. I’m sure I mentioned it to the detectives on Saturday.”

“They might’ve thought you were talking about the outside cameras. Can you show me the system?”

“Yeah, just over here.” Vega walked over to an open laptop computer on the desk, typed for a moment or two and said, “Here it is.”

Smythe whistled. “Jesus, Boss.”

Ryker and Smythe stared over Vega’s shoulder, looking at the laptop screen. A grainy black-and-white live video of the synagogue played.

Vega said, “This is the staging display. Once I place the request, it processes and renders in color—1080p. But going back to Saturday will take a little while.”

“We’re due in court, but do you think you can pull Saturday’s footage to a thumb drive for us?” Ryker snapped his fingers to Smythe and gestured toward the stairs. “Grab a drive and transfer form.”

Smythe went down the stairs to the car.

“Sure, but I have to put in the request. It’ll process then download. Whole day will take a few hours.”

Ryker thought for a moment. “No, just Saturday 5:00 pm until 10:00 pm. Want me to have a police tech help you?”

Vega shrugged. “System autosaves everything to the cloud, Detective. Even if this laptop died, it’s still up there—safe.”

Ryker nodded. “Good. That’s what I needed to know.”

Smythe came back holding two thumb drives and an empty evidence bag with some papers inside.

“They’re both high speed, 1 TB,” Smythe said. “Should be more than enough space.”

Smythe handed Vega a small carbon form.

“Sign here—just confirms you’re holding the footage until transfer. Keeps the chain clean.”

Vega signed without reading it, tapping the line with a smudge of grease. “No problem.”

Ryker tapped the empty evidence bag. “Once it’s done, drop the drive in here and seal it before you leave.”

Vega paused, then nodded. “Got it. I’ll get it for you and bring it to you this afternoon.”

“You sure you don’t want me to have an officer come pick it up?” Ryker asked.

Vega shook his head. “No need. I live in Echo Park—couple miles away. Besides, it gives me an excuse to knock off early.”

He clicked his tongue and winked—like a man sharing a harmless secret he didn’t quite believe himself.

Ryker wrote the room number on his card and handed it to Vega. “We really appreciate this, Lucien. Bring it to the Clara Shortridge Foltz Criminal Justice Center—Department 42. I’ll be there all afternoon. It’ll be a big help.”

“Kind of exciting,” Vega said. “See you soon.”

Smythe had a bounce in his step. “Can you believe it? The murder’s going to be on video. Not that the DA doesn’t have enough already—but at trial, this might be all they need. Jury’ll get the day off. Hell, so will we.”

Ryker remained guarded.

“You sure you don’t want me to stay and bring the drive myself, Boss?”

“No. We’re good. We can trust him. He didn’t disappear. Besides, having a uniformed officer here might slow things down.”

They headed for the stairs.

Smythe whistled off-key.

“Shut up, Smythe.”

CHAPTER FORTY-FIVE

The Fall

Those who can make you believe absurdities can make you commit atrocities.
— Voltaire, *Questions sur les Miracles* (1765)

The voice of your brother's blood cries out to me from the ground.
— Genesis, KJV (1611)

"The worst sin toward our fellow creatures is not to hate them, but to be indifferent to them: that's the essence of inhumanity." — George Bernard Shaw, *The Devil's Disciple* (1897)

No one destroys reputations more effectively than the mob.
— Steven Gold, *Journal of Existential Psychodynamics* (2025)

Monday, afternoon

Cameras clicked and flashed the instant Rachel and Oldman stepped from their Uber onto the steps of the Clara Shortridge Foltz Criminal Justice Center. Reporters surged like a breaking tide, microphones jabbing toward her face.

Above the crowd, placards bobbed—**No Sanctuary for the Slayer. Thou Shalt Not Kill. God Sees All. Blood on Your Hands.**

"Mrs. Gold—do you believe your husband is *the Sanctuary Slayer*? Do you think he'll walk free?"

Rachel froze—her chest constricting until breath became impossible.

The old headlines seared back: *Sacrilege and Slaughter. The Devil at the Parish. Priest Crucified, Nun Slain.*

Now he bore the name they branded him with—*The Sanctuary Slayer*.

The label burned like a brand. Her knees nearly gave way on the courthouse steps.

It was everywhere—cable, radio, the endless scroll of feeds. Photographers had camped outside their house for days, lenses targeting each window. Flashes exploding whenever she opened the door or peeked through a shade. An avalanche of shutter clicks at any movement—a silhouette, a shadow behind glass.

Oldman plowed through the crush like a pulling tackle, carving a narrow lane with his shoulders.

“Dr. Oldman—are you Gold’s psychiatrist? Is he schizophrenic?”

“Mrs. Gold—weren’t you bat mitzvahed by Rabbi Shapiro?”

“Mrs. Gold—does your husband hate religion? Should clergy be afraid?”

“Mrs. Gold—does Dr. Gold worship Satan?”

“Did Gold kill the priest and nun at St. Augustine’s? Is he the Sanctuary Slayer?”

It felt like a stoning. The *Atlantic* piece that had once elevated him now gave them a script.

She pressed against Oldman’s arm, but there was no escape. Foam-tipped microphones grazed her cheeks, knocking her Chanel sunglasses askew and exposing the bloodshot eyes beneath.

“Back off!” Oldman’s voice was gravel, his bulk a wall. “Keep moving,” he muttered, muscling her forward. Rachel’s arm was locked in his—Prada clutch in one hand, a handkerchief streaked with mascara in the other.

Inside, the courthouse was stripped of frenzy. Phones surrendered at security. No cameras, no shouting—just varnish and stale air along the corridors. Still, the words echoed in her skull—*Sanctuary Slayer. Satan worshiper. Schizophrenic.*

The courtroom doors yawned open—packed. Journalists jammed one side, congregants the other. Every eye pivoted toward the defense table. **Steven Gold.**

Rachel’s breath caught. They got what they wanted—the *Sanctuary Slayer*’s wife, caught in her first glimpse of him in court. Shock. Fear. The hollowing of hope.

Gold sat in gray county scrubs, glasses smudged, stubble shadowing sallow skin. His hair lay matted, pressed flat by the cot.

Shoulders caved, hands slack—he seemed smaller. Diminished. Resigned. **Already condemned.**

Gold turned slightly. For a heartbeat their eyes met. She tried to smile—lips trembling. No cameras now, only the weight of every gaze, heavier than flashbulbs. His glasses slipped; he gave the faintest nod.

The clerk called the case. The judge, stern above the bench, intoned, “Case number 25-CR-4179, People v. Steven Gold—murder under Penal Code 187.”

The judge asked, “Dr. Gold, do you understand the charges?”

I understand that I'll be punished regardless. If I don't remember doing it, then I'm guilty and insane. If it was an accident, then—but for me, he'd be alive. His blood is on my hands regardless of this outcome.

The courtroom doesn't weigh truth—it only weighs what it sees.

Katz rose. “Your Honor, we waive formal reading. My client pleads *not guilty*.”

A hush swept the room—waiting for the words *by reason of insanity*. They never came.

Deputy District Attorney Richardson rose at once. “Your Honor, the People request remand without bail. The defendant appears on Ring video entering the synagogue before the murder, and the victim's blood was found on his shirt. In light of the St. Augustine killings, the religious community is fearful. His release would endanger the public.”

Gasps rippled through the gallery. Rachel's stomach coiled tight.

The judge leaned forward. “Mr. Richardson, are you filing charges against Dr. Gold for the St. Augustine murders today?”

“No, Your Honor.”

“Then we will not try uncharged crimes in this courtroom. Do you agree, Mr. Richardson?”

He bowed his head slightly. “Yes, Your Honor.” Katz tried to disguise a pleased smirk.

The courtroom was already restless when the doors opened again. Vega, still in coveralls, slipped inside, breathless—then the sealed evidence bag appeared, clutched tight against his chest.

Detective Ryker, seated just behind the prosecution table, rose halfway to meet him. Vega pressed the bag into his hands and whispered something Rachel couldn't catch. Ryker nodded once, extracted the thumb drive, and slid it to the prosecution table.

Richardson nodding appreciatively, took it, and turned back toward the bench.

"Your Honor, this is video evidence recovered from inside the synagogue at the time of the murder. The People request permission to present it immediately."

The gallery erupted—gasps, shouts, benches scraping.

Katz turned to Gold, who was looking down, lost in thought. "Steven, what's this going to show?"

Gold looked up, hollow-eyed. "The answer to Pilate's question—'What is truth?'" He looked down again.

Katz shook his head. Puzzled. Disappointed. Fearful.

But Light said, "Truth isn't binary."

The gavel cracked like a gunshot. "Order. This is an arraignment, not a trial. If the People insist on presenting evidence, the courtroom will be cleared. Only counsel, the defendant, deputies, and Detective Ryker—as case agent—may remain."

The gallery slowly emptied—benches creaking, chairs scraping—until the heavy door slammed shut.

Katz rose. "Your Honor, in light of the extreme media frenzy and the prejudice already inflamed against my client and his wife, I request that Mrs. Gold be permitted to remain—and that Dr. Robert Oldman, the defendant's psychiatrist, be allowed to view the video as well."

The judge said, "This is an unusual request, but if Mr. Richardson has no objection, I'll allow it. However, Mr. Katz, you've already entered a plea of not guilty. I will not have this footage used to turn the proceedings into a circus or to ambush the District Attorney with an insanity plea. Otherwise, we'll invite the People's psychiatrist as well."

“I understand your honor. No, our plea stands—*not guilty*, full stop.” He cast a glance at Gold, his head still down.

“Mr. Richardson?”

“No objection, Your Honor. But I’d also ask that the victim’s wife be permitted to remain, should she choose to do so.”

The judge slammed her gavel again. “Only counsel, the defendant, deputies, and the case agent—and by courtesy, the victim’s widow and the defendant’s wife—may remain. We’ll take a brief recess to set up the video equipment.”

The room convulsed in protest. Reporters shouted as bailiffs herded them out. Karen Shapiro sat rigid in the front row, face pale but steady. Karen—here—allowed to stay.

Their eyes met across the aisle. Rachel willed compassion into her gaze, but Karen’s cold stare gutted her—not anger, not blame, but a grief so vast it hollowed the air. Rachel wished she could vanish.

Oldman squeezed her arm. “You can do this,” he whispered, guiding her forward as the bailiff motioned them past the rail. Gold was already being led toward the bench. Katz leaned in, voice low.

“Steven, if this shows the murder, it could bury you. The rabbi’s blood was on your shirtsleeves. Are you absolutely certain? Let me come up with a way to postpone this proceeding.”

Gold shook his head sharply, his glasses slipping down his nose.

“I didn’t do it. I don’t know who did, but I’m not a murderer.”

Except for my father.

Maybe this will be my punishment for that murder.

Katz studied him for a long moment, then turned toward the bench.

Rachel slid into the defense row, Karen opposite—two wives bound by the same tragedy. The bailiff turned the key; the heavy doors clanked shut. The chamber sealed like a tomb.

Richardson stepped forward holding the thumb drive.

“Your Honor, the People are prepared to proceed.”

The judge gave a curt nod.

“Play it.”

The large monitor flickered to life.

Richardson dragged the progress bar, scanning for the relevant moment. “I apologize, Your Honor—this is my first time viewing the footage as well.”

“I trust you’re not wasting the court’s time.” Judge Williams’s eyes caught the pristine image and time code. She leaned forward, intent.

An image appeared. The camera—mounted on the side wall near the *ner tamid* and the ark—captured the entire sanctuary.

Richardson advanced the footage. The sanctuary stood empty except for Rabbi Shapiro, arranging a few items on the bimah. Karen began to sob.

Gold entered, climbed the steps, and said, “Aaron, I’m sorry about the fight. I lost my temper. I’ve been going through something—forgetting things at times, not myself. I don’t blame you for Rachel.”

Rachel gasped—the sound splintering the hush like glass. She looked at him. Detached. Distant. As if another man occupied the screen.

Shapiro strode toward Gold until they were nearly nose to nose. “You embarrassed me in front of the entire book club. You deliberately call me ‘Aaron’ to avoid showing the respect I’m due as head rabbi. I’m sorry about Rachel. She was too young to have that child—alone—and under those circumstances. It was early enough to abort.”

Rachel’s tears blurred her view. She looked at Gold. “Bob, I want to run to him.” Oldman’s steady hand anchored her in place.

The video showed Gold throw up his arms. He shouted, “I came here to apologize! I hate your religious hypocrisy. The truth is, you convinced her and her parents that she should abort. Why? You knew she wanted to keep the child. It didn’t make sense. I’ve heard you quote the Mishnah, ‘Whoever destroys a single life, it is as if he had destroyed an entire world and the commandment,’ and the

commandment, ‘You shall not murder.’ But then you convince her parents to do exactly that. Why?”

Judge Williams cut in. Richardson froze the frame. “Mr. Richardson, the court’s time is valuable. Locate the criminal act, not a therapy session.”

“With respect, Your Honor, this context bears directly on motive. As I mentioned, I haven’t viewed the footage myself, but based on the time stamp, the incident should occur momentarily. Mrs. Shapiro, you may wish to look away.” He pressed play.

“Steven, I’ve never told anyone this—and I expect it to remain confidential—but I was once in a similar position. As a college freshman, I got my high-school girlfriend pregnant. She was three years younger; legally it would have been statutory rape. She decided to have and raise the child on her own, but I wouldn’t marry her.”

We’re all guilty.

Karen gasped and bowed her head, shame radiating—not for herself, but for the man she loved: the father of her children, the temple’s rabbi.

Judge Williams muttered, “This is straying far beyond relevance.”

Shapiro continued, “I was young and immature. I disappeared—and I saw what became of that mother and child. I still regret it. They were both killed in a tragic car accident, which I’ve always believed was my punishment from God.”

Rachel gulped, her hand gripping Oldman’s knee.

“Are you fucking crazy? You’re that egotistical—to think God would punish you by killing two innocents? That’s exactly what I mean about religion. If there were a God, would He take their lives just to make you feel guilty? What an asshole—Him and you both.” Gold turned to walk away then spun back and burst out, “How many lives have you ruined with your pride, your ego, your religion? If God exists—and if He is good—you’d be punished.”

“Steven, my guilt has been more punishment than I can bear.”

Gold shook his head and turned away.

“Steven.” Shapiro reached for his arm. Without turning

back, Gold jerked his arm free. Shapiro slipped, losing balance. Gold lunged to catch him but missed—Shapiro toppled backward, his head striking the floor.

Rachel's breath caught—echoing in the courtroom.

Something in Gold went quiet—like a switch thrown in a dark room.

Motionless. Blood pooling. Gold's face went slack, distant—the same hollow look he wore now, watching yet not watching the video. He didn't offer aid, didn't show a flicker of emotion. The man standing over Shapiro wasn't him at all—and the part of him that should have rushed to help was simply gone. He turned and walked from the sanctuary.

Gold recognized it instantly—the clinical distance, the psychic anesthesia. Dissociation, not malice. On a screen, there would be no difference.

Richardson stopped the video.

Katz sprang to his feet. “Your Honor, this was clearly an accident—neither homicide nor even involuntary manslaughter. There was no intent.”

Gold felt the word accident buckle under its own weight. It was too small to carry what had just happened.

Judge Williams sat wide-eyed. Karen wept openly. The confession—and the death—were simply too much.

Rachel clung to Oldman. Both turned toward Gold. He sat utterly still. The man on the screen might as well have been someone else.

Rachel stared at him. He mistook the fear in her eyes for judgment. He would not understand the difference until much later.

Judge Williams began, “In light of this evidence...”

Ryker cleared his throat.

“Excuse me, Your Honor. The cause of death wasn't the fall—it was a severed jugular, cut by the yad.”

The hand of God.

“We haven't yet seen the writing in blood on the wall. This still

doesn't explain the blood on the defendant's shirt."

The whole truth?

No one moved.

Had silence already passed judgment?

CHAPTER FORTY-SIX

All That Glitters Is Not Gold

Trust no secret, for Time will bring it to light.
— Sophocles, *Oedipus Rex* (paraphrased, c. 429 BCE).

Nothing in all creation is hidden from God's sight...
— Hebrews, KJV (1611)

God sees everything, and waits.
— Fyodor Dostoevsky, (paraphrased)

If you can't see the pattern, you're probably part of it.
— Steven Gold, *Notes on Therapy* (2024)

Monday, afternoon

Ryker's voice stayed flat. "The body wasn't in that position when we found it. Let's see what the video shows. Your Honor, may DA Richardson continue playing the video?"

Light said Cain was unfairly blamed for Abel's death.

All eyes turned to Judge Williams—except Gold, adrift in his own private fog. "Good point, Detective. Yes, let's use the video to get to the truth."

A process cannot be understood by stopping it.

Some lies are easier to believe than the truth.

Gold blinked. The words scraped something raw inside him—a memory half formed, half feared.

Oldman studied him, troubled but not surprised.

Karen, still weeping, glanced at Rachel, dabbed her eyes, and forced herself back to the screen.

Katz remained seated. The room held its breath as Richardson hit play.

Gold exited. The sanctuary doors slammed, the echo rolling like thunder across stone.

Footsteps. Slow. Uneven.

Three deliberate claps. Then laughter—low, jagged, unhinged—mocking prayer itself.

That voice.

He had heard it before—close enough to feel on his skin.

Judge Williams leaned forward. “Can you fix the lighting? Exposure? Anything?”

“No, but the camera should switch to night vision automatically any second now.”

A figure stirred in the right front row, moving toward the bimah. The camera hadn’t switched yet—only blackness, the laughter swelling closer, too close.

The feed snapped into night vision—grainy, ghost-lit, drained of color. The bimah table floated in the haze; something metallic glinted faintly beside a shadowed book, an arrangement both sacred and spectral.

Ryker squinted. “Is that... Vega?”

Richardson frowned. “Vega?”

“The janitor who found him—and handed me this video,” Ryker said.

Katz leaned forward, voice tight. “Then why hand it over? A confession?”

Oldman leaned closer, brow furrowed. Something about it tugged at recognition.

A low voice whispered: “Maybe God is punishing you, rabbi... saving me the trouble. You’ve got much to be sorry for... much to be punished for.” The terrifying words clung like smoke, followed by a hoarse, broken laugh.

Karen buried her face in her hands. “I can’t—can’t watch this.”

Perfume?

Gold turned his head and sniffed the air.

Memory isn't evidence—unless it convicts you.

Richardson paused the video. Karen staggered to the door. “Aaron was a good man... human, fallible... he was a good man.” Handkerchief pressed to her mouth, she pushed toward the exit.

Rachel turned from Oldman to the bench. “Someone should be with her. This isn’t her fault. She can’t be alone—out there.”

The judge pointed to a deputy. “Mrs. Shapiro—don’t open those doors.”

It was too late. The hall roared—shouts, flashes, bodies pressing in. Reporters swarmed Karen like piranhas in a feeding frenzy.

Judge Williams banged her gavel and shouted, “Lopez! Take Mrs. Shapiro—my chambers.”

Lopez yanked Karen back inside as cameras snapped wildly, a feeding frenzy still howling beyond the door. The door slammed shut, leaving silence as abrupt as a cut. Lopez guided her out through a side corridor.

Judge Williams said, “DA Richardson, proceed.”

Richardson tapped the three-second back button and pressed play—

“...saving me the trouble. You’ve got much to be sorry for... much to be punished for.”

Rachel’s hand rose to her throat—too fast to stop—and closed around the chain before she realized she’d moved.

A match flared near the bimah—a sudden halo of fire as a hand touched flame to the waiting wick. The silver *yad* gleamed in the glow, a prayer book lay half open beneath. In that thin, trembling light, Shapiro’s body sprawled at the foot of the lectern like an abandoned offering.

“I know that voice,” Oldman whispered—his own catching, as if he’d recognized a ghost wearing someone else’s skin and feared that naming it might summon something evil.

CHAPTER FORTY-SEVEN

Karma's a Bitch

Every man is guilty of all the good he did not do.
— Voltaire, *Philosophical Dictionary* (1764)

Justice is a machine that, when it functions, is blind; but when it malfunctions, has a thousand eyes.
— Octavio Paz, *Corriente Alterna* (1967)

Monday, afternoon

“It’s her.” Oldman whispered—voice steadier now.

He turned to Rachel. “You know it too.”

“No... no. It can’t be.”

Earlier that day—though only a handful would ever know—her DNA app buzzed:

Parent/Child Match Detected.

Estimated shared DNA: 49%

Predicted relationship: Parent/Child.

She typed into the messaging box: I’m your biological mother. Please...

The message flashed *read*.

Moments later the profile blocked her.

A lifeline she’d waited her whole life to grasp was cut—snapped clean, the last tie severed.

The video continued playing.

Jane’s voice rose, low and broken. “Do you know what happened today? She found me—or I found her. Forty-nine percent. My own blood. I begged her to answer, to let me in—she blocked me. Blocked me. Like I was a stranger. Nothing.”

I knew I'd be blamed.

She advanced, eyes blazing white in grainy black and white. “You did this. You and your papers—the signatures, the sealed files, the lies. You stole her from me—and now even she wants nothing to do with me.”

Her voice cracked into a hoarse scream. “You took my daughter, rabbi—again.

I’ve lost her all over again!”

“Who is that woman?” Richardson asked.

Rachel looked at Oldman. Both stayed silent.

Shapiro stirred, voice faint, groggy. “Help... help me, please.” His hand lifted weakly toward Jane.

“Help you?” Her voice dripped with scorn. “You dare ask me? Should I help you the way you helped me? You stole the only one I loved—the only one who could have loved me.”

Shapiro whispered, breath rasping. “I’m... sorry. It was best for the child. You couldn’t... be her mother. Breaking all communication was best.”

“You buried her alive so I’d never find her.

And now that I have, she turns from me—because of you.”

Jane extended her right hand as if to lift him—then, with her left, plunged the *yad* into his neck.

“Best to cut all ties!”

The strike was crude, fast, packed with all the years between.

A single blow—and history rerouted.

Gold’s body jolted. Not fear—certainty.

Justice never balances—it just tips.

Shapiro jerked, then sagged, as if the room itself exhaled.

“Karma’s a bitch, eh rabbi?”

Shapiro fell back, arms flung wide, blood spurting from his

neck. His yarmulke rolled aside, already stained.

Jane twisted violently—hair whipping like a storm—and fled the sanctuary.

CHAPTER FORTY-EIGHT

The Writing on the Wall

When we are no longer able to change a situation, we are challenged to change ourselves.

— Viktor Frankl, *Man's Search for Meaning* (1946)

Not everyone in the story makes it to the end.

That doesn't make them less real.

— Steven Gold, *Case notes*

No man ever steps in the same river twice, for it's not the same river and he's not the same man.

— Heraclitus, *Fragments* (5th century BCE)

The truth is rarely pure and never simple.

— Oscar Wilde, *The Importance of Being Earnest* (1895)

There are no clean slates, only rewritten pages.

— Steven Gold, *Journal of Existential Psychodynamics* (2026)

Monday, afternoon

“Who is that woman?” Richardson asked, his voice tight with unease.

Ryker said, “We’ve got an SID tech who might be able to clean up the images so we get a better look at her. We’ll get on it right away.”

Sharp, floral. Impossible here.

Rachel whispered, “Thank God Karen left. She shouldn’t have to see this.” Oldman gave a grave nod.

Katz turned to Judge Williams, “Your Honor, it’s clear Dr. Gold is not the perpetrator... and I move for immediate reconsideration of custody and recommend dismissal with prejudice pending the Court’s review.”

Richardson turned to the judge and said, “The People have no objection to dismissal based on the evidence so far presented. I recommend we proceed toward dismissal with prejudice. Dr. Gold and his wife have certainly suffered. They should not be additional victims of this heinous crime.”

Rachel’s hands tightened on Oldman’s shoulders, a smile breaking through her tears.

Ryker cut in. “I agree—the woman did this. But look.” He pointed at the frozen screen: a blur of hair, Shapiro sprawled behind her.

Judge Williams said, “I’m sorry, Detective. What are we looking at? What am I missing?”

“The wall’s still clean. No writing.”

Williams nodded. “Mr. Richardson, can you hit play, so we can end this mystery.”

Richardson clicked the Play icon and the video continued.

Jane twisted violently, loose strands of hair snapping against her cheeks as she drifted down the aisle, murmuring, low and broken: “karma... karma...”

Light flared at the edge of the frame, revealing Gold re-entering the synagogue.

I heard something... didn't I? I was going to apologize—to say something—but for what? What had happened? Did I already know, and just refuse to see it?

He saw Jane. “What—what are you doing here? You’re bleeding.” He reached, but she swept past him, toward the exit.

She screamed, “You! Your fault! Karma—you’re next!”

A flash from the sanctuary door—and she was gone.

She’s right. I am guilty.

But for me, Shapiro would be alive.

If I hadn’t gone into the room with her, none of this would’ve ever happened.

Every sin finds a mirror.

Rachel gripped Oldman's arm, "Bob?" Her gaze shifted to Gold, his eyes locked on the screen, reliving the moment.

"Decisions often carry unintended consequences."

Light's words echoed.

Jane's gone. Could she come back?

Can I?

Gold walked to Shapiro's body—crouched down, cradling the rabbi's head.

"I'm sorry... Aaron. Rabbi. I'm so sorry." He lowered the head gently.

"Find peace in your heaven."

His blood-slick fingers traced the symbols across the wall—directionless, ancient, unbound by any script. He wiped his hands on his long sleeves, walked down the aisle, and left the video screen.

Richardson froze the frame. Silence.

The *ner tamid* glowed faint above—eternal light against the dark.

Shapiro's body lay cruciform at the lectern's foot, eyes lifted toward the writing on the wall. Darkness pressed close—except at the edge where a flare of light intruded.

Ryker nodded his head, mystery solved.

So many butterflies... and every flutter sets something in motion—every choice, every silence. Step on one without meaning to and the whole world changes. Even the ants we crush without thought leave their mark. Intention doesn't matter. We're all guilty.

For the first time since the video began, Gold spoke. He turned, facing Rachel and Oldman. "Rachel. Bob." His face flickered with recognition, as if waking from a dream.

"Bob—I need help."

I still hear it—that sound. A shift of air; a scrape... something. I don't trust the memory; I don't trust

myself. Did I know? Or am I inventing guilt because I can't bear the alternative?

"Bob, I... I think something's wrong with me.

"I think I have DID."

"DID?" Richardson asked.

Oldman leaned forward. "Dissociative Identity Disorder. Multiple identities. Memory gaps. Almost always rooted in trauma."

"Schizophrenia?"

He could feel the courtroom deciding what kind of man he was.

"No," Oldman said. "Not psychosis. Not delusion. It's identity itself that fractures—splintered states, lost time."

"I don't think Light exists," Gold said softly, regret clouding his voice.

But does Steven Gold still exist? Did he ever?

Richardson asked Oldman, "What does he mean light doesn't exist? Is that depression?"

"No. Light was a patient he'd been seeing... thought he'd been seeing."

"Samael Light." Ryker said.

Oldman nodded toward Ryker. "Yes. He wasn't... ever in the room, Detective. He felt like a patient—but he wasn't real."

Then Oldman turned back to Gold. "Stevie, you're right. Pretty sure it's DID. Light existed, exists—one part of your dissociated self."

Gold smiled.

Oldman said, "Now the healing can begin."

Healing, yes. But absolution is a myth for any thinking being.

Rachel, crying, crossed the courtroom and sank onto Gold's lap, wrapping her arms around him. She whispered, hugging him tightly, "Steven—I can't live without you. Come back to me."

He held her tight, eyes awakening, the Saturday-morning

smile flickering back.

“Rachel... I was afraid I hurt you. Lost you. You’re my life.”

Ryker asked, “Dr. Oldman—like Jekyll and Hyde? Or Sybil?”

Oldman shook his head. “Stevenson’s story was allegory, not science. But it caught a truth. Samael Light wasn’t a scapegoat or a trick. He was a compartmentalized self—rage, guilt, rebellion—split off, given voice. That fracture became Light.”

Rachel asked, “Like a mask?”

Oldman shook his head. “No—a fracture. People with DID can show distinct voices, mannerisms, even handwriting. They lose time when the other identity is in control.

“Stevie—Light is real... to you. He is you, the part you couldn’t face.”

Ryker asked, “What did you write, Dr. Gold?”

Gold hesitated. “I... I didn’t even know I was writing. But seeing it there, hearing it... yes.

“I wrote: Find peace in your heaven.

“That’s what was etched on Light’s ring.

“The words I spoke to one dying man... now to another.”

Too late, he saw the answer he should have given. Just as clearly, he saw that it would not have changed anything.

CHAPTER FORTY-NINE

Justice Isn't Always Blind

Nothing in this world is harder than speaking the truth, nothing easier than flattery.

— Fyodor Dostoevsky, *Demons* (1872)

The tongue may conceal the truth, but the eyes—never.

— Mikhail Bulgakov, *The Master and Margarita* (1930s; published 1967)

The eyes of the Lord are in every place, keeping watch on the evil and the good.

— Proverbs, KJV (1611)

Monday, late afternoon

Judge Williams tapped the gavel block.

“All charges against Dr. Gold are dismissed, with prejudice. Deputy, remove the cuffs.”

His hands were free, but freedom didn't feel like innocence.

Katz clasped Gold's shoulder. “Congratulations, Dr. Gold.”

Gold's eyes welled as the words sank in.

Rachel clutched his arm, trembling. “Steven—I love you.”

Oldman swept him into a bear hug. “Theah ya go, Stevie. Glad ta have ya back. But we got work ta do!” He lifted Gold off the floor, laughing. “Maybe I'll spring fuh new cahpet, so you won't wahry about any muggahs.”

Gold turned to Katz and Richardson. “Thank you both.” He shook their hands in turn.

Outside, Katz strode into the swarm of reporters, cameras flashing as he basked in the spotlight.

Gold crossed to Ryker and offered his hand. “Thank you, Detective—for not giving up.”

Ryker's voice stayed flat. “It's my job.” But one corner of

his mouth twitched, reluctant warmth behind the mask.

“You told me you were innocent. Something in the way you said it felt real. But this isn’t over. “You’re tied to her—whether you know it or not.” He cast a glance at Rachel, quickly looking away when their eyes met. “She’s dangerous—and she said you’re next. You’re not safe. Neither is your wife.”

Rachel’s breath caught; she couldn’t meet his eyes. Gold’s grip tightened on Rachel. He said, “Yes. We know that now. Her name is Jane Sanders.”

Ryker’s brow rose. “The supermodel?”

Gold nodded. “Yes, she’s Rachel’s sister.”

Ryker exhaled. “We’ll pick her up. But until she’s in custody, I want a patrol car outside your house.”

Rachel stepped forward, hugged Ryker, who stiffened with embarrassment, and kissed him on his cheek. “Thank you Detective. I’ll give you Jane’s contact information. Please—be gentle. There’s no excuse for her crime, but she’s had a hard life, and it’s pushed her over the edge.”

Rachel turned back to Gold. They walked to the side of the courtroom. Oldman gave them their space.

“Steven, I was terrified. You really had no idea? You swore you were innocent. I’m sorry I ever doubted you, but the blood...”

He wrapped his arms around her, dropped his head onto her shoulder, burying his nose in the nape of her neck. He whispered, “Rach, I was doubting myself. I knew something was wrong. From the start, I suspected Samael Light might have been dissociative.” He smiled faintly. “I guess he was—we were—after all.”

She drew back, searching his eyes. “Steven, will it continue? Or is this some sudden cure?”

He drew her close, his voice low but steady. “Rach, it doesn’t vanish overnight. DID isn’t cured by one revelation. But it can, and will, get better—with therapy, time, and patience. The dissociated parts can learn to live together. It isn’t magic, Rach; it’s work. And I’m ready to do it—for you... for us.”

She touched his cheek. “So there’s hope?”

He smiled and kissed her on her nose. “Yes,” he said. “I’ll

have to get in touch with my feelings—the ones I needed Light to deal with—but there's hope."

Gold gestured for Bob to join them. "Bob, let Rachel know what to expect."

Oldman took her hands in his, lowering his voice. "Rach, this ain't no magic cure. Truth is, there ain't no cure. Dissociation's how the mind keeps from breakin' when life gets too much. Light wasn't madness—he was Stevie's shield.

"The mind don't just drop its shield and surrendah overnight. It's careful, cautious—lowers it slow-like, only when it starts to trust again. It takes work, wicked hahd work."

"But he will get better, right?"

"Yeah, he will. Stevie's got what matters most—love. We'll get him the right help. We'll get ouah Stevie back. But I gotta be honest, Rach. With most people it takes yeahs—that's what the research shows. Stevie's smaht, motivated, and, knowin' him, he'll outperform everyone's expectations. With his Haavaht background, I wouldn't be suhprised if he comes back fastah than anyone I've seen."

Oldman shot a glance to Gold, "With his Haavaht background, I wouldn't be suhprised if he didn't come back faster than anyone else has from this."

"Will he need to be medicated?"

"No, probably not. Treatment is mostly different types of psychotherapy—not drugs. He may still see Samael Light from time to time—ghosts of his own making—but that don't mean he's losin' ground. There might even be others he don't yet realize ahn't separate—he might still think they're real."

Rachel shuddered. "Others?"

"It's possible."

"But he knows Light's not real, right?"

"Yes and no. He knows Light's not a different person, but as a paht of Stevie, he is real—to Stevie. It's not a delusion, it's Stevie dealin' with different pieces of himself that splintered due to some trauma. That's what the psychiatrist and Stevie will work on—identifying and re-integrating those pieces of his personality that have

split off.

“He’ll get better, I promise you, because I’m going to be holdin’ his hand...” Oldman turned to Gold and smiled, “and kickin’ his ass along the way.”

Gold smiled and chuckled. “I love you, Bobby.”

He kissed Oldman’s bald head, then stepped back, whistling a shaky bar of the Old Spice theme—half-joke, half-nervous release.

“Guess we oughta let the press have their shots. And I want my wedding band back—I feel naked without it.”

Rachel kissed Oldman on his cheek. She clasped Gold’s hand in hers.

Gold barely touched the door before it blew open and the roar crashed in. Reporters and spectators surged. The angry placards were gone. Flashbulbs detonated. Microphones thrust forward like bayonets.

“Dr. Gold, how do you feel?”

“The DA said you saw the murderer. Do you know her?”

“Mrs. Gold, did you know your husband was innocent?”

Is anyone innocent? I wasn't the murderer—but we all carry the mark of Cain.

But for one butterfly—how many lives have I changed without ever knowing?

Gold lifted his hands, the din softening around him. “Please—just a moment.”

Red lights blinked from phones and cameras, the hallway glowing with silent eyes.

For a moment he couldn’t find his voice. Then he could feel the mask slide into place.

“First, I want to say how deeply sorry I am for this painful loss of Rabbi Shapiro. He’s been taken from his family—a wife, two children, and an entire community.”

Gold’s eyes welled.

“I’m not a religious man. Rabbi Shapiro and I argued plenty—sometimes loudly—but we respected each other’s faith... and our

doubts.”

Mauvaise foi? No. I respected him—just thought he was mistaken. Maybe we both were.

“No one should be punished for belief—or disbelief. We need to keep asking questions, and listening to the answers. Sometimes the asking changes us more than the answers could.”

He spotted Ryker at the edge of the crowd, head bent over his phone. “Detective Ryker kept asking—kept pushing—for the truth. Thank you.”

He looked to Rachel, then to Oldman, “My wife. My best friend. You kept me standing when I couldn’t stand on my own.”

Facing the reporters again, he steadied his breath. “There is a suspect—but she’s not connected to the St. Augustine murders.”

*Wait. Light said he was in town briefly last year.
Why am I doing this to myself?*

A reporter shouted from the crowd. “The DA said you saw, talked to, the rabbi’s murderer. Do you know her? Are you going to testify against her?”

From the back, another reporter lifted her phone high and shouted, “Did you have a relationship with her, with the murderer?”

Gold ignored the jabs. “We can’t control others—only ourselves. But what we do ripples outward.”

Rachel flinched, her hand squeezing Gold’s tightly.

“The Mishnah says: ‘Whoever saves one life, it is as if he saved an entire world.’ Its shadow truth is that whoever destroys one life destroys a world. Rabbi Shapiro’s family has lost their world. A reason is never an excuse.

“So please—no celebration. Let’s take a moment—for Rabbi Shapiro, for those he left behind. Ask yourself—or whatever name you give God—how something like this can happen. Demand the answers... and be ready for the responsibility they bring. Rabbi Aaron Joshua Shapiro, may his memory be a blessing.”

Gold bowed his head. The hallway stilled—only camera shutters ticking like clocks.

Rachel's hand tightened around his.

He looked up. "We're all responsible for how we make others feel. It's hard, but we have to try—to imagine what it's like to wear someone else's shoes, then walk a few careful steps in them."

I guess I know that now.

There were two versions of me in that moment—the one who heard nothing, and the one who heard everything. Which one was real? Do I really want to know? The problem is, I do... and they're both real.

Cameras flashed—then something flickered at the edge of sight, a shimmer where light shouldn't bend. A sudden flash to his left. A handsome thin man with jet-black hair and blue coveralls held up his phone, recording.

Familiar... too familiar.

Lucien Vega winked—one piercing blue eye—and pressed a finger to his lips. A flash caught the gold ring on his hand. A hint of aged cognac hung in the air—ghostly, impossible, like a shadow given scent. Gold's stomach turned; his knees wavered.

He steadied himself, voice thinning. "I'm sorry... I'm exhausted."

His pulse roared; when he looked again, Vega had vanished.

Sometimes even light refuses to cast a shadow.

He understood, with a sick calm, that clarity would never be absolution.

Epilogue

Even a Shadow Can Cast Light

We understand ourselves only in retrospect, and even then, imperfectly.
— Steven Gold, *Journal of Existential Psychodynamics* (Winter 2026)

Four Years Later

Gold sat, flipping through *This Time Called Life*—a worn paperback of Walter Rinder’s poetry and photographs.

We arrive in this world alone.
We depart alone.
This time called life—
Was meant for us to share.

He closed the book with a small, knowing smile.

“*Dawn*,” from Dario Marianelli’s *Pride and Prejudice* soundtrack, played softly. A cross-breeze from the open windows carried jasmine’s sweetness through the house. Light spilled through the skylight, falling on Rachel as she stood before her easel, her brush moving through bright oils with the quiet assurance of someone who no longer needed permission to begin.

Entranced, he studied her.

She had no idea how beautiful she was. In the mirror, she still hunted for flaws—fine lines, small changes, evidence of time only she seemed able to see. To everyone else, she was radiant.

Pain and guilt had once veiled her, like ash drifting across the sun, but they had never truly dimmed her grace. They had only kept her from seeing it.

Guilt did that. It clouded beauty—not only in the guilty, but in those forced to carry what was never theirs.

The thought came to him cleanly, without ornament. That still

surprised him. For most of his life, every feeling had arrived dragging an explanation behind it. Now, sometimes, the feeling itself was enough.

Rachel dropped a brush onto the table, startling him from his reverie.

Her artist's eye found the essence in everyone it beheld. And with their children, she had finally begun to see some of that beauty in herself.

She was his balance.

She turned, as if sensing his gaze.

"Thank you," he whispered.

"What for?" she asked, smiling.

"For marrying me. For putting up with me. For saving me. For being perfectly you."

The Meryton Townhall track began—bright, buoyant, impossible to resist. Gold reached for Rachel, gently plucked the brush and palette from her hands, and set them aside. With exaggerated gallantry, he bowed deeply, tipped an imaginary hat, kissed her hand, and launched into a lopsided English country dance, all angles and color, like one of her early canvases brought awkwardly to life.

Rachel laughed and pulled him close. In her arms, he understood what balance meant—not through reason, not through metaphor, but through contact. When he spun clumsily, she laughed again, light and free, the sound spilling through the room.

"Shh, Steven—you're going to wake Tommy with all that pounding."

"He's got to get up anyway. Bob'll be here soon."

"Oh—I forgot. I need to get dressed. And get Tommy dressed."

"You don't need to do anything. You look great."

These days she rose more slowly, one hand instinctively resting on her belly whenever she stood too quickly.

So much had changed. And yet Light was not completely

gone. Dr. LeConte had warned him he might never be. The challenge—his struggle—was not to destroy that voice, but to live with it in peace.

Gold remembered Bob's admonition, warm and rough-edged: "Stevie, did you ever read *I Never Promised You a Rose Garden*? It's gonna be wicked hard, but LeConte's one of the best. You'll get through this. We'll all get through it—together."

Sitting here now—with Rachel, Tommy, another child on the way—Gold understood the promise differently.

But every rose had thorns.

Gold had not seen Light in over two years.

"There is no *him*," LeConte had told him. "Only you. Eventually, the voices will quiet. They won't vanish—but they'll find harmony."

When she heard about his mushroom experience, she had warned him that psychedelics fracture the self before they heal it—if they heal it at all.

For Gold, that night had done both. It tore him open, and through the breach he saw what therapy alone had never allowed him to see: Light had never been only a ghost, never only a demon. He was also the shadow of Gold's unspoken need to believe.

Integration, LeConte said, was not forgetting. It was remembering differently.

And, in time, he had.

For the first time in his life, the silence inside him felt less like absence than a room with windows.

Feelings had never been the problem.

They came uninvited. They always had.

But what followed—

That was something else.

Something closer to action.

To choice.

Verbs, not adjectives.

RING CHIME.

Gold went to the door.

“Stevie! How the hell are ya? Ya look great.”

Gold lifted both arms just in time for Oldman’s bear hug.

“Uncle Bobby! Uncle Bobby!”

Tommy ran up and grabbed Oldman’s leg like it was a tree stump.

“Walk me.”

“How’s my little man?” Oldman said, lumbering down the hall like Frankenstein’s monster, stiff-legged, with Tommy clinging to him and shrieking with laughter.

Gold’s eyes brimmed—joy rising in him like a tide he had not realized he had been waiting for.

Rachel came in from the studio.

“Rach—hey, beautiful. I heard Tommy before, but I can’t find him anywhere. Where’s he hiding?”

Tommy giggled, holding tight as Oldman continued his stiff-legged march.

“I’m here, Uncle Bobby! Down here!”

“I thought that was a frog on my leg. Turns out it’s just a stinkbug.”

Oldman scooped Tommy onto his shoulders. Tommy laughed all the way up.

“Uncle Bobby,” Tommy said, leaning forward over Oldman’s head, “why’s Daddy crying?”

“‘Cause he’s so happy. Sometimes ya cry when you’re so happy it’s too big for your chest. Joy don’t like being alone. It wants company.”

Oldman settled Tommy on his shoulders, still chuckling. Then his face softened.

“Rach, Stevie—I saw Jane yesterday.”

Rachel winced.

“She’s still at Patton,” Oldman said. “Clean. Meds are working. Therapy too, finally. She’s not blaming Stevie anymore.”

Rachel looked down.

“Has she seen her daughter?”

“Not yet. But they’re writing. That’s something.”

“And Jason?” Rachel asked.

“Visited once.” Oldman nodded. “That’s something too.”

Rachel hesitated. “Will she get better? Like Steven?”

Oldman lowered Tommy from his shoulders and set him on the couch.

“She’ll never be the same. But she’s not dangerous anymore. She’s taking responsibility. That’s where it starts.”

Rachel nodded, eyes filling.

“But it’ll be a while before she can forgive herself,” Oldman said. “The DNA test cleared Stevie, but she’ll carry that guilt forever. The loss. I don’t know if she’ll ever be whole.”

Rachel hugged him and kissed his cheek.

“Bob... you’ve been so good to us. I wish there were some way we could thank you.”

She glanced at Gold. He gave the smallest wink—there and gone so quickly only she would have caught it.

Tommy looked up from the couch.

“Mommy... are you happy too?”

Rachel wiped her face and smiled.

“Yes, Tommy. Mommy’s very happy.”

Gold looked down, the old pain moving through his face before he could hide it.

“You okay, Stevie?”

“Berkeley was wrong, Bob. Some things don’t go quiet just because no one listens. Jane still leaves voicemails in my dreams.”

Oldman studied him. “Yeah. But at least you ain’t picking it up when it rings.”

Gold nodded.

“You don’t have to answer every time,” Oldman said.

Gold shook his head and gave Bob a hug. He knew he couldn’t erase the past. No one could. Healing was not erasure. It was learning to walk with the shadow without becoming its shape.

Rachel added quietly, “I spoke to Karen Shapiro again last week. She’s still hurting, but the congregation is holding her close.”

Oldman nodded.

“At least the kids were too young to understand what happened. At the time.”

The phrase settled over them: *at the time*.

There was always an after.

Over dinner, Oldman asked Rachel, “So, Rach, do you know the sex yet? Is Tommy getting a baby brother or sister?”

Rachel looked at Gold. He smiled and nodded.

“Tommy’s going to have a baby brother.”

Tommy cheered.

“We’re going to name him Gerald,” Rachel said. “Gerald Robert Gold.”

Gold met Oldman’s eyes—steady, grateful.

“For my father,” he said. “And for you, Bob. My brother.”

Oldman looked away first.

“Don’t make me cry in front of the kid,” he muttered.

Gold laughed and wrapped Oldman in a tight bear hug, trying to lift him off the ground.

Tommy clapped.

“Daddy’s happy again!”

Gold laughed.

“Yes, Tommy. Daddy’s happy again.”

“Exudious,” he said, looking over to a teary-eyed Rachel.

Later that night, after Oldman had gone home, Gold read Tommy’s favorite book, *The Little Boy Who Wouldn’t Go To Sleep*. Then, as he did every night, Tommy repeated whispered prayers with his father—words small and careful, a ritual they had made together. Sometimes Tommy added his own lines at the end. Sometimes Gold did. But it always ended with both of them saying, in unison, amen.

From the doorway, Rachel watched them, Tommy’s hair haloed by the night-light glow.

On one wall hung her new painting. She had overpainted an old canvas—*Portrait in Absence*. In its place stood *Exudious Joy*: an ouroboros coiled within a vast field of tulips, their petals alive with impossible color beneath a bright blue sky.

Under raking light, ghost-ridges of the old portrait pressed faintly beneath the tulips—pentimenti that refused to vanish.

Gold loved that most.

Nothing truly disappeared. It changed shape.

Across from it, above Tommy’s bed, hung a simple black frame holding a parchment inscribed with four Proto-Sinaitic letters.



(Heaven)

Gold felt Rachel watching him and turned. In the quiet between them, something settled—no beginning, no end. Only the middle they had chosen, held between their hands.

He turned off Tommy’s lamp. The night-light switched on, bathing the room in a dim, soft glow.

Gold walked over and hugged Rachel, careful not to press too hard against her belly.

It was a magic hug. Her scent rose toward him—rich, earthy, warm as loam after rain, something the body knew before the mind

had time to name it. He felt her soften into him, held, safe, loved.

“That’s all I need,” she whispered. “All I ever wanted.”

“Rach. . . I love you so much. I don’t ever want to let go. I’m sorry I hurt you. And I’m sorry I didn’t see how much you were hurting.”

“Steven,” she said, “‘in sickness and in health.’ That’s the vow. We finally reached the better.”

She looked at Tommy sleeping in bed, then rubbed her belly.

“Neither of us ever thought we’d have this.”

Gold placed one hand lightly over hers.

“One thing I learned from Samael Light—from myself—is that maybe there is a God.”

Rachel looked at him.

“Maybe?”

He smiled.

“Maybe is the best I can do.”

“That’s a lot better than never.”

He kissed her.

“There’s our eternity,” he said, looking first at Tommy. “There,” and then placing his hand gently on her belly, “and there.”

They stood in the doorway, arms around each other, serenaded by Tommy’s rhythmic breathing.

Gold whispered, “The mind is its own place. Is this what heaven is like?”

The question rose and passed, leaving only the quiet behind.

After Rachel went to bed, Gold went to his study.

The house was silent now—the kind of silence that was not emptiness at all, but fullness waiting to be heard.

He thought of Light—not as demon now, not as patient, not even as enemy, but as fire. Dangerous, yes. Destructive. But

illuminating too. Some flames only burned. Others revealed the shape of the room.

Perhaps Light had been both.

Never there.

Never gone.

On his desk sat the paper bag from the Judaica shop. Gold took out a yahrzeit candle and held it a moment before lighting it.

The flame bent, steadied, then held.

He watched it breathe beside him.

For his father.

For Rabbi Shapiro.

For Jane.

For the man he had been, and the man he had almost become.

His laptop waited open on the desk. The blank screen glowed softly, catching the candlelight in its glass.

A ridiculous hesitation took hold of him. He had written articles, case studies, lectures, notes, journals, fragments, half-finished essays, abandoned books. He had spent a lifetime arranging experience into language.

But this felt different.

This was not a case study.

Not a defense.

Not a confession, though it would contain confession.

Not therapy, though he suspected LeConte would disagree.

He touched his wedding band to his lips—an old ritual, no longer purely apology. The gold caught the candlelight and flashed briefly into his eyes. For an instant, he saw another ring: darker, heavier, impossible to hold without fear.

Then it was gone.
Only his own hand remained.
Only this ring.
Only love.
Gold opened a blank document.
The cursor blinked.
Waiting.

He thought of the epigraphs he had collected over the years, the passages underlined in books, the notes in margins, the phrases he had mistaken for truth because someone wiser had written them first. He thought of the stories he had told himself—about Jane, about Rachel, about God, about his father, about Light.

He thought of the assignment LeConte had given him—the story that had begun the morning he woke at 4:17, heart racing, mouth dry, certain he would be blamed for something that had not yet happened.

Or had happened already.
Or had always been happening.

He closed his eyes—not to shut anything out, but because he finally could.

“Okay,” he whispered. “Let’s begin.”

For a while, he did not type. He only listened—to Rachel breathing down the hall, to Tommy turning in sleep, to the faint hum of the house around him, to the candle’s soft, nearly soundless insistence.

He had spent his life naming shadows. Only now did he understand that naming them was not the same as learning to live with them.

Then his fingers moved.
Slowly at first.
Then with rhythm.

He typed the title before he knew whether he had earned it.

A QUESTION OF BALANCE

He stared at the words.
They seemed both accusation and mercy.
Then, beneath them, he started typing:

PROLOGUE

Darkness does not always arrive suddenly.
Sometimes it gathers—quietly, patiently—
until you realize you can no longer see.

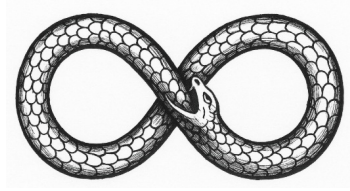
He stopped.
The words stared back at him as if they had been left there by
someone else.

Gold almost laughed.
Of course.
Even now.
Especially now.
The flame flickered, bent, steadied again.

He placed his hands on the keys and began to write the story
as honestly as memory would allow, knowing honesty was not the
same as truth, and truth was not the same as peace.

But it was a beginning.
And for once, beginning was enough.

Behind silver-rimmed glasses, wide, unblinking eyes caught
the glow of the *ner tamid*—the eternal flame above the ark.



AFTERWORD

A poem is never finished, only abandoned.
— Paul Valéry, *Tel Quel* (1941)

To the Reader—

If you've made it to this point, thank you. Not just for finishing the book, but for sitting with ideas that may have unsettled your beliefs, your comfort, or your sense of certainty. This novel was not intended as doctrine or manifesto. It is, quite deliberately, a provocation—*questions posed rather than answered*.

I've always thought it more important to understand the questions than to demand answers—as I wrote, years ago, in my poem *The Birth of a Man*, which I've used in this novel:

*I sought not answers, nor made suggestions,
I merely wished to learn the right questions.*

Some of the themes—religion, guilt, madness, love, death, and the nature of evil—cut close to the bone. I understand that. They cut close to the bone for me as well.

You may have found parts of this story troubling. I hope you did.

Not because I wanted to upset you—but because I believe that art, like therapy, like philosophy, sometimes requires discomfort to do its work. The aim was never to offend, but to reframe. To ask you, gently or forcefully, as the narrative demanded, to reconsider—from another angle, from a parallax view.

The characters you've met are flawed, like all of us. Their voices carry pain, contradiction, longing, and—in some cases—audacity. Some speak with love, others with fury. All of them, I hope, felt human. That was the point.

And there's one final layer I should acknowledge. By now, you may have noticed that *A Question of Balance* is itself the book Steven Gold begins to write at the end. The ouroboros completes its circle. The abundance of epigraphs, the catalog of books on his

shelves, even the detailed naming of clothing brands—all of it belongs to him. Those flourishes are not mine, but his. They reveal a mind still reaching to impress, still hungry to prove erudition and taste, still defining self through intellect and display. That, too, is part of Gold's recovery. He still can't quite stop performing. The novel you've just read is his therapy—his confession, his argument, his mirror. It is the story he needed to tell, in the only way he knew how.

If you find yourself disagreeing with what was said—good. That means you were listening. If you find yourself still thinking about it tomorrow, or next week, even better. That means the dialogue continues—between the page and whatever in you it stirred.

Thank you for engaging—for allowing me to pose difficult questions. And for understanding that while not every prayer can be answered, each one deserves to be prayed.

In the end, *A Question of Balance* is less about answers than about equilibrium—the fragile harmony we seek between what we know and what we can never fully know. Guilt, belief, grace, and self-deception are not separate threads but entwined strands of the same human fabric.

Guilt, when faced honestly, gives birth to empathy.

Belief, stripped of dogma, evolves into relational faith.

Grace, no longer divine decree, manifests as human forgiveness.

Self-deception, once denial, yields to self-awareness.

Together, these form the balance — the reconciliation of knowing and not-knowing, sin and redemption, faith and reason. It is, perhaps, the only balance we are ever granted in life.

In 1772, Voltaire wrote, *Le mieux est l'ennemi du bien* (the perfect is the enemy of the good). As much as I have loved playing with the questions, ideas, and stories in this book, I think I've said enough... for now.

Perhaps Steven Gold will have more to share at some point in the future. At this point, he might think to himself:

*Obsession is not love—it is fear dressed as discipline.
Knowing when to stop is the rarest form of control.*

I hope I didn't abandon this work too soon.

David S. Sherman
January, 2026

AUTHOR'S NOTE

We move through life unevenly—some of us catching every detail, others missing what lies directly at our feet. Some attend to every flicker, every small shift in light or voice; others step past what matters most, unaware of the meaning sleeping inside those moments.

Therapy isn't simply the act of connecting the dots in a person's life. It's the work of stepping far enough back—high enough above—to see the picture those dots have been forming, and then helping someone understand it, make sense of it, accept it.

At first, the picture resembles a Rorschach inkblot: shifting, ambiguous, open to countless interpretations depending on our perspective, our fear, our light. But as we move farther away, the view paradoxically sharpens. The dots multiply. The forms deepen. And what once seemed random reveals itself as something intricate, deliberate, and deeply connected.

The shape of a life begins, at last, to emerge—interwoven and impossibly alive with meaning we could not see, could not understand, without that elevated vantage.

Like most childhoods, mine was a mosaic of flashes—small, scattered, unforgettable.

My imagination was kindled by mythology, religion, comic books, and encyclopedias—each striking sparks against the dry kindling of suffering, blindness, and death. The sudden loss of a grandparent's vision—and the deaths of beloved pets and grandparents—raised questions few children know how to ask: Why do people suffer? Why do we die? Why would God allow it?

Those sparks smoldered through adolescence, flaring at times into obsession—but they ignited in college, fanned by Paul Cantor's *Myths of Creation* and courses in philosophy and psychology. They were further fueled by classes in expository and creative writing—and by the independent research I conducted for my undergraduate

honors thesis on schizophrenia. I poured those questions into stories—and into therapy. Each became a vessel for a fire I couldn't quite name.

This novel is a thought experiment—an imaginative lens through which I explore my reflections on psychotherapy: its promise, its pitfalls, and its profound complexity.

I've been a licensed psychotherapist since 1981. In that time, people have entered therapy for countless reasons. Most find it helpful. Some, tragically, do not. And in rare cases, it makes things worse.

In graduate school, I remember a professor holding up Eysenck's study like it was radioactive—his voice low, as if invoking a heretic. The claim? That most neurotics recovered on their own. That therapy might be ineffective—or even harmful. It was scandalous. And unforgettable.

His legacy sparked an enduring debate about psychotherapy's efficacy and ushered in a more empirical approach to its study. Subsequent meta-analyses estimate that 75–80% of patients improve with therapy—yet 5–10% actually worsen.

Among the most critical predictors of therapeutic success is the therapeutic alliance: a collaborative, egalitarian relationship between therapist and client. That's why Carl Rogers and other humanistic psychologists abandoned the term *patient* in favor of *client*—to emphasize relationship over hierarchy. Therapy depends on trust, mutual respect, and a sense of hope. A session should offer a space to speak freely, without judgment—to collaborate in the process of self-understanding.

In *Studies in Hysteria* (1895), Freud and Breuer introduced the ideas of projection and transference. In subsequent writings, including *The Dynamics of Transference* (1912), Freud expanded this framework to include countertransference—the therapist's own unconscious reactions—and emphasized the importance of self-awareness to avoid contaminating treatment.

That's because therapists—whether psychiatrists, psychologists, counselors, or social workers—are human. We bring our own feelings, unresolved emotions, and psychological baggage into the room. Despite our training, psychotherapy is no exact science. It's a soft science—an interpretive art, practiced by fallible

humans. Therapy can be a descent—into memory, projection, or loss.

Originally trained in the medical model—I began college premed as a biology major (though I first considered Folklore and Mythology). I’ve always believed in the model: that physical and mental conditions are the result of specific biological causes. I’ve always found the stress-diathesis model—where biology meets circumstance—the most truthful.

I’ve always believed that patients and clients deserve full transparency—especially in a soft-science field like psychotherapy. The therapist’s personality, ethics, and worldview are inseparable from the treatment process. A therapist’s own mental health and emotional self-awareness are paramount.

Psychology’s major schools—psychoanalytic, behavioral, cognitive, humanistic—reflect the personalities and moral visions of their founders.

Human behavior resists tidy classification. The DSM—now in its fifth major edition—evolves with each generation’s fears and fashions. Its categories reflect the era as much as the mind. Like an artist changing palettes, psychology redefines disorder with every cultural shift. Therapy, too, resists clarity. What begins as insight may end in echo—or silence.

Therapy is like art school. There are tools, techniques, and theory—but what matters most is the artist. Even the greatest prodigies—Mozart, Liszt, Yo-Yo Ma, or Arshile Gorky—required structure and mentorship before creating works that changed the world. They learned fundamentals before breaking the mold.

But not everyone becomes a master. A Stradivarius won’t play a concerto on its own. In the hands of Jascha Heifetz, even a thrift-store violin can create magic. What separates the mediocre from the transcendent isn’t just training—it’s temperament, awareness, and timing.

Some see only chaos in Pollock, hear only noise in Stravinsky. But others glimpse revelation. Genius lives in the interplay between skill, culture, and personality—like Rachmaninoff reimagining a Paganini theme into a slow, soaring melody of sublime beauty.

We would be impoverished by a world with only one genre—only rap or classical, only minimalism or surrealism. The human

psyche requires variety.

Some therapist-client pairings click. Others fail. In art, the artist is key—and so it is with therapy.

Freud's insight about countertransference remains essential: therapists must examine their own emotional reactions, or risk harming the very people they seek to help.

Every therapist paints with the palette of their own psyche. Some create refuge. Others, unknowingly, reopen wounds with every stroke. Insight is their only shield—and often, it comes too late.

Therapists vary—sometimes wildly. Some violate the foundational maxim attributed to Thomas Sydenham: *primum non nocere*—first, do no harm. While psychoanalysts are required to undergo their own analysis, many clinicians are not. That lack of self-examination can compromise the care they offer.

At its core, therapy is moral philosophy—applied and intimate. Every therapist, consciously or not, brings their own ethical, emotional, and existential framework to the room.

The story is not a theory, but a descent.

One man. One room.

The struggle of vision—too much, or too little.

The demand it makes: a cost no one escapes.

Some mirrors are shields—they don't reflect, they expose.

David S. Sherman

May 2026

The One Demand

Prometheus.

Endure.

Yield not to Zeus. Hold fast your humanity.

Sisyphus—

Let your hill starve.

Toil not for any god.

Atlas—

Drop your celestial sphere.

Gods are naught.

Without Man—what is God?

Without Man—wherefore God?

This is my one demand:

No God before the face of Man.

The mind illuminates what it can and leaves the rest in shadow.
— Steven Gold, *Notes on Therapy* (2026)

A Guide for the Perplexed

What you've just read is, in its way, Steven Gold's attempt to understand the most disorienting chapter of his life. This narrative is his reconstruction of what happened—filtered through his training, his defenses, his long-buried grief, and the fractured way he came to perceive himself.

We never see our own lives evenly. Some moments blaze with painful clarity; others pass unnoticed, their meaning only recognized when we finally step far enough back to understand the pattern they were forming.

Throughout the book he writes as both participant and observer—a clinician, but also a man struggling to organize memory in the aftermath of psychological rupture. His perspective is necessarily incomplete. Some distortions arise from trauma, some from guilt, and some simply from the unavoidable subjectivity of human recollection. What seems vivid in one chapter may blur in the next; meaning shifts as Gold's vantage shifts.

The ouroboros is not only a symbol of self-devouring but of renewal: a life reconstituted from its fragments. Its presence here is intentional. The narrative's looping shape—its echoes, doublings, and recurring shadows—mirrors Gold's attempt to integrate conflicting parts of himself. Identity, like an ambiguous image, can appear chaotic or contradictory until we gain enough distance to see its hidden coherence. Gold circles back not because he wishes to, but because he must. In that sense, the story is less a case report than a therapeutic document: the record of a mind trying to realign after being broken open.

We all live inside the stories we tell ourselves. We read our lives the way we read shifting shapes in an inkblot: projecting fear, desire, and memory onto the patterns before us. Even Gold's intellect—his quotations, references, and curated shelves—reveals as much about

his need to impress, to defend, and to distance himself from pain as it does about the subjects he invokes. When inconsistencies appear, they are part of the design. They belong to Gold, not to the reader. His account is sincere, but sincerity is not the same as precision. The man who wrote these pages is still trying to assemble a coherent self from splintered memory.

In telling the story, Gold becomes its center—and its lens. This is the tale as he lived it, as he believed it, and as he needed to shape it in order to move forward. The writing becomes its own vantage point, its own release: the teller becoming the tale, and the tale becoming the means by which he finally sees the shape of his life emerging from the fog of memory.

Notes for Book Clubs and the Curious

How to Read This Novel

A Question of Balance is not structured as a conventional mystery, nor as a philosophical treatise, though it borrows elements from both. It is best approached as a psychological and moral inquiry told through a subjective lens. The narrator is intelligent, articulate, and sincere—but not omniscient. Meaning in this novel emerges gradually, often retroactively, and readers are invited to tolerate ambiguity rather than resolve it prematurely.

On Truth, Interpretation, and Guilt

One of the book's central claims is that truth and meaning are not identical. Facts may resolve what happened, but they do not automatically absolve guilt or restore balance. Throughout the novel, guilt operates independently of intent, attaching itself to silence, proximity, survival, and memory. Readers may wish to consider when guilt functions as moral signal—and when it becomes a psychological regime that condemns without repairing.

Samael Light: Character, Pressure, or Mirror?

Samael Light is not offered as a puzzle to be solved, but as a force that tests boundaries—between belief and disbelief, reason and faith, therapy and confession. Whether read as a literal character, a psychological construct, or a symbolic presence, Light functions primarily as pressure. He exposes what the other characters, particularly Steven Gold, would prefer to keep unexamined. Book clubs may find it useful to discuss not who Light is, but what changes in Gold when Light is present—and what changes when he is gone.

Religion Without Resolution

The novel engages deeply with religious language, scripture, and theology, but resists doctrinal conclusions. God is examined not as an answer, but as a problem—an inherited structure of meaning that shapes guilt, authority, and silence. Readers are not asked to believe or disbelieve, but to notice how belief functions: when it consoles, when it controls, and when it fractures responsibility.

Therapy, Authority, and Ethical Boundaries

Because the novel is centered on a psychotherapist, questions of authority and ethics recur throughout. Therapy is portrayed not as a neutral space, but as a relationship shaped by power, projection, and avoidance. Book clubs may wish to consider when therapy in the novel serves understanding—and when it becomes another form of control or concealment.

Love, Silence, and Repair

Love in *A Question of Balance* is not redemptive by itself. It does not erase harm, undo silence, or purify guilt. Instead, love is presented as habitation—the willingness to remain present without resolution. Forgiveness, when it appears, is felt rather than declared. Readers may find it useful to track moments where silence is protective versus destructive, and where honesty risks loss but enables repair.

Why There Is No Final Answer

The novel closes without offering a definitive moral verdict. This is intentional. Balance, as the book understands it, is not achieved by solving the past but by learning how to live with it honestly. The absence of final answers invites readers to examine their own relationship to guilt, certainty, belief, and responsibility.

Suggested Discussion Questions

1. At what moments did you feel certain about what was happening—and when were those certainties challenged?

2. How does the novel distinguish between truth and meaning? Can one exist without the other?
3. In what ways does guilt operate independently of action or intent in the story?
4. How did your perception of Samael Light change over the course of the novel?
5. Where do you see authority quietly shifting hands—and how does that affect responsibility?
6. What role does silence play in the harm caused by the characters? When does it protect, and when does it wound?
7. Does the novel ultimately argue for belief, disbelief, or something else entirely?
8. What does “balance” come to mean by the end of the book?

Argument of the Whole

A Question of Balance follows a man trained to interpret others who slowly discovers that interpretation itself may be his most dangerous defense.

Steven Gold is a psychologist whose life has been built on clarity, discipline, and the conviction that understanding confers control. When a death occurs without malice or witness, meaning rushes in where none was chosen. Interpretation hardens before truth can speak, and guilt—unmoored from intention—begins its quiet work. From this moment forward, Gold is drawn into a narrowing corridor where certainty replaces inquiry and coherence masquerades as truth.

As the narrative unfolds, authority shifts without announcement. Therapy becomes entanglement, insight becomes idolatry, and belief—disavowed in name—reasserts itself in other forms: anger, spectacle, accusation. The figure of Samael Light functions not as explanation but as pressure, exposing the fault lines between reason and faith, skepticism and allegiance, guilt and responsibility.

Throughout the book, guilt appears untethered from love—circulating freely, attaching itself to proximity, silence, and survival. Innocence before the law proves insufficient; truth resolves events but leaves the soul unsettled.

Only when interpretation loosens its grip does another possibility emerge. In surrendering mastery—through confession, presence, and shared endurance—Gold encounters a form of meaning that does not require purification or certainty. What is restored is not innocence, but balance.

Chapter Arguments

Prologue

Blame precedes understanding.

Argument:

An act of death occurs without malice or witness, yet meaning rushes in where none was chosen. Interpretation hardens before truth can speak, and judgment settles in advance of intention. What follows is shaped less by what happened than by what the mind requires to believe.

Chapter One — Light Often Blinds

Desire becomes liability when secrecy fails.

Argument:

Exposure, not temptation, unmasks desire. A man practiced in self-command discovers that longing turns dangerous not through craving, but through consequence. What was once hidden now insists on being named.

Chapter Two — Lust

Self-deception survives through disciplined certainty.

Argument:

In arranging his world through intellect and philosophy, the healer persuades himself that insight confers immunity. Order becomes protection, and certainty becomes armor. Bad faith refines itself into structure.

Chapter Three — Mauvaise Foi

Fixation forms before meaning is assigned.

Argument:

A stranger arrives without demand or display, yet leaves behind unease that resists classification. Attention shifts quietly from authority to fascination. Something is marked before its significance is known.

Chapter Four — Truth Hides in Shadows

Authority erodes through silence rather than challenge.

Argument:

The therapeutic frame is tested not by confrontation, but by restraint. Power passes without struggle, as silence exerts greater force than speech. Control changes hands without **Argument**.

Chapter Five — An Anchor Chained to Your Heart

Insight does not absolve guilt.

Argument:

Guilt is offered classification in the hope that understanding may loosen its hold. Instead, guilt withstands explanation. The attempt to heal exposes the healer to judgment he did not anticipate.

Chapter Six — Sympathy for the Devil

Ambiguity survives all attempts at resolution.

Argument:

The patient claims the name of Satan without spectacle or insistence, forcing belief, metaphor, and pathology into uneasy coexistence. Skepticism remains intact, yet no explanation restores safety. Ambiguity stands unrelieved.

Chapter Seven — Paradoxical Sleep

Dream dissolves boundary.

Argument:

In dream, distinctions between observer and participant collapse.

Symbols recur without consent, identity loosens, and perception slips its anchors. The voice that addresses Gold cannot be securely placed outside himself.

Chapter Eight — Purgatory

Attachment reveals itself through omission.

Argument:

What is no longer recorded speaks more clearly than what is said. Silence accumulates where confession should be. Authority continues to erode through quiet procedural acts.

Chapter Nine — Wrestling With God

Doubt conceals allegiance.

Argument:

Disbelief is examined not as negation but as response. Anger toward God emerges not as rejection, but as sustained engagement. Doubt proves less a distance from faith than its most persistent form.

Chapter Ten — Orphaned by God

Belief hardens into authority when doubt is refused.

Argument:

Certainty offers refuge when uncertainty becomes intolerable. Inquiry gives way to assertion, and conviction replaces understanding. Belief reveals itself as strategy rather than truth.

Chapter Eleven — Ars Gratia Dei

Insight becomes idolatry.

Argument:

Understanding promises mastery over ambiguity, yet risks becoming an object of devotion. Interpretation displaces experience, and clarity hardens into judgment. Meaning turns inward and begins to consume itself.

Chapter Twelve — Bible Study

Myth falters when belief demands accountability.

Argument:

Sacred history shifts from symbol to lived authority. Interpretation hardens into fact, and the story meant to protect the self begins to threaten it. The boundary between understanding and complicity collapses.

Chapter Thirteen — Every Angel Is Terrifying

Purity destabilizes what cannot absorb it.

Argument:

Reason fractures not through error, but through severity. Belief and delusion blur as consensus becomes enforcement. Terror emerges not from chaos, but from unyielding clarity.

Chapter Fourteen — Some Prayers Are Best Unprayed

Hope persists as habit after belief collapses.

Argument:

Prayer survives as reflex rather than conviction. Memory reasserts what was never reconciled. Faith is not lost—it is deferred.

Chapter Fifteen — Was God Even Watching

Witness becomes burden.

Argument:

Guilt endures not as error, but as residue. Survival becomes sentence, and forgiveness remains inaccessible. Care emerges as the only remaining form of grace.

Chapter Sixteen — Everybody Has Baggage

Innocence does not erase guilt.

Argument:

Responsibility detaches from causation and binds itself to proximity. Silence compounds harm long after intent vanishes. No one emerges untouched.

Chapter Seventeen — Et Tu, Brute?

Betrayal wounds most deeply when born of care.

Argument:

Intimacy mismanaged becomes injury. Authority collapses into vulnerability, and rage gives way to recognition. Forgiveness arrives through shared fallibility.

Chapter Eighteen — There Are More Than Two Sides to a Couch

Guilt speaks when analysis fails.

Argument:

Professional distance dissolves into testimony. Guilt is no longer examined but asserted. Transformation begins with the courage to speak what cannot be undone.

Chapter Nineteen — Guilt, Untethered from Love

Guilt without love becomes tyranny.

Argument:

Severed from mercy, conscience turns punitive. Insight sharpens judgment but offers no repair. Theory collapses under the weight of what can no longer remain concealed.

Chapter Twenty — Infinity in the Palm of Your Hand

Deferred guilt begins to accuse.

Argument:

Understanding ceases to console and demands response. What was withheld asserts its cost. Meaning expands beyond analysis into obligation.

Chapter Twenty-One — Nagging Doubts

Doubt becomes atmosphere.

Argument:

Certainty erodes without announcement. Avoidance masquerades as distance. Doubt settles quietly and refuses to leave.

Chapter Twenty-Two — Ringside Seats

Belief becomes spectacle.

Argument:

Inquiry yields to dominance, and rhetorical victory replaces care. Accusation without restraint hardens into cruelty.

Chapter Twenty-Three — Sometimes Light Hides in Shadows

Compassion emerges where judgment collapses.

Argument:

Responsibility can no longer be displaced. Guilt reframes itself as abandonment rather than crime. Meaning shifts from explanation to shared endurance.

Chapter Twenty-Four — Myself Am Hell

Evil claimed reshapes identity.

Argument:

Guilt moves from abstraction to embodiment, and theology becomes confession. Understanding risks becoming accomplice.

Chapter Twenty-Five — Does God Cast a Shadow?

Belief becomes contagion.

Argument:

Sympathy hardens into implication. The boundary between inquiry and endorsement collapses. The healer risks transformation by

belief itself.

Chapter Twenty-Six — Darkness Visible

Absence clarifies what belief concealed.

Argument:

Certainty dissolves into memory. Darkness reveals what was always present. Clarity arrives without comfort.

Chapter Twenty-Seven — To Fathom Hell or Soar Angelic

Surrender precedes healing.

Argument:

Interpretation gives way to experience. Defenses loosen, hierarchy collapses, and feeling arrives before meaning. Presence replaces mastery.

Chapter Twenty-Eight — I'm Here Too

Love restores what confession cannot.

Argument:

Reconciliation emerges through shared presence. Forgiveness is felt rather than spoken. Intimacy returns as mutual inhabitation.

Chapter Twenty-Nine — The Birth of a Man

Creation redeems fragmentation.

Argument:

Identity coheres without purification. Love functions as catalyst rather than cure. Becoming is integration, not arrival.

Chapter Thirty — The Sound of Blood Crying Out

Guilt speaks through grief.

Argument:

Symbols collapse under responsibility. Evil is reframed as human

deferral. What cries out is the cost of denial.

Chapter Thirty-One — Exudious Joy

Honesty restores love.

Argument:

Silence relinquishes its claim as protection. Truth risks loss and reveals intimacy's condition. Joy returns as consequence, not reward.

Chapter Thirty-Two — The Brighter the Light, the Darker the Shadow It Attracts

Guilt multiplies faster than truth.

Argument:

Violence awakens meaning before facts can follow. Fear seeks patterns, theology seeks blame, and conscience outpaces reason.

Chapter Thirty-Three — Thou Shalt Not Kill

Judgment precedes intent.

Argument:

A death is discovered already shaped by meaning. Symbols are read, guilt imagined, and narratives imposed before motive can speak.

Chapter Thirty-Four — Shadows Can't Hide Everything

Suspicion crystallizes through narrative convenience.

Argument:

Investigation accelerates toward coherence rather than certainty. Pressure hardens interpretation where truth remains incomplete.

Chapter Thirty-Five — Josef K

Knowledge becomes evidence before truth can speak.

Argument:

Private knowledge is reclassified as incriminating foresight.
Authority enters as inquiry and curdles into presumption.

Chapter Thirty-Six — Some Cells Don't Have Bars

Guilt survives confinement.

Argument:

Physical restraint exposes a deeper captivity untouched by procedure. Guilt travels inward and tightens where freedom once lived.

Chapter Thirty-Seven — Haystacks

Certainty arrives before understanding.

Argument:

Circumstantial coherence replaces doubt. Ambiguity becomes intolerable, and justice drifts.

Chapter Thirty-Eight — Violated

Violation reveals what was most deeply loved.

Argument:

The breach of space becomes a breach of trust. Guilt migrates freely in the absence of answers. Love persists as need rather than certainty.

Chapter Thirty-Nine — In His Own Hand

Coherence masquerades as truth.

Argument:

Symbols, schedules, and silences align through paperwork rather than confession. Authorship becomes evidence.

Chapter Forty — Miranda Waived

Procedure replaces inquiry.

Argument:

Coincidence hardens into narrative. Meaning is inferred through alignment rather than truth.

Chapter Forty-One — Where Does a Ring Begin?

Memory completes the circle.

Argument:

In isolation, identity loops inward. What was removed returns in dream, demanding reckoning.

Chapter Forty-Two — Tartarus

Punishment does not require guilt.

Argument:

Guilt detaches from action and becomes atmosphere. The terror lies not in crime, but in unresolved self-witness.

Chapter Forty-Three — Mirrors in a Hall of Mirrors

Identity fractures under reflection.

Argument:

Responsibility dissolves into interpretation. Innocence and guilt coexist without resolution.

Chapter Forty-Four — The Janitor

What is unseen governs what is remembered.

Argument:

Meaning forms not from intent, but from residue. Fate emerges as pattern noticed too late.

Chapter Forty-Five — The Fall

Public judgment manufactures truth.

Argument:

Fear and spectacle harden accident into atrocity. Silence becomes evidence, and meaning collapses into verdict.

Chapter Forty-Six — All That Glitters Is Not Gold

Truth requires process.

Argument:

As evidence unfolds, certainty collapses. Judgment exposes its own blindness.

Chapter Forty-Seven — Karma’s a Bitch

Justice assigns blame too late.

Argument:

Truth arrives after damage is done. Certainty hardens into vengeance rather than repair.

Chapter Forty-Eight — The Writing on the Wall

Truth records rather than redeems.

Argument:

Exoneration arrives without relief. Justice clears a man; truth leaves him changed.

Chapter Forty-Nine — Justice Isn’t Always Blind

Law resolves cases, not conscience.

Argument:

Freedom returns without peace. Memory continues the reckoning.

Epilogue — Even a Shadow Can Cast Light

Balance is learned, not proven.

Argument:

Meaning endures without final resolution. Light remains only when shadow is no longer denied.

A Note on the Proto-Sinaitic Writing

The Proto-Sinaitic writing used in the novel was made by taking the Hebrew phrases and then, phonetically, writing them backwards in a Proto-Sinaitic font. While actual Proto-Sinaitic writing is actually pictographs, not phonetically as an alphabet, in the story, Gold wrote them based on the Hebrew phrases, spelling out each word as a transliteration, letter-by-letter right to left. This was based on his rudimentary childhood education in Hebrew and his reading and understanding of the fictional article in the non-fictional *Israel Exploration Journal*.

Proto-Sinaitic (or Early Canaanite) isn't a one-to-one alphabetic script like modern Hebrew — it's a set of pictographic symbols, each representing the earliest known phonetic ancestors of Hebrew letters. Below is a transliteration into Proto-Sinaitic glyph sequence with each symbol's ancient pictographic meaning.

Symbol meanings (approximate):

- מ (mem) – water / flow
- I (tsade) – plant / hook
- O (ayin) – eye / insight
- W (shin) – teeth / sharpness
- L (lamed) – staff / guidance
- מ (mem) – water / peace
- ב (bet) – house / family
- W (shin) – heaven / divine fire
- מ (mem) – water / vastness
- י (yod) – hand / action
- מ י ב – ben ("son")

A Question of Balance

Sound	Hebrew Letter	Proto-Sinaitic meaning	Keyboard Letter	Proto-Sinaitic
ʔ	א (<i>aleph</i>)	ox head	A	𐤀
B	ב (<i>bet</i>)	house	B	𐤁
G	ג (<i>gimel</i>)	camel	C	𐤂
D	ד (<i>dalet</i>)	door	D	𐤃
H	ה (<i>he</i>)	window/breath	E	𐤄
W/V	ו (<i>vav</i>)	hook	F	𐤅
Z	ז (<i>zayin</i>)	weapon	G	𐤆
H	ח (<i>het</i>)	fence	H	𐤇
T	ט (<i>tet</i>)	wheel	I	𐤈
Y	י (<i>yod</i>)	arm/hand	J	𐤉
K	כ (<i>kaf</i>)	palm	K	𐤊
L	ל (<i>lamed</i>)	staff	L	𐤋
M	מ (<i>mem</i>)	water	M	𐤌
N	נ (<i>nun</i>)	snake/fish	N	𐤍
S	ס (<i>samekh</i>)	fish	O	𐤎
ʕ	ע (<i>ayin</i>)	eye	P	𐤏
P	פ (<i>pe</i>)	mouth	Q	𐤐
ʃ	צ (<i>tsade</i>)	papyrus/plant	R	𐤑
Q	ק (<i>qaf</i>)	monkey/sun	S	𐤒
R	ר (<i>resh</i>)	head	T	𐤓
ʃ	ש (<i>shin</i>)	tooth	U	𐤔
T	ת (<i>tav</i>)	mark/cross	V	𐤕

(extras X-Z in your font may duplicate shapes or unused consonants)

ABCDEFGHIJKLMNOPQRSTUVWXYZ

𐤀 𐤁 𐤂 𐤃 𐤄 𐤅 𐤆 𐤇 𐤈 𐤉 𐤊 𐤋 𐤌 𐤍 𐤎 𐤏 𐤐 𐤑 𐤒 𐤓 𐤔 𐤕 𐤖 𐤗 𐤘 𐤙 𐤚 𐤛 𐤜 𐤝 𐤞 𐤟 𐤠 𐤡 𐤢 𐤣 𐤤 𐤥 𐤦 𐤧 𐤨 𐤩 𐤪 𐤫 𐤬 𐤭 𐤮 𐤯 𐤰 𐤱 𐤲 𐤳 𐤴 𐤵 𐤶 𐤷 𐤸 𐤹 𐤺 𐤻 𐤼 𐤽 𐤾 𐤿

Find peace in heaven, son

מצא שלום בשמים, בני

*(Pronounced: *metza shalom ba-shamayim, b'ni*)

Find peace in heaven, father

מצא שלום בשמים, אבי

*(Pronounced: *metza shalom ba-shamayim, avi*)

father-son-father-son-father-son

אב-בן-אב-בן-אב-בן

*(Pronounced: *av-ben-av-ben-av-ben*)

In Hebrew, the word for “**heaven**” (or “sky,” depending on context) is:
:shamayim — שָׁמַיִם

Root: שִׁמַּיִם (*sh-m-y*) — relates to “height” or “loftiness.”

Form: It’s a **dual plural** noun, literally “the heavens” or “the skies.”

Meaning range:

- o Physical sky (as in weather, stars, etc.)
- o Spiritual heaven or divine realm
- o Poetic “heights” or “upper worlds”

In **Proto-Sinaitic**, “heaven” would likely have been rendered phonetically as **ŠMYM** — using symbols for *shin–mem–yod–mem*.

The Novel's Seed

What in me is dark, illumine.
— John Milton, *Paradise Lost* (1667)

This novel's seed took root in 1978, during the early days of my psychotherapy career. That summer, I worked the night shift in a locked, acute-care psychiatric facility. One night, around 2:00 am, I made my usual rounds—quiet halls, dimly lit—no horror-movie moans, just reverent silence. Hushed—most patients restrained, physically or chemically.

I opened one door—and froze. A young woman—perhaps roused by the hallway light or the sound of the latch—shot upright in her bed. Her wrists jerked—restraints clanking like chains in a tomb. Her black hair lashed across her face as she thrashed, silhouetted by a dim nightlight behind her.

“Get the fuck out!” she screamed. “I am the devil.”

Whether she was delusional, hallucinating, possessed, or the devil herself—I'll never know. But something in her voice—some fusion of fury and certainty—lodged in my chest and never left. It wasn't just what she said—it was that she believed it.

That encounter—and another, years later, with a young man convinced he was God—haunted me.

Not because I believed them, but because they believed themselves.

This novel grew from those sparks.

In his *Lyrical and Critical Essays* (1958), Albert Camus wrote, “A novel is nothing but philosophy in images.” (author's translation).

A Question of Balance is precisely that attempt—an exploration of belief, guilt, grace, and self-deception rendered not in argument, but in image and voice.

You may find yourself reading not just what happened, but what someone needed to believe happened. Sometimes the difference between the two is where the real story lives. None of this requires explanation in advance. All will make itself known in time.

David S. Sherman

January, 2026

*To open the Eternal Worlds, to open the
immortal Eyes
Of Man inwards into the Worlds of Thought:
into Eternity
Ever expanding in the Bosom of God. the
Human Imagination
— William Blake, Milton: A Poem (1804-
1810)*

Architectural Notes: On Structure, Memory, and Voice

A Companion Essay for Writers, Scholars, and the Particularly Curious

Author's Note-

This brief essay is offered for readers interested in the architecture beneath the surface of *A Question of Balance*. It reflects my thinking about structure, memory, and voice—not answers, and not instructions. The novel itself remains the primary experience; these notes are optional, and intentionally incomplete.

The Shape of the Story: A Loop, Not a Line

A Question of Balance was designed as a circular narrative rather than a linear one. The story ends in a quiet act of beginning—Steven Gold writing the very account the reader has just experienced. This is not a trick of metafiction, but a reflection of Gold's psychological journey: a wounded man circling the same questions until he has the courage to face them.

The novel's structure mirrors the logic of trauma. Memory does not progress cleanly forward; it returns, revises, reinterprets. Events are revisited not because they are unresolved facts, but because they remain unresolved meanings. The circular form reflects repetition, self-consumption, and the difficulty of escape from one's own internal narratives. The loop closes only when integration becomes possible.

A Story Told by Gold—and Shaped by Him

The novel is intentionally framed as Gold's manuscript, written after the events have concluded. This grants the reader intimate access to his voice, but it also means the narrative is shaped by his perceptions, omissions, and defenses.

Gold is not unreliable through deceit; he is unreliable because he is human. His training as a psychologist gives him language, but his wounds determine how—and whether—that language is applied. Throughout the novel, tension emerges between:

- what Gold perceives
- what he fears
- what he remembers
- what he cannot yet acknowledge

When Gold misreads others, it is revealing. When he contradicts himself, it is diagnostic. The novel's reality is therefore Gold's reality—offered sincerely, but incompletely.

Memory, Fragmentation, and the Limits of Knowing

One of the book's underlying philosophical commitments is that memory is not a static archive, but a creative act. We remember in order to survive. We reorganize experience into coherence. We misremember in proportion to guilt, fear, and longing.

This principle shapes both content and form:

- scenes recur as emotional pressure points
- details gain symbolic weight because they dominate Gold's inner life
- gaps persist where the psyche still protects itself

Even the prose shifts accordingly—at times clinical, at times dreamlike, at times confessional. These variations are deliberate. They function as a psychological seismograph, tracking Gold's oscillation between control and collapse.

On Samael Light: Presence and Pressure

This note does not seek to resolve Samael Light.

Light appears as fully real because Gold experienced him that way. Whether read as a psychological double, a symbolic presence, a dissociated self, or a literal figure whose existence becomes contested, Light functions less as an answer than as **pressure**—a force that exposes fault lines already present.

The novel invites readers to hold multiple interpretations simultaneously, not to collapse them into a single solution. Human beings generate internal versions of others; sometimes those versions exert more influence than the people themselves. Light occupies that unstable territory where interior and exterior voices blur.

The Ending as Beginning

By the novel's close, Gold has not resolved every mystery. What he has achieved instead is the capacity to speak truthfully—to himself, to Rachel, and to the world he inhabits.

Writing becomes an act of integration rather than explanation: a way of holding complexity without fleeing into certainty.

The loop closes not as finality, but as readiness. Another beginning becomes possible.

How to Use This Piece

This essay is **not required** to understand the novel. It is offered for readers interested in:

- narrative structure
- unreliable voice
- trauma and memory

- the ethics of interpretation

The novel itself remains the primary experience.

This companion simply traces the architecture beneath the surface.

APPENDIX: SELECTED JOURNALS AND MARGINALIA

Reveries and Unanswered Questions from the Edges of Life

Collected from the notebooks and marginalia of Dr. Steven Gold

The pages that follow were found among the scattered debris of Steven Gold's life—scribbled on the backs of patient charts, in the margins of books, typed into his phone during sleepless nights, and folded into his wallet beside expired credit-card receipts.

They are neither essays nor finished thoughts, but fragments: reveries scratched between sessions, questions that never found answers, philosophical barbs tossed at the universe, confessions he never dared voice aloud.

Taken together, they form the map of a restless mind pacing the edges of life, where philosophy, therapy, guilt, faith, love, and longing collide.

He never intended these for an audience—yet they reveal as much of the man as any polished case study or lecture ever could.

What follows is not offered as doctrine, but as witness: a record of a psychologist wrestling with himself.

I. On Existence, Bad Faith, and Philosophical Restlessness

*Know men by how they act—
by the sum of what they do,
by the effects their presence leaves behind in the world.
A man is shaped as much by what he invents about himself*

*as by what he truly desires.
The final pages of a life are already written
in its opening lines.*

— *Reveries and Unanswered Questions from the Edges of Life* (2026)

*Boethius says guilt clings only to those who choose evil. But Light wasn't
choosing anything. He was drowning in a story written long before he was
born.*

— *jotted inside Consolation of Philosophy*

Feelings = adjectives.

Emotions = verbs.

— *circled twice in the margin beside:*

"Man is nothing else but what he makes of himself."

— *Jean-Paul Sartre, Existentialism Is a Humanism* (1946)

The self is not something I am. It's the last thing I'm pretending not to be.

— *journal fragment, mid-therapeutic leave*

*Kierkegaard says despair is not knowing you're in despair. I envy those still
in that luxury.*

— *annotated copy of The Sickness Unto Death*

Freedom is unbearable unless you first believe you deserve it.

— *post-group session, veterans program*

I envy Camus. He believed the absurd was enough. I want more.

— *margin, Le Mythe de Sisyphe*

*To live authentically is to wake up each day and choose your own
executioner.*

— *early manuscript, unpublished*

Authenticity is just mauvaise foi—wearing better cologne.

— *post-it on Sartre, Being and Nothingness*

*Boethius insists suffering has purpose. But purpose is a story we invent when
the pain refuses to leave us alone.*

— *marginalia, Consolation of Philosophy*

The absurd is not the enemy of meaning. It's the soil in which we bury it.

— *Gold's notebook, on a patient considering divorce*

Even Sisyphus rested between pushes. Why can't I

— margin note, Camus

Some characters shape the plot but don't survive to the epilogue.

— patient file, redacted

The most dangerous form of bad faith is certainty.

— margin note, Sartre

Every diagnosis is a story we agree to believe in.

— journal margin, DSM-5

II. On Art, Creation, and the Divine

God may not be dead—but He's out of material.

— margin note, Cantor's Creature and Creator

What if we're not created in God's image, but in His draft form

— journal entry, post-therapy session

Creation is the divine coping mechanism for eternal loneliness.

— marginalia on Cantor's Milton essays

Oster says we seek affirmation through reality. But what if reality itself is unworthy of affirmation

— lecture notes, rejected for APA panel

Art is proof that we believe something sacred still listens.

— written after visiting Rachel's gallery

You can't draw fire—not real fire. It leaps, writhes, refuses to sit still. Better to sketch a hummingbird mid-flap; at least wings pause. Fire never does.

— marginal note on representation and instability

The artist is not a creator but a stenographer of divine failure.

— notes on Blake and Oster

Emerson had it right: genius begins when the private thought dares to believe it may be universal.

— *marginal note, Self-Reliance*

We mistake the artist for the artwork, the word for the Word.

— *underlined line, Cantor on Nietzsche*

Affirmation without reality is denial in a prettier suit.

— *marginalia during conference prep*

Every attempt at affirmation is a negotiation with loss.

— *fragment dated during a period of self-doubt*

III. On Phenomenology and Subjective Distortion

If phenomenology begins with experience, then madness is simply a deeper phenomenology.

— *margin note, Hanlon's On Presence and Disappearance*

Pain has more presence than the self it afflicts.

— *highlighted passage, circled twice*

The more aware I become of the now, the more I mistrust my memory of it.

— *psilocybin trial journal*

Perception is a lie we have learned to believe consistently.

— *Gold's gloss on Husserl*

When I see Light's face, I know it's mine. But I don't feel it yet. Is that

phenomenology or psychosis

— *post-session journal*

What vanishes is not reality, but the illusion that it stays still long enough to know.

— *marginalia, Hanlon's Temporal Drift and Existential Focus*

IV. On Patients, Practice, and

Therapy

Therapy isn't about truth. It's about tolerable lies.
— draft lecture notes

We tell children not to talk to strangers. Then we pay adults to become them.
— conference keynote draft

Insight doesn't heal. But it hurts more cleanly.
— journal entry after a session with Light

A well-framed question is often the most honest thing in the room.
— graduate school mantra

There is only the present. No tomorrow.
For most patients, the key to the past is getting past it.
— clinical teaching notes

Listen for echoes. Sometimes they speak more clearly than the voice that made them.
— margin note, *The Interpretation of Dreams*

I became a therapist to translate pain. Somewhere along the way, I forgot the language.
— notebook cover, year eighteen

Therapy isn't brilliance. It's pattern recognition—echoes of textbooks, mimicked mentors, scripted lines.
The genius, if there is any, lies in knowing when to stop performing it.
— marginal note inside Frieda Fromm-Reichmann's *Principles of Intensive Psychotherapy*

To love someone is to forfeit your right to be rational.
— private notes on transference

The unconscious is not a dungeon. It's a garden we forgot we planted.
— margin note, Jungian workshop program

My patients always thought they were broken. I knew better: they were haunted.
— rejected submission to *Journal of Existential Psychodynamics*

V. On Rachel, Love, and Regret

When love loses its footing, obsession tries to take its place—but it never fills the hole.

— personal notes on Rachel

Rachel loved me because I felt everything. She left me because I stopped.

— unsent letter found in desk drawer

She touched my chest like she was trying to unlock something—and for a moment, I almost opened.

— journal entry, three days later

Her tears on my shoulder meant more than my insights ever did.

— scribbled note folded into her book of poems

The body knows how to forgive what the mind keeps rehearsing.

— psilocybin reflection

I called it therapy. She called it love. She was closer to the truth.

— note filed in a folder labeled Boundary Ethics

My training never prepared me for the holiness of skin.

— psilocybin journal, written at 3:14 am

She smelled like citrus and safety. I wept for the years I wore gloves.

— memory fragment from two weeks after reunion

VI. On Psilocybin, Sex, and Insight

Under psilocybin, I didn't make love to Rachel. I remembered how.

— margin note, never shown to her

It wasn't orgasmic—it was sacramental. Like I'd knelt before a cathedral and finally looked up.

— *psilocybin trip notes, page four*

*Psychedelics don't reveal truth. They disarm the part of you that insists on
being blind to it.*

— *withdrawn lecture draft*

*I don't believe in miracles, but I've seen people stop lying to themselves—for
a few hours.*

— *clinical observation, psilocybin pilot notes*

Insight earned under psilocybin must be earned again in daylight.

— *annotated on post-trip debriefform*

It's not the mushrooms. It's the moment of permission.

— *comment to Bob Oldman*

VII. On God, Guilt, and Spiritual Collapse

Maybe God stopped speaking because we kept calling it schizophrenia.

— *conference handout, withdrawn before publication*

Doubt is the scar tissue of faith.

— *note taped above office light switch*

*God is a metaphor. So is Satan. But they are metaphors that have killed
millions.*

— *marginalia in Augustine's Confessions*

Even God has a shadow. That's where the clergy hide.

— *margin note in Jung's Answer to Job*

The Book of Job is a therapist's worst nightmare: the patient is right.

— *rejected APA presentation slide*

*Mephistopheles denies. Satan accuses. Light did both—but only one of them
felt like truth.*

— *marginalia, Faust*

Maybe God lives in Meinong's jungle—vivid enough to inspire wars, elusive

enough to escape disproof.
— scrawled in a battered copy of William James' *Varieties of Religious Experience*

Guilt is a mirror that turns slowly into a blade.
— case notes, later crossed out

Sometimes we mistake God for the voice that says you should have known better.
— margins of a Rilke anthology

The drug didn't show me God. It showed me how much I feared letting Him look at me.
— note folded into a Gideon Bible

Maybe the silence after a prayer is God trying to figure out how to say no.
— legal pad, date unknown

The real sin of Eden wasn't disobedience—it was not knowing what they were affirming.
— marginal commentary on *Oster*

VIII. On Identity, Dissociation, and Dr. Le Conte

How do you heal a mind you don't fully occupy
— DID notebook

Le Conte keeps asking which part of you believes that and I keep wondering which part answered.
— early session notes

He says dissociation is protection. I say it's treason.
— margin of workbook

If Light is a splinter of me, why does he bleed more truthfully than I do
— reflection after session

Structural dissociation: emotional tax evasion.
— doodle in clinic binder

*He says integration isn't erasure. Then why does becoming whole feel like a
funeral
— unsent homework assignment*

*We all have shadows. The trick is not to conquer them, but to dance with
them without pretending they aren't there.
— later treatment note*

*I asked if voices count as company. He didn't laugh. That scared me.
— session log*

*A DID diagnosis: relief and terror sharing the same seat.
— clinic lobby note*

*Madness doesn't begin with delusions. It begins with questions you can't
quite dismiss.
— treatment note, early integration work*

*Some myths are not lies. They are survival structures, carved from trauma.
— later treatment note*

*He says my mind split to survive. But what if the splitting was the wound
itself
— midnight entry*

*The worst part of DID treatment is discovering how many rooms in your head
you've never dared to enter.
— post-hypnosis journal*

*I thought Light was real. Can I be certain LeConte is?
— scribbled note*

*Could Steven Gold be a manifestation of someone else
— marginal note in Zhuangzi*

IX. On Bob Oldman, Mentorship, and the Cost of

Being Known

Bob wasn't just my therapist. He was the only adult in my life who spoke to me like I wasn't a burden.

— early training notebook

I trusted him because he didn't flinch. Not when I cried. Not when I raged. Not when I lied.

— supervision notes

He failed me, yes. But only people who matter can fail us.

— reflection after confrontation

He told me once that understanding is a form of love. I wish I had believed him then.

— ethics binder margin

Bob taught me how to sit with pain without trying to fix it. It took me decades to realize he was teaching me how to survive myself.

— journal entry on a rainy day

We broke each other's hearts. That's the cost of real mentorship.

— two weeks after reconciliation

X. On Telling His Story, Rachel's Fear, and the Ethics of Revealing Oneself

Writing all this down feels like peeling my skin off with a fountain pen.

— psilocybin integration notes

Therapists aren't supposed to confess, only interpret. Maybe that's why so many of us die half-finished.

— margin in DSM-5

Rachel asked if I wanted strangers parsing my life like a case study. I told her no. But I also told her truth doesn't survive in the dark.

— note typed into his phone

She guards her privacy the way I guard my guilt.
— journal entry

I don't know if I'm writing this for healing or absolution. Maybe both. Maybe neither. Maybe I just want the pain to have somewhere else to live.
— index card

She said she feared being exposed. I told her I feared disappearing.
— unshared dialogue fragment

Telling your story is an act of violence against your own secrets.
— inside back cover of *Man's Search for Meaning*

She's right to worry. Every confession reveals more than the confessor intends.
— yellow legal pad

But silence is its own kind of betrayal.
— final note in the same pad

XI. Aphorisms and Stray Marginalia

Fault Lines Beneath the Psyche

The personality of the therapist is the most important tool in the toolbox.
— clinical teaching notes

A therapeutic cure isn't a light bulb. It's a slow sunrise. But the sun sets every day.
— journal margin

Many patients come to therapy for vindication, not change.
— clinic observation

It's dangerous for a therapist to assume every conflict has a resolution.
— supervision notes

If you're stuck in the past, you can't create a future.
— workshop handout

Cognitive dissonance can turn a therapist into God. The effect never lasts.
— annotated lecture

Speech is a psychosocial event.
— graduate seminar notes

We are more accurately defined by our silences than our voices.
— Steven Gold, *Journal* (unpublished)

One problem with lying: eventually you forget which part was the truth.
— case reflection

When you realize you're stuck in a hole, stop digging.
— self-reminder, written twice

One of the earliest signs of psychosis is a sudden, intense interest in religion and philosophy.
— clinical pearl

Some guilt is earned. Some inherited. The hardest is borrowed—you can't return it.
— patient file margin

Why don't they teach therapists how to recognize when a horse is dead?
— lecture notes on psychotherapy practicum

The Machinery of Hurt

We're all packrats and hoarders when it comes to hurt. But that's living in the past.
— patient note on considering divorce

Fear is always about some kind of loss.
— margin, trauma seminar

We circle what frightens us.
— journal note after first session with Light

Children are never adults in their parents' eyes.
— after family session

You can rewire your brain, but not your heart.
— personal note after session

Intentions don't count. No one can see them.
— frustration scribbled during a fight with Rachel

Everybody's got baggage, but she had bags I couldn't carry.
— journal line

Spontaneity dies when we wait our turn. Truth rarely survives that silence.
— argument debrief

If you always push people away, loneliness becomes a habit.
— momento mori index card

Honesty is a gift. Hard to give, harder to receive.
— therapy reflection

Secrets aren't gifts. They're handcuffs.
— case consult margin

God, or the Things We Invent

Blind faith is dangerous. Faith with doubt is safer.
— theological notebook

Don't anthropomorphize the universe. It's how we invented God.
— philosophy lecture notes

And on the eighth day, man invented Satan to avoid blaming God.
— pencil note on sermon pamphlet

And on the eighth day, God created Satan to avoid being blamed for evil.
— counterpoint scribbled beneath the first line

Do the clergy suffer from Stockholm Syndrome

— *marginal inquiry*

Do not assume coincidence is proof of God.

— *note after near-accident*

Can a rose be credited for its beauty

— *reflection while examining Light's argument*

Why wasn't Eve celebrated like Prometheus

— *comparative mythology notes*

If God is silent, who will speak for Him

— *journal question on a blank page*

*People think Gold and God are almost the same word. They never see the hell
between the letters*

— *scribbled on a patient chart*

I found the Devil in my closet, and he was wearing my shoes.

— *dream log*

The Weather Systems of Love

Life's not a multiple-choice quiz.

— *arguing with himself in the car*

You can't truly deceive yourself. You can only distract yourself—for a while.

— *therapy homework prompt*

We get hurt when we let our desires determine our beliefs.

— *self-correction after a breakup*

Most people are scorpions. What did you expect

— *reflection after betrayal*

Decisions feel binary. They rarely are.

— *clinic hallway thought*

You have to light a lot of candles before a room finally reveals itself.

— *romantic observation*

Follow your heart—you can rewire your brain, but not your heart.

— relationship notebook

*Who is happier: the one who thinks things can't get worse, or the one who
knows they can*
— late-night musing

The optimist knows things could always be worse.
— self-description

A pessimist is only an optimist with a longer memory.
— late-night musing

The optimist knows things could always be worse.
— self-description

Life's too short to nurse old wounds like pets.
— Rachel's advice, written down to remember

The Weight of Memory

Know a man by his books.
— library inventory note

*Anyone remember their great-great-grandparents Four generations, then
oblivion.*
— existential reflection

Life can't be censored. People get sick trying to turn down the volume.
— clinical warning

Forgiveness is giving up all hope for a better past.
— self-therapy note

People aren't cats. We don't always land on our feet.
— jotted during a period of instability

The brighter the light, the darker the shadows it attracts.
— reflection on Light

On Death and Its Echoes

Life is like a Monopoly game. At the end, everything goes back in the box.
— mortality reflection

A diagnosis can feel like a death sentence—condemned to a story you didn't write.
— patient consult notes

Sometimes guilt feels like a séance where the dead refuse to stay silent.
— journal reflection

Death doesn't end relationships. It changes the rules.
— handwritten note after a funeral

Freedom's Terrible Arithmetic

Life is nothing but choices. We are nothing but their consequences.
— margin note

We always have a choice—even when we call it fate.
— moral self-check

Intentions don't count. Only actions survive.
— daily reminder

It's dangerous to let your desires determine your beliefs.
— post-conflict reflection

The only thing worse than not getting what you want is getting it.
— personal note

A rose cannot be credited for its beauty. Neither can an angel be credited for virtue—no free will, no merit.
— theology notes

The Heart and the Mind Both Scar

Scar tissue forms in the heart the same way it does in the mind—wherever the

*wound stayed open too long.
— post-breakup reflection*

*A heart scars when it survives. A mind scars when it remembers.
— clinic note*

*Scar tissue is the body's way of saying you lived. In the mind it says you have
not yet let go.
— therapy insight*

*Some wounds close. Others calcify into memory and call it healing.
— journal entry*

*The heart scars quietly. The mind scars loudly.
— reflection during insomnia*

*The worst scars form not at the moment of injury, but in the long hours we
spend telling ourselves it didn't hurt.
— dream analysis notes*

*In the heart, scar tissue strengthens. In the mind, it restricts.
— self-analysis*

*What the body seals, the mind reopens.
— case reflection*

*The heart lays down scar tissue the way winter lays down ice—layer after
layer, until the original shape is lost.
— psilocybin imagery*

*The mind's scars braid themselves into thought until one day you mistake the
injury for personality.
— clinical metaphor*

*Some scars thicken; some fade. The ones in the mind learn how to whisper.
— late-night journal*

*A heart attack leaves a lesion you can find on a scan. A betrayal leaves one
you find only when you speak.
— self-reflection*

*Time doesn't heal wounds. It teaches the scar to quiet down.
— personal note*

The soul scars too—but that's harder to admit.
— margin of a Kierkegaard volume

*Sometimes I wonder if therapy is just the slow softening of scar tissue—
cardiac, psychic, spiritual.*
— ethics seminar reflection

XII. Fragments on Insomnia, Clarity, and the Hours That Refuse to End

3:17 am – Kitchen Table
Insomnia is less a failure of sleep than a failure of surrender.
— herbal tea cooling beside him

Edge of the Bed
*There's a peculiar honesty between two and four am The mind stops
pretending to be civilized.*
— margin of Hanlon's Circadian Minds

*People think insomnia is racing thoughts. It isn't. It's orbiting thoughts—
circling, circling, refusing to burn up.*
— annotated copy

*Bob told me sleeplessness is the psyche's emergency brake: you're awake
because something refuses to let the day close.*
— Oldman's advice, ignored

*He appears most vividly when I'm exhausted—Samael Light, slipping
through the thinned veil between thought and hallucination.*
— insomnia log

God has silence. I have hell.
— fragment from a sleepless night

The brain without sleep is a poor bouncer.
— clinic joke that wasn't a joke

I don't take medication. Not out of virtue. Out of fear.

— *fear of dreaming something he can't unsee*

*The sleepless mind is a cruel archivist: it catalogs every regret and files it
under Tonight, Again.
— desk drawer notebook*

*Morning doesn't mean rest. Only that the nightmares have moved from the
bed to the mirror.
— dawn entry*

XIII. Scattered Erotic Reveries, Sensory Impressions, and Forbidden Dreams

Erotic Reveries — Rachel, Jane, and the Temptations of Memory

*The body remembers before the mind does.
— scribbled on a patient chart*

*Rachel never tries to be beautiful. That's what undoes me.
— post-shower note*

*Jane had a wildness that felt like trespassing.
— old photo reflection*

*Rachel's body is a promise. Jane's was a dare.
— marginal note, *The Unbearable Lightness of Being**

*Her weight on my chest felt like ownership, and I didn't mind.
— night journal*

*Jane's kiss tasted like defiance mixed with apology.
— memory fragment*

Watching Rachel paint is erotic in ways no one warns you about.
— studio note

Desire is the nervous system asking the world to press closer.
— clinical-sounding but not

Wanting two different versions of being seen is its own kind of sin.
— therapy self-admission

The back of Rachel's neck is an invitation.
— morning note

Jane smiled like she knew the damage she was doing.
— after too much wine

*Rachel's leg draped over mine afterward is the closest I come to believing in
grace.*
— afterglow entry

Bodies don't lie. That's their cruelty.
— reflection on lust and guilt

The Senses — Desire in Sight, Scent, Taste, and Touch

*Desire begins with sight—one stolen glance the body recognizes before the
mind admits it.*
— first draft line

Some bodies aren't looked at; they're witnessed.
— studio reflection

The most erotic moment is the pause between seeing and being seen.
— clinical-sensory note

Scent is the oldest memory of the body.
— jotted after an embrace

Her fragrance lingered on my shirt like a truth I wasn't ready to name.
— scent memory

Touch declares.

— *skin note*

The body tells its stories in light, salt, warmth, and breath.

— *sensory meditation*

Certain silhouettes undo me.

— *visual reverie*

*Her presence altered the light in the room; my eyes followed without
permission.*

— *studio reflection*

Some faces ignite longing; others awaken memory. The rarest do both.

— *portrait note*

Forbidden Dreams — Where Memory and Desire Blur

Jane appears in dreams as she was, not as she became.

— *dream fragment*

She looks at me like sin disguised as invitation.

— *dream note*

Her breath on my neck is the worst part. I feel what she isn't touching.

— *post-dream reflection*

Hesitation is its own seduction.

— *dream entry*

My guilt wakes before I do.

— *marginal note*

The dreams aren't about sex. They're about wanting what I shouldn't want.

— *clinical self-analysis*

*She whispers a word I can't hear, but my mind supplies the one it fears most:
yours.*

— *dream transcription*

Each time Jane appears, Rachel disappears.
— moral fracture note

Desire in dreams is appetite wearing a mask.
— interpretive reflection

Her perfume arrives before she does. Scent is the body's oldest betrayal.
— dream scent note

*The version of Jane my waking mind resents is not the version my sleeping
mind worships.*
— dual-self observation

Desire and danger share a voltage.
— marginal note

*Some part of me wanted her because she might destroy me; some part of her
wanted to be wanted that way.*
— final forbidden dream entry

*Is Jane real, or just another manifestation of me, like Light? Is Jane darkness
—just another internal shadow*
— scribbled note

* * *

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A Question of Balance

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